

転生したら スライム

That Time I Got
Reincarnated as a SLIME 19

Story by Fuse, Illustration by Mitz Vah

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みつばー



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GC NOVELS



He ignored the surprised Feldway and took Velgrynd into his arms.

“...Masayuki?”



GC NOVELS

転生したら
スライム
だった件 19
Regarding
Reincarnated to Slime

Story by Fuse, Illustration by Mitsuhiko

伏瀬
みつぽー

That Time I Got Reincarnated as a Slime

Volume 19

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Turmoil in the Royal Capital

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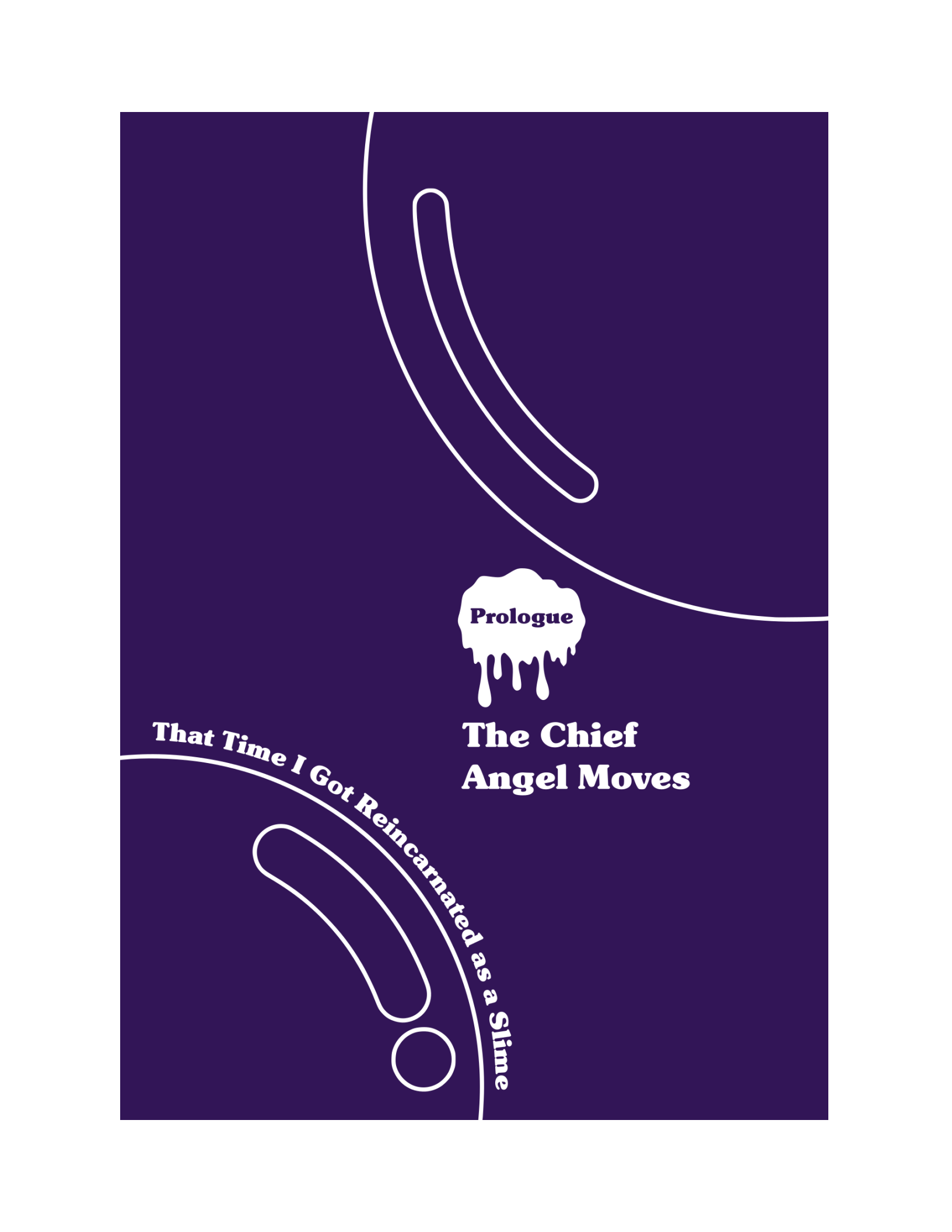
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The background is a solid dark purple. It features several white curved lines: a large one in the upper right, and another in the lower left that curves around the text 'That Time I Got Reincarnated as a Slime'. In the center, there is a white splash-like graphic with the word 'Prologue' inside it, and several white droplets hanging from the bottom of the splash.

Prologue

**The Chief
Angel Moves**

That Time I Got Reincarnated as a Slime

Prologue

The Chief Angel Moves

He knew that it was just a dream, an unfulfilled wish. Reviving the Star King Dragon, Veldanava, in his entirety was not possible for the ‘Justice King Michael,’ who was merely a Skill. But even so, he couldn’t shake the hope. A world without Veldanava held no value for Michael.

.....

.....

...

Michael’s eyes fluttered open. He shook his head gently, trying to rid himself of the lingering emotions. He couldn’t help but feel a bit confused at the feeling, as if his emotions had been laid bare for the first time.

I thought I wasn’t as naive as Rudra, but I was wrong.

In the end, that was the lesson. Trust no one and use everyone as pawns—if he had done that from the start, Obera’s betrayal could have been avoided. He hadn’t because he believed in Feldway. He thought that Feldway’s friends, the people he trusted, would also be trustworthy to him. But that was a mistake. When the Ultimate Skill ‘Salvation King Azrael,’ bound to his hand, returned to him, Michael realized his error.

Obera had betrayed them. She had used her administrative privileges to

erase 'Salvation King Azrael' and escape Michael's control. In an attempt to make up for that loss, he had used Feldway to bolster his control over the Angelic Skill holders currently under his domain through the 'Ultimate Dominion.'

With that, there is no problem with the Phantoms. The Insectars may betray us, but our interests are still aligned. Monitoring will be essential, but once the battlefield is prepared, we'll be able to handle the rest.

The battlefield was the land where the contract with the Insectars took place. Michael had promised Zelanus that he could carve out any area he wanted and make it his domain. That's right. If anyone lived there, the Insectars would take care of them. In other words, Michael intended to send Zelanus to the fiercest battleground. The location would slowly be determined, but there were several problems. The first, needless to say, was how to deal with Obera's betrayal.

The Phantoms were loyal to Feldway, so there was no need to worry about a drop in morale. He could have even postponed the decision, judging by the threat level, but he had a feeling that it would be a bad idea. Obera's role had been to monitor the 'World-destroying Dragon' Ivarage. Now, however, that importance had been diminished. Whatever happened in the Otherworld was none of Michael's concern, and if anything, the situation of Ivarage's manifestation in the Cardinal World was incorporated into his strategy. In other words, he didn't care if Obera abandoned her mission. However, it would be a different story if she tried to cooperate with the enemy forces such as Demon Lord Rimuru or Demon Lord Guy. In order to nip such concerns in the bud, taking the initiative seemed more certain.

So, who should they send? That was the main question. This was also related to the following issue. Should they proceed to the next target as planned? If they were going to take out Obera, shouldn't the plan be

revised? This was not a trivial matter. After all, the troops under Obera's command were a part of Michael's army. The loss of strength due to his mistake made Michael feel uncomfortable. This was also a new experience for him.

Emotion was something that Michael, as a Manas, had a difficult time understanding. And yet, recently, his thoughts had been disturbed like a noise in a song. So he suddenly had the thought to enjoy the feeling.

If this is an 'emotion,' then perhaps I should consider myself lucky. Even if there is only one perfect answer, there are innumerable ways to get there. The shortest way is not necessarily the right way, so I can be forgiven for enjoying the process.

As Michael sat and reflected on his current predicament, he realized that if he allowed his emotions to be disturbed every time a problem arose, it would be better to simply enjoy it. He knew that impatience would narrow his field of vision and that anger would dull his thinking. Regret was meaningless, and the most constructive thing to do was to avoid making more mistakes in the future. With this in mind, Michael found a solution to his current problem.

...That's right. I, myself, should defeat the rebels, he thought to himself.

He knew that any losses should be recovered within the day, and that it was better to make up for his own mistakes rather than imposing them on others. This way, he would not have to worry about opening up old wounds and could calmly tackle the next problem. As soon as he reached this conclusion, Michael's mood lifted. It was the first time he had ever experienced this feeling.

"Emotions" are not so bad after all, he concluded.



In the Otherworld, there is no such thing as gravity. It is similar to outer space in that there is no concept of earth and sky. There are only objects made of condensed magicules scattered throughout the empty space. Such objects were as strong as magisteel, and generated powerful gravitational forces, so they were processed to be used as ‘bases’¹. The former angels, the Phantoms, used such bases to live a life similar to one in the Cardinal World, so as not to forget their lives in a gravitational field. The base of Obera, which was comparable in size to an asteroid, was the frontline base against Ivarage. Its strength was unrivaled by any other bases and was one of the most important facilities for the Phantoms. Michael jumped towards that base.

When ‘Spatial Transportation’ was used from the Heavenly Star Palace, Obera’s base was already empty. However, Michael immediately sensed the presence of a large army nearby.

Over there, Michael thought, as he turned his gaze.

Obera also seemed to have noticed Michael’s presence and immediately responded by taking an intercepting stance. With unhindered movements, she and the others had formed a full-blown formation and turned their hostility towards Michael. Because there was no ground and sky, the type of formation was different from that on earth. A full-sky formation was a tactic that was built on the premise that the enemy was small in number. It aimed at annihilation of the enemy by encircling them from above, below, right, and left.² It was a successful formation against cryptids.

The cryptids were specialized in their individual fighting ability and

rarely swarmed together. Therefore, using a tactic that encircled them in large numbers was very effective. Obera had always been at the forefront of the battle, and her command was excellent. The soldiers who responded to her were also worthy of praise.

Ah, it really is a shame. At any rate, I wish I could have made better use of this force—

Michael sighed. These were the people who had been holding off the cryptids for so long. Their usefulness was impeccable, and it would be a shame to lose them here. However, there was no room left for negotiation. Michael's decision to eliminate the traitors and make up the losses was unwavering even in the face of Obera and the others.

"That was faster than I expected."

Obera remarked. Michael responded with a few words of his own.

"Your actions were meaningful in that they made me aware of my mistakes. However, you should understand that there is no forgiveness for that."

"Of course, I am not going to ask for your forgiveness. Michael, was it? I don't know if you are the will of a Skill or anything else, but I have no obligation to obey the orders of someone who reeks³ of suspicion."

The intentions of both parties were confirmed. And just like that, the war began. Obera was the first to move. Hundreds of thousands of troops moved at her will, filling the other world with the light of annihilation. Using the full-sky formation, the soldiers were deployed in three dimensions, forming a hemisphere. The front was lined up with defense specialists, and the back rows were constantly attacking as layers were replaced over and over. This made it seem as if it was filled with light. Light converged on Michael from all sides of the hemisphere. An army trained to battle cryptids could function without problems, even at the scale

of the entire army. The energy wave offensive, which emphasized efficiency to the utmost, was unleashed continuously even as the troops were replaced. Naturally, there was no way to avoid them, so Michael was directly hit by the concentrated fire.

But Michael did not panic. This was because no matter what the attack was, it would be ineffective against the ‘Castle Guard.’

—However, there was a problem here.

“Geh, this—is this pain?”

‘Castle Guard’ was supposed to disable all attacks, but for some reason it hadn’t done so this time. As a result, the overlapping energy of Obara’s concentrated fire burned Michael to a crisp. It was an unbelievable event for Michael. His own body was gradually being damaged. Unperturbed by this, Michael pursued the reason this happened.

...No energy is reaching the ‘Castle Guard’? I see...apparently, none of them are loyal to me.

Michael was convinced that this was the reason, and he was correct. Rudra, with his charisma, had a huge following of Imperial subjects. However, Michael himself did not have any loyal subordinates. This was because very few people in the world even knew of Michael’s existence, and those few people already had masters of their own. Moreover, those masters were only connected by mutual interests, and they did not trust each other, nor had they sworn allegiance. The only exception was Feldway, with whom he was bound by friendship. Moreover, Michael’s own Parallel Existence, the Ultimate Skill ‘Justice King Michael,’ had been transferred to him, so they were treated as the same entity. There was no point in manifesting the power of ‘Castle Guard,’ using one’s own loyalty. That was a very natural logic.

I see, I didn’t understand anything about my own skill.

Surprisingly, people did not understand themselves. In the same way, Michael had been mistaken about 'Justice King Michael.' Previously, when he had confronted Rimuru's group on the airship, he had thought that he was protecting Feldway with his 'Castle Guard.' But that was different. Feldway was Feldway, and he was using his skill. Unlike back then, Michael could no longer use the loyalty to Rudra. That is why the 'Castle Guard' was ineffective. Because this skill nullified all attacks, the conditions for using it must be strict. Michael understood this deeply through his own pain.

Obera, the attacker, was also surprised at the unexpected turn of events. She was aware of Michael's 'Castle Guard.' She had been told that any attack would be useless, so she was confused to see Michael taking damage. That said, there was no doubt that this was an opportunity, so before she could worry about all that, she gave her orders.

"Keep on attacking with all of your strength! Keep the coordination smooth, and do not allow Michael to rest!!"

The soldiers also knew what they were doing and attacked at full force without needing to be told to do so. Obera thought to herself. Michael's pursuit was within expectations. There had been a high probability that her betrayal would be discovered when she erased the angelic skill, and she had been prepared to take some sort of action at that point. Because she would have definitely done the same. As a countermeasure for such a case, she planned to launch a full-scale attack, as was being done right now, while continuing to fight a battle of secret withdrawal.

The destination of escape was the enemy's territory. She had intended to guide Michael well and hit the cryptids. However, it seemed that this was not currently necessary. From Obera's perspective, Michael's energy level

was several times greater than her own. He appeared to be a formidable fighter, but his combat experience did not seem to be as good as she had expected.

Perhaps we can win like this? No, that's too naive. I feel sorry, but some of my soldiers will have to act as decoys in the end.

Obera was a cool-headed and brilliant commander. She was willing to sacrifice her weaker subordinates by dividing her army into numbers. The ability to sacrifice the minority in order to keep the majority alive was also a prerequisite for commanding a large army. That is why she could order her subordinates to die without hesitation. The selection of whom to let live had already been made. If Michael did not make a move, she could teleport out during that opening. Now that Michael was here, she would be able to open the Great Gate of the Sky from inside the Otherworld. It was with this in mind that Obera, the strategist, set up this escape.

“Oma, you will lead the First Legion out of the battlefield. The destination is our Lord, the Demon Lord Milim-sama.”

Obera commanded her loyal followers. She herself intended to stay here and take command until the very end. The First Legion was the most elite of those under Obera. Oma was also an excellent second-in-command, and her fighting skills were outstanding. With the addition of her undead elf body and increased strength, she would be indispensable to Demon Lord Milim in the future. Believing that, this was Obera's last order. However...

Oma did not agree. Oma, who had regained her speech⁴ when she became an undead elf herself, asserted fluently.

“You must be joking⁵. The key to the gate can only be handled by you, the Primordial⁶. Even if that were not the case, a warrior could never leave their lord, whom they must protect, just to run away.” With that said, she smiled quietly. All the soldiers under Obera's command shouted at the top

of their lungs in agreement.

“ “ “Our glory is with you!!” ” ” ”

Without Obera, there was no point in surviving. Those were their true feelings, and their pride. If Obera had been possessed by ‘Justice King Michael,’ the absolute ‘Castle Guard’ would have been manifested. An unbreakable command and a loyal soldier would have been realized, but unfortunately that was only a hypothetical story.

“You guys...”

Obera was troubled. The worst thing that could happen was that they all died here. At the very least, someone had to reach Milim and inform her of their situation, providing as much information as possible.

Should I stay? Or should Oma take over?

At this point, feelings were irrelevant. What mattered most was the decision with the highest success rate. Obera had made her decision and was about to say it when—

“All hands, spread out as fast as you can!!”

She sensed something was wrong and gave the order immediately. Obera was deep in thought, but she still kept her attention on Michael, who was under heavy fire. She was not foolish enough to make such a mistake on the battlefield. That’s why she had noticed. Michael’s energy had suddenly stopped decreasing. In other words, it meant that he was no longer taking damage, but before she could figure out why, she sensed that Michael was condensing a vast amount of energy. Therefore, she had opened her mouth before she could worry about it.

Following Obera’s orders, hundreds of thousands of troops began to move at once. Since those closer to the outer rim were faster, they tried to spread out in all directions without getting jammed. However, as if to ridicule their movements, Michael’s technique was activated.

“Scorch Dragon Cardinal Acceleration.”

It was a blow that made the power he had gained from capturing Velgrynd completely his own. The multi-headed crimson dragon laid waste to Obera’s army, and more than ten thousand soldiers perished in that instant. It was like a scene from a nightmare. But even so, the damage was not as serious as it could have been. If Obera had not noticed, everything would have ended in that instant.

“Y-you⁷...!!”

Obera was furious that her lovely subordinates were killed, but she remained calm despite her anger. She analyzed the current attack and calculated the ratio of strength based on its power. Just from that, she concluded that there was an overwhelming difference between Michael and herself. It was obvious that if things continued as they were, the worst would come to fruition. In fact, the tens of thousands of scattered rays of light, which had started to counterattack, were being repelled by an ice barrier Michael had put up.

Not only Velgrynd-sama, but perhaps it’s also the power of Velzard-sama...

Michael’s body was surrounded by a beautiful blue-white layer of icy diamond dust. It didn’t matter that there was no atmosphere in this other world, Michael’s aura was generating a supernatural phenomenon. And that power was undoubtedly the ‘Snow Crystal’ shield of the Frost Dragon Velzard. An absolute barrier that was said to prevent all attacks. Although it was a defensive technique classified as a physical phenomenon, its nature allowed it to cut off all wavelengths and frequencies.

Spiritual attacks could work, but it required an amount of energy comparable to that of Velzard to penetrate. The current Michael was comparable to, or even greater than Velzard. In other words, it would be

impossible for Obera alone to shatter ‘Snow Crystal.’ In the first place, only a few of Obera’s subordinates were capable of spiritual attacks like ‘Disintegration.’ Even if she were to unite the power of all the survivors and launch Disintegration, it was unlikely that it would even reach Michael.

“Oma, I am entrusting the mission to you. Escape from here. And to Milim-sama—”

“I cannot accept that. Obera-sama, as Chief of Staff, I have the authority to disobey orders from you. This is the perfect moment to do so!”

Showing a rare moment of disapproval, Oma spoke up once again. Obera could feel Oma’s determination. In that case, there was only one course of action to be taken.

“Then I shall leave this to you. Everyone, give it your all!!”

“Die,” Obera ordered. And yet:

The soldiers under Obera’s command all wore gleeful expressions.

“ “ “Our lives are yours⁸!!” ” ” ”

That declaration was the signal. The merciless destruction resumed, and...

**Chapter
1**

The First Battle



That Time I Got Reincarnated as a Slime

Chapter 1

The First Battle

The place where we transported was extremely frigid. A world of silver. It was as if we had wandered into Guy's castle. I had tried to use the 'magic transfer circle,' but the spell did not work. Therefore, I used 'Spatial Transportation' to reach the limit of what I could see with my surveillance spell 'Argus,' and was greeted by a stinging cold air. It was freezing to the core. It must have been 'that.' I was able to nullify the cold, but the fact that I still felt a chill was definitely due to Velzard's influence. There was a presence in the air that made the air tremble, telling me that this was definitely a battlefield. The greatest source of power was coming from the battlefield where Guy and Velzard were facing each other. They had created a deadly space where no one could intervene.

So, I'd just leave that part alone. I thought I felt someone looking at me, but I just ignored it. I felt like I had been hit by a wave of anger saying, 'You bastard, you just ignored me!' but it wasn't good to overthink things. I'm just an extra, so it's probably best if I don't intervene.

«...»

I could feel someone's dismay, but my conclusion remained unshakable. Jumping into a situation that you know is dangerous is not a choice that a wise man should make. On that note, I should find out where I can intervene. The next option is—let's see, it's Diablo. His opponent is Zalario, so let's ignore that one too.

Oh well. It's Diablo, so it should be fine to just leave it to him. If he can't handle it, then there's nothing I can do about it.

«No, that's not—»

Tsk, tsk, you don't understand, Ciel-san. I've noticed recently that Diablo's been slacking off whenever I'm watching him. He's probably not aware of it, but it feels like he's not working because he wants to see what I can do.

«...I see, that makes sense.»

Oh, it's been quite a while since I last beat Ciel-san to the punch. I'm feeling good, but I'll just go ahead and give instructions to everyone.

"Leave the outside alone, we're heading for Leon. It looks like there are a few battlefields, so please deal with them as you see fit!"

Benimaru, Souei, Ranga and Kumara nodded at my decision. Roughly speaking, this was an emergency. For the time being, I decided that it would be best if we all went together. By the way, was there another battlefield out here? There was. I could sense a thick magical residue near the ground.

But...my instinctive intuition told me to ignore it. Why was that? Without any reason or evidence, I decided to follow it. Well, now was not the time to be troubled, so I decided to take immediate action. Everyone

seemed to have no objection, and we all began moving towards the castle.



The visibility was terrible. I was doing my best to activate ‘Universal Perception,’ but I couldn’t even get a sense of distance. The reason was simple—Velzard’s snowstorm was contaminated with magicules. That’s why the ‘Natural Effects Nullification’ was disabled. As long as we were sensing distance using the reflection of magicules in the atmosphere, everything would become ambiguous if the space was filled with magicules. So, all we could do was to move in the direction where the magicules were shaking. That ended up being the correct answer, and we soon reached Leon’s castle.

The inside of the castle was better. I was relieved to have my sight back. And so, I looked for signs of battle.

“All right, I’ve detected a sign of Leon. Benimaru and I will head out, so you guys go support the rest of the battlefields.”

“Understood!”

“I understand!”

“Leave it to me.”

Without any objection to my order, Ranga, Kumara, and Souei moved out. Without even seeing them off, I took Benimaru and activated ‘Spatial Transportation.’ In any case, the moment we entered the castle, the signs of battle swelled greatly. A chilling presence. The energy was so intense that it exceeded my current full power, and I decided that this would be dangerous. The scene at the end of the transport was a true race against

time. I performed ‘Thought Acceleration’ at several hundred million times the speed and tried to read the situation—

Laplace and Teare were protecting a woman, led by Yuuki, who had summoned up the last of his energy. The woman looked familiar to me. Yuuki’s secretary—she must have been the possessed form of the Demon Lord Kazalim. Her name was Kagali, and the last time I saw her, she had been under the control of Lieutenant Kondo. I don’t know what had happened to her, but she seemed to have regained her free will. No, the current problem was not that, but rather the gigantic fireball that the enemy was about to unleash.

Strengthened by an ultimate skill, its heat and destructive power had been increased to such an extent that it could shatter even the spirit. In other words, it would even destroy the soul. And it had already been unleashed. I would be safe. My ‘Void God Azathoth’ could eat up the power of destruction, so I was well protected against the release. Naturally, Benimaru was also under its influence, so there was no need to worry. However, Yuuki and the others, who were exposed to the gigantic fireball and took the direct hit from the front, had already been damaged. Then, they were already—

«No. If you eat them with ‘Void God Azathoth,’ or—»

Do it! Before I could even finish listening to the entire explanation, I gave the order. In no time at all, Ciel-san took action. And yet, however—

The result was a huge explosion that blew away the castle. Yuuki was swallowed up by the light and disappeared. And so did Laplace. The large explosion that distorted space was largely suppressed by my power. However, for the two people who received a direct hit...

‘I’ve given you a lot of trouble up until now, but I didn’t dislike you, Rimuru-san.’

‘Same here. I’m relieved that you’re here now. I leave the rest to you!’⁹

—I felt like I heard voices speaking. I think it was an auditory hallucination. Yuuki and Laplace disappeared without a trace. Certainly, they had always been a pain in the ass. But Yuuki was still a fellow countryman that Shizu-san had entrusted to me. And then there was Laplace, who I thought I could get to know in a way that I couldn’t hate him now...

«—Both of them are stubborn, so the possibility of them being alive somewhere is not zero.»

There’s no need to console me. It’s obvious from this situation that it was just a fantasy. But even so, those words brought me back to reality. I thanked Ciel-san and changed my mind. Yuuki and Laplace had been sacrificed, but they had nothing to do with the victory goal in the first place. Besides, they were the most stubborn people I knew, so there was still the possibility that they might be alive. In that case, now wasn’t the time to get sentimental. I still had work to do.

It would be an insult to them if I didn’t do my job and became consumed with regret. The time that Yuuki and Laplace earned was not wasted. The ‘Barrier’ that Yuuki and Laplace had put up with all their strength, with Teare risking her life to support it with all her might, had saved Kagali from serious injury. I knew this because I was still observing her condition by isolating her in my ‘Stomach.’

It was actually Ciel-san who was doing this—meaning that as a result of Yuuki and Laplace’s actions, I was able to rescue Teare and Kagali in time.

After confirming the safety of the two, I turned my attention to the enemy. One of them was Feldway. And the other one was Footman—or actually not. It was a different person.

Leon, who I had been wondering about, was fighting someone unknown. No, her face looked just like El-tan's, but I could sense that she was a different person. She seemed to be very strong just like El-tan, but she also felt different by nature. I could see that she was an ally, so I left the questions of who she was for later. She appeared to be fighting on equal terms with Leon, so I decided to leave this to her and concentrate on the enemy.

“I expected you to go after Leon, but you moved slower than expected.”

For the time being, I would stir things up. I had no intention of showing it, but I felt sorry that I couldn't save Yuuki and the others. I was so angry with myself that I didn't intend to show any mercy.

“Who are you? Just who are you to interfere with me, you unpleasant infidel?”

“Jahil, that's one of the most important figures, Demon Lord Rimuru. You'd do well to remember that.”

Mmm-hmm.

The man who appeared to have taken over Footman was named Jahil. He's also the one who launched the attack, so he was definitely a bad guy. Two enemies, and two of us. I would take care of Feldway, and Benimaru would take care of Jahil. However, it looked like—

“Jahil, was it? I will deal with him.”

Oh, Benimaru-kun?

He was so happy to be here that I could not even get worried about him. There was no use worrying about things now. I decided to let things happen as they will.

“Huh, I didn’t expect to have to fight here, but it will save me a lot of trouble.”

“That’s my line!”

I responded and drew my sword.



I’m going to do it. I’m seriously going to do it. Michael is difficult to defeat because he has ‘Castle Guard,’ but fortunately, he is not here. I wanted to take advantage of this opportunity to take out Feldway alone. And I am the type of person who does not hesitate once my decision has been made. In a drawn-out battle, there is no such thing as interruptions. In such a case, you should decide the game with a killing blow.

That’s right, I had prepared it for such a situation. In all times and places, it was the thing that all shounen manga protagonists had—the sure-kill technique.¹⁰

“Imaginary Blade!!”

If someone were to ask what the *strongest* sword technique against an individual was, the answer would be obvious. It was the ‘Melt Slash,’ which could even slice through the spirit. Then, if someone were to ask what the *best* sword technique against an individual was, the answer would be the ‘Haze style’ (Oboro-Hyakka Ryouran). Combining both of these characteristics was Benimaru’s special move, the ‘Oboro-Kokuen Hyakka Ryouran¹¹,’ which can be considered his sure-kill technique.

This sword art was the highest form of the technique, but with the ultimate skill added to increase its power. Therefore, its power had been

raised to the realm of shattering the spirit, making it comparable to the ‘Melt Slash’ technique. There is no doubt that it was the strongest in terms of both power and skill. And then, I had a thought. I can’t lose to Benimaru, you know?

So I asked Ciel-san to come up with a useful sure-kill technique. Of course, I also gave my own opinion. I asked it to use ‘Nihilicity Collapse,’ which I still had a difficult time understanding even after it was explained to me, and to make it more powerful. That is how the ‘Imaginary Blade’ was born. Rather than slashing through the spirit, this technique eats it. It’s the main characteristic of this technique. Because it eats the target and throws it into ‘Imaginary Space,’ it has a broken¹² performance that is virtually impossible to defend against.

The only effective way to counter this is to avoid it. Even if it is caught with a sword, because it has a one-hit kill effect¹³, the battle ends immediately. One of my aesthetics was that “a sure-kill technique should be a sure-kill technique.” It’s a matter of course for my friends that the second time was not the charm. If a technique is shown even once, the opponent will take countermeasures, so the best thing to do is to not show anyone your sure-kill technique until it’s time for the actual performance.

Well, there was also a way to deal with that using ‘Parallel Existence’ like Velgrynd, but when it came to a battle between high-ranking spiritual life forms, the main focus was the scramble for energy... In other words, the one who exhausted their opponent first was the winner. Although it was no longer an Insta-kill, it was still a terrific sure-kill move. At this stage of the battle, I generously revealed my sure-kill technique with a strong will to kill Feldway on the spot. And yet, even then—

The space made a screeching noise, and my sword was caught.

«...?!»

I could feel Ciel-san's surprise. I suppose that made sense. I was surprised too.

«No way, to think that the jinx that Master feared would be proven true...»

Hmm? Um, a jinx?

«Yes. It's a shounen manga trope that if you use your sure-kill technique as the first move, it will be blocked...»

Pffft!!

You—I couldn't help but burst out laughing in this serious situation. No, did I say that? You're right, I did say something like that. But, there's no way...right?

...

«...»

Phew. Let's just forget it. These things just happen. He had caught the sword easily as if it were a joke, and it seemed to have upset him a bit. I switched my mind and focused on Feldway. Ciel-san had already started investigating the cause of the blockage before I did. It would be pointless to attack again until the results were out, but I needed to pretend that I didn't care about that. I decided to bluff my way into a conversation with Feldway.

“Wow, you blocked that really well.”

Pretending that I wasn't upset inside, I slashed at him and tried to talk to him. I thought that I would be ignored, but he unexpectedly responded to me.

“When I think about how attached the Black King (Noir) is to you, I don't feel threatened at all.”

He's got an annoying way of saying things. I don't really care about being compared to Diablo, but to think that he didn't even bother with my new sure-kill technique...

«No, it's unnatural. I don't think there is anyone who wouldn't feel threatened by it. The only person I can think of is Michael, who is protected by the 'Castle Guard'—»

You say that, but in reality, it didn't work at all. At this rate, even the 'Abyss Annihilation,' which I learned from watching Carrera in the labyrinth, might not work. Feldway's sword appeared to be mythical-grade, and 'Imaginary Blade' did not work either. Of course, that meant that the backwards-compatible 'Melt Slash' would be useless as well. In that case, one might think that slashing at the body would be enough, but this was not so easy. Because this Feldway guy was quite skilled.

When I crossed swords with him, I felt that Feldway's abilities were considerable. He was as good as or better than me in terms of pure swordsmanship alone. I'd say that he was on par with Benimaru. Since I had become a True Dragon race, my physical abilities had increased greatly. It was not a metaphor, but I was now able to move several times faster than before. In addition, I thought that my skill with the sword had also improved, but I still couldn't get to Feldway. In my case, I was able to deal with it because I had been cheating in many ways and could even ask Ciel-

san to take my place if I had to, but I really felt that I had no chance in a fair and serious fight.

In such a situation, the best thing to do was to switch to using magic attacks, which swords could not receive. However, large-scale magic would cause a lot of damage to Leon's kingdom. So, the only other option was to use magic for individuals. The 'Abyss Annihilation' that I just mentioned had a destructive power that could affect the entire planet, so it couldn't be used anyway. However, I used it as an example because it was one of the highest classes of magic in terms of power. When it came to anti-personnel magic, I couldn't really think of anything that could surpass it. 'Disintegration' was barely comparable to it, and anything else would just be guessing. The simple anti-personnel nuclear magic: Nuclear Cannon, was not nearly as powerful as Disintegration...

Even if an ultimate skill was used to increase the power, it could be dealt with if the opponent also had an ultimate skill. Even without it, there was no way to make it hit. Fortunately, Feldway was keeping a wait-and-see attitude. If he started to fight back, I wouldn't be able to afford it. At the moment, it seemed that the best thing to do was to try to find a way out of the situation through conversation. I started talking so as not to let him know how irritated I was.

"I'm just a harmless slime. It's only natural that I don't seem like a threat."

"Hmph, you're talking out of your ass. That's the kind of thing that makes you seem just like master and slave."

"That doesn't make you happy?"

"Well. You're just a hindrance to me, so I have no reason to be pleased. If that makes you uncomfortable, then that's just a bonus."

I thought he would just ignore me, but surprisingly, the conversation

continued. That made this all the more disappointing. If I couldn't communicate with the other party, defeating them with no hesitation became much easier...

Well, I was currently in the middle of searching for a successful strategy, so I didn't have the time to think about it from a different perspective anyway. That said, I was still curious. Why wasn't Feldway fighting back? It was convenient for me, but if we didn't do something, we'd end up in an endless repetition of moves¹⁴. I was using 'Nihilicity Collapse,' but it was not as fatiguing because it was an absorptive rather than a releasing system. However, the same was true for Feldway who was not receiving damage.

Feldway seemed to be defending himself with some kind of skill, but since he was only defending himself, the fatigue appeared to be minor. One strategy was to use a sword technique that Feldway could not catch. To be perfectly honest, I had another secret technique up my sleeve. It was an improved version of Benimaru and Carrera's 'Hyakka Ryouran,' and could not be used without Ciel-san's full support. I was hesitant to use it because it was a technique that exceeded my current skill-level and made me feel like I was cheating.

But now was not the time for such things, and I considered using it when the opportunity presented itself—but I just couldn't picture it succeeding. There was something ominous about it all. It seemed that Ciel-san agreed with me, and I decided to give priority to finding out Feldway's secrets for now. That's why we were currently in an indefinite battle, but when I thought about it more deeply, it was also a good time to calmly check the other battle situations. I was also concerned about the safety of the others. While keeping my eyes on Feldway, I focused on my friends.



Benimaru was the one I was worried about. His opponent seemed superior in all aspects, so I tried to observe the situation with ‘Universal Perception’ without looking at him.

Hm?!

Jahil was wielding a ghastly blood-colored spear. I had no idea when or from where he brought it out, but I could feel a tremendous power coming from that spear.

«It seems that the spear is called the Origin Blood Spear. *“This spear, given to me by the Divine Ancestor, will pierce you through!”* That’s what he said.»

O-oh, I see...

Unlike me, it seemed that Ciel-san was already aware of Benimaru’s situation. Well, it’s true that we couldn’t be too careful, but we weren’t necessarily in a bad situation. If worse came to worst, I still had Veldora, so even if I died, I could be revived. It could be said that I didn’t have a high enough sense of danger, but it wasn’t worth being impatient until I found a way to attack. And so, I continued my observations.

I wasn’t sure of what kind of existence Jahil was, but he didn’t look uncomfortable even though he had taken over Footman. In other words, his movements were light, and his spear wielding was very good. Because I had increased my perception speed by several hundred million times, I could clearly see that he fought like an expert. It was hard to believe that he was using someone else’s body, and that only made obvious just how

troublesome Jahil was. And moreover...

Jahil's existence value was over three times that of Benimaru's, and what's more, that spear, the Origin Blood, was estimated to have an existence value of more than ten million. Such a weapon should be illegal.

Since we were outside Ramiris' labyrinth, I couldn't calculate the exact values, but the overall difference in strength between them was more than four times. It was only due to Benimaru's skill-level, which was superior to mine, that the battle was barely feasible. In other words, if Benimaru did not have his 'Heat King Amaterasu' he would have been defeated long ago. That's how troublesome this bastard Jahil was.

If that was the case, I wanted to help him out right now. But I didn't have that kind of time, so I had no choice but to ask Benimaru to do his best. As for the other battles, well...

This one was an indefinite draw. The mysterious woman who was fighting Leon looked just like El-tan¹⁵, so I assumed that she was related to her. Surprisingly, she was just as powerful as an Awakened Demon Lord. No, perhaps even more than that? She appeared to have an Ultimate Skill and was doing her best against Leon without retreating a single step.

«Their fighting styles are very similar. I presume that they have a master-disciple relationship.»

Hmm...

I hadn't noticed it because they were using different types of weapons, but now that you mention it, they might be very similar after all. Perhaps that woman was Leon's mentor. And their Ultimate Skills were of the same lineage¹⁶. Since they were able to read the other's movements, they were stuck in an indefinite draw. There wasn't going to be an easy way to settle

this. Any help couldn't be expected, but the fact that support wasn't immediately needed could be considered quite lucky.

“Rimuru-kun, right? If you can afford to observe all this, then shouldn't you help me out a bit?”

Oh, she's quite the perceptive person. She caught me scrutinizing their battle. I couldn't actually afford to do much either, but it's true that I had been observing the other battles, so it was hard to refute her. In that case, I had no choice but to answer as honestly as I could.

“I'm sorry. I didn't have anything better to do, so I couldn't help looking over my shoulder.”

“Hah? What kind of nerves do you have to do something like that when you can't even afford it? I had heard from El-chan that you didn't have any common sense, but you—you really should take things more seriously.”

That was undeniably true. I wasn't expecting to be found out, so I had let my guard down, but it was certainly out of the ordinary to look away in the middle of a battle.

“I shall take your suggestions back with me and consider them seriously.”¹⁷

“Hmm, it sounds like you're not interested in reforming at all, but whatever. So, do you think you can win?”

Very perceptive, this one. I was planning to play it off lightly, but she saw right through me. I really had to start taking this more seriously, or Feldway was going to think I was crazy. Preparing for a possible counterattack, I answered her question.

“I can't at the moment. There's no room for an opening.”

Feldway snickered upon hearing that. Unexpectedly, he joined in on the conversation.

“Heh, I'm the one who should be surprised that you're looking away

while fighting me. And yet, you say that there's no room for an opening? How ridiculous. From whose mouth are you speaking from?"

"Shut up! It's only because I showed you my trump card and you blocked it so easily! If you'd have just let yourself get hit by that, I wouldn't have had to go through all this trouble!"

"Don't make me laugh. If you bastards hadn't interfered with me, our plan would have come to fruition much earlier. In the first place, you should realize how many of our plans have been foiled because of your servant, the Black King Noir!"

It seems that I was too aggressive and had made him angry.

"I had nothing to do with those Diablo incidents."

"It is the owner's¹⁸ job to take responsibility."

"No, we haven't known each other for that long."

I have a policy for not taking on unnecessary responsibility. I firmly insisted that I was not at fault here.

"You really are a cheeky one."

"Hm, I agree. You're pretty incredible. I almost respect you for being so relaxed in this kind of situation!"

That was not a compliment. I mean, you should just be focusing on Leon! Just kidding. I'd never say that out loud, because that would be like treading on the tail of a snake.

"By the way, who are you?"

"Oh, me? I'm El-chan's mom. You can just call me Silvia!"

That was a surprising introduction. Well, elves were a long-lived species, so I suppose it could be the case...but I still felt like I wouldn't easily be able to nod my head in agreement even if El-tan called her mother right in front of me. The common sense of my previous life got in the way too much. When I glanced over at her, I saw that she was fighting a very

close battle to the extent that it was strange that she even found the time to talk.

Both Leon and Silvia-san were dodging each other's swords by the slimmest of margins and counter attacking, as if they had practiced it beforehand. This person seemed to have a lot of guts if she could speak casually under such circumstances.

"So, do you think Leon will be able to pull through? You're his master, aren't you?"

"Ah, you caught that? I won't deny that I'm his master, but I don't think I can do anything about this. To be honest, I didn't expect Leon-kun to be this strong..."

That response sounded playful, but it was probably the truth. Those two had been walking a tightrope since before we arrived, so it was no wonder that they had lost their concentration. The current state of equilibrium would collapse if any part of it was missing, so it certainly wasn't the time to be complacent. But then... I was left wondering what to do about Leon.

I did have a plan for dealing with Leon, but I wasn't sure if I should go through with it. In any case, I wanted to aim for more effective timing, but right now didn't seem to be the right time. The situation was severe, but we were still in equilibrium. I felt that if I overreacted now, I might end up putting us all in danger. I would continue to wait and see about Leon. As I was making such a decision, I received a complaint from Benimaru.

"Rimuru-sama, I understand that you can afford to do so, but I'm in a really difficult spot here!"

How unusual, for Benimaru to be complaining—well, I guess it was understandable. A power difference of more than four times was too severe.

"It's bad?"

"It's really bad."

That's right. It was fortunate that Jahil specialized in flames because it gave Benimaru an advantage in terms of compatibility. He would have been defeated long ago otherwise, so even the current situation was miraculous. Now then, what to do...

The battle would be decided once the equilibrium was broken, but even I didn't have the strength to do so. I had a few hidden trump cards, but it was difficult to know when to use them. As for the opponents, aside from Leon, Feldway and Jahil were too much at ease. We were overwhelmingly at a disadvantage. In that case, perhaps I should kill the enemies elsewhere and wait for someone to rush in, or even perform Demon Summoning, one of our trump cards, and call in Testarossa. However, I was afraid that if I did that, my opponent would be able to do the same thing, and things would quickly go out of hand. After all, the best option was to wait and see for a while.

"Benimaru-kun, please do your best just a little longer!"

"Wai—seriously, I can't buy that much time, you know?!"

It's been a long time since I had heard such a pathetic reply coming from Benimaru. With that in mind, I began discussing with Ciel-san again if there were any other ways to overcome this situation.



Ranga, Kumara, and Souei had separated from Rimuru, and each of them was heading to support a different battlefield. They did not consult with one another in particular, but had naturally decided on where to go based on the general strength of the enemy.

The opponent Ranga was headed for was Vega. He was the one who was giving off the strongest presence, even stronger than Ranga's. And as expected, it was the fiercest battleground.

Hmm, he seems to be stronger than me, but if we bide our time, Souei-dono and the others should be able to dispose of the enemy and rush to our aid...

Ranga trusted his friends. That is why he was able to take on the strongest of opponents with no fear and no doubts.

"I shall assist you!"

Ranga shouted and jumped at Vega. Maetel was delighted by this. White Knight Maetel, the leader of the White Knights under Leon, had desperately been trying to recover, but there was a limit to how much time he could buy with his current strength. The five demon peers under Raine and Mizeri's command—Misora, Squall, Ulrich, Alban, and Georg—were all as powerful as the old demon lords. However, their opponent, Vega, had an existence value of more than ten million, and the difference in their abilities was too great.

Misora, the Duke-class commander, was very talented as Raine's second-in-command. She was always looking after Raine, who tended to slack off, and she possessed a broad perspective with good leadership. But even so, there was no room for effective leadership when some of them had been crippled by Vega's attacks. In spite of this, the battle line did not collapse thanks to Misora's efforts. And it was Maetel's restoration magic that desperately supported this.

Normally, these proud demons were very individualistic, but with the cooperation of all five of them, they managed to maintain the front line, even making full use of illusion magic to deceive. However, when Ulrich and Alban fell at the same time, the burden on those who remained

increased. Maetel's recovery magic could not keep up, and total annihilation was imminent. It was at this critical moment that Ranga intervened.

“What the hell, you dog! You dare to interfere with me!”

Vega was on a high. Now that he had so much power, he believed himself to be invincible. That's why he decided that one more monster wouldn't be much of a threat. But that was a mistake. Ranga's existence value was less than half of Vega's, but his combat experience was not to be underestimated. Because he was always lurking in Rimuru's shadow, he had witnessed many battles. That is why Ranga was able to flexibly adapt his tactics to the enemy. This time, the strategic victory would be to get through this without any casualties. By understanding that, his role became more clear.

“Use me as a shield and regroup. Reinforcements will definitely come. My lord will not be defeated!”

Wagging his tail, Ranga assured them. With that alone, Misora and the others understood that Rimuru had arrived. Misora accurately read Ranga's intentions and figured out what the best course of action would be.

“I shall take your word for it. Maetel-dono, please concentrate on Ranga-dono.”

And with that, the tactics were swiftly rearranged, and the battle changed with Ranga as the focal point. From this point on, Vega's high would come to an end. This was because Ranga, whom Vega had initially dismissed as inferior, performed better than expected. Without thinking, Vega attempted to eliminate Ranga. By using his Ultimate Skill ‘Evil Dragon King Azi Dahaka’ to the fullest extent, he tried to subdue him with pure power.

The Ultimate Skill, 'Evil Dragon King Azi Dahaka,' was a skill acquired after Vega's upbringing. Vega was descended from the 'magical inquisitors,' one of the Rosso's research achievements. He was a monster that possessed both monster and human characteristics, and could recover from any injury as long as he was fed. It was a secret that Yuuki had modified him to become a kind of imitation slime.

Vega's whole body was a collection of miniscule magical bacteria. Therefore, he could regenerate freely, and as long as a single part of his body remained, he could be revived without any problems. He was able to mimic the structure of living organisms, and depending on the probability, he could even acquire the Skill of the opponent after Predation. It was precisely because of this that Vega was able to acquire the Ultimate Skill 'Evil Dragon King Azi Dahaka.'

The true value of this skill was that it absorbed the power of the eaten target, just like the Vega's essential nature. It was a power very similar to Rimuru's 'Gluttonous King Beelzebuth,' and was an aggregation of terrifying abilities such as 'Ultraspeed Thought,' 'Parallel Thought,' 'Analyze and Assess,' 'Organic Domination,' 'Mass Reproduction,' 'Skill Absorption,' and 'Multilayer Barrier.'

It had an extremely high performance. If the victim had a physical body, it's information could be read using 'Organic Domination' and its racial abilities could be acquired. Even if the victim was a spiritual life form, it was possible to steal away its energy using 'Skill Absorption' and even make its Skills their own. On top of that, as long as there was an organic body to use as a material, the user could mass-produce and manipulate 'replicas' of themselves. The Ultimate Skill 'Evil Dragon King Azi Dahaka' was a skill that, if it could be mastered, could help the wielder become as strong as they wished. If it could be mastered...

Unfortunately, Vega hadn't had that much experience since he was born. He had grown at an alarming rate, and his power had only increased, but he had yet to master his own powers. Vega could only use 'Organic Domination' to strengthen his body, 'Analyze and Assess' to understand his enemies' weaknesses, and 'Skill Absorption' to weaken his enemies. He also used 'Ultraspeed Thought' unconsciously, so he was able to make good decisions, but unfortunately, he could not use 'Parallel Thinking,' and was unable to claim victory despite having an overwhelming advantage. However, Vega himself was enjoying his strength so much that he didn't even realize that he had missed his best chance...

—And with a vicious power, Vega's fist pierced through Ranga.

“—Hm?”

Vega wondered at the lack of response. He should have pierced through him, but he couldn't feel anything. Let alone stealing energy, he could not even use 'Analyze and Assess' on the enemy. The reason for this was that Ranga was using his own abilities to the fullest. Ranga's ultimate skill, 'Stellar Wind King Hastur,' had the effect of transforming his body into a magical wind.

Physical attacks would not work against Ranga, who had turned into a terrifying 'demonic wind' that contaminated everything it touched. In fact, the moment something touched Ranga, it would be damaged by the 'death-calling wind.' The current Ranga was magic itself.

The logic was the same as that of Karion's Burst Roar; He maintained his regular form and mass but was transformed into a willful particle of destructive energy not unlike a spiritual life form. Even a simple physical attack would become an attack of great destructive power. One did not need an explanation to understand how terrifying this was. Furthermore, unlike

with Karion, this was not Ranga using a special move, but rather undergoing a change in state. Naturally, the rate of energy consumption would be higher, but there would be no restrictions placed on him just for entering a magical wind state.

This was the power of someone who could utilize their Skill to the fullest extent. Although Vega was superior in terms of existence value, Ranga was the winner in terms of ability.

“Hahaha, that fist doesn’t seem to work on me, does it?”

Actually, Ranga was surprised. He had expected Vega to be stronger and had been wary of him. Because Rimuru was always so cautious, he learned to imitate him. That is why he never let his guard down against Vega, who possessed more than twice the amount of energy as he did. On the contrary, he even suspected that this was a trap of some kind.

“Damn you! You have no respect, even though you’re just a dog!”

And after Vega tried to hit him, he realized for the first time that the other party was an idiot. If he had hit Ranga, who had turned into magical wind, without thinking, the result would have been the same as hurting himself. Vega would have taken the damage on his own, and Ranga was left dumbfounded. In this case, the correct answer was to wrap your fist in a skill-enhanced aura and then hit him. The same applied to attacking with weapons. Skills could only be dealt with by skills.

If he was a spiritual life form, he could be as effective as an ultimate skill by increasing his energy, but Vega did not take any of that into consideration. If he had mastered his Ultimate Skill ‘Evil Dragon King Azi Dahaka,’ he would not have shown such a disgraceful appearance.

“You fool. I thought you were playing a trick on me, but it looks like you were actually serious. In that case, I shall make my move at once.”

As soon as Ranga announced this, he began to run at full speed. He

became a jet-black wind that tossed Vega around, leaving the sound behind and filling the space with afterimages from the earth to the sky. Then, it became a howling that reverberated inside the space. Ranga amplified his own speed and destructive power through the ‘Sound and Wind Domination’ of the ‘Stellar Wind King Hastur,’ and then created a force field using ‘Spatial Domination’ while running at full speed. After that, he created a ‘Death Storm’ within the force field by using ‘Weather Domination’ for the final blow—this eventually lead to the ‘Apocalypse’ that destroyed everything.

This technique was called ‘Apocalypse Howling.’ It was the most powerful individual attack technique that Ranga had devised. Incidentally, if one made a howling roar, they could also fire it as a directional beam. Normally, that would be the simpler and more correct way to use it. However, if one wanted to cause more damage, it was better to use a beam that was confined to a certain space, as was the case in this situation. By confining the target, there was no waste of energy, so a greater effect was to be expected.

Vega took a direct hit from this, but surprisingly, he survived. Although he was not able to use the ‘Evil Dragon King Azi Dahaka’ properly, he was still subconsciously affected by the skill in his body. Moreover, Vega could be characterized by his stubbornness. Although he was not left unharmed, he was able to regenerate his own body in time before being killed by activating ‘Organic Domination’ and ‘Mass Reproduction.’ His magicule count was not to be underestimated. Vega took a deep breath and bellowed with all his might.

“Shit, shit, shiiiiiiit!!”

Then he glared at Ranga. Vega took a deep breath to calm himself down, and then spat out.

“Damn it! It’s been a long series of continuous battles, and it looks like I’m tired too. I’ll call it a draw for today, so prepare yourself for the next time we meet! See ya.”

Vega’s cowardice was the only reason why he was so good at sensing danger. Realizing that the situation had become disadvantageous for him, he immediately decided to run away. Ranga had no objections. From the fact that he had withstood his own strongest move, he could see that Vega was superior to him in terms of existence value. He understood that he could not defeat Vega unless he was able to finish him off with that current blow. In that case, there was no need to push himself. His tactical goal was to buy time, so if he could force Vega to retreat, then that would be considered a success. Therefore, Ranga’s decision to not engage Vega was the correct choice.

Thus, the battle against Vega, the fiercest of the battlefields, came to an end.

Now then, everyone was pleased by Ranga’s support, however—

Misora thought to herself.

This Ranga fellow is the pet of the Demon Lord Rimuru-sama, isn’t he? So then why is he so strong?!

That strength was just illogical. Misora had a rough idea of how large or small Vega and Ranga’s energy values were. This was because a good fighter could not survive if they were unable to measure the strength of their enemy. In Misora’s perspective, Ranga was a serious contender, but Vega still seemed to be a more formidable opponent. And yet, Ranga had been the overwhelming victor. She had planned to use Ranga as a shield and reconfigure her tactics, but now she felt like she had been let down.

“You know, Misora, there are some extraordinary beings in this world.

Once you take a good look at Rimuru-sama, you will understand how I feel right now.”

Misora remembered the words of her boss (Raine).

“I see now...just by watching his pet, one can understand the caliber of the owner. I did not doubt Raine-sama’s words, but now I understand them wholeheartedly.”

Misora couldn’t help muttering, and the four remaining demon peers nodded their heads in total agreement. And White Knight Maetel, who had almost run out of mana, was left dumbfounded that he had no part to play. It was as if they had escaped reality.

I like dogs, and I’ve always wanted to have one. They’re just so dependable. After this battle, I’ll have to rush to the pet store to buy one!

It was a complete abandonment of thought. By the way, pet stores in this world did not sell pet dogs. They sold animals and monsters that were trained by a tamer and could really fight, at a high price. Later on, Maetel would buy a forest wolf and give it the name ‘Ranga II,’ but that was another story.



Red Knight Fran and Yellow Knight Kizona were struggling against Oria. The word ‘struggling’ was an understatement. If Oria had seriously intended to kill them, the battle would have instantly been decided.

“Kuh, she’s just too strong...”

Fran muttered, biting her lip. Kizona, who was exposed to Oria’s attack, agreed.

“She’s just toying with us. Now it’s a mace? It was a short-sword earlier, but she’s making the weapons weaker and weaker, testing their performance on us.”

Kizona’s point was correct. At first, Oria was holding a morning star.¹⁹ With one blow, Kizona’s full body armor had been shattered. The next blow would have killed her, but Oria’s next move was to switch weapons. Kizona felt as if she was being taken for a fool, but it was also true that she felt lucky.

“It’s disgraceful to be ridiculed like this, but I guess it can’t be helped since there’s such a large difference between our abilities...”

“Let’s think positively. If we keep stalling for time, I am sure that Leon-sama will come to help!”

Fran and Kizona were determined to not give up and face Oria with an unrealistic hope. They both understood that such hope was an illusion. Their master, Demon Lord Leon, must be in an even more treacherous situation. Otherwise, Leon would not have abandoned his subordinates. So, all they could do was try to stay alive until help arrived.

But that was long overdue. The disparity in their abilities was too great. Not even ten minutes had passed since the battle had started, and they were already wounded to the bone. And Oria was also satisfied after testing her abilities to some extent.

“Yeah. Is that enough?”

Oria spoke and transformed her weapon into the ‘Trident.’ It was the main weapon of a woman who had once been named Orca. Fran and Kizona also understood that Oria’s presence had changed.

So this is it... I did my best, but I regret that I couldn’t complete my mission...

Fran was despairing. Kizona was more materialistic.

I wish I could have eaten some cake in the end...

They waited for everything to end while thinking to themselves. However, the end never came. Instead, what came was—

“You seem to be in some trouble. I thought it would be tactless of me to intervene, but I will leave that matter to you.”

Kumara, who had transformed herself into a beautiful woman, stood before Oria as if to protect Fran and Kizona.

Thus, the battle between Kumara and Oria began, and once again, it was a one-sided affair. But this time, it was Oria who was completely outmatched.

“There’s no way, why?!”

A startled cry escaped Oria’s mouth. Oria’s Ultimate Enchantment, ‘Multiple Weapons,’ was the power to create mythical-grade weapons of any performance. The full-body armor she wore was also mythical-grade, as it should be. And yet, the nine-tailed punches that Kumara was unleashing by manipulating her tails were damaging Oria without any regard to her mythical-grade armor. It did not shatter the armor, but the impact still penetrated and reduced Oria’s physical strength.

“You’re pretty weak, aren’t you? If that’s the case, I don’t need to send out the Eight Legions.”

Kumara had wondered if she should send out a Tailed Beast to gauge the enemy’s strength, but after one battle, she had decided that there was no need. Oria was a top-notch warrior and a formidable opponent who could even control advanced magic. However, her movements did not deviate from the realm of human beings, and she did not stray from Kumara’s expectations in any way.

For Kumara, who had experience with strong opponents such as Karion

and Frey, this opponent was unsatisfactory. It was Oria's armament that should be of concern, but that too was not a threat to Kumara. Because Kumara had evolved even further. From a Nine Tails to a fox djinn. Kumara's power had increased greatly once she took on divinity.

Of course, Oria had a seraph in her, so she also had divinity. Moreover, when comparing the existence values between them, there was not much of a difference. Kumara had grown a little, but still had an existence value of less than 2 million, while Oria had an existence value of a little more than 2 million. By numerical values alone, Oria had the advantage. And yet—

Oria, with only her experience as a human, had too narrow of a range of uses for her power. When they were humans, Oria—Orca and Aria—had been the most senior executive members of the Mixed Corps under Yuuki. They had been as strong as the Imperial Knights, the most powerful group in the Empire. The souls of these two women mingled and awakened as undead elves, and even gained the power of the seraphim. On top of that, the Ultimate Enchantment 'Alternative,' given to them by Michael, had been transformed into 'Multiple Weapons.' She was convinced that there were no enemies worth noting on earth.

After experimenting with Fran and Kizona to confirm this, Oria was convinced that her power was the strongest. The weapons created by her skill were second to none for any existing mythical-grade equipment. As proof of this, Fran's and Kizona's attacks had not worked on Oria at all. They couldn't even touch her body, and the two had been repelled by her mythical-grade armor. Her weapon could shatter the enemy's weapon with only a light swing. Oria had become overconfident in her own power. That was why she refused to acknowledge the current reality.

“Do not take me for a fool! I'll be getting serious from here on!”

Now that the experimenting was over, Oria swung her 'Trident' around

with all the skill she possessed. The magic that Aria had been so good at transformed into a purple light. Even Kumara would have been mortally wounded if she were to be hit by the spear that Orca was unleashing with her brilliant skill. However...

Nine tails, cloaked in a divine aura, moved freely to block the 'Trident.' At this point, the difference in ability was obvious to everyone. Just as it was natural for people to differ in power even when they had the same physical abilities, there was a difference between those who had studied martial arts and those who were still amateurs—perhaps even greater than that.

Even Fran and Kizona, who had only been watching the fight between the two women, could clearly see the difference.

"Wow, that's amazing..."

"Hey, is that person one of Demon Lord Rimuru's subordinates?"

"I don't know, but I'm pretty sure she's on our side."

"How should I put this... I think I've come to realize that we should never become enemies. I mean, even the people we don't know about are so powerful..."

"Shut up. I agree with you even if you don't say it."

They were admiring Kumara's brave figure while talking about her. Kumara, the bewitching beauty herself, was standing gracefully without moving an inch. Once one realized this fact, it was like being shown that there was not any point in arguing about who was better.

"Well, are you ready?"

Kumara asked, her smile deepening.

"I won't accept this. That's right, I won't. I—we have acquired the strongest power. This power exists only to serve the great Michael-sama!"

“Hmm, I see. But it won’t work on me.”

Kumara ruthlessly replied to the angry Oria. It was an obvious fact, but it was still enough of an insult to make Oria angry.

“Don’t be silly! I am Oria, the one who defeats Michael-sama’s enemies!!”

Oria took pride in herself and attacked Kumara with all her might. But that was just reckless. A suicide attack without a plan was nothing but a meaningless attack to Kumara. Oria’s spear was flicked away by Kumara’s tail, and her limbs were restrained by four tails. The dull sound of shattering joints echoed through the air—A merciless ending for Oria.

“My ‘name’ is Kumara. Kumara the Chimera Lord. Receive this as a souvenir for the dead.”

Kumara finally announced her name as she slammed her tails into the immobilized Oria.



Arios had mastered the Ultimate Enchantment ‘Punishment King Sandalphon’ and was overwhelming the Blue Knight Oxian and Mizeri’s lieutenant, Kahn. The bastard sword that Arios held was also a mythical-grade sword borrowed from Oria. He had grown in strength and power beyond what he could have ever imagined as a human. That’s why Arios had put off killing them. The two inferiors were just the right playmates for him to test his strength on.

Both Oria and Arios knew that it was not an honorable thing for the strong to bully the weak. Unlike Vega, both of them had common sense and

would not normally get involved in personal affairs in the middle of a mission. But this time, the situation was different.

They both believed that if they didn't test out their powers, which was very different from what they were used to, it would be a hindrance to their future battles. It was also a necessary task for a first-class warrior to grasp what they could do and to what extent they could push themselves. Therefore, he had taken this opportunity to allow himself a certain amount of play. Oxian and Kahn were aware of Arios' intentions. It was humiliating for the two proud men, but this time it was convenient.

The victory condition was to buy time, and it was difficult for them to achieve that with their abilities alone. So, even though they knew they were being toyed with, they had no choice but to face Arios desperately. Aside from the intelligent Oxian, the old demon, Kahn, was boiling like magma on the inside.

I'll kill him. I'll never forgive him!!

Kahn was the leader of Mizeri's subordinates and was normally a calm and collected person. However, his patience was not as strong as Misora's. He was always in awe of his colleagues, wondering how they could endure under someone like Raine-sama. So now, after being humiliated like this, Kahn's fury was at an all-time high. However, there was still a cruel wall between him and Arios.

It was not so much a difference in skill-level, in fact, Oxian and Kahn were probably better than him in that aspect. But even so, the reason why it was so one-sided was that there was a large gap between their existence values by several times. Moreover, Arios possessed the fearsome 'Punishment King Sandalphon.' Aside from a mythical-grade weapon, nothing could even compete with the ultimate skill. It had been a long and painful time, but that was coming to an end. They could tell from Arios'

expression that his stance had shifted.

“Heh, that’s enough. You guys were pretty strong, right? Well, I’ve had a lot of fun, so I’ll kill you easily without causing you any more pain.”

Having tested his strength enough, Arios must have decided that it was time to stop fooling around. He told Kahn and Oxian as such. There was nothing they could do about it, Oxian had decided.

I will have to leave the rest to Leon-sama. I shall apologize in the afterlife for being unable to complete my mission.

Oxian apologized inwardly. Kahn, too, etched anger into his soul.

Even if I die here, I will never forget my grudge. Arios—I will remember that name. I will definitely come back one day and kill you!

For a demon, death was merely a change of state. As long as the core was left intact, they could be revived over time. Depending on the amount of damage, it might take hundreds of years or more, but no matter what, they could always be revived. That is why Kahn swore to take revenge. Incidentally, it was necessary to interfere with the spirit in order to damage the mind. As represented by ‘Disintegration,’ the ‘information particles’ could not be reached without destroying the spirit. Now that Arios had the ‘Punishment King Sandalphon,’ he should be able to destroy the core if he was aware of it.

However, Kahn was not so worried. Arios’ swordsmanship, physical ability, and Skill were all first-rate, but his spirit did not deviate from that of humans. He didn’t seem to have much experience in dealing with non-humans, and he didn’t seem to know how to deal with demons. That was why Kahn believed that he could get out of this situation by pretending to be dead.

Arios’ sword was held up to Oxian, and the gun in his hand was pointed at Kahn. Kahn’s body was already at its limit. Now that Arios was serious,

there was no way he would be able to continue fighting any longer. Although he felt bad for Oxian, Kahn's strength was his ability to keep a cool head.

So this is it for now. I'll have to successfully withdraw—

As Kahn was thinking this, Arios took one look at Kahn with a broad smile and put his finger on the trigger.

“Hyahaha! I'll start with you first—”

The best I can do is smile for now, Kahn thought, but then his eyes widened as something caught his eye.

Behind Arios, someone jumped out from the shadows at his feet and swung a sword. At this point, the crisis was over.



Kahn recognized this person. He remembered that he was a subordinate of the Demon Lord Rimuru, and that he had called himself Souei. Oxian also noticed him at about the same time.

“Souei-dono, so the reinforcements arrived in time?!”

Oxian shouted with joy, to which Souei replied bitterly.

“Damn, I thought that I'd kill him with one blow, but I guess that was a little naive. He's still alive, so don't let your guard down.”

Although Souei was a gentleman in front of Rimuru, he was more of a self-confident and self-centered person at heart. Aside from perhaps the head of state of another nation, he would never defer to a senior executive. In addition, this was an emergency, so he had taken the initiative to take control of the situation, placing Oxian and Kahn under his command.

Meanwhile, Arios, who had been suddenly ambushed, was still alive as Souei had said. He was coughing up blood, but somehow still managed to regain his position.

Arios had just barely noticed the deadly blow from his blind spot that also carried Souei's 'Insta-kill' ability—'Assassinate'—he narrowly avoided the attack that would have pierced his heart.

"Bastard, now you've really done it."

"Your reaction time is impressive. However, I won't miss the next time."

That's all that was said before they rushed into battle. Arios was arrogant, but he still had a cautious personality. Before being reborn as a Yōten (Heavenly Demon/Spirit)²⁰, he had been a powerful otherworlder. He had been involved in assassination missions and had learned all kinds of skills. He was an expert in interpersonal warfare and had learned all the manner of ways to be careful when being targeted.

That is why he never let his guard down under any circumstances. Even while he hunted down Oxian and Kahn, he had not neglected being vigilant to his surroundings. That was what saved his life. But that was all it did.

"Hmm, so your strength is greater than mine. That'll be tough to beat."

"So, what will you do?"

A battle of competing forces. And a fight for one's life. Arios felt that he was very much alive. Already, his injuries had healed. His life force had been strengthened to an extraordinary degree, and he now possessed the power of the seraphim. It was just that he still hadn't broken free from the conventions of being human, but Arios has long since entered the realm of the non-human.

With this power that surpasses even a demon lord, no matter who you are, you're no match for me!

He was proud of himself and looked forward to Souei's next move.

Arios was already aware. As Souei had said, he was more powerful than him. He did not doubt his victory, as he felt that he was not that far behind in terms of skill-level. He did not let his guard down, however, he was much too arrogant in dealing with Souei. From the very start, Souei had not intended to compete with Arios. The battle must be won. No matter how good the battle was, a loss was game over. That is why Souei did not care about how he won.

From the very beginning, he had kept his ‘split body’ hidden and watched for Arios’ to leave an opening. In this way, while fighting a close battle, he gradually made Arios feel that he was going to lose, so that Arios would be caught off guard. While making it seem like he was doing his best, he stripped away at Arios’ moves one by one, and built a solid path to victory. Then came the decisive moment.

“Hyahaha! You’ve been a tough opponent. I’ll give you that. That’s why I’ll kill you with my best move!”

With that said, he unleashed ‘Judgment,’ the sure-kill move of the Ultimate Enchantment ‘Punishment King Sandalphon.’ It pierced right through, and Souei’s ‘Split Body’ fizzled out. Seeing this, Arios was convinced that he had won. It was understandable.

Judgment could only be fired once a day, but it was the strongest means of attack. It was less powerful than the one that Lieutenant Kondou had fired, but it was still a blow that could not be broken. It was understandable that he believed Souei’s death to be certain, but that was exactly what Souei was waiting for.

“Thousand-Hand Shadow Kill.²¹”

“Wa—?”

A shadow stretched out and grabbed Arios.

“W-wait!”

Souei blocked Arios' movements and pierced through his heart with the twin swords in his hands.



It was Feldway's words that changed the stalemated situation of the battle.

“—It's about time to move on. It appears that further battles are meaningless.”

When I heard that, I thought to myself.

I should have made my decision sooner.

If I could corner him here, that would be the best. But unfortunately, I felt that we were at a disadvantage. If we continued fighting like this, I was pretty sure that we would get support, but to be perfectly honest, I wasn't certain. Ranga and the others wouldn't lose, but I couldn't deny the possibility that we were being too optimistic. There was a hint of danger in the castle, so I was worried that they might be struggling. Basically, I only wanted to fight battles that I could definitely win.

But this time, I had not been prepared enough. I didn't anticipate that even the communications would be cut off, and I had come to the battlefield without properly analyzing the enemy's strength. I had a few expectations because of Dino's report, but when we actually fought, I found that the enemy forces were much stronger than expected. For Jahil to overwhelm Benimaru as he did was a foul play. I had been expecting Benimaru to quickly defeat the enemy as usual. And yet, the situation had been so unbelievable that it was even a wonder that he hadn't been defeated...

So, if he was going to retreat here, I had no intention of stopping him. I

had no intention of stopping him—but I would not forget to fan the flames as well.

“Whoa, you’re not thinking of running away now, are you?”

Silvia-san, who was dealing with Leon, turned her attention away from him when she heard that. She was glaring at me as if to tell me to mind my own business. Unlike El-tan, she wasn’t proficient in conversational implicature.²² For this kind of thing, the one who hides their true intentions is the winner. In times of distress, the rule is to deceive your opponent by saying the opposite.

“Hmph, I’ve accomplished my goal of bringing Leon, the owner of the ‘Purity King Metatron,’ into the fold, and I’ve also identified and eliminated the traitor in my way. On top of that, I was able to determine the extent of your abilities. It’s a good result overall.”

Hmm, as expected, he didn’t take this kind of gossip lying down. But that was the main purpose, wasn’t it? By saying something pitiful, the other party will feel good about retreating. For me, it would be more annoying to hear them say something like, ‘yeah, I quit.’ So, while thinking *go home, go home, hurry up and go home!* on the inside, I continued to urge Feldway on.

“So, you’re scared, huh? Well, my people will be coming for you soon. Once they do, we’ll win, so I can understand why you’d want to run!”

While saying that, I launched a fierce attack. Perhaps my words had upset him a little, but Feldway’s sword slowed for a moment. I felt my sword graze his body, but Feldway was unharmed. Was I mistaken? No, no, I feel like I had grazed him a few times before...

“As Noir’s master, you sure are a cocky little bastard. The next time I see you, I’ll crush you with a desperate fighting power, so be prepared.”

“That’s my line! Since you seem to have such an issue with Diablo, I’ll let him deal with you next time!”

“...”

When I spat out a line, sounding as if I came straight out of some crappy manga, Feldway looked mortified. I didn't miss the look of disgust on his face. This was the secret technique, 'leave it to someone else!'

However, it worked so well this time that I was planning to force it on Diablo even if he didn't like it. Well, reading the atmosphere and observing other peoples' reactions are essential skills for working people. If you watch people carefully, you will eventually learn what makes them happy and what makes them uncomfortable. On top of that experience, I had previously worked for over ten years in the construction industry, where socializing was very important, and I was very good at harassing people like this. It was obvious from Feldway's behavior that he had a problem with Diablo. I thought that I might be mistaken, but I was relieved to see that I was correct.

“You really are a jerk, you bastard.”

“I am honored by your praise.”

“—Damn it, you really are getting carried away. Jahil, Leon, we're leaving.”

Feldway escaped from the argument with me and announced his retreat. A victory in spirit—that was a joke, but this was, in fact, a tactical victory.

“Hmm. Wouldn't it be better to settle this here?”

“Ah. It's a command from Michael-sama.”

“—Well, that's fine. I owe you a debt of gratitude. My body doesn't seem to be in the best of shape, so I'll just do as I'm told.”

Jahil had overwhelmed Benimaru, but he grudgingly agreed. To be perfectly honest, I thought it would be troublesome if he had insisted on continuing, so I felt relieved. Or at least I did—Benimaru then started to agitate Jahil.

“Huh, are you running away? I almost had the chance to win, but it was my inexperience that stopped me from finishing you off. I’ll win next time though, you can be sure of that.”

I wondered what in the world he was doing, but I couldn’t complain, since I was the one who started this in the first place.

‘What the hell is wrong with you guys?’ that’s what Silvia-san’s painful glare seemed to say.

I could understand that feeling. From a third person’s point of view, I would have thought that we were idiots, too...

“You don’t know your place in the world, you worm!! If you continue to taunt me, the Great Magician, then I—”

“Jahil, that’s the slime’s right-hand man. If you lose your composure, then you’ll lose a battle you should be able to win.”

Thank you for that misunderstanding! I think he misunderstood by a spoonful or two²³, but if he took things that way, I was happy. For the very first time, I felt that Feldway might be a decent guy. It was probably due to my usual demeanor, but I think I was successful in making him more cautious than necessary.

“Hmm...that’s true. I’ll allow this bastard to save face this time. There won’t be a next time, you brats.”

Jahil seemed short-tempered, but he was surprisingly thoughtful. He had been all ready to go on another rampage, but he followed Feldway’s lead. And Leon, being manipulated as he was, did not argue. Having reached a consensus, the three of them flew away from the broken ceiling and into the sky.

After seeing them off, Benimaru and I sat down on the spot, our strength gone. I personally thought that it was better to be aggressive in a fight, but

this time I had gone too far. I would have to be more careful next time, or it might have the opposite effect. Just as I was thinking about this, Benimaru turned to me, exhausted and complaining.

“Rimuru-sama, it was too dangerous to stir things up in that situation!”

It was full of pent-up emotions that should have been said earlier.

“You have no right to say that! We were just about to settle things, but then you goaded Jahil, and I was left wondering what was going on!”

“No, I was just following Rimuru-sama’s lead. If my lord is not ready to retreat, then I cannot pull the plug myself. Besides, well, I’d feel like I lost if I didn’t do so.”

When I saw Benimaru’s nice smile, I felt like I was seeing his real intention. Then I noticed Silvia-san staring at us with a dumbfounded expression, but Benimaru and I just acted as if nothing had happened.



Vega, who escaped from Ranga, did not think that he had lost. Vega’s fault was that he never reflected on himself, but his positive attitude was still something to learn from. Vega arrived at the battlefield where Kumara and Oria were fighting. He hid his presence and observed the situation. The conclusion of the battle came quickly. Oria had been fatally damaged by Kumara’s tail barrage. Fortunately for Vega, she was blown to the vicinity of where he was hiding.

How lucky. It’s as if the heavens are telling me to eat this thing!

Vega thought selfishly. He had no sense of camaraderie, so there was no honorable moral that urged him to help others. This was especially true if

the person in need was worthless. Vega licked his lips and crept closer to Oria.

“Hey, you look good.”

“Ve-Vega? Thank goodness, that person is stronger than I expected.”

“Looks like it. But don’t worry. I’ll take care of the rest and avenge you.”

Oria wondered if Vega had a soft side, but she was mistaken, and was forced to realize it by the intense pain she felt immediately afterwards. Vega’s gentle touch burned Oria’s skin. He then began to erode and eat Oria.

“Gah, wh-what are you—”

“I’ll eat your soul, so give me that Skill of yours, too. That’s right, with that, I’ll be able to take out those small fry bastards easily.”

“No way, Michael-sama will never forgive you—”

“Shut up! This is a world of survival of the fittest, right? I’m sure that Michael bastard would be more than happy to see me get stronger!”

Vega shouted as such, laughing vulgarly. He then accelerated the erosion, without showing any mercy to the suffering Oria. It eventually reached her neck as he ate Oria to death with a sickening crunch.

“Just what you’d expect from the work of a brute...how very ugly.”

“To me, that’s a compliment.”

In fact, even if eating Oria and her comrades was considered an atrocious act of cruelty to others, for Vega, it was merely a natural means to sustain his life. He followed his instincts and utilized the Ultimate Skill ‘Evil Dragon King Azi Dahaka.’ As a result, Oria was completely decomposed by ‘Organic Domination’ and became Vega’s flesh and blood.

“Wonderful, how wonderful! This power, I can feel myself getting stronger and stronger!”

Vega was ecstatic and tested out the power he had inherited from Oria. The mythical-grade armor covering his entire body, which had been recreated by ‘Metal Manipulation’ of the Blue Dragon Spear he had taken in, glowed in the color of blood. Even his hands, feet, elbows, and knees, were armed like the fangs and claws of a beast. It was at this moment that Vega’s majin form evolved into something even more hideous.

Kumara, who had witnessed such a Vega, was highly alert from the start. The reason why she had thrown Oria out of the fight without finishing her off was because she had lost control when she sensed his persistent gaze. To a certain extent, Vega’s evil presence could not be concealed. As a result, Oria was dead, but Vega had been strengthened. He seemed to have been wounded when he first came here, so this could be considered a complete failure on Kumara’s part.

I’ve failed, haven’t I? What matters is not the quantity, but rather the quality of enemies. I cannot face Rimuru-sama if I allow the enemy to grow stronger.

Inwardly breaking out in a cold sweat, Kumara thought about how to recover. Having been defeated by Karion and then Frey, Kumara was not overconfident in her own abilities. It would have been best if she could have killed Vega here and now, but she knew that it was beyond her control. When one meets a strong opponent, it is necessary to assess their strength. If they failed to do so, the only thing that awaited them was defeat—In other words, death. Kumara sincerely understood that this was unacceptable. Now that she had been taken out of the deathless labyrinth, she could not make the mistake of getting herself killed.

For that reason, although she felt ashamed for allowing Vega to grow stronger, she was able to avoid being dragged into a situation where she might have caused an even bigger mistake. One single decision could make

all the difference. If Kumara had lost her temper and attacked Vega, she would have been beaten back and ‘Predation’ would have been the result. However, Kumara’s decision to wait and see allowed a third party to intervene in the situation.

“We have been ordered to withdraw. Vega, the battle is over.”

A figure suddenly appeared on the scene and stopped Vega, who had been ready to attack. That person was Mai Furuki, who had been standing idly by until then. Feldway ordered her to retrieve everyone, so she had used ‘Instantaneous Movement’ to arrive at Oria’s positional coordinates. However, Oria hadn’t been there, and she had stopped Vega’s outburst by chance. Vega obeyed quietly. He had just gained a great deal of power and instinctively understood that he would not be able to absorb any more food. Thus, Kumara’s crises ended, and the battle was over.

Mai retrieved Vega and went to the place where Arios was dying. His heart had been destroyed by Souei, and Arios was doomed to defeat. However, Arios and the others who had become ‘Yōten’ would not die even without a heart. It was not blood that flowed through their veins, but rather mana, or divine power²⁴, that was the source of their strength. If they became skilled enough, they would be able to control the power at will. However, there was no doubt that being without a heart was a critical situation because it prevented them from exerting any great power. In the case of Arios, the remnants of his human life had not yet been shed, and he was fatally weakened. If nothing was done, he would have been dealt a crushing blow and would have died.

“Who are you?”

Souei, who had jumped back as soon as he sensed the presence, spoke to Mai. It was Vega who answered.

“My name is Vega.²⁵ You should remember this and be grateful that I gave it to such small fry.”

Upon hearing this, Souei wondered if his facade would slip away.²⁶ In all honesty, Souei was aware that he was prone to losing his temper. However, that was a demerit for a covert agent, so he had learned how to separate his head from his heart and turn his anger into energy. Normally, he would be angry, but would also smile coolly and then calmly torture his enemies. This time, however, it seemed to be difficult to do so, because Souei understood at first glance that Vega had become abnormally strong.

This person is...one of the leaders of Cerberus, Vega the Power. What happened in this short period of time that he became so different from the previous findings?

In this world, it was possible for one's power to drastically increase to the extent that they became almost like a whole other person. Rimuru, Souei and the others' Lord, had also experienced the aforementioned 'super-enhancement' such as with his demon lord awakening and the True Dragon conversion. Therefore, Souei also had an understanding of such cases. However, that did not mean that he could so easily accept this. Souei believed that it was necessary to answer the question of what had happened with Vega. But that opportunity was lost. Mai did not want to waste time talking and had quickly withdrawn from the scene.

“...That woman, appearing without any sign and disappearing without any warning...she may be a more troublesome opponent than Vega.”

Souei muttered to himself. Kahn nodded in agreement.

“That was probably a form of ‘Instantaneous Movement.’ Whether it's magic or a Skill, a preliminary step is required to cross through space. To be able to ignore that and jump instantly from the spot without leaving any trace is something impossible even for the primordials. Although it is

theoretically possible, it is a dream-like feat that has yet to be achieved.”

As he walked up to Souei, he gave his reasoning for what Mai had done. Despite his wounds, Kahn’s demeanor remained dignified. As a high-ranking demon of the demon realm, he continued to express his gratitude for Souei’s help. Oxian came over and thanked him along with Kahn.

“There is need to thank me. I was merely following Rimuru-sama’s orders.”

Even though the two men had thanked him, Souei was not satisfied. For Souei, allowing the enemy to escape was a huge loss.

“—Besides, we failed to eliminate that Arios guy. Because of that, we now must assume that our information has been leaked to the enemy, and a harder battle will have to be fought the next time. We’ve achieved our tactical goal of survival, but I don’t think we can be too happy about this.”

While Souei responded with his usual matter-of-fact manner, Kahn and Oxian looked at each other. From their point of view, they were just grateful to have survived this moment. However, Souei could not afford that luxury, so it was natural for him to be wary of what might happen next. At any rate, just like their opponents, they had obtained information about the enemy. Based on this information, Souei thought it necessary to rethink his strategy for the future, and while reflecting on his failure, he changed his mindset.



The battle was over. The forces that had been fighting outside the castle withdrew as soon as Feldway had, and they all left the scene. That’s why we were all gathering to meet in the conference room, where it was now

safe.

Benimaru and I participated, along with Souei. Diablo as well. The knight captains of Leon's forces were also there. And Guy and the other demons. There was also the mysterious helper Silvia-san, Elmesia's mother, who joined in. Not to be forgotten was the important witness, ex-demon lord Kazalim, aka Kagali.

I succeeded in using 'Isolation' on her at the very last moment, so she was not seriously injured. However, Teare, who had been protecting Kagali, was badly injured. Because the recovery potion was not working on her, Maetel-san, the leader of the White Knights who specialized in recovery, was currently taking care of her in the hospital room. The only way to overcome an attack of the ultimate level was through one's own will. I could only pray for Teare's recovery.

Well, I was worried about Teare, but there was not much I could do about it. What mattered now was the future, which was why we were here. Each of us would report to the others and share any information about the enemy. The goal was to review our strategies for the future.

As soon as our eyes met, a certain someone came right at me.

"Rimuru-kun—"

It was Guy. He seemed to be holding a grudge against me for ignoring him on the battlefield, and I was positive he only had complaints, so I decided to use my 'It-never-happened' skill to the fullest and cover it up.

"You bastard, how dare you ignore me that time!"

"N-no, I didn't! I have no idea what you mean by ignoring you."

"You were looking right at me!"

"I-i didn't notice you at all. More importantly, I'm just glad that everyone's okay!"

“Hey, don’t just change the subject. Besides, Leon’s been taken away, so there’s no way that everyone’s okay!”

That’s true. But still, we had already taken that into account, right?

“Now, now, things are still on schedule with Leon.”

“You mean the plan that you were talking about before? I can’t help but think you’re just pushing off the problem, are you really sure about this?”

“Maybe...”

Guy glared at me. Regarding Leon, I had actually thought of a plan beforehand. As Ciel-san had suggested, using ‘Predation’ on Leon, and destroying the ‘control circuit’ itself, was a surefire countermeasure. The main reason I didn’t do that was not because I believed in Leon—rather, I didn’t like the idea, physiologically speaking. That was not a joke...but there were other reasons.

The first reason was to avoid alarming Michael. By leaving Leon here, I wanted Michael to think that there was nothing we could do against him. The second reason was the “hope for the best” strategy.

“But you agreed when we discussed it, didn’t you? If Leon, who is under the enemy’s control, comes back to his senses after attacking, we can turn the power gap upside down.”

“Well, yeah. I agree that it’s a reasonable plan, assuming that Leon is safe. If we can get to the point where Leon is attacking, that alone would give us an advantage.”

That’s what I was thinking. He was right about me pushing off the problem, and there was still the question of whether or not I’d be able to conveniently get there, but if this went well, we could easily take out one of the enemies. Regardless of the number of troops, if we could replace Leon’s strength with our own, the battle would be as good as won. As soon as Ciel-san suggested that, I had made up my mind. In any case, the die had been

cast. Now that Leon had been taken, I had no choice but to act with faith in the success of the mission.

“Um, is Leon-sama going to be okay?”

Alrose asked, and I gave him a big nod in response.

“We have the means to free him, so don’t worry.”

It would be bad if he was suddenly executed, but I didn’t think Michael would do such a nonsensical thing. That was also why I had approved Ciel-san’s plan.

“Either way, we are out of options. Let’s trust His Majesty Rimuru. So then, here’s the plan.”

Claude-san spoke and re-established the situation. Guy still seemed dissatisfied, but this achieved my goal of diverting the conversation.

“Never mind Leon, then. But Rimuru-kun, you definitely made eye contact with me back then, didn’t you?”

Damn it, this guy...he just won’t let it go.

“Um, what are you talking about?”

“Don’t you dare play dumb with me! You bastard, I was having such a hard time dealing with Velzard, and you just ran away without even pretending to help me!”

“I didn’t run away. I trusted you, you know!”

“Hah? As always, you’re such a smooth talker. The point is, if you had just quickly come to the rescue, we wouldn’t have had to go through all that trouble!”

Hold on, none of that was my fault.

“Whoa, whoa, what are you saying when you’re the ones who didn’t contact us? We were on alert and responded as quickly as possible.”

“Hah? Isn’t that what the magic transfer circle was for?!”

“It didn’t activate! I mean, shouldn’t you have been able to make a call

with this ring under any circumstances?”

That’s right, I was told that the Demon’s Ring, which I had received upon becoming a demon lord, would allow me to contact the others under all circumstances. And yet, neither Guy nor Leon had contacted me. If Dino hadn’t told me, the response might have been delayed even further. I hoped that he would consider that a bit more.

“Ah, that’s right. That ring was made by Velzard, so she could easily sabotage it. Sorry, I forgot about that.”

Uh, well if he says that so openly, I can’t really say anything back...

“Um, yeah. Well then, let’s just say that it was both of our faults this time.”

“You’re right. It would be a problem if there was any conflict between us, so let’s stop fighting right now.”

So that’s what we did. There were still a few things I wasn’t clear on, but honestly speaking, it was too much trouble to argue further. I would just be the adult this time. But enough of that.

“So, why are these people sitting on the floor²⁷?”

The people I was staring at were Raine and Mizeri. For some reason, they had been forced to sit on the floor the moment they were called into the room. Incidentally, Leon’s castle was made of stone, so the floor was completely covered with marble. It was difficult to sit upright even on tatami mats, so sitting upright on the floor in such a place seemed quite strenuous.

“Oh, those guys. Do you want to hear about it?”

If you ask me if I want to hear about it, I’ll only feel troubled. Guy’s eyes were kind of scary, and I didn’t want to get involved.

“Oh, I’m not interested in—”

“Actually, these two dumbasses were having fun drinking while we were

all fighting desperately. I'm also a little pissed off, so I'm trying to figure out what to do."

I said I wasn't interested in hearing about it, but I think Guy just wanted to complain. Or rather, did they seriously do that?

"Is that really true?"

I asked, not to Guy, but to Raine and the others. Mizeri remained distant and silent, but Raine appealed to me with tears in her eyes.

"No, it's not. It's a tragic misunderstanding, Rimuru-sama."

As soon as I heard that, I understood. It was not a misunderstanding.

"Don't listen to her. You'll soil your ears."

"Okay. We don't have much time anyway, so let's just hurry and exchange information."

I jumped in at Guy's words. The others, who had been watching our conversation, seemed to be silent on the matter. Diablo was the only one who shook his head in disgust, but he didn't seem to want to interfere. So, we left Raine crying and Mizeri looking like an idiot and got straight down to business.



It was now time to listen to everyone's opinions in order. Although there had been a tangent in the middle, the report went by smoothly. Incidentally, the aforementioned tangent was the exchange made by Kahn and Misora when they reported. When it was their turn, Kahn and Oxian stood up, but then Kahn had turned from everyone and bowed to Guy to relay his wish.

"Under normal circumstances, I understand that it would be an

unforgivable sin to speak to our master, the Red King (Rouge). However, I beg of you to listen to me.”

He was so sincere that Guy allowed him to speak. In response, Kahn requested, “Can you please forgive my lord Mizeri-sama’s iniquity?”

I agreed with him. She had been sitting upright on the floor for the entire discussion. She was probably okay because she was a demon, but I was still wondering when it would be time to let her go. However, it wasn’t Guy who became enraged, but Mizeri, the one who was being punished.

“Kahn! You fool. It is unforgivable—”

She tried to reprimand Kahn with great force even as she was sitting on the floor. It was Guy who stopped her.

“Now, hold on a minute. You’ve grown up, Kahn, for being able to talk to me. Fine then. For that, I’ll let Mizeri off the hook this time.”

True to his word, Guy forgave Mizeri and ordered everyone to have a drink. That was all well and good, but then came a new problem. As you can imagine, Raine, who was still sitting on the floor, did the same thing. Now it was Misora’s turn to stand up and speak, and like Kahn, she wished for her master Raine to be released. But Guy wouldn’t allow it.

It didn’t seem to be for a petty reason, such as it being the “second version.” I’m also pretty good at reading the atmosphere, so I could tell that Guy was annoyed. I think Misora noticed it too, and when he said no, she quickly backed off. Knowing when to back off was a sign of competence. It made me think that Misora was a very capable person, unlike what I’d expect from Raine’s subordinate. However...

There are also people who can’t read the atmosphere.

“Why is that, Misora?! Why do you give up so easily when you’re so much better than Kahn? You have to try harder to help me! Why am I the only one sitting on the floor while Mizeri is free? I don’t get it!!”

And on and on she went.

I was convinced. As I thought, Raine possessed the unconstrained self-indulging trait of the youngest child. Misora admonished Raine.

“Please give up. If you continue committing more crimes—”

Finally, Raine seemed to have calmed down after being told that much. She glanced at Guy and seemed to understand that she was in a bad position.

“You should be a little more sincerely sorry, you know. Do you understand what you did wrong in the first place?”

“Yes?”

When Guy asked her about it, Raine tilted her head with a blank expression. It was cute, but now that I had seen her true nature, all I could sense was annoyance. Guy spoke to Raine with a deeply tired expression.

“I don’t have time for this, but I’ll be the one in trouble if I let you get away with your misdeeds. Those empty bottles lying around the igloo, they’re rare and expensive liquors, aren’t they? How did you get them? It doesn’t look like you stole them, or did you mug one of your subordinates again?”

Um, if she’s even doing that, then she’s definitely a bad child. Or rather, why would a demon even mug someone? Even without committing such petty crimes, she didn’t seem to have any money troubles...

While I was thinking about that, Misora interrupted me, as if she couldn’t stand to watch anymore.

“May I be allowed to speak?”

“You may.”

With Guy’s permission, Misora defended Raine.

“Even our lord, as expected, she is not that clever.”

“N-not that clever...”

Raine was about to say something, but everyone ignored her. This incident reminded me of the importance of daily conduct.

“But at the very least, she is someone who does things for a reason, so you can trust her on that point.”

“Hmm.”

“In the first place, it wasn’t money that Raine-sama needed.”

“Hm? Then how did this guy—”

Although he didn’t listen to Raine’s words, he was taking Misora’s plea seriously. Seeing him like that made me feel that Guy was surprisingly decent. And then something strange happened here.

“Now, now, that should be enough of that, correct? We are in the middle of an important conversation about the future, and Raine’s punishment is insignificant.”

And then Diablo took Raine by the shoulders. It was so blatantly unnatural that not only me, but also Guy, was staring at Diablo.

“I can still believe in Diablo after all!”

Raine’s eyes were sparkling as she spoke, as if she was impressed, while the others were just confused. Something is going on. My gut was telling me so.

“That’s suspicious.”

Guy seemed to agree, muttering to himself.

“Diablo, it’s not good to keep secrets, okay?”

“Kufu, kufufufu. Rimuru-sama, I would never hide anything from Rimuru-sama.²⁸ However, that person seemed so pitiful that I felt that I should offer a little help.”

No, no, no, you don’t have that kind of personality—I almost said that out loud, but I held myself back and swallowed it. Instead, I just stared at him. This was very effective in such situations. And sure enough, Diablo’s

eyes began to waver. I had thought that he was a demon with a weak mind, but it turned out that I was right. He immediately became flustered and told the truth.

“No, that fine liquor was actually a gift from me to Raine...”

“Hah?”

“That’s crazy. No matter how much of an agreement you two came to, why would you give Raine something when you’ve been in conflict until not too long ago?”

That was absolutely correct. Well, but now I knew why Diablo confessed so easily. As long as we had the finished liquor bottle as physical evidence, we could quickly determine the distribution route. Souei was here as well, so he must have decided that it would be impossible to keep quiet about it. That was all well and good, but the real problem was the relationship with the culprit (Raine).

While Guy and Diablo were quarreling, I gave Souei a look. He understood what I was asking and promptly secured the evidence. I saw empty bottles of magic black rice amazake,²⁹ traditional Japanese sake, black rice refined sake³⁰, and many other products, all of which had increasingly higher alcohol content. A person couldn’t buy this stuff even if they paid a lot of money, because it was not available on the market. It was only available in our country, so even if it wasn’t Souei who was investigating, one could easily identify the culprit. I mean, come on...

“Uh, you mentioned that you were having a drink earlier, did you actually drink this much?”

“That’s right. It’s only natural that I was mad, right? You have to do something about them, Rimuru.”

Well, of course that would make someone angry.

“Are you kidding me?! Everyone else is working, and we’re the only

ones...?”

I didn't think I'd end up feeling sorry for Guy, but it was the boss's job to clean up after his subordinates. I was actually surprised that Guy was so forgiving, only making them sit upright on the floor. And yet, Raine was making excuses.

“You're wrong. This was a necessary item for advanced psychological warfare, and we weren't trying to have fun on our own!”

“Psychological warfare?”

“Yes, that's right. I went through a lot of trouble to acquire these items so that Pico and Gracia would speak up. In fact, I think I deserve a pat on the back!”

This kid was incredible. Even in this situation, she was insisting that it was all her own achievements...

She's a primordial demon, after all. Her mental strength was nothing to sniff at. Diablo also seemed to adhere to the theory that as long as you didn't admit defeat, you hadn't lost, so I guess they were similar at heart.

“So, Diablo, I'm curious as well. I don't think you would give something to Raine for free, so what kind of a deal did you make?”

I would leave it to Guy to judge Raine's claim, and I would pursue Diablo's involvement.

“W-well, that's...”

He seemed to think that he couldn't lie to me, and was slurring his words, but that didn't last long. After all, Souei was there, too.

“Get on with it.”

Souei's words were enough to make Diablo give up. He confessed that he had been supplying the items in question in return for Raine's share of paintings.

“I see, so the unknown artist who was distributing my paintings was

Raine...”

“That makes sense...”

That was why we couldn’t trace her. But it seemed that my wild guess, that Diablo could be an accomplice to the portrait crime, was wrong. I couldn’t blame him if he was only supplying goods because it was a valid act. However, I didn’t intend to leave my portraits unattended, so I let Souei deal with it.

“Please rest assured. I have already ordered Souka to search Diablo’s room.”

“Isn’t that a bit excessive?”

“No. It infringes upon his publicity rights and is a serious crime deserving of punishment. A search warrant has already been issued, so there are no problems.”

What quick work! As expected, it could only be Souei. Diablo was crumbling in shock, but I pretended not to see it.



While Souei and I were solving the mystery, Raine was finishing her explanation to Guy. It was both annoying and surprising because it was really useful information. She told us where the enemy’s base was, and about the forces that had been gathered. Although I was not sure how much of it could be trusted, she seemed to have gleaned quite a bit of useful information. Above all, the information she provided at the end was very important. Even I, who had just been listening to the conversation, turned to Raine.

“—That’s how I got the information out of them! Then, it seemed that the battle was over, and Pico said, ‘Oh, I was contacted by Feldway. He’s leaving now,’ so I ended the girls’ party—no, I mean, I ended the interrogation!”

Putting aside the fact that her true feelings were obvious, Raine’s story was too important to ignore. It was Pico’s reaction that was important. As a result of Michael’s complete control, Leon had fallen to the enemy. Diablo’s report also confirmed that Zalario had been taken over in the process. And yet, Pico and Gracia were not under control. Otherwise, it would be difficult to explain why they had been enjoying the girls’ party until the very end. This brought me to a conclusion. Michael’s control might not be effective in ‘Isolation.’ This was very reliable information.

Perhaps, whether it was through visibility or ‘Magic Perception,’ the control was effective only when the object was recognized. In that case, if the controlled person left Michael’s sphere of control, there was a high possibility that he would not be able to recognize whether the control had been established or not. If he periodically issued orders via ‘Telepathy Net’ and checked whether the orders were carried out properly or not, he might not have such suspicions. However, if Leon was secretly released on the battlefield where Michael was not present, it would be possible to decide the outcome of the battle before the enemy knew about it. I glanced at Guy, who was also looking at me.

“I think Raine’s achievements are significant.”

When I said that, Guy nodded reluctantly.

“Yeah. She’s a dumbass, and is useless during crucial times, but she also does things in ways I don’t expect. I hate to admit it, but that’s what she’s done this time.”

I didn’t like to admit it either, but there are just some people in this

world who are good at what they do. Even when they look like they're fooling around, they still end up getting results. These were the so-called "genius" types, and recognizing the work of these people would always be a test of ability to those who were in charge. Taking away the achievements of others would be a problem, but otherwise, they should be evaluated properly.

Raine was listening to our conversation, but her eyes were moistened, as if she realized that she was going to be saved. I could even feel her gratitude towards me.

'That's Rimuru-sama for you,' I could practically hear the voice of her heart. No, she was talking about it out loud.

"After all, I knew that Rimuru-sama would understand the real me. Rimuru-sama, if there is anything you need from me in the future, please let me know!"

Even if she was saying that with such a firm expression, the moment was ruined because she was still sitting on the floor like that. That kind of thing was no good. I realized once again that Raine was a no-good child, even if that wasn't literally true.

"You'll make Guy angry if you keep acting like that. You should reflect on yourself more."

I couldn't help but give her my sincere advice. However, I still had to admit that an achievement was an achievement. Raine's actions were not praiseworthy, but she did produce results. In that case, there was no need for further punishment.

"'Sure punishment or reward'³¹ is what they say, so why don't we just let her go?"

"That's true. I guess I'll let it go this time."

I nodded to Guy. Thus, Raine's freedom was decided.

After being released from her floor sitting, Raine was being congratulated by Misora and the others. Mizeri, who had brought tea, spoke to Raine in a dumbfounded tone.

“I admit that you are a child capable of many things, but I wish you would change your usual attitude a little more.”

Raine was proud to hear that.

“Fufufu. How about that, Misora? Even Mizeri praised me. A capable woman like me, even when I try to hide it, my abilities can’t help but come out in full force.”

As I listened to this exchange, I thought to myself. This kid, she’s no-good. Guy seemed to agree.

“‘*A child capable of many things*’ is not a compliment, you know?”

He spat out gravely. Until recently, I had thought she was an excellent maid from the first few times I saw her, but she really must be a big deal to make Guy feel so troubled...

While we were left feeling resigned, Raine and her subordinates were having a great time.

“Well done, Raine-sama!”

Why does this Misora girl always stir things up? This is why Raine is always getting carried away. I was getting a sense of déjà vu...it was that. This was just like how Treyni-san was with Ramiris. She must have grown up to be a no-good child because she was always being spoiled like that. As for Raine, it seemed to be too late to correct her, even if we re-educated her from now on. So, at the very least, I decided to educate Ramiris so that she would not become like Raine.



Well, we went off on an unexpected tangent, but the discussion itself went smoothly. And so, I will summarize what we learned about the enemy situation. Vega, who was supposed to be one of Yuuki's friends, seems to have gained power and become much more powerful. Ranga intervened just as Misora and the others were in danger, and somehow managed to fight him off. However, Vega had eaten the enemy named Oria that Kumara defeated, and rapidly healed his injuries and improved his fighting ability.

The exact numbers were unknown, but if we compare only the existence values, he seems to be stronger than both Ranga and Kumara. He apparently had a vulgar character, flattering to the strong and intimidating to the weak. However, he also seemed to have excellent survival instincts, having survived to this point and acquiring great power, despite all odds. My impression of him was that he would be a very troublesome opponent.

Incidentally, Oria had apparently been able to create mythical-grade equipment with her own Skill. Unlike Velgrynd, Oria seems to have only materialized her weapons, but they hadn't disappeared when she was eaten by Vega. This was the testimony of Fran and Kizona, the Knight Captains under Leon, and I also checked with Kumara, so I believed it to be correct.

In other words, Vega must have inherited the 'Weapon Creation' Skill. This kind of problem was the type that became more dangerous if left unattended, so I thought that it would be better to deal with him as soon as possible. I, myself, am a similar type of person, so this was something I felt with a real sense of reality.

The warrior whom Souei defeated by surprise was named Arios. Unfortunately, he had escaped before he could be finished off. It was a rare mistake for Souei, but it seemed to be unavoidable after hearing his story. After all, there was a user of 'Instantaneous Movement' on the enemy side. Kahn also testified to this. It was not magic, but a Skill. The ability to jump

through space without any preliminary movement was troublesome because it was difficult to measure the strength numerically. If she had mastered this Skill, we might be caught off guard. The fact that we had found out in advance that there was such a person on the enemy's side was a big gain.

The girl's name was Mai Furuki, and it seems that we would have to rethink our strategy to take her skill into account. So far, those four people were the weakest of the enemies, but they still had given us a lot of trouble.

Some of them, like Raine's drinking buddies Pico and Gracia, had been reluctant to follow, but it seems that Michael's 'Ultimate Dominion' had turned them into our enemies. Well, I'm sure Ciel-san would be able to do something about it, but that would require a certain procedure. There was still the possibility that the control could be broken by one's own will, so we would have to carefully assess the enemy. And then there were the serious enemies.

Velzard, Zalario, and Feldway. There was no other word to use for them but threatening. I had actually fought Feldway, so I understood how strong he was. He didn't seem like he was serious about it, so I really thought it would be best to leave it to Diablo. And so, I would postpone my talk about Feldway for later.

"By the way, Guy-san, is Velzard-san going to be okay?"

"Bastard, you didn't even come to help. You're talking as if you're somebody else..."

"No, no, no, that was more of a lovers' quarrel, and I didn't think a third party was needed."

"Quit screwing around!"

You know what they say, "not even a dog will bite into a lovers' quarrel!"³² If I say this out loud, he might get seriously angry, so I told him so in my mind. When I asked him what he really thought about everything,

he replied as if he was fed up with it all.

“Well, you’re not completely out of your mind. It feels like she’s full of pent-up resentment, and her main goal is to harass me.”

It seems that Guy had been desperately trying not to let this country disappear.

“Normally, I’d create an ‘alternate space’ and fight there, but even I can’t control Velzard. It doesn’t matter if she agrees to it, it’s impossible for me to impose something of my own convenience onto her.”

Indeed, I didn’t think that the ‘Barrier’ used at Walpurgis was going to be able to control Velzard. I’m sure there were more powerful techniques, but Guy seems to have decided that it was still too difficult.

“Well then, I guess Guy-san’s role will be a tough one.”

“Hey, wait—”

“It’s too much for us to handle, so for this, we’ll let Guy-san show us what he’s made of!”

Guy was about to say something, but I ignored him and went on with the conversation. My instincts told me that if I didn’t, I would surely be caught in the middle of it all. It was worth it, because Guy seemed to be convinced, although he was glaring at me resentfully. I was relieved to see that and switched my thoughts to the next enemy.

“So, Diablo. How did it go with Zalario?”

“Kufufu, to be honest, Zalario is a strong opponent. If we compare on simple strength alone, he might even be better than Feldway.”

“Seriously?”

“Yes. Feldway will come to you if you encourage him, but Zalario is a cold-hearted warrior. Psychological warfare does not work on him. He’s a very uninteresting opponent, but that is why we have to play to our strengths.”

Guy agreed with this.

“Yeah. Zalario’s always been strong, unlike Cornu and the others. He was quite useful in the fight against the ‘World-destroying Dragon’ Ivarage.”

I see. So, he’s a solid opponent who is hard to upset. No matter the world, I guess it’s common knowledge that the strongest are those whose minds can remain undisturbed. If an opponent runs away as soon as they are about to lose a battle, they are not a threat, no matter how strong they are. On the other hand, an opponent who does not give up no matter how difficult the situation is troublesome because you cannot let your guard down against them until the very end. In that sense, Cornu was the former, and Zalario was the latter.

Especially in the case of Cornu, he had a good lieutenant whom Guy paid more attention to than Cornu. Now that Cornu and his team had been wiped out, there was no point in talking about them here. In any case, it’s clear that Zalario was a threat. Then, Diablo started saying something interesting.

“However, right after Feldway reappeared, his movements became monotonous. Something must have happened to him.”

Diablo was suspicious and had kept a watchful eye on him. As a result, he concluded that it was not a trap but some kind of anomaly. What was interesting was the fact that it was just after Feldway’s move. What was Feldway’s purpose in the first place?

“He didn’t participate in Kagali and the others’ battle, right?”

“Yes, that’s correct. As soon as I saw Feldway, I was put under Michael’s control, but Feldway himself kept a watchful eye on me.”

Hearing this, Benimaru and I looked at each other. If Feldway had entered the battle earlier, we would not have made it in time and Kagali

would have been killed. If that had happened, Silvia-san would have been in danger. It was unnatural that he didn't make a move, and unless he had no intention of doing anything, there was no need to go to the place where Kagali and the others were fighting...

So then, why did he need to move?

"There must have been a purpose, right?"

"I suppose so. I mean—"

"Hmm. One possibility is that our speculation was correct."

As soon as I thought of it, Guy nodded, looking convinced. I hated to admit it, but that was the only explanation I could think of.

"I suppose we should assume that Feldway can also use the Ultimate Dominion."

It was Diablo who said this. Guy was not happy, as if Diablo had said it before he could.

"What do you mean?"

It was Silvia-san who asked, but Kagali seemed to be thinking about it as if she had something in mind. After pondering for a while, she opened her mouth.

"Um, I don't expect for you to believe my opinion, but..."

Kagali seemed to understand that she was in a delicate position and started the conversation in that way. However, Guy denied it outright.

"I believe you, Kazalim. So don't hold back."

Guy seemed to have recognized Kagali as the ex-demon lord Kazalim at first glance. And yet, he was ready to listen to her without a care in the world. In a way, this was the moment when I realized that Guy was a big deal.

"You're still as confident as ever, Guy. I'm not a demon lord anymore. So, I'll just be Kagali."

With a small smile, Kagali began to speak her thoughts.



To summarize Kagali's story, she had free will before Feldway's arrival, and she had made plans to betray him after consulting with Leon in secret. After walking a tightrope of a battle, Feldway showed up just as she was about to jump into the 'magic transfer circle.' Immediately after that, she was taken over without even being allowed to resist. The timing was so bad that it could only be described as bad luck.

Yuuki had apparently regained his self-awareness, so it would have been a perfectly happy ending if they could have escaped to our country. However, it was meaningless to talk about that now, as it was a hypothetical story. In any case, there was no doubt that there was a close relationship between Feldway and the domination. In other words, the credibility of Diablo's reasoning had increased, but I didn't like to admit that, so I presented a negative possibility.

"The problem is the condition for triggering the 'Ultimate Dominion.' Michael seems to be able to transfer certain powers, and it may be possible to activate it from a distance as long as someone can see you."

In my case, I was able to exert a certain amount of power over the area I could see through the Argus spell. This was one of the secret techniques that I wanted to keep secret as much as possible, since it allowed me to take people by surprise from a great distance. However, I should have realized that what I could do, others could do as well. That's what I was thinking, but Guy denied it.

“Hmm. It’s possible, but if it’s a spatial power, or even a power that affects the mind, I think the conditions for activating it would be more severe.”

I was convinced that was the case. As I had said many times, ‘Spatial Transportation’ required one to know the positional coordinates of the destination. If you could get that information, then you could influence the area around the coordinates as an application. Or, if you know the positional coordinates, it is easy to activate the spell. When I think about it, it makes me feel vain that I was so happy when I said it was a secret technique.

In the first place, Feldway was not the only one who was Michael’s eye, and it was strange that Kagali was free when Michael gave her the power. In other words, it is probably because of Obara’s betrayal that Michael became more cautious. If he had been able to activate the ‘Ultimate Dominion’ when he became more alert, he would not have needed to rely on Feldway. But since that was not the case, there must be a reason why Feldway was Michael’s eye. Then...was Feldway given the Ultimate Dominion, as Diablo said? Or—

«This is a speculation, but Michael has taken in Velgrynd’s dragon factor. If so, it would not be surprising if he was able to utilize her ‘Parallel Existence’ ability.»

Ah, so that’s a possibility. I had thought that a certain level of control could be lent to him, but I hadn’t expected him to have duplicated all of the abilities. Nevertheless, I could not ignore Ciel-san’s opinion, and now it really felt as if I was dealing with Michael. In that light, it certainly explained why he could use the Ultimate Dominion. On the contrary, he could even use Castle Guard, so it was no wonder that my attacks were

completely unsuccessful. He had been bluffing when he blocked my sword, and he actually hadn't even needed to defend himself. I was really relieved that I didn't show off my secret techniques.

"What Guy says is correct, but if Feldway can use the same powers as Michael, doesn't that explain what happened?"

"Huh? So Michael was ceding his power to Feldway?"

"No, not that. I'm saying, as much as I hate to admit it, that both of them can utilize the same powers."

"What? What the hell are you talking about—no, so it's that! Velgrynd's 'Parallel Existence'?!"

That's Guy for you. He understood what I was trying to say so easily. Guy and I both frowned at that unpleasant speculation. I was hoping to be mistaken, but that was also why I definitely thought it to be the case.

"It looks like they weren't all taken over at the same time, so that's fortuitous."

The fact that the effects of control did not occur at the same time was obvious from the fact that there was a time lag between Zalario's domination and the domination over Leon and Kagali. In addition, the extent of the influence of control was also limited. This was evidenced not only by the difference between the inside and outside the castle, but also by the fact that Pico and Gracia, who had been in Isolation from the outside world with the igloo, were not taken over until later. Leaving aside the pros and cons of the "igloo," this information was valuable. That was because it confirmed that domination could not be achieved unless it was recognized by some means.

"Ah. Raine and the others slacked off, but it was still a worthwhile achievement. It proves once and for all that you must be able to recognize your opponent in order to dominate them."

Guy seemed to agree with me and said so in a dissatisfied tone. The reevaluation of Raine certainly seemed to be a touchy subject. But, well, this allowed us to correctly evaluate the enemy.

“Um, I can’t keep up with this conversation at all...”

I briefly explained to Silvia-san, who raised her hand in a reserved manner. El-tan was terrifyingly sharp, but Silvia-san didn’t seem to be the same way. Or perhaps I was comparing her to the wrong people. Leon’s knight captains didn’t seem to be able to follow our conversation either. To begin with, Leon’s subordinates were a different story. It didn’t matter how smart they were. In the first place, without an Ultimate Skill, it would be impossible for one to understand this conversation.

As one could see from the fact that El-tan had founded a country as the celestial emperor, it meant that Silvia-san’s daughter had a certain savvy over her. In fact, while Silvia-san is said to be stronger than El-tan in terms of strength, El-tan is said to be more insightful and adaptable. It went without saying that El-tan had the political strength, so they were able to share their roles properly. And so, while explaining the situation to Silvia-san and others, I tried to sort out the situation in my own way.

It was likely that Michael was duplicating his powers and giving them to Feldway. So, in effect, Feldway could not be defeated without breaking through the ‘Castle Guard.’ And because he could probably utilize not only the Ultimate Dominion but also the control system, it was impossible for anyone but an Ultimate Skill user to defeat him. In that case, the number of people who could take on Feldway and Michael would be limited.

“Well, it’s not all bad.”

“Oh?”

“My attacks didn’t work at all against Feldway, but I feel better now that I understand why. Moreover, Velgrynd told me that the ability is fueled by

loyalty to the master. When Rudra used it, he was invincible as long as there were Imperial subjects, but that has nothing to do with Feldway. His subjects are probably Phantoms, so it makes me feel a little less guilty.”

Killing innocent people in the Empire was honestly too much for me. Well, actually, if that was really the only way, I guess I had to accept that the happiness of the many would come from the sacrifice of the few... I thought I was prepared to do it, but I wasn't completely sure if I would. I think I may have just been bluffing with Michael, but I didn't think I could have actually done it.

The Phantoms are invaders, so they must be prepared to die. Therefore, it would be polite for me to resist with all my might, and my conscience would not be hurt. When I expressed my feelings straightforwardly, Guy was taken aback.

“Ha! Are you still talking so naively? Well, it's true, but if you overthink things, you'll be the one who dies.”

I even got some friendly advice from him, but I thought that Guy was surprisingly lenient to his people.



Now that we had discussed the main enemies, there was still one left.

“So, who is this Jahil?”

“That's the guy I had been dealing with. To be honest, I thought I had gotten pretty strong, but that guy was surprisingly powerful. I barely survived because we shared the same attributes.”

When I brought up the question, Benimaru took a stab at it. He has

always had a cool personality, yet he was praising Jahil, his enemy. Well, he wasn't praising him exactly, he was just accurately analyzing the enemy's strength...

"It's rare for Benimaru to honestly admit defeat."

"No, I didn't lose though? It's just that I can't easily say that I'll win the next time."

I wondered about that, but was relieved to see that Benimaru's confidence was still intact. However, if there was more than a fourfold difference in the estimated existence value, a slight difference in ability will not be enough to overturn it. Benimaru had gone through a lot of training to reach his current level of skill, so it was unlikely that he would grow rapidly from here...

«...»

Well, as long as he didn't lose heart, he could stand up and face them. On the other hand, I had to be careful not to let Benimaru do anything rash. Guy, for example, seemed to like Benimaru, and said, 'That's the spirit!' Then, as if remembering something, he suddenly muttered.

"Hm? Come to think of it, what was the name of the bastard who summoned me?"

This was answered by Mizeri and Raine.

"It was a lowlife bastard who called himself the Great Magician Jahil, the head of state of the Great Magic Empire."

"That ba³³—he was a high human created by the Divine Ancestor. I think even the Divine Ancestor considered him a failure because of his mental problems."

It's said that he was killed after summoning Guy a long time ago, and he

was mentioned in various grimoires and history books. The books I saw in Ingracia didn't mention him by name, but his reckless misfortune made him quite famous as a fool who unleashed the worst demon onto the world. That demon was the primordial—that is, demons like Guy and Diablo and the others, so it was understandable that El-tan and Gazel were wary of them. But now, it was no use worrying about them.

The worst of them, Guy-san, has become one of us. Also, the said fool's name was Jahil, which couldn't be a coincidence. While I was pondering over this, Kagali said something surprising.

“It can't be...that Jahil, he was definitely my father.”

She said that Feldway had protected Jahil, who had lost his body and had become a wandering soul and had incarnated him in Footman. According to her conversation with Jahil, there was no doubt that he was Kagali's father. However, Silvia-san objected to this.

“No, no, that can't be right, can it? He admitted that he and I are colleagues. He was the first highborn brother of the Divine Ancestor, and I was the third. By the way, Luminas-chan was the second.”

Jahil is the ancestor of the high humans created by the Divine Ancestor. And naturally, the true ancestor of the vampires is Luminas. So, the ancestor of the high elves is Silvia-san, I guess? It's said that there were other highborns, but they are not known to exist now. They are said to have disappeared into history like Jahil. Incidentally, Gazel's grandfather, Gran Dwargo, the first Hero King of the dwarf race, was a kind of ancestor who inherited the blood of the High Dwarf and was a close friend of Silvia-san. For long-lived species, even historical figures were acquaintances. Silvia-san and Guy were like living witnesses of such history. I didn't think it was wrong to say that.

“Eh? My father was definitely a high elf...”

Kagali was puzzled, but she understood that her perception was more unreliable. She was trying to figure out why there was such a discrepancy. And the conclusion arrived at the same time.

“My father, by Jahil was—”

“He was taken over by Jahil, then.”

“Well, what can I say, that guy was a lowlife bastard. It’s no wonder Raine and Mizeri couldn’t get rid of him, but that seems to have caused a problem.”

That is what Kagali, me, and Guy had to say about it. With the three of us in agreement, Jahil’s identity had been confirmed.

“So then, my father is...”

Kagali muttered, leaning back in her chair. Unsure of what to say to her, we decided to leave the room quietly.



And then, it was night. Guy and I moved to another place to have a drink together. By the way, the drinks being served were the ones I kept in my ‘Stomach.’ It was the result of Guy’s forceful insistence that I prepare the same drinks that Raine and the others had been enjoying. I wanted to tell him to shove it, but I was a sucker for things that would last. It was too tedious and tiring for me to defend myself against Guy, so I decided to give in and sell him the favor.

Diablo, Benimaru, Souei, Raine and Mizeri were also present at the party. Another person, Silvia-san, was also present, and the secret late-night meeting proceeded quietly. What would we do with this country now that

Leon was gone? That was the content of this secret discussion.

Since we had been able to ascertain the enemy's strength during the daytime meeting, we were now reconfirming our future plan. The damage to the town was not too bad, but Leon's castle was badly damaged, and there were people who had nowhere to go. It was a problem that there was no place to receive the refugees. The general consensus of the knight captains was to stay in the country and rebuild the town and castle, but if the Aggressors were to target this place, it would be difficult to deal with it. They would not be able to stop them from overrunning the place because they did not have enough forces to fight them. Now that Leon was gone, the probability of this place being targeted was low, but even so, I didn't think we should do nothing about it.

"If they're going to stay, why don't we just let them do what they want?"

That was Guy's opinion. I'm the one who was against it because it was dangerous.

"But you know, there's no point in just talking about ideals, right? You can ask El-chan, but I don't think Sarion will accept them, either."

The total population of Leon's country was less than 20 million. It would be impossible to prepare enough food to feed such a large number of people. Well, they could endure for a few days, but if they didn't know for how long, there was nothing they could do. The people of the Golden Land El Dorado would be psychologically disheartened if they were to be sheltered without working. To be away from one's work for a long period of time was enough to make one feel uneasy. The idea of evacuating to another country was unrealistic, as was pointed out earlier. On the other hand, having someone stay behind to guard them was also...

"By the way, Guy, you won't be staying here, right?"

“Well, I guess it’s fine.”

“I guess it’s no good. As I thou—eh?”

“What, it’s not like we have a choice. This place is of little importance anyway, but even so, there’s always the possibility that they’ll take it out on them.”

No way, is this a joke?! I hadn’t expected Guy to agree so openly, so I was at a loss as to how to respond.

“I’m surprised... I didn’t expect the terribly ruthless and cruel Red King (Rouge) to be such an understanding demon...”

The peoples’ rumors sure were unreliable, Silvia-san was surprised. I agreed with her.

“Are you bastards trying to pick a fight?”

“No way! There’s no way I’m going to pick a fight I can’t win!”

“Of course not, I’m counting on you, Guy-san!”

“...”

His eyes were glaring. Silvia-san and I exchanged glances and tried to cover it up with a friendly smile.

Well, it was agreed that Guy would defend Leon’s territory. Then, Ms. Kagali arrived.

“Oh, Kagali-san. Have you settled down yet?”

“Yes, it was so long ago that I don’t even remember the details now. There is no point in getting overly sentimental about it.”

Kagali replied as such, but it was clear that she was trying to be tough. Mizeri had thoughtfully prepared a seat for Kagali. Kagali thanked her and sat down.

“So, is there something you wanted to talk about?”

It was Guy who asked directly. I think that was one of Guy’s strengths.

Perhaps Kagali felt the same way, and she opened her mouth with a wry smile.

“I just thought I’d tell you everything I know.”

Looking at Kagali’s refreshed expression, I thought to myself. This is going to be a long story. Although I had listened roughly to the discussion during the day, I felt that what I was about to hear would include Kagali’s private life. So, I wanted to first ask for confirmation.

“Are you sure it’s okay for us to hear about this?”

“Yes. I am grateful to Rimuru-dono, so if you don’t mind, I would love to do so.”

If she was putting it that way, then there was no reason to refuse. We listened to Kagali’s story in silence.

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It was a personal story. It summed up Kagali’s long life as a princess of a great nation. The guilt she felt towards Milim, the fear she felt towards Guy. Her resentment towards Leon and its sublimation. Listening to Kagali’s story, I almost felt guilty for having killed Clayman. After all, the Clayman in Kagali’s story was a kind and caring man. I could tell from Kagali’s tone of voice that he was loved by his friends. However, he had been distorted by his role as demon lord, and in the end, he was used by Lieutenant Kondou. As a result, he became the cause of many misfortunes, and was abandoned by demon lords, particularly Guy. And I was the one who had killed Clayman.

“About Clayman, well...”

“Oh, there is no need to apologize. It was I who devised the plan, and Rimuru-dono was just better than I was. After all, this is a world of survival

of the fittest, and there is no need to show mercy to the loser.”

That was also true. In the first place, Clayman had been completely evil from our point of view, and if I hadn’t eliminated him, we would have suffered a great deal. Even if you say that there was another side to him, it can only be said to be true. However, there were some things that I should think about regarding the fact that he was probably being manipulated, and I might have even developed some sympathy for him in an unorthodox way. That’s why I decided to tell Kagali something that I had been holding back, wondering whether I should tell her or not.

“Actually, I wanted to talk to you about Teare—”

Teare was another one of the Moderate Clown Troupe members who had been giving us trouble. She wasn’t as bad as Clayman or Footman, but that didn’t change the fact that she had been a nasty enemy. But now that we had an agreement, we were no longer enemies. It was natural for us to help her as an ally, if not as a friend. That’s why I rescued Teare when she was about to be killed by Jahil, but she had been seriously injured while protecting Kagali. She was still resting in her hospital room, but Ciel-san was helping her.

«‘Isolation’ of the information particles that constituted Clayman’s heart has been completed. Would you like to combine them together to make up for Teare’s missing components?»

When I was asked this question, I agreed to do so. Looking back on it, I had swallowed Clayman’s end whole. I thought I had absorbed all of him as energy, but it seems that the residue had been placed in ‘Isolation.’ I didn’t want to leave such a thing behind, and I thought Clayman would be happier to return to his friends rather than to remain in my body. Perhaps, Ciel-san

could have revived Clayman completely. It seemed to me that the success rate would have been reasonably high if the Emulated Soul had been inhabited by the information particle residue and given a temporary body. But I never heard the answer.

Clayman was dead. That is why I wanted to help him as a part of Teare from now on. This was completely my own decision and ego, and I had not been sure if I should tell Kagali and the others. But now, I thought I should tell them.

“Is that so...that kid, with Teare...thank you.”³⁴

Kagali muttered and smiled wistfully.



I thought I was just doing it for my own self-satisfaction, but I'm glad Kagali seemed to be happy too. It would have been better if the conversation had ended there—

“By the way, Rimuru-kun, I've been listening to you, and I think you're being too selfish.”

“Indeed...even the Divine Ancestor didn't do such a crazy thing as collecting the residues of the dead and transplanting them into others!”

I forgot these guys were here. It would have been better if I had just ignored them, but I took the bait.

“When did you guys become such good friends?”

“Huh? We don't really get along. It's not bad though.”

“Yeah, that's right! From my point of view, I'd say you're the one who's incomprehensible when you just casually chat with the Lord of Darkness,

who is synonymous with fear!”

It doesn’t matter even if you say something like that, you know? After all, Guy was a little more open-minded than I initially thought. He didn’t get angry over trivial things, so as long as you kept in mind the things you should pay attention to, he was easier to get along with than you might think.

“I knew Rimuru-kun was strange. Even more so than what El-chan told me. To begin with, I thought Guy Crimson there was a horrible demon who became a demon lord after killing my brother Jahil in seconds. If it were that easy to get along with him, no one would have any trouble, right?”

I didn’t have the chance to interrupt her as she rambled on. Seeing us like that, the person in question spoke with a laugh.

“I think it’s quite brazen of you to say that in front of me.”

Ah, Silvia-san seems to have taken a liking to Guy. Guy has a tendency to give respect to those who don’t fear him. This seemed like a nice start to a good relationship for the future. In any case, I thought I had gotten away from the subject, but that was not the case.

“So, Rimuru. What did you do with the Clayman residue?”

Unfortunately, Guy hadn’t forgotten, so I had no choice but to explain.

“No, no, it just sort of happened, you know? It really was just a coincidence when I was saving them from Jahil’s attack—”

I just let it slip out of my mouth. It’s a little sad that I had gotten used to this, but telling the truth was out of the question. I had no intention of revealing my abilities, and if the situation arose, I intended to keep silent.

“That’s suspicious...are you hiding something?”

“Talk to him more. He always keeps his mouth shut about the important things.”

“Sh-Shut up, you guys! There’s a lot of things I don’t understand, and I

don't know why it happened this time either!"

Actually, it was Ciel-san who did it, right? I don't know anything about it. So, I don't want others to get involved in it either...

Rather, Guy and Silvia-san had never met before, yet somehow, they were in perfect harmony. Today was the first time we had met too, but Silvia-san looked just like El-tan, so it didn't feel like it was the first time. And so, unexpectedly, the late-night secret meeting became friendly and lively. Following the flow of the conversation, Silvia-san broke the ice.

"By the way. Kagali-san, I wasn't sure if I should ask this, but I was wondering if you could tell me about your friends?"

There was no mockery in her manner, but rather an air of determination.

"Eh?"

Kagali, who responded, was also puzzled to see Silvia-san like that. But then, as if remembering something, she opened her mouth.

"I have an idea of what you want to ask me, so it's fine. Also, you don't have to address me with 'san,' so you can just drop the honorifics."

"Thank you. Then you can call me Silvia as well. Now, I know it may seem sudden, but—"

"It's about Laplace, right?"

"Yeah. You heard about it?"

"Yes. Laplace was reacting to your voice when you called him Sarion. Sarion...if the Sarion from the Sorcerer's Dynasty is Laplace's real name, then I've got a hell of a person on my side..."

Their conversation continued. I had no idea what they were talking about, but they seemed to be talking about Laplace's true identity.

—Or rather...

"Eh? Laplace is an ex-Chosen Hero?!"

"Yes, that's right. And by the way, he's my husband, and El-chan's

papa.”

“...Seriously?”

“Dead serious.”

I looked at Kagali in astonishment, and she nodded back calmly. She seemed to have already sorted things out in her mind. And the same could be said for Silvia-san, I guess. It must have been a long time ago, but she didn't show any sign of resentment towards Kagali, even though she should have resented her more for the fact that her husband, who she thought was dead, had been turned into an undead elf.

“I'm sorry. I don't blame you for hating me, but I'm still glad that I met Laplace.”

“I'm happy to hear that, too. It makes me believe that he didn't change his character even after he died. The way he defended you at the end made me realize that the man I loved is gone—”

According to Silvia-san, Laplace could have escaped if he had wanted to. But he didn't do so, perhaps because he was proud to be a member of the Moderate Clown Troupe. Well, there was no way of knowing the truth now...

“Well, that's not necessarily true.”

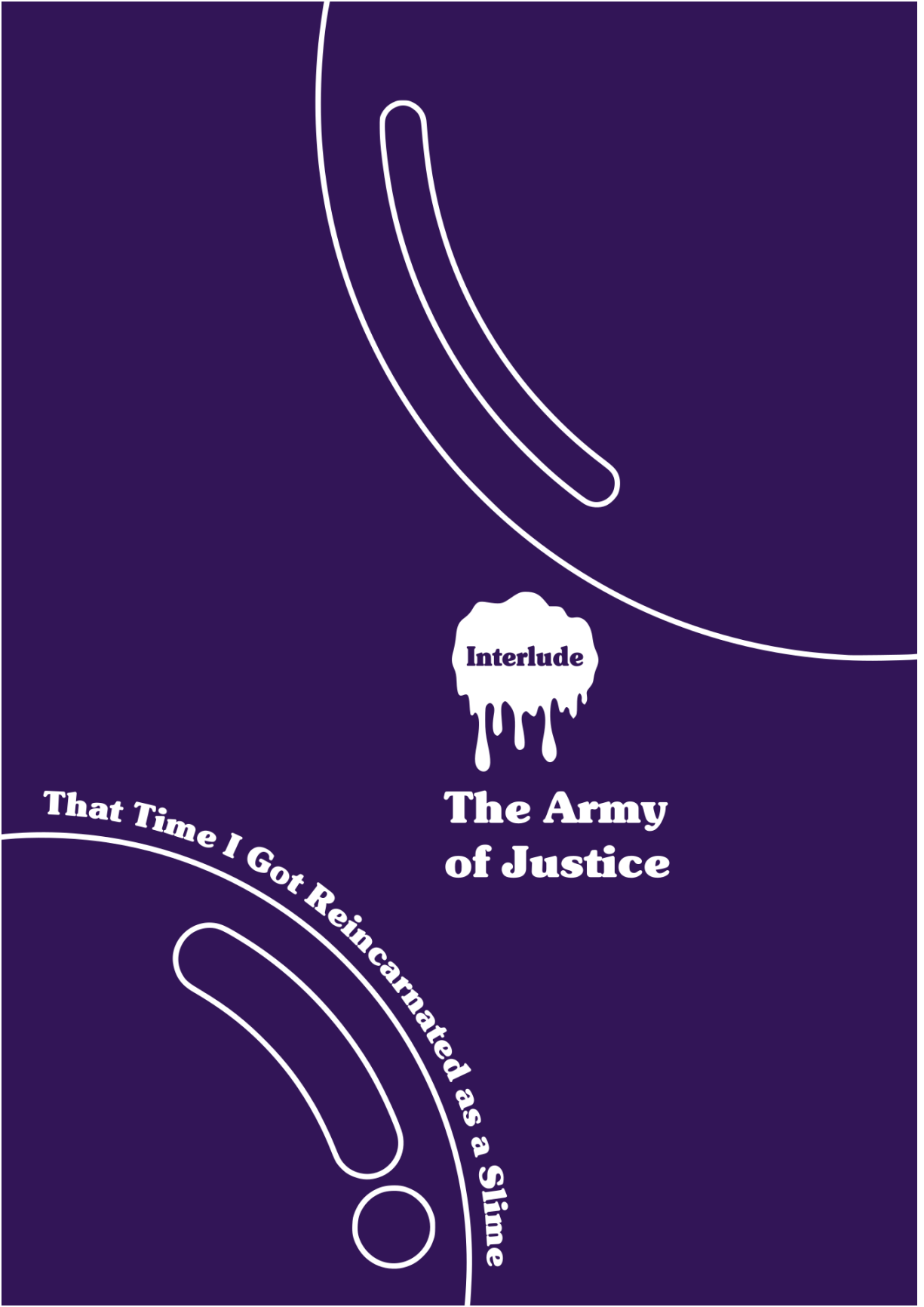
I didn't mean to comfort her, but those words came out of my mouth. It was selfish of me, but I couldn't give up hope. Ciel-san had told me that the chances of them being alive were not zero. That's why I decided to believe that Yuuki and Laplace were still alive. In the first place, Yuuki had always given me a lot of trouble, but as he was also Japanese, and a disciple of Shizu-san, I expected to be more shocked at his death. The reason why I did not feel sad was because I suspected that his death was a lie. No, it's true that he had disappeared right before my eyes without a trace, but I couldn't trust him. Because I had been deceived by him many times. That's why he's

alive. As long as I thought that, there was no need to be sad.

“You’re right. The boss is really stubborn.”

“Yeah. Sarion has been alive all this time and hasn’t even contacted me, so he really is a no-good person. He just reincarnated as an undead elf and lost his memory, leaving me alone. It’s no use worrying about such a no-good guy, so I’ll change my mindset!”

Apparently, my words were not in vain. I was worried that my words might have been inappropriate, but if I could lighten Kagali’s and Silvia-san’s feelings even a little, then I had done a good job. And so, the late-night conversations continued. Overcoming today’s sorrows to win tomorrow’s battles.



Interlude

The Army of Justice

That Time I Got Reincarnated as a Slime

Interlude

The Army of Justice

When Feldway returned to the Heavenly Star Palace, Michael had just returned.

“Looks like you got beat up pretty bad.”

“Ah. Something unexpected happened. I went out to purge the defector Obera, but my ‘Castle Guard’ didn’t work.”

“What? I didn’t have a problem—”

“That’s probably why. These powers are one at their core. Since you’ve set your loyalists as phantoms, I’m guessing that there’s no one who knows about me.”

“But there’s me?”

“Fufu, that’s against the basic principles of the skill. It’s natural for your allegiance to be nullified.”

The two reported each other’s situation as if they were having a casual conversation. It was a surprise to Feldway that Michael could not use the Castle Guard. However, because he was able to figure it out without sustaining serious damage, it was okay. What he was more concerned about was what Obera, the traitor, would do and how it would end.

“So, what happened with Obera?”

“Unfortunately, she escaped. Obera’s subordinates were admirably loyal and successfully protected her from the rest.”

Michael stated matter-of-factly that it was a shame to have lost such valuable assets. Even though he had killed them all himself, his attitude was like that of someone else.

“The soldiers under Obera’s command were excellent. It’s a shame to have lost such a force.”

Even Feldway’s reply was so indifferent that it was hard to believe that it came from the heart. In fact, Obera’s subordinates were loyal only to Obera and had no relation to Feldway. That is why he did not consider this a great loss to him. It would not affect the Castle Guard in any way, so he decided that it was not a problem. This callousness was the reason why Feldway was not well-liked. However, Feldway did not care about this and continued his rationalism to the utmost. It was different in the past, but there was no trace of that time left in the present Feldway.

“Now then—”

Michael changed the subject. He looked at the newcomers, Leon and Jahil, and confirmed that their forces had decreased since before the battle. He nodded his head and began to speak.

“I think we need a chain of command for our forces. Feldway, since you are the Supreme Commander, I think we should consider who should be placed under you, what do you think?”

When asked, Feldway nodded with a “Hmm.”

“Right. Now that we’ve talked to the last person we were negotiating with, we should decide on what to do before we start the full-scale invasion.”

Thus, once again, the main members of the Celestial Realm, excluding Zelanus’ forces, gathered in the audience hall.



First, Feldway presented the results of the current operation. Michael nodded in agreement, but since he had already heard the story, this was just a formal exchange for Dino.

“I see, so Oria was killed in action.”

Dino spoke absent-mindedly. In truth, she had been eaten by Vega, but such an explanation was omitted. Dino had never really known her, but she was still a friend. He closed his eyes and prayed for Oria’s soul, thinking that he should be allowed to mourn for her. Dino was followed by Pico, Gracia, and Mai, while the rest of them kept blank faces. No one seemed to wonder about the tenuous relationship, and the meeting began without further discussion.

Feldway took over as the moderator of the meeting. Michael, not wanting to interfere, remained silent and watched the proceedings. The topic of the meeting was the appointment of positions. The purpose was to clarify the hierarchy so as not to interfere with the full-scale invasion. Vega was the only one with an ambitious look in his eyes, while the others were indifferent. Dino, for his part, seemed blatantly unmotivated and shrunk back to avoid being forced to take any responsibility.

Under such circumstances, Feldway’s announcement began.

There was Michael as Supreme Leader³⁵.

Feldway himself was named Commander-in-Chief³⁶ and Chief Executive Officer.³⁷

Velzard was the advisor. The decision was made to leave her free to roam, as she alone would be a fetter to block Guy’s movements.

Of the remaining people, only nine were strong enough to be

commanders, most notably Zalario. No, there was one more.

The last one, who was not here, was an old acquaintance and friend of Feldway's. Including him, there were ten of them.

Normally, a commander would need to have a tactical mindset, but on a battlefield where individual strength was important, strength was all that mattered. Feldway's idea was that as long as the hierarchy was set, the rest could be left to the discretion of the commander. This was completely wrong, but it had worked so far. So, without any hesitation, Feldway set the hierarchy of strength. The strongest, along with himself, was the old friend who was not here. He was followed by Zalario and Jahil. Feldway decided to appoint these three as the new Three Phantom Commanders.

"First of all, we will establish the new Three Star Commanders³⁸ to replace the position of Three Phantom Commanders. As generals of Veldanava-sama, I want you to exert your power to the fullest."

The reason for the name change was that there were two people other than the phantoms. The star, of course, referred to the Star King Dragon. It was a title intended for one to serve as a general with the purpose of reviving Veldanava.

"Cornu is dead, and Obera has betrayed us. In place of these two, I will appoint Jahil. The other one is expected to enter the war soon and will be appointed at that time."

As soon as he announced this, there was a murmur of discontent. It was Vega.

"Hey now, you're appointing some random bastard to be a supreme general of the Heavenly Army instead of me? That doesn't make any sense!"

This time, Vega, empowered by eating Oria, was getting carried away again. He was a very unfortunate man who appeared to have lost the

concept of remorse. The only person who could handle Vega well was Yuuki, but Feldway didn't care.

“Shut up. My decision is final. If you make another comment, I'll have you executed. Are you prepared for that?”

Feldway didn't have any idea how to utilize human resources.³⁹ He possessed a very clear mindset that all that mattered was whether someone was useful or not. Anyone who was not useful would be discarded. That is why he was not well-liked, and Feldway did not care about that. Next time, if Vega disobeyed him, he would seriously dispose of him. Vega, with his superior survival instincts, could sense this. Vega, who had been feeling all-powerful after his growth, found Feldway's strength to be on a different level. He knew that he was not yet a match for Feldway, so he had no choice but to retreat quietly.

“Damn, I'm sorry. I wanted you to think more highly of me, so I interrupted you...”

He made up for the mistake and pushed down his dissatisfaction. However, he smiled once he heard Feldway's next comment.

“Don't be so rotten about it. I think highly of you as well. That's why I'm giving you the lead position of the 'Seven Angels of Death.'”

The Seven Angels of Death was also the name of the group that was supposed to consist of the ultimate skill holders of the angelic lineage. But alas, there were not enough of them. Feldway, who did not care about details, designated the remaining main force as the Seven Angels in order to make up the numbers. Originally, he had planned to appoint Kagali and Obera as part of the Seven Angels, and Vega was going to be included as one of the Four Star Commanders.

Mai and Oria were going to be assigned as auxiliaries, to serve as support. Unfortunately, from the very beginning, the plan had been

drastically modified. In any case, he decided to assign Zalario, Jahil, and one more person, as the Three Star Commanders. The Seven Angels consisted of Leon, Dino, Pico, Gracia, Arios and Mai Furuki, with Vega at the top.



Now, the Three Star Commanders were to command their respective corps, while the Seven Angels were to engage in single and multi-personal operations. And then, the main strategy was discussed.

“Now that we have Leon amongst our ranks, it can be said that we have broken one of the demon lords’ forces. This means that we have one less point to attack.”

At Feldway’s request, Mai projected a miniature version of the Cardinal World and lit five points of light on the ground. One of them, the white dot on the continent controlled by Leon, disappeared.

Only four spots remained. But then, Feldway pointed to a point. Mai changed the color of the spot from white to red.

“We don’t need this place either. My friend has promised to help me, rather than Guy.”

The extinguished spot of light displayed the far west, Dagrue’s territory.

“Are you saying that Dagrue has switched sides?”

It was Leon who asked that question. The one who nodded in agreement was the third member of the Three Star Commanders. He was a slender man with an exceptionally large physique.

“I have arrived, Feldway. You’ve done a bold thing, releasing me from

the seal.”

The man was not Dagrue. His long, shaggy hair was green. It was not the same as Dagrue’s dull blue hair. His eyes shined like jade, which was also different from the blue-eyed Dagrue. However, they were vaguely similar in appearance.

The man’s name was Fenn. He was the younger brother of Dagrue, the Continent’s Wrath, and was known as the Crazy Fists titan who had been sealed away by Veldanava during a rampage in ancient times. The first to react to the sight of Fenn was Dino, who was normally laid-back.

“It can’t be, you released the Gleipnir that was binding Fenn?! Even though Dagrue has been so vigilant, Feldway, what the hell are you thinking?!”

And, quite unusually, he questioned Feldway. He was still surprised, and his tone had become rough.

“Hmph, don’t worry. Fenn and I are friends. Our interests are aligned, and—”

Feldway insisted that Fenn’s abilities were tremendous. Fenn’s magics, which he was not trying to conceal, were leaking out as a supreme energy that overwhelmed the others. In terms of existence value, it exceeded sixty million, and was so vast that it could be said to rival the True Dragons. However, there were other people besides Dino who were uncomfortable with Fenn.

“Damn, an evil deity sealed away in ancient times. He’s the kind of tyrant that even I wouldn’t want to deal with, let alone the Divine Ancestor!”

Jahil spat viciously. He did not know the man directly but had heard about him from the Divine Ancestor. According to him, he was an evil deity who had been sealed by Veldanava for his destructive acts. In Jahil’s mind,

he was the second most evil incarnation after the World-destroying Dragon Ivarage. That legend was now standing in front of him. Faced with this fact, Jahil was disgusted to the point of nausea. But Fenn didn't care. Smiling, he put his arm around Jahil's shoulders and whispered in his ear.

"Hey now, we're all friends, right? Let's get along. I heard about it. Like you, I was appointed as one of the Three Star Commanders. Unlike the rest of those small fry, you've got something to offer. You're more than qualified to be my servant⁴⁰."

It was a statement that completely disrespected Jahil. Jahil shuddered in humiliation. For Jahil, who believed that he deserved to reign as the emperor, it was unthinkable to be looked down upon. But he could not complain. He could feel the desperate pressure of the arm around his shoulder. A cold sweat broke out on Jahil's forehead, and he sat back in his chair.

"Hmph! I forgive you for now. I don't intend to end up like this either, but I'll leave things alone for now."

And with that, he agreed to work for Fenn. Now that that was out of the way, they were wondering about the reaction of the remaining Zalario, but he didn't seem to have any intention of fighting in the first place. This was not just because he was under the control of the Ultimate Dominion, but also because Zalario, as a warrior, understood his own strength. Whether he could win or not could only be seen in actual combat. However, an all-out battle would cause enormous damage to both sides and would undoubtedly affect the future of the war. It would be pointless, to say the least. That is why Zalario decided to end the situation by giving in himself. Thus, Fenn was appointed as the leader of the Three Star Commanders.

With all the actors in place, all eyes turned once again to the miniature

Cardinal World.

“So, Feldway. What do you mean that Dagrue’s not a problem? I understand that Fenn-dono has joined our ranks, but that’s not the end of the matter.”

Fenn replied to Jahil with a smirk.

“Hey now, that’s just sad. Are you underestimating my abilities? If you know me, then you should understand, right? Dagrue is certainly my big brother, but I’m more powerful than him.”

Jahil replied bitterly to Fenn.

“I don’t need that kind of boasting. If you really have no problem with it, just show me the results.”

Jahil was arrogant. Even though he recognized Fenn’s ability, he did not intend to give up his pride as an emperor to follow him. Fenn seemed to like Jahil and smirked at him.

“Even though you know me, you still have that attitude. That’s fine, I’ll live up to your expectations.”

Fenn smiled happily. He hadn’t had a chance to talk to anyone ever since he had been sealed away in Veldanava so long ago. Despite this, scenes of the world had still been flowing into his mind as if he were dreaming. This was because he was connected to his brother, Dagrue, and his other brother, deep in his soul. That is why he was aware of the world situation to a certain extent. He understood that they were at the verge of the beginning of the age of civil war, and that this was an environment where he could be violent.

Feldway was the only one who had visited Fenn when he was sealed up. As for Feldway, he had only been taking care of Fenn because Veldanava entrusted him to do so. At some point, they became friends, exchanging small talk and consulting each other. Feldway had no relatives to talk to

because he was the leader. Fenn, too, had come to realize that solitude was lonely after being sealed for so long. In a sense, it was inevitable that they had come to trust each other. And now, Fenn had been given a place to play, and a friend to show off his power. There was no reason for Fenn not to be excited. It wasn't that Fenn was less violent than he used to be, it's just that he had learned to value his friends more. Fenn was more than happy to have friends. That is why he was grateful to Feldway from the bottom of his heart.



Fenn had announced that he would take care of Dagrue, but Dino was still not satisfied with this.

“Wait, wait, wait! Hey, are you seriously okay with this, Feldway? If we let Fenn go, won't we lose the reason why Dagrue is guarding the Heaven's Tower?”

The Heaven's Tower was the stairway to the Heavenly Star Palace. Those who did not have the key to open the main gates had no way to enter the Heavenly Star Palace except through the Heaven's Tower. It was Dagrue who guarded it, and his reason for doing so was to keep Fenn from being unleashed upon the world. Dino was saying that if Fenn were to attack, there would be trouble depending on the outcome. Even though he was under the control of the Ultimate Dominion, Dino's thoughts were free. It would be different if he were under a stronger control, but he could still say what he wanted.

Incidentally, the same was also true for Leon. His actions were

constrained, but his thoughts remained unchanged. That is why, even in the battle with Silvia, he was able to minimize the damage by not attacking extensively. In addition to that, he had also sent signals with his eyes, but unfortunately Silvia did not understand them. It was not because Silvia was not perceptive enough, but because she had been very busy. However, even if she had been able to understand the signals, the information would have been limited to ‘Leon still has free will,’ so it wouldn’t have been very meaningful anyway...

In any case, at the moment, the Ultimate Dominion only restricted his actions, but still allowed him to think freely. For Feldway, however, this was more convenient. He couldn’t have a strategy meeting without flexible thinking, so Dino’s comment was welcome.

“That’s a good point. So, what do you think we should do to alleviate this anxiety?”

“No, well, I don’t know...”

Dino’s momentum dissipated as soon as he was asked the question. He had been so surprised that he spoke up, but when he thought about it, it’s not like he’d be at a disadvantage. He was back to his normal self, wondering what he’d even gotten upset about.

“N-no...even if you ask me such a difficult question, well, it’s not like there’s a problem, right?”

At any rate, as safely as he could, Dino tried to sit down as if his role was over. But Feldway would not allow it.

“I believe in Fenn, but Dino’s concerns are justified. So, I think the best solution for this situation is to send some other people.”

You were planning to do that all along, Dino thought. Saying it out loud might sound like Feldway didn’t trust Fenn, so Dino’s comment must have been a blessing in disguise. More importantly, in this case, Dino, the

speaker, might be forced to participate...

Dino's prediction came true.

"You're worried about it, aren't you Dino? In that case, you should see for yourself how strong Fenn is with your own eyes."

"Ah, no, I'm not..."

"No, don't be shy. You won't be able to have a turn, but if you want to see how strong I am, I won't stop you."

He wasn't planning to do that anyway, but now it was too late. Dino gave up and nodded reluctantly.

"Th-that's true. Then, I guess I'll take your word for it and participate with Pico and Gracia."

"Wha—hey, Dino! Don't drag us into this!"

"Seriously, I really don't want to. I just had a fight to the death with Raine. Don't you think it's cruel to ask me to fight again?"

Dino's companions were furious, but Dino ignored them. He figured out that they were probably slacking off anyway, and forcibly involved them to distribute the work. Feldway had no objection to this and approved it. It was true that he trusted Fenn, but Dagrue! was also a powerful man. He was not to be taken lightly, and Dagrue! also had another brother. The story of the three giants who rampaged in ancient times was well known. As someone who knew the truth of that legend, Feldway was prepared to make the best move.

"Leon, please join them. In addition to Fenn, there will be four of the Seven Angels attacking the Heaven's Tower. I think that should be enough."

Thus, the members being dispatched to the next target had been decided.



The meeting seemed to be ending, but instead of that, everyone moved on to the next topic.

“Now, let’s determine the next attack point.”

“Eh? Isn’t it time to go on the offensive?”

“Ah. We’re planning a simultaneous invasion, taking full advantage of the aggressor’s capabilities. Rather, with all due respect to Fenn, you are the decoy.”

“A decoy...then who’s the *real* target?”

Dino was not interested in the mission, but he wanted to ask. He thought it might make himself feel a little better if the other locations sounded more difficult. Besides, if he could successfully meet up with Rimuru, he might be able to ingratiate himself with some useful information. Even though it was not in his character, he asked Feldway the question.

“The first thing I want you to remember is our purpose.”

That was the answer. Dino wondered what the purpose was. It must have been something ridiculous, like bringing back Veldanava. Of course, Dino would be happy if Veldanava was revived—

Doesn’t Veldanava-sama have his own reasons? Maybe Feldway became too much trouble for him, or maybe he wanted to back off until the humans had matured.

Dino thought that it would be more ignorant for them to make selfish assumptions about Veldanava, the creator and transcendent being.

Those who speak for the god are the most troublesome. They can distort your opinion without your permission when you openly state a different interpretation. It seems that Luminas had a difficult time with this, and that’s why she said she stopped appointing humans as the Pope...

Even if they hear the exact same words, there are differences in the perceptions of those who receive them. Because people believe only what

they want to believe, they are reluctant to admit when they are wrong. As an actual example, Luminas had never said that she was the ‘one and only God.’ Yet, for some reason, her followers had come to believe that Luminas was the only god. It seemed that this was more convenient for Luminas, so she did not deny it, but the fact that the truth changed when people intervened in the interpretation of the truth was troublesome if it was handled in the wrong way. After observing the human world for a long time, Dino had come to understand this. And yet, his colleague was setting a bad example, and he felt like giving them a break.

“Only the Veldora factor remains as a necessary element to revive Veldanava-sama. But there’s one more obstacle we mustn’t forget. Isn’t that right?”

Is that so? Dino wasn’t involved. And yet, Feldway’s eyes were on Dino.

Whoa, whoa, whoa, it’s me?!⁴¹ Give that to someone else!!

As he looked around, he saw that everyone had kept a serious, blank expression on their faces. Zalario seemed to be holding on to the fact that he was dominated and was ready to ignore Feldway completely. Leon had just arrived and did not seem to be following the conversation, nor did he seem interested in it in the first place. The same went for Fenn and Jahil. Fenn and Jahil did not know the answer to the question, because it was still new to them. Pico and Gracia didn’t seem to know either. They were hiding behind Dino, looking down for good luck. The other members of the Seven Angels were not Feldway’s friends, but useful pawns. They were not the ones he wanted to ask for opinions, and Dino was the one who had to deal with them.

Is this a joke?! Because Kagali and Yuuki are gone, I’m being put in charge of the thinking?!

Wait a minute, Dino thought. That should have been Zalario's job. Dino finally realized that he had unwittingly drawn the short straw. But that didn't mean that he could do anything about it. He didn't want people to get their hopes up, so he decided to play along.

"Do you want to hear about it?"

He smiled and replied in a suggestive manner. At that, Feldway nodded in satisfaction.

I knew it. He's too smart for his own good and doesn't want others' opinions. I thought I could have a conversation with him if I just praised him!

Dino nodded back, thinking it was a good thing.

"That's right. Dino is correct, we must get rid of this irregularity, Masayuki. In the unlikely event that Rudra is resurrected through Masayuki, there is no guarantee that it won't affect Michael-sama."

I didn't say anything, Dino thought, but he was careful not to show it on his face. He nodded his head in agreement. He knew that the logic was warped, but he wasn't so good-natured as to point it out here, so he was inclined to let people do as they pleased.

The others were similar, and none of them expressed their opinions. Feldway continued his explanation.

"Now that Veldora is deep in that troublesome labyrinth, our next target is Masayuki. If we start with that and reduce their strength one by one, he'll have no choice but to come out of his hole."

'If he doesn't come out, we'll just cut off his other forces,' Feldway said.

I'm pretty close with Masayuki, Dino thought, but he wasn't paying attention. He wanted to tell Masayuki that he was being targeted somehow, but he couldn't think of any way to do so now that Michael's control had

been strengthened. Even the 'Telepathy Net' with Rimuru could not be carried out, as this would be a clear act of betrayal. The only thing left to do was to hope for a great coincidence there, but that seemed impossible, so Dino gave up. The only thing left to do was pray that he would get away safely.

"So, do you know where Masayuki is?"

"That's a good question, Dino. Regarding that, Velzard..."

"Yes, yes. From Velgrynd's presence, I have a rough idea of his location. There are several locations inside the Empire, and one in the Kingdom of Ingracia, where the girl is responding. The haki is completely hidden, but my eye cannot be deceived."

This was the Frost Dragon Velzard's cognitive ability, equal to or greater than Milim's 'Milim Eye.' She had no trouble detecting the presence of her siblings, let alone other people. Velgrynd appeared to be using 'Parallel Existence' to fortify the empire. At the same time, it was assumed that she was also guarding Masayuki. In response to Velzard's comment, Mai manipulated a miniature light spot.

Following the west end ruled by Dagrue, the central west area ruled by Luminas changed from a white light to a red light. Feldway pointed to the red light.

"This means that Masayuki is here, in Ingracia. I will leave it to you to attack there, Vega. What do you think?"

This was not a question, but an order. He was only saying that to lift Vega's spirits a little. Vega, being a simpleton, did not see it that way. He grinned and nodded happily.

"Leave it to me. It's a former home, with many hidden passages that no one knows about. I'll sneak in and take care of this Masayuki kid."

"Hm," Feldway nodded.

He had planned to let Vega run amok as a diversion and have Arios kill Masayuki while he was at it, but he wondered if that was possible. Either way, he intended to go to Ingracia's capital himself. Therefore, Feldway decided to let Vega do as he pleased and watch the enemy's movements. Of course, that was not all.

"Zalario, you are to lead the entire army to our support. Find out what Luminas is up to, and if she moves, stop her."

"And if she doesn't?"

"Stand by. If I give the order, launch an all-out assault on Ingracia's capital."

"Understood."

Feldway's orders were absolute. Zalario nodded meekly, keeping his frustrations to himself. Currently, Jahil was the only one who hadn't been ordered to do anything yet. There was no way Feldway was going to leave his Three Star Commander force idle, so Jahil waited for Feldway's words while preparing himself.

"Also, let's be careful. Jahil, you're on standby. I'll leave you in charge of my subordinates, and you'll do what you can to help Fenn."

"Whoa, whoa, isn't that a bit much? I don't think that's necessary."

"Don't say that Fenn. It's just a precaution. Once you take control of Dagrue, you'll have an army of your own, right?"

"I guess."

"But as long as Dagrue is alive and well, there will be times when the Titan's army will get in the way."

"And it's my job to stop them?"

"Yes, it is."

Fenn boasted that it was unnecessary, but Feldway was correct in this case. As for Jahil, it didn't matter to him either way. If Fenn is active, he

can just watch him, and if he is in danger, he can sell him a favor. Besides, he didn't even need to be in a hurry to succeed, because the opportunity to play an active role would eventually come.

“Hmph! It's a shame that they're not the ones I trained, but it can't be helped. As soon as I see Fenn's victory, I'll attack from the west to the center, do you mind?”

“Sure, do as you like.”

As soon as he heard that, Jahil went silent, implying that the conversation was over. Jahil was an ambitious man. He owed a debt of gratitude to Feldway, even if it meant doing his bidding. Considering the difference in strength, he thought it would be wise to follow him for the time being. Incidentally, Velzard reported directly to Michael, so Feldway had no authority to give her orders. The current policy was for Feldway to let her do as she pleased. In this way, everyone's roles were defined.



Once the plan was settled, Michael spoke up.

“I have one more thing to say. Regarding the labyrinth in the Demon Lord Rimuru's domain, it is not a good place to be trapped. I think it would be better to lure them out, as Feldway said. Therefore, I've decided to hand over Demon Lord Milim's sphere of influence, centered on the former Eurazania, to Zelanus. As for the capital of Ingracia and the territories of Milim, Demon Lord Rimuru will not be able to ignore any war that breaks out in his land. Be sure to defeat the reinforcements that he will send. If we do, our victory will be unquestionable.”

Michael's words were full of conviction. In fact, that was the greatest advantage for the aggressors. The destruction of the enemy's forces through individual assaults. Repeatedly doing so would guarantee victory. In addition, once the bases other than the capital Rimuru were eradicated, the siege formation would be complete. There were many mysteries in Ramiris' labyrinth, and it was possible that there was more than one way in and out, but being able to stop the operations was significant. It may be possible to bring in strategic supplies, but once separated from the world, it would be easy to reduce their influence.

However, since the ultimate goal was to capture Veldora's dragon factor, they couldn't simply wait and see. That being the case, Michael decided that it would be best to bring the situation to that point and then slowly devise a strategy. This may have been the right strategy, but Dino was not convinced.

"Whoa, whoa, Milim is the daughter of Veldanava-sama, you know? Do you understand that?"

He complained, as if expressing his indignation. But Michael remained aloof.

"...Are there any problems?"

He asked Dino, his cool expression still intact.

"Are there any problems? No, no, I'm just wondering if it's going to result in Veldanava-sama's displeasure..."

That was a natural question from Dino's point of view. It would be an act of betrayal to Veldanava to touch Milim. So, what was Michael thinking? However, Michael's reaction was very calm, and he seemed to think that there was no problem at all. The same was true of Feldway.

"Dino, I am aware. Demon Lord Milim is the daughter of Veldanava-sama, however, she is no different from us in that she was created by him."

There was doubt of that being Michael and Feldway's true thoughts. Their respect and loyalty seemed to be directed only to Veldanava, with not even a shred of affection for his daughter.

Jahil seemed to agree, sniffing and scowling at Dino with a mocking gaze. Having been destroyed by Milim's wrath in the past, he was feeling a sense of pleasure at the Eurazania invasion operation. Dino's opinion, which might interfere with it, was not interesting to Jahil either.

Hey now, this is why Obara betrayed us! They really have a bad way of thinking...

Dino thought to himself as he looked back at Feldway. If he didn't do something, he would be branded a traitor. Feldway spoke to Dino.

"Don't worry, Dino. If my actions are wrong, then he will come back to correct them. If his beloved daughter is in danger, he will surely come to her aid. That is why my actions are correct."

Now that he had said that, there was nothing left for Dino to say. His old friend was dead. If only he had realized this sooner, he would have been able to escape—Dino regretted it even now.

And so, the outline of the Tenma Great War was decided and carried out. And on that day, the world was thrown into a whirlpool of chaos by a great calamity that would drastically change the course of the world.

**Chapter
2**

**The Beginning
of the
Great War**

That Time I Got Reincarnated as a Slime

Chapter 2

The Beginning of the Great War

After the discussion that night, it was decided that Kagali and Teare would remain in my country's custody. Teare was still unconscious, and it was safer to take care of her in the labyrinth. We could get detailed information and find out if there was any malicious intent at work. So, it was only natural that Kagali would come with me. I accepted the two of them without any complaint.

Silvia-san returned to Sarion. She would've been a great help as a warrior, but what was most important to Silvia-san was Sarion, where her daughter was. I couldn't just force her to do anything I wanted, so we promised to cooperate with each other if anything happened. I also gave her a cell phone, just in case. El-tan had one, but I decided that it would be better for Silvia-san to have one as a backup. The communication function of the Demon's Ring was not universal, and it was best to have as many means of communication as possible. After this trouble was all over, we could use them for fun. After exchanging our contact information, I saw Silvia-san off.

And now, I was in my office. There was so much paperwork that I

almost felt as if my daily life had returned to normal. Just by looking at them, my anger towards Feldway seemed to increase by about 30 percent. Look, I wasn't just playing around either. And yet, there were piles upon piles of proposals that needed my approval, and a mountain of meeting notes for various measures that were being taken.

For the time being, I was putting off the meeting notes. I didn't need to rush to look at them because they had already been done. I looked through the new projects that needed approval and quickly decided whether they were acceptable or not. I was busy, but it couldn't be helped. After all, the day after tomorrow, the world conference would be held in Kingdom of Ingracia.

That's right, a world conference. This would be the first such event in history. The participation of the Emperor of the Eastern Empire in the Western States Council, which was regularly held in the West, was an unprecedented event. Actually, I was supposed to meet up with Myourmiles in the Kingdom of Blumund and go with him. But then some idiot decided to invade Leon's country, and that's why our plans were thrown off. It was a mistake that I was now forced to fill in the gaps with these documents.

But that was all over now. All I had to do now was to sip some tea and relax. I would try to calm down and collect my thoughts before the show.

"Rimuru-sama, here's your tea."

It was Diablo, not Shuna, who brought me the tea. He was working hard as a secretary, probably because Shion was away.

"Thank you. You should take a break with me, too."

I said as such, encouraging Diablo to sit face-to-face. Diablo was thrilled and looked at me to say something like, 'I'm honored,' but I ignored it and started talking.

"So, what kind of guy is Feldway, from your point of view?"

From my point of view, he seemed to be surprisingly unpopular. If he wasn't, Dino wouldn't have betrayed him so easily. Anyway, what I needed now was information about the enemy. If you know what kind of character they have, you will be able to judge to what extent they can bluff or not in case of emergency. I understood well enough that he was cautious, so I thought I would ask if there was anything else. Diablo thought for a moment and then answered.

“He's a serious guy. He is hard-headed, inflexible, or whatever you wish to call it, but once he has made up his mind, he will not bend his will. He has a personality that doesn't consider other people's opinions even as a reference, so his peers were divided in their evaluation of him.”

In other words, for a yes-man, he is an easy boss because they only have to do what they are ordered to do, and for a talented and creative person, he is an uninteresting boss who ignores their own opinions. It can be very stressful if your opinion is not accepted. If there is a good reason that is explained to you, you will be satisfied, but if there is just a rejection, you might be left with a grudge.

“Is there anything else?”

When I asked, Diablo began to worry, muttering, “That's right...”

Then he responded with an “I'm not certain about this,” and went on to tell me something more important than I had expected.

To put it simply, it was about how to get to and from their base and this world. They—the Aggressors, were the altered versions of those banished from this world by Veldanava and the angel legions that were their watchers. Their base, of course, was in the Otherworld. The connection between the Otherworld and this place, the Cardinal World, was a special force field called the Underworld Gate, and there were several of them around the world. They were guarded, or rather controlled, by the demons.

Surprisingly, they were expanding their sphere of influence around the Underworld Gate. The only one known to exist was the Underworld Gate guarded by Carrera, not too far from Leon's territory. The other gates guarded by Testarossa and Ultima had disappeared due to a major battle.

"We're better off without them. If you go to the Otherworld with your body, it will be contaminated and transformed. Those who come here from the other side are almost certainly Aggressors."

He told me bitterly. In short, it would be easier to destroy the 'gate' itself, since it only brought chaos in this world. Testarossa and Ultima didn't approve of that. They had been guarding the gate for a long time, but when Diablo went to scout for them, the gate was broken, so they had been easy to recruit. I thought to myself, *That can't be true, right?* but I didn't say it.

As proof, the gate that Carrera had guarded appeared to be broken. At present, it seemed that the gates had been left unattended because one could not come and go without great power. I secretly thought that the correct answer was that it was broken on purpose. But back to the main topic, what Diablo was wondering about was how Feldway and the others had come to this world. Diablo speculated that perhaps a new 'gate' had appeared somewhere in the Empire.

"Or maybe they've restored the gate that Testarossa used to guard?"

"I cannot deny that possibility. However, it doesn't match the time when Feldway appeared in the Empire, so it is certain that another 'gate' exists."

Well, that made sense.

"So then, you're assuming that the Aggressor's base is inside the Empire, right?"

So, I confirmed as such, but Diablo's concern was something else entirely.

“No, that’s not all. From what I heard of Kagali’s story, there is no doubt that Feldway has opened the gates to the Heavenly Star Palace. One would need a key to open it—”

The Heavenly Star Palace, also known as the place of beginnings, and the birthplace of Veldanava, I believe. As Kagali had explained, Feldway’s base was adjacent to every world. In other words, Diablo’s concern was about how to get the key—

“There is no point in worrying about how they got it. What matters is that if you pass through the gates of the Heavenly Star Palace, you can come to the Cardinal World with the body that exists in the Otherworld.”

Oops, I’m glad that I didn’t put that into words because it was way off. Even so, what did he mean by the body that exists in the Otherworld?

“Of the Primordial Angels, only Feldway was given a body by Veldanava-sama. The current one is only inhabiting a temporary body, so there is no point in killing it.”

“Is this something like Velgrynd’s ‘Parallel Existence’?”

“No, it’s different from that. It’s not like they are connected all the time, but rather they’re splitting their consciousnesses. He’s probably synchronizing his memories periodically, so there are no inconveniences...”

That’s why it was so troublesome, Diablo explained to me. From what I could understand, Velgrynd was like a set of synchronized computers connected to the internet, and Feldway was like a set of computers disconnected from the internet, with only the data being transferred from the terminals.

«That seems to be the correct understanding. In other words, ‘Spacetime Continuous Attack’ will not be able to reach the main body, so he is a very troublesome opponent.»

I see, very troublesome.

“So then, unless we go to the place where the main body is to defeat Feldway, you can’t defeat him. It’s certainly troublesome...but, huh? If the main body is going to go out of its way, isn’t that convenient for us?”

Rather than searching for someone we don’t know where he is, it would save us a lot of trouble if he came to us. That’s what I thought, but it seems that it was not that simple. Diablo answered.

“Yes. However, he is simply quite strong. It’s possible that his main body’s fighting ability could surpass that of Guy’s. That is why I wondered if we needed to be prepared for any eventuality.”

The body Veldanava had given him was a treasure to Feldway. That’s why Feldway was always inhabiting a temporary body to avoid damaging it. But we also had to consider the possibility of him reversing that belief. I think that was correct. The situation should not be turned upside down by a single idea from the other party. And even more so when it was a force that couldn’t be ignored.

“A serious Guy is on par with Velzard-san. That means that Feldway is also comparable to a True Dragon, right?”

“Kufufufu, that is correct.”

Diablo says that Feldway was pretty bad back in the day. Compared to the Insect Lord Zelanus, and the World-destroying Dragon Ivarage, he was a bit of a letdown, but in reality, that wasn’t really the case. Even the existence value measured in the labyrinth was not accurate if it was not the main body. So, Feldway’s true power was unknown...

“I’ll leave it to you, but you’ll be okay, right?”

I planned to leave Feldway to Diablo. I was surprised to hear that Feldway’s true strength was that of a True Dragon, but I knew Diablo would be able to handle—No, isn’t it impossible, as expected? But as soon

as Diablo heard my words, he replied with a big smile on his face.

“I am deeply moved⁴², Rimuru-sama. I will continue to strive to live up to your trust!”

Oh, this, it looks like it’s okay. Diablo may be overconfident, but he does not take on things he cannot do. He may or may not be able to win, but he seems to think it’s possible to deal with Feldway. If so, it would be foolish for me to worry about it. It is always better to have a trusted subordinate fight against an opponent who’s fight may turn out to be an indefinite battle. So, I decided to let Diablo do his best, as I had originally planned.

Now that I understood how bad Feldway was, I was curious about the next target.

“How do you think he’ll make his move?”

“Hmm, that’s right...it’s hard to predict, but based on Feldway’s personality, I’d say he’s most likely planning to go after Masayuki-dono.”

“Eh?”

The unexpected answer took me by surprise. But it was certainly an opinion I could not ignore. I thought there was no point in going after Masayuki, but then I reconsidered the possibility. Why was Masayuki targeted in the first place? They had probably suspected that he was the reincarnation of Rudra and wanted to kill him. And this was proven by the fact that Velgrynd loves Masayuki. Feldway was probably more wary of Rudra than Masayuki. The reason for this was unclear, but it was certainly not surprising that Masayuki would be a target.

“In the first place, I don’t think the reason is important. I don’t mean to be insistent, but Feldway is a hard-headed man who won’t admit to his own mistakes. He is not the kind of guy who would give up just because he

failed once.”

Diablo said it just like that. I was even more convinced in that case.

“Then the next meeting might be dangerous. Velgrynd-san will be escorting him, so unless something goes wrong, I think we’ll be fine, but you should be on the lookout as well.”

“Please rest assured. I am always perfectly prepared for anything.”

That’s the kind of thing I can trust in Diablo. Regardless of his personality, he is an excellent worker. His rival, Shion, was also on a business trip right now, so there was no need to worry about him. Diablo and I were continuing our detailed conversation, identifying any concerns, when we received some shocking news.

〈There’s been a huge problem, Rimuru!!〉

The call came from Milim, full of a hint of trouble.

〈What’s the matter?〉

〈Actually, Obera has escaped.〉

〈Oh?〉

〈She said that she was caught betraying Feldway and got into a fight with Michael.〉

This was not something one should talk about on the Telepathy Net via Demon’s Ring. And so, I decided to go to Milim’s place.



Milim’s castle was under construction, but there were still some habitable parts that were already completed. There was also a medical facility in one such corner, and Obera was lying in one of the rooms there. When she had

first escaped to this place, she had been in a serious condition, to the point of unconsciousness, but now she was awake, and her upper body was upright on the bed. It seems that she had been asleep for a long time, and we hadn't been able to hear what happened. Nodding my head, I greeted Obera.

“Hi, I'm Rimuru, Tempest. I'm a demon lord.”

Since it was our first meeting, I started by introducing myself. Frey-san, who appeared to have grown more attractive, looked at me as if she was taken aback.

“It may be impolite to say this to the Demon Lord Rimuru, but don't you think you should learn to show a little more dignity? It is one thing to be able to do your duty during an emergency, and another to be able to do so duty in your everyday life. The difference is obvious to anyone who sees you.”

I immediately received a complaint, but from Frey-san's point of view, it was probably because she was worried about the negative influence on Milim. Because Rimuru was—because Milim was always making excuses. That was probably it. It was like a mother worrying about her bad friend. I couldn't help but smile because it was so funny. Seeing me, Karion smirked.

“Hey, it's tough having Frey on your radar.”

Hey now, don't say that just because you got a new ally. Both Karion and Frey-san, while they might say a lot of things, treated me casually when nobody else was watching. I had asked them to do so and was grateful to them because I didn't have to be so formal that way. Even so, the atmosphere around the two of them had changed significantly. Benimaru had reported it to me, but now that I was seeing them in person, they were like different people.

“I heard about it, so you’ve taken full ownership of the power you’ve awakened?”

“Oh yeah. Tell Benimaru that I owe him for his help the other day.”

Karion was good friends with Benimaru. He liked Benimaru when he picked a fight with him during their first meeting, and they had been friends ever since. Even though the power relationship between them was now reversed, the fact that Karion didn’t mind at all, and even boasted that he would soon catch up to overtake him, proved how big of a person he was. The same was true of Frey-san.

“I’m grateful to you for that. Now I can be of more use to Milim than before.”

She smiled and thanked me, but that didn’t mean that it was easier to scold Milim now, did it? I suspected as much but accepted her words of gratitude as it went without saying that I would need her strength to survive the Great War.

“Even so, Ramiris’ labyrinth is a foul play. I never realized that there was such a use for it, even though we had been together as demon lords for such a long time.”

“That’s for sure. I thought she was just Guy’s favorite, but I’m surprised the little pipsqueak⁴³ had that kind of power hidden.”

“I’m sure she wasn’t hiding it. It’s just that no one noticed.”

“I knew about it!”

“Knowing about it is useless if you are unable to do anything with it. That labyrinth made me understand that. That’s why, Milim, don’t be a sore loser.”

The know-it-all Milim was being chided by Frey-san. Laughing at this, Karion expressed his opinion.

“But well, I can’t laugh at Milim. We look like idiots too. But, hey, it

makes sense, doesn't it? When it comes to treating others well, no one can match Rimuru."

"That's right. In that sense, we are also the ones being used."

Frey-san nodded, but I hadn't expected that about Ramiris' labyrinth.

I initially thought I would just try and make use of it, and after asking, I couldn't help going, *What? Is that really possible?!*

I was surprised. And through trial and error, the current labyrinth was born. Since I had not envisioned it from the beginning, their opinion was an overestimation. But well, just by the results, the labyrinth really was amazing. The fact that you can come back to life even if you die in the labyrinth is a foul play, no matter how you look at it. The labyrinth was perfect for training, and from a defensive point of view, it was just too impregnable. It's a wonder that Ramiris had been underestimated, and it felt like my own achievements were practically nonexistent. However, I felt that it was wrong to talk about it, so I just laughed and covered it up.

"Now then, let's finish our greetings and get down to business, shall we?"

Frey-san's words changed the atmosphere of the hospital room into a serious one. At this point, Obera, who had been looking at us with a wide-eyed look⁴⁴, tightened her expression. Finally, she said a few words of greeting to me.

"Nice to meet you, Demon Lord Rimuru-sama, I am Obera of the former Three Phantom Commanders and head of the anti-cryptid forces."

Obera began by saying so. She spoke with a mysterious look on her face, but there was no hint of a lie. Just as Milim and the others believed, my intuition was telling me that it was true. But just in case, I decided to poke my head in.

"Just for the record, you do understand that betrayal on the eve of a

major war can lead to suspicion of espionage, right?”

“Of course. I have no way of proving my innocence, but I will tell you everything I know.”

The expression on Obara’s face was sincere, without a single trace of cloudiness. She explained what had happened, even though she wasn’t in the best of shape yet. After she had finished her discussion with Milim, she returned to Feldway and the others. It was good that she received a physical body there, but at the same time, she also acquired an angelic skill. Sensing that she could be in trouble, Obara considered the possibility that she might be controlled by this power. She then discarded the Ultimate Skill ‘Salvation King Azrael’ that she had acquired before Feldway could take control of her.

Silvia-san taught me this technique of separating the mind from the Skill. I was impressed by her knowledge, but when I thought more about it, I wondered if her betrayal had been exposed because the enemy had sensed Obara’s abandonment of her Skill. As a result, Silvia-san and Kagali and the others had a difficult time, but it might be wrong to put the blame on Obara. I would just dismiss it as an unavoidable situation and pretend that I didn’t notice it. What was more important was the truth or falsity of Obara’s story. Quite frankly, I found it credible.

«I agree. The story was coherent, and she even talked about information that normally should have been hidden. If she’s willing to go this far, it’s not worth the price of espionage.»

That’s right. She spoke fluently to us about being attacked by Michael, and about his power. She told us that Michael’s ‘Castle Guard’ had not been activated, that he had used both Velgrynd and Velzard powers as a matter of

course, that his power had destroyed Obera's army, and so on. It was interesting to examine the information from the perspective of whether there would be any merit should it be false. That is why I had always searched for the opposing opinions of information on the Internet and tried to find out whether the information was for or against, and what the source was, and so on.

This method was also effective on Obera. If Obera had been deceiving us, she would have lied about Michael's powers, but this information was too true. Even Ciel-san's verification result showed that it was true. What's more, Obera had agreed to accept my 'Analyze and Assess.' If I did this, I could almost certainly confirm the existence of her skills. The result of this also came out clean. It was determined that Obera did not have the 'Salvation King Azrael' and was not being controlled by Michael. After all this, believing in Obera was the correct answer. I gave Obera recovery medicine and honey and asked her to try to recover as soon as possible.



It was decided to leave Obera to Milim and the others. The information obtained from Obera was shared among the demon lords. This was no longer a time to be afraid of leaking information. We all agreed that it would be too late to explain anything after something had happened to someone. Two days passed by in a hurry, and just like that, the day of the World Conference had arrived.

Benimaru was staying back home. As commander-in-chief, I entrusted him with the protection of Tempest. For my escort, I had Ranga and Souei

lurking in the shadows, and Diablo as my secretary. With this group, I was sure to be able to deal with things even if Feldway himself attacked.

“Hey, Boss! I don’t think there’s much I can do for you today for the big event, but please let me know if you need anything.”

Youm greeted me. Myuran was not in sight, apparently staying at home. Instead, Gadra was there as Youm’s escort. We greeted each other briefly and promised to meet up later. After today’s events were over, there would be a buffet party. After that, some of us were planning to go to Ingracia’s capital for a drink in a relaxed atmosphere with people we knew well. I went to the assembly hall with a bit of excitement and met up with Masayuki at the square in front of the hall. Since Masayuki was the main character of the day, I welcomed him as an acquaintance and an intermediary.

“Huh, have you grown taller?”

I had grown a bit taller since I became a True Dragon. I used to be able to look Masayuki in the eye, but now we were back to the same height difference as before.

“You can tell? I think I’ve actually grown up a bit.”

Masayuki smiled happily. Upon closer inspection, his hair was also a bright blonde.

“Your hair too?”

“Yes, it’s completely discolored. I’ve gotten used to it, but it was a bit disconcerting at first.”

At this point, I wondered if it was some kind of anomaly. I had thought it was an exaggeration, but Rudra might actually be coming back. But then again, Masayuki was still Masayuki. I stopped worrying about it, and we went into the chamber together.

In the large circular venue, which I had already visited several times before, the heavyweights from various countries had already arrived. It was noisy and bustling in its own way, but as soon as they saw us, it all went quiet. All eyes were focused on us, but we were used to it by now. Masayuki seemed to be the same, and he didn't appear to be nervous.

"You've become more dignified."

"That's true. When I was enthroned in the Empire, there were so many people below me that I could barely see them all."

The experience of declaring his accession to the throne from the castle balcony to all his subjects seemed to have helped him grow strong.

"It was wonderful, Masayuki."

Velgrynd-san said as such as she recalled it with a wistful expression on her face. Velgrynd-san had come as Masayuki's chaperone, but she herself had a powerful presence. Not to mention her good looks, she looked great in her military uniform. Velgrynd-san must have been the one who drew most of the attention of the attendees. In the midst of all this attention, Chairman Leicester, with his bushy white beard, came running up to us and led Masayuki and me to our seats.

As befits a leading role, we were in the front row. I was seated face-to-face with Masayuki. I could also see Testarossa at the moderator's table. With the arrangements in place, the historic reconciliation between the Western Nations and the Eastern Empire would go off without a hitch as long as there were no interruptions. When thinking about something like that, red flags were bound to appear. This time as well, that law would come into effect, but I didn't realize at the time, and simply waited quietly for the meeting to start...



The Kingdom of Ingracia, the Great Underground Maze. It was a secret passage that had been dug for over hundreds of years. It was a facility prepared in case of the invasion of angels and was widely known as a maze because of its intricate complexity. There were several large open areas in the levels near the surface which could be used by anyone as a place of refuge in case of emergency.

However, that was only on the surface. At the lower levels, there were secret places that only a few people knew about. It was the dark side of the Royal Capital, an evil research facility that could never be revealed to the world. The research there was controlled by magical inquisitors, and the content of their research was the method of incorporating the monster factor into the human body.

The results of their research were still quite impressive, including muscle strength ten times greater than that of normal humans, skin tougher than steel, and skeletons to support those muscles. The result was their own bodies, but the king's judgment was that it was not enough to face the supernatural existence of the demon lord.

“Another failure. This one's a little more fragile than I thought.”

“Kihihihihhi. If we want to incarnate a greater demon, we have to make a stronger body. I heard that the Empire was developing a weapon called the Battle Chimera, and the concept is similar to ours.”

“Hmm. There's a difference between modifying the human body directly and using it as a synthetic beast.”

The existence of a drug that could induce medical skills had been a closely guarded secret and was not widely known. Therefore, the

researchers here believed that the Battle Chimera was the perfect weapon. However, they believed that strengthening the human body directly was quicker than using synthetic beasts, and that they were superior to them. That is why, without any sense of repulsion, they were repeating experiments that would seem forbidden to ordinary people.

But it was still not enough. They were not satisfied with the results. Currently, they had exhausted the factors of capturable monsters, and had succeeded in extracting some factors (essences). The reinforcement rate was steadily increasing, and the model was being upgraded, but this time the vulnerability was not a physical issue but rather a mental issue.

It is said that a sound mind resides in a sound body. If this is true, then a strong body should be accompanied by a strong mind. With this in mind, the researchers began to search for a way to fuse spiritual life forms. The quickest way to do so, they argued, would be to tap into the power of demons. The reason for this was that it was easy to obtain a body. In the north, there were repeated skirmishes with demons, and lesser demons and greater demons were procured by capturing weaker ones. Such demons were lodged into dead bodies and incarnated. Thanks to these demons, they had succeeded in analyzing their composition, and discovered some interesting results.

What is the mechanism of demon incarnation? The answer to this question was that the magicules eroded human cells and transformed them to be compatible with magic. However, this was only the case when the demon took the initiative, and forcibly taking in the demon's power was nothing but a poison to the human body. That was a given. Energy intake through food, sleep, and even breathing would become unnecessary, and even life span would disappear. It would be like being reborn as a completely different life form, and to control that by human will would be

the ultimate form of recklessness.

Besides, the magical inquisitors were mistaken. They focused only on strengthening the body, while the important thing was the power of the will. They thought that only the physical body should be trained, because the mental aspect was strengthened by the demon's power, and so the experiments were repeated in the wrong direction.

And one more thing. This misunderstanding was fatal. By cultivating the cells incarnated by the demon, a factor (essence) is extracted. They thought that by injecting it, the subject would also possess the demon's power. This was a big mistake. A demon took the incarnated body as its own with the power of its will. No change would come from a cell without will, only a poison that would consume the subject. In other words, the torturous experiments were being repeated with no hope of success.

For the subjects, this environment was hell itself. That is why the subjects selected were not the best people, but rather orphans and slaves who would not cause a fuss if they were disposed of. And then there were the criminals. Those who had committed serious crimes were secretly executed and brought to this laboratory—

Reiner was breathing heavily and repeatedly. Despair and fear occupied his heart. He had fallen from the honorable position of Commander of the Knight Order of the Kingdom of Ingracia, to the status of a disposable experiment. Many of Reiner's beloved subordinates had been killed. At first, he was angry at the injustice, but soon his heart was broken. The help he had expected did not come. Reiner's family home was destroyed, and the Knight Order abandoned him. It was only natural.

Reiner had acted outrageously at a previous council meeting. He used Elric, the first prince of the Kingdom of Ingracia, as a motive and fought

against Demon Lord Rimuru and Holy Knight Commander Hinata. If he had won, he would have been a champion, but he lost easily. In such a case, Reiner had to be charged with treason. Naturally, all the people involved in Reiner's crime were executed. In other words, he was used as an experimental subject in this laboratory. The help that Reiner hoped for was never going to come. Reiner understood this, and now he spent his days fearing when he would be used as experimental material.

Damn it! Why, why is this happening?!

The only reason he hadn't completely gone insane was because his anger came back from time to time when he remembered. It was a complete resentment against Demon Lord Rimuru and against Holy Knight Commander Hinata.

I'll make you weep! Even if you beg for your life, I won't forgive you. I'll make you accept everything that happened, and then I'll torture you to death!!

A fierce hatred was holding Reiner's heart together. Moreover, there was another reason why Reiner had become that way. That was because, as of now, Reiner had only undergone physical enhancement surgery. The plan was to strengthen him as much as possible, and then move on to the experiment of merging with the demon. In particular, Reiner was a precious specimen with over A rank in value, so the researchers treated him with care. It was doubtful whether one could call it good fortune or not, but in any case, Reiner was still alive and well, and if one only looked at his power, it had reached Special A rank. And then, on that day. A hope that was never meant to come appeared before Reiner.



“Wow, I didn’t expect it to be this easy to break in.”

The one who praised Vega was Feldway, who had half-heartedly entrusted Vega with guiding the way. There were four of them in the room. Vega was followed by Arios and Mai, and Feldway was at the back. After their strategy meeting, each of them made their own preparations. They all agreed not to start the attack at the same time, but to let the demon lords focus on the first attack and then hit the main target. This meant that Feldway and the others, who were aiming for Masayuki, would be a step behind.

Fenn, a Three Star Commander, was to make the first attack. He was responsible for attracting the attention of the demon lords with his flamboyant rampage. He would defeat Dagrue, a member of the Octagram, and take control of his army. The impact would be so great that it would send chills to the hearts of the other demon lords.

Jahil, a Three Star Commander was also assigned to assist Fenn. With this, they had assembled enough forces to bring down the west. Feldway and his group were the main contenders. Their goal was to go to the world conference in Ingracia’s capital and dispose of Masayuki. In order to keep others out of the way, Zalario, a Three Star Commander, was sent to stand by in the sky to stop the Demon Lord Luminas if she made a move. Or, at Feldway’s signal, he was to launch an all-out attack on Ingracia’s capital. In addition—

At the same time as Fenn’s attack was to begin, the forces of Insect Lord Zelanus were scheduled to attack the Demon Lord Milim’s stronghold in the former Eurazania. Currently, the six remaining of the Octagram were Guy, Rimuru, Ramiris, Milim, Dagrue, and Luminas. Since they were going to attack two of them at the same time, he hoped that it would upset the other demon lords. However, the Demon Lord Rimuru, who was as

much a target to watch out for as Guy, was reported to be near Masayuki, whom Feldway and the others were targeting. The name had been on the list of participants for today's meeting, but he could not deny the possibility that this was a trap.

That is why Feldway was thinking of acting cautiously and responding flexibly. For this reason, he accepted Vega's advice and made use of the hidden passageways instead of entering the capital by force. That was a good decision.

Located in the forest on the outskirts of the Royal Capital, was one of the exits to the passageway. By entering through there, it was very easy to get in without being affected by the Barriers that guarded the capital. And that wasn't the only fortune.

"So, this laboratory is still active. I missed this place. I remember when they experimented on me here."

Vega muttered such a thing, and indeed, there was a hint of human presence coming from the end of the passage. From Feldway's point of view, these people were all insignificant in power, but by human standards, they had a certain strength. At first, he thought it would be troublesome to cause a ruckus here, but he soon realized that this was an unexpected blessing.

"Oh, I knew it. The people trapped in this cage are experimental subjects for our research here."

As Vega explained this, he approached the cage unprotected. He then addressed the person in the cage in a friendly manner.

"Hey, brother⁴⁵. You doing okay?"

The person he was speaking to was Reiner, whose heart was on the verge of breaking.

"What...you...are not those damn researchers...?"

Reiner noticed someone standing in front of the cage and cowered in fear. He looked up to see Vega, confused by the unusual situation. Vega laughed.

“By the looks of it, you’re pretty messed up.”

“You are...?”

“Heh, I’m Vega. I guess you could say I’m your senior.”

“Senior...you said?”

“Yeah. I’m someone who was once used as a test subject here. I was lucky to escape, but it’s still a bad memory that gives me nightmares.”

Hearing this, Reiner became familiar with Vega. He felt a sense of camaraderie with Vega as someone who understood the harsh environment.

“You are just like me...”

“Yeah, I am. So, how about I help you out?”

Vega went off on his own. Feldway, who was listening to it all, didn’t interfere. The mission was in Vega’s hands, and until now, things had been going well. He thought it would be a good idea to leave things to him, and he would just keep an eye on things. Besides, there was another reason.

In addition to Reiner, there were many other prisoners here. Other experimental subjects. There were nearly a hundred of them. Their bodies were similarly enhanced, and they seemed to be in good shape. So, he wondered if he could use these experimental subjects for Yorishiro, a phantom who had not yet incarnated. While Feldway was pondering, Vega and Reiner continued their negotiations.

“What?”

Reiner was puzzled by the unexpected news. If Vega was going to help him, then there was no way he could refuse. However, Vega and the others were too suspicious. He wondered if he could really trust them, though that was only for a moment. After all, if he turned down their offer, all that

awaited him was destruction. He would lose his mind in fear and despair and die in the not-too-distant future. It would be better if he could pass away without suffering...when he thought more about it, it was much better to be deceived here.

“Help me. If you ask me to swear allegiance, then I will swear to give you everything I have! So take me out of here!”

Reiner shouted. Hearing this, Vega grinned and put his hand on the steel cage. Even strengthened by magic, it was easily twisted and torn apart by Vega’s power. The sheer power destroying the cage made Reiner realize the difference in rank. But what surprised him more was that there were several dead bodies of the magical inquisitors lying at his feet. They had been disposed of quickly and quietly by Arios. Reiner, who had been worried about the slow arrival of the patrol, turned pale when he found out the cause of the delay.

I can’t believe that the secret forces of the Kingdom of Ingracia, to whom even I can’t match up, were killed so easily. It’s hard to believe, but these guys are truly monsters!!

Even as he was thinking this, he felt truly relieved. Reiner knew that he had made the right choice.

“Nice to be working with you, brother. If there’s anyone else you want to help, let me know. I’ll rescue all of them.”

Reiner’s face flushed with joy at this unexpected offer.

“Y-yes! All of them. All of them are my subordinates!”

Only those who had been deemed to be able to withstand the enhancements were gathered here. The women and children had been sent to other experiments and were already dead. Reiner and the others who were being held here had been told this as part of their punishment. So, they chose to follow Vega without hesitation.

“Okay, from now on, you’re under my command. We’re going to run wild in the capital up there. You’ll follow us even if you don’t want to.”

“Of course. Rather, it’s a good order. We have a grudge against this country, too.”

Vega’s words were met with a happy response from Reiner. The knights under Reiner’s command nodded with the same feeling of regret for their fallen comrades and families. Now that their lives had been spared, their resentment against being used as test subjects in a horrible experiment had increased. At this moment, their anger was uncontrollable. And now, Feldway was giving them a boost.

“Then I will give you the power to do the same. Are you ready, Mai?”

“Yes. I have a hundred warriors from Jahil-sama.”

Following Feldway’s wishes, Mai had already taken action. In this short time, she performed an ‘Instantaneous Movement’ and had taken a selection of warriors from Jahil.

Jahil was not happy, but Feldway had given him an order. There was no way he could disobey, so the order was carried out swiftly. And so, deep underground the Kingdom of Ingracia...

The incarnation ritual was performed on Reiner. The being with the stronger will would take control of the body. In some cases, the egos would be merged, but Reiner accepted this as better than those inhumane experiments. And so—

“I am filled with power. Vega-sama, thank you for saving us and giving us the chance to take revenge.”

“No problem. I’ll lend you this thing, so you can go wild!”

Reiner took the weapon from Vega. It was a knight’s sword embodied by the ‘Multiple Weapons’ ability that Vega had taken from Oria. Needless to say, its performance was equivalent to a mythical-grade weapon, but Reiner,

who had the power of a ‘staff officer⁴⁶’-class phantom, would be able to use it. The current Reiner’s power was over a million in terms of existence value. With the addition of the mythical-grade weapon, he had been strengthened to the equivalent of two million.

Reiner’s subordinates had also been reborn with existence values ranging from 200,000 to 500,000, equivalent to Special A rank or higher. Vega was in a good mood, having acquired an unexpected asset. Feldway was also satisfied.

This was an unexpected pick-up. Now, go wild and do your best to help me.

With a smile on his face, he watched as Reiner and the others left in high spirits.



A huge tremor hit Heaven’s Tower. On that day, the Holy Void Damargania was on the verge of extinction.

“Ahh, that feels pretty dangerous. Could it be the one who ravaged the earth a long time ago?”

Hearing Ultima’s murmur, Veyron and Zonda, who had been recalled, became tense.

“I will go check with Dagrue!-sama right away.”

“Right. We have to consider the worst-case scenario, so Zonda should run to Beretta-san’s location now and make sure Shion-san is informed as well.”

As soon as they heard Ultima’s order, Veyron and Zonda moved out. If

this place were to fall, it was obvious that Lubelius with Shion would be the next target. It was natural to contact the headquarters, but it was also safe to inform Shion of the seriousness of the situation. Perhaps because he understood this, Zonda did not argue with her at all. The fact that he didn't say anything unnecessary such as "Why?" or "I'll fight with you," was due to his absolute belief and fear in Ultima.

Unlike the lower demons, those under Ultima's direct control understood. They understood their master's character. Ultima was unforgiving to those who disobeyed her, and she had no mercy for those who did not agree. And above all, Ultima's judgment was accurate. Zonda had tested it and found that the area had already been sealed off from magic. All means of communication had been jammed, and it was impossible to communicate with anyone. Of course, they were fully prepared for such a situation.

Rimuru had instructed everyone to keep in constant contact with each other, as this was an issue that had come up during the previous attack on Leon. He told them to communicate with each other regularly, once every five minutes. This way, any point where contact was lost would be considered abnormal. So even if they didn't panic, others would know within five minutes that there was something going on, but Ultima must have decided that it would be too late.

If that was the case, then all Zonda could do was follow the orders to the best of his ability. Zonda was not so incompetent as to waste his precious time. Zonda took with the wind and disappeared. Ultima stood up and bit her nails.

"Now then, if my expectations are correct, should I consider running away?"

Ultima didn't want to do that, but she was determined to do so in the

worst case.

Rimuru-sama also believed in Dagrue. But at the same time, he had his doubts...

Rimuru seemed to be a good-natured person, and it's true that he was gullible to a fault, but in fact, he was quite cunning. Even Ultima, a king amongst demons, respected him for his calculating nature. Back then, Rimuru had muttered something casually.

"It's a little curious that you're asking Veldora for support even after explaining the enemy's purpose."

At the Walpurgis' banquet, Dagrue had constantly been asking Veldora to come to his aid. Michael was after Veldora's dragon factor. Dagrue knew this, yet he still wanted Veldora to come instead of Ultima. It made sense that it was because they knew each other, but he was still curious. It's because they were familiar with each other—that was certainly convincing, but it had still bothered him.

As for Ultima, she didn't think that Rimuru was overthinking it. After hearing Rimuru's story, she had finished all her thoughts about Dagrue. As a result, she had come to the same conclusion as Rimuru that the possibility of Dagrue betraying them was not zero.

To begin with, Dagrue was born from the Mad King of the Giants, wasn't he? He went on a world-destroying rampage, and was sealed up by Veldanava-sama...

She didn't know the details, but could still guess.

To begin with, this land was adjacent to the area that was Ultima's territory. Naturally, Ultima knew more about Dagrue than anyone else. Rimuru must have sent Ultima here in anticipation of this.

It's easy to get excited when you think of the people who are counting on you.

Ultima thought of this, and upon arriving in Damargania, she had been studying Dagrue, investigating whether or not he had betrayed them. She found a clue.

Dagrue was said to have three brothers, but only one younger brother was introduced to her. She thought that the remaining one would be the key, but right now, a powerful presence was attacking. The presence resembled that of Dagrue and his brother, Glassord—

“The Mad King of the Giants.”

Ultima muttered, a fearless smile on her face.



When Veyron entered the throne room, it was filled with shouts of anger. It was understandable. The divine structure known as the Heaven’s Tower had been restored to its former function. In other words, a door to the heavens had opened. Originally, the Heaven’s Tower was a divine fortress that could protect them from any enemy. But this time, the Heaven’s Tower had become a battlefield. It was inevitable that the people living in this land would be very upset.

What’s more, the presence that came down from there was familiar to the old giants. Even before they could see the enemy, the giants were disturbed. There were many individual differences in the lifespan and abilities of giants.

First of all, there was no lifespan for the ancient individuals. There were times when they would be replaced by their successors by entrusting their memories and powers to them, but that was only a measure in case they

were killed in battle. Spares and replacement individuals did have lifespans, but these lifespans grew longer with each generation, and even the most recent generation had lifespans of several hundred years. And as for their abilities, the ancient individuals had powers worthy of being called gods.

The Giants were huge, ranging from 2 to 2.5 meters at their normal size, but they grew several times larger in battle. The strength of their bodies was the true essence of the Giants. In the case of Dagrue, the oldest of the Giants, the difference between his normal size and battle size was more than tenfold. In other words, he could grow to over 20 meters in size.

Among the Giants, there was one who was as strong as or even stronger than Dagrue. That was his younger brother, Fenn. Dagrue had three brothers, but his youngest brother was a tyrant who had lost control of his emotions while maintaining his intellect and reason. He was sealed away by Veldanava, and since then, Dagrue had kept the seal. That is why he had not been able to move from this land, even though his territory had been turned into a desert.

The place where Fenn was sealed was the Heavenly Star Palace. And there was only one way to get there, through Heaven's Tower. There were other ways, but that was reserved for those who possessed the key. Incidentally, there was only one owner of the key. Only Veldanava's sister, Velzard, was allowed to open the gates to the Heavenly Star Palace. Dagrue knew this, so the situation was not unexpected.

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Dagrue glared at the lower levels from the upper floors of the Heaven's Tower. It reminded him of the Walpurgis the other day. Selfish demon lords had been repeatedly asserting themselves while still being considerate of

their opponents' positions. They seemed to have no sense of cooperation, yet their opinions were strangely united.

In accordance with the terms of the agreement, Demon Lord Rimuru's subordinates had been busy coordinating the 'magic transfer circle' until just the other day. They had now settled down, just in time for the final battle. He was impressed at how hard they worked, and they had done a perfect job. Dagrue was also very pleased and held a grand feast to thank the team for their hard work.

Now it felt a little lonely, since there was only Ultima and her friends left as their guests. The 'magic transfer circle,' which looked like an art form depending on one's point of view, shone brightly and sat in the center of the lower floor. However, it was its performance that was noteworthy. The purpose of the magic circle was said to be for allowing people to come and go in case of emergency, but in truth, there was no doubt that the creator had their eyes set on the distant future. Although it was a makeshift project this time, Dagrue believed it to be a great enough achievement. If it could be used to move troops, it could also be used on a large number of merchants.

Demon Lord Rimuru, huh. Someone who cannot be underestimated. By using the magicules in the air, he created such a complex magical device that's accessible to everyone. There may be a limit to the number of times one can use it but it's only a matter of refilling the magicule supply. It would be much safer than crossing through that magical desert.

In this abandoned and dying land, it was all they could do to import enough food to satisfy their people. The Giants could not live by eating nothing. They needed to eat enough food to keep up with their huge bodies, and the younger they were, the more energy they consumed. It was a sign of life, but in a sense, it was also a curse. They exported the materials of desert

monsters and depended on the food supplies from other countries. To do this, young men and women became travelers, crossing the harsh desert over and over again. This was the reality of the 'Holy Void' Damargania.

However, with this 'magic transfer circle,' they would be free from such hardships. Until now, it had been common knowledge that food and other things could not be teleported. But now, in the future, such problems would be solved.

It's scary. I never thought I'd be able to find the solution to my problems so easily...if that's the case, we won't have to force ourselves on Lubelius.

It was frightening for Dagrue! to see how far off the Demon Lord Rimuru was looking. The demon lord named Rimuru, who possessed ideas that he had never thought of, was honestly amazing. He admired his recklessness and did not want to make an enemy of him. However, someone had come to interrupt Dagrue!'s excitement. All of a sudden, a voice echoed in his mind.

◁My friend Dagrue!, it's been a long time. I'm glad to hear you're well. I wanted to get in touch with you as soon as I got back here, but things have been crazy. I'm glad I finally got the chance to speak with you.▷

Dagrue! did not panic. This situation had also been expected.

◁Hmm, so it's you, Feldway. I'm happy that you call me a friend, but you and I are enemies now. I don't want to talk too long, so tell me what you want.▷

Upon hearing his reply, Feldway, the owner of the voice, seemed to feel let down.

◁It's a shame that you're being so cold. I was hoping to ask you to help me as well, you know?▷

Dagrue!'s reaction to Feldway's pompous tone was even colder.

◁The revival of Veldanava? I'm not interested. I don't hold any grudge

against him for sealing Fenn, and I am indebted to him for giving us this land and taking care of us, but that doesn't mean that I think it's right for me to help him come back.>

In the first place, Feldway and Dagrue were not on such good terms. Rather, from Dagrue's point of view, he was even angry with Feldway when he heard that Michael had mental control over Dino, his true friend. At the time when he heard that Dino had betrayed them, he had wondered what kind of madness he had gotten into—

To begin with, there was no way that that idiot (Dino) would voluntarily choose to betray us in such a troublesome manner.

And he was deeply convinced when he heard the story. That's why Dagrue brusquely turned down Feldway's offer. Feldway was not amused by this.

<Hey now, has Dagrue the Titan of Rebellion been tamed after becoming a demon lord?>

He tried to use Dagrue's temper to his advantage in the negotiations. In ancient times, the Vicious Titans⁴⁷ had challenged the Star King Dragon Veldanava and had been sealed away. That was Dagrue and his two other brothers. A king of tyranny, spreading destruction across the earth. His tremendous powers of great destruction had turned many lands into scorched earth. Dagrue and the others were even called the worst gods of destruction, but they became quiet after obeying Veldanava.

He lived quietly in the territory he was given and guarded Heaven's Tower as his duty. However, this did not mean that he had become quiet in nature. Even now, with his power having been sealed away by Veldanava, his rage had earned him the nickname Continent's Wrath. Feldway thought it would be easy to provoke him. However...

<Sorry. Things are different now. I've become more hopeful about the

future. Considering that this is all thanks to Rimuru, I can't betray him.›

The offer was rejected quite easily. Then, seeing that further negotiations would be meaningless, Dagrue said, ‹The next time we meet will be on the battlefield›, and unilaterally terminated the ‘telepathic communication.’

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“It’s beyond control,” Dagrue muttered.

“That Feldway, I can’t believe that he unsealed Fenn. Is this because I refused to cooperate?”

“Don’t worry about it, Brother⁴⁸. He is trapped in his obsession. Sooner or later, I’m sure this would have been inevitable.”

Veyron looked at the brother, who was standing at ease, and expressed his displeasure.

“Hey now, I can’t just let that statement go. Has Dagrue-sama been in contact with the enemy?”

This was an order from Lord⁴⁹ Ultima. Veyron pursued the matter, determined not to allow any excuses. However, this ended up as a letdown. From the very beginning, Dagrue had no intention of hiding anything.

“Now, don’t be so hard on me. I’ll admit you’re a powerful man, but you’re weaker than I am.”

Dagrue replied without panic. His brother, Glassord, followed suit.

“Calm yourself, Veyron-dono. It is true that my brother received an offer from Feldway. However, he turned him down, and that is why we are here now.”

With that admonition, Veyron nodded with a “Hm.” He had been aware of the situation to begin with because he had raised his voice to question them. The attitude of Dagrue and the others did not indicate any signs of

lying, and he judged that they were telling the truth. So then, why did they say something that would benefit the enemy during Walpurgis?

“Our great king was concerned that Dagrue!-sama’s actions were questionable. I would like a clear explanation—”

And just as Veyron was about to question him...

“Well, I get it. You wanted to ask Rimuru-sama for help, didn’t you, Uncle⁵⁰? At Walpurgis, you wanted to make a statement that would arouse suspicion and show that you were involved with the enemy, didn’t you?”

Ultima, who had arrived late, asked Dagrue! that question. Or rather, it was not a question but an assertion. Hearing this, Dagrue! smiled broadly and happily.

“Excellent! As expected of my old nemesis. I’m glad you’re here instead of Carrera!”

This was Dagrue!’s true opinion. Carrera was too logical and wasn’t as good at reading in between the lines. If she had misunderstood that Dagrue! was betraying her, it would have been very difficult for her to solve it. In this respect, Ultima was a relief. She had been a long-time enemy of Dagrue!, and he trusted her intelligence.

With a big smile on his face, Dagrue! told Ultima that she was right. By suggesting that he was involved with Feldway, he was suggesting that he and the Holy Void might be targeted. Like Dino, he did not want to be turned into a traitor through no fault of his own. If the possibility of that was not zero, he decided that he should tell them about it. However, he also felt that saying it as it was, would only lead to misunderstandings, so he deliberately left it as a hint.

“Hmm. So that’s what it was after all. Then, it was exactly as Uncle expected, right? Because Rimuru-sama understood exactly what was going on. Rimuru-sama is a cunning and all-seeing person, so this situation was

probably part of his calculations. That's why, I think, we can manage without worrying."

Ultima said with a smile. Dagrue! nodded widely and smiled with relief.

"You hear that, Glassord? My colleague is a remarkable guy. I knew that the man with the eye of god, who took Clayman by a storm, would see what I was up to!"

Ultima and Dagrue! shared a heart-to-heart without Rimuru. It must have been a blessing for the both of them that they didn't realize that the reason for this was a complete misunderstanding. In any case, the reconciliation between the two was concluded.

"Well then, let's do our best until Rimuru-sama comes."

"Ultima-sama, I am at your command. I will destroy your enemies and bring them to your sight!"

Ultima and Veyron believed in Rimuru and went into battle.

"Right, I guess I'll have a crack at him, too. It's going to be a bit of a challenge to take on Fenn, but I might be the only one who can stop him."

"I'll go with you, Brother."

The Dagrue! brothers were inspired by the spirit of Ultima and the others, who were supposed to be their guests. Quickly, they all moved to intercept the attackers.



Milim and her group was aware of the horizon beyond.

"Oh, that's bad."

Karion was the first to mutter, as everyone's faces paled in silence. The

earth and sky were filled with swarms of insects⁵¹. Their ferocity was immeasurable, and the threat was unimaginable.

“Those are eight of the Insect Lord Zelanus’s Twelve Armies... It’s terrible, even Zelanus’ trusted Twelve Insect Generals are here...”

Karion was answered by the recuperating Obara. Thanks to the care of Milim and the others, she was now fully recovered. Obara was determined to get revenge on Michael, who had destroyed her beloved subordinates. Even she was at a loss for words in the face of the abominable reality of those horrible insects. Or perhaps she simply hated insects. Otherwise, she would not have asked Zalario to come forward to take charge of the more dangerous World-destroying Dragon. Regardless of such a backstory, now was not the time to be escaping reality. Milim spoke up.

“Hey, Frey. Is it okay if I blow them up with ‘Drago Nova’?”

Hearing this, Frey pondered, “Well...”

It wasn’t a bad idea. Obara was looking at Milim expectantly, and it seemed like a good idea to allow it. If Frey had been uneasy with insects, she would have agreed to the idea without a thought. However, Frey decided to wait. She had no particular reason to oppose the idea, but she had a bad feeling about it.

“I suppose it is tactically possible to make a maximum attack on the first move. But I think it is also a good idea to expose your opponent’s capabilities while they are still unknown.”

Frey rejected Milim’s idea, saying that it was too uncertain. With so many enemies, it would be tempting to have Milim wipe them out. However, she decided that the insectars should not be underestimated. The reason was that she knew Zegion.

Frey had fought Insect Queen Apito, but she had also observed Karion and Zegion’s fight. Apito, whom she had just barely defeated, was a

fearsome majin, but to her, Zegion was like something from a whole other dimension. This time, the enemy was the same species as Zegion.

“Honestly, maybe I’m just overly concerned, but I don’t think we should underestimate our enemy.”

No one laughed at Frey for being soft when she said this. On the contrary, Karion agreed with her.

“No, I agree with Frey. That kind of intuition is not to be taken lightly, and I myself feel that we should be cautious about what we do. I don’t think Milim has anything to worry about, but let’s go for it.”

And Midley was the same.

“Well, the problem is that there are so many of them, but their individual strengths are closer to B rank. If we destroy the A-ranked insects that appear to be the commanders, the rest will just be a ragtag bunch. Since the commanders’ strengths are distinct, it won’t be difficult to find the targets. It might be easier than we think.”

And so, he was saying something rash, based on his own brainless standards.

That is not a strategy, Frey thought, but then she remembered that Midley’s subordinates were used to such recklessness and swallowed her words.

“Well then, we’ll take care of the ones flying in the sky and leave the ground-crawling insectars to Midley-dono.”

Frey wrapped up the conversation as if she didn’t care about anything else.

“We can’t just leave it to Midley alone. I’ll have my warriors take care of the commander-level enemies as well. The headless limbs will make a good training ground for the new army.”

“Yes, that would be very helpful. After all, it’s not exactly right for a

priest to be on the front lines.”

Karion spoke as if he had no choice, and Midley agreed with a wry smile. Seeing such an exchange, Obara thought to herself.

It wasn't just a little off, it was fundamentally wrong. But Obara wisely did not say what she thought, but only said, “I will take care of Milim-sama's escort.” And finally, Milim declared with a laugh, “Wahahahaha! As my Four Heavenly Kings, I expect you all to do your best!”

In a happy manner as always. And again, the conversation became more relaxed, as if things were back to normal.

“Whoa, whoa, are you seriously saying the Four Heavenly Kings?”

“Milim, you are influenced too much by Rimuru. Why don't you use a more normal title instead of the Four Heavenly Kings?”

“No! I like the Four Heavenly Kings! I've always thought it was unfair that Rimuru was the only one with Four Heavenly Kings!!”

“Well, I'm fine with it.”

“I am as well. Milim-sama can do as she wants, and I will follow her wishes.”

“As for me, I actually like it. I'm glad it was accepted.”

“...What? Well then, I won't be the bad guy who objects. That's fine, then.”

In the end, Frey finally broke from the line of agreements.



In the face of the enemies from the Otherworld, Milim's forces also deployed and waited. The total number of them had swelled to the largest in

the Octagram, having combined three of the old demon lords. Karion and Frey had evolved into the Million-class, and a reorganization was underway. Karion was appointed the General of the General's Army and was given command of the entire army. Frey, as Chief of the Guard, oversaw Milim's personal escort. Midley, as High Priest, was in charge of logistical support, leading the Warrior Priests. Obera, who has recently joined the group, became the military advisor and was in charge of strategy planning. These four were the Four Heavenly Kings of Milim.

The first group to be introduced was the main unit led by Karion—the Flying Beast Knights⁵². The leader was Suphia, and her second-in-command was Phobio. The former Beast Master's Warrior Alliance, a thousand members strong, was leading the remnants of Clayman's army and the warriors of the Beast Kingdom. The number of warriors had multiplied by a hundred, creating an army of 100,000. Add to this Karion's command, and it made for a fearless army.

Next to be introduced was Milim's Guards, a super-elite unit directly led by Frey. Lucia and Claire acted as adjutants, providing support to Frey, the commander. The knights of the skies soared while riding the griffins that were Frey's tiger cubs. They numbered a little over 3,000. The team was led by Frey's close aides, the Soaring Flock with each unit consisting of ten to thirty riders. Although the griffins were rank one magic beasts, their strength had been raised to rank by being trained by Karion. With the elite warriors of the Beast Kingdom and the Sky Queen's elite guards from all over the world riding on them, their overall strength exceeded A rank.

In addition, the Soaring Flock members were all affected by Frey's awakening, and their individual strengths were equivalent to the high A ranks. There were some who were comparable to Special A rank, and they were a considerable force to be reckoned with. In this world, it was the

largest army consisting of only those above A rank. Although they were only a little over 3,000 in numbers, they were fierce warriors who could easily fight in the air with high-speed maneuvers as one.

Finally, the last group to be introduced were the logistical support troops that had been gathered in a hurry. Although Midley was the representative, they were actually commanded by Hermes. There were stray majins, human mercenaries, and Clayman's former subordinates. It was a mixed unit consisting of a variety of people, but they had been entrusted to Midley to assist in the battle. Most of them had been involved in construction work until then, and their individual strengths ranged from D rank to B rank at best. Their temperament was not suited for fighting, and their duties were to carry supplies, procure food, and assist the priests as medics. However, they were numerous and numbered about 100,000.

This was the entirety of Milim's force, which totaled over 200,000. It was a formation in which the combat troops were in the front, protecting the support troops. In addition to this, there were reinforcements from Tempest.

Most conspicuous was the army led by Geld. They had been summoned for the construction of Milim's castle city, but they had gone straight into the defensive battle. Although not all of them had been sent to support other divisions, the Yellow Numbers and the Orange Numbers totaled to 35,000 people. They were a force specialized in defense, but the Yellow Numbers were particularly impressive.

With Geld's evolution, the fighting ability of the high orcs under his command had also greatly increased, and the number of members had risen to 10,000. Some of them had even reached rank A, making them a fearsome army on average. The Orange Numbers had also gained combat experience and were now an army of warriors. Their average rank was B, and they were as strong as any knightly order. In addition, when combined with

Geld's authority, they would serve as a shield to protect their allies with an ironclad defense. This time, they would not go to the front lines, but would protect the rear.

And let us not forget the Hiryyu led by Gabil. There were only a hundred of them, but all of them were Special A rank which was a ridiculous force. They were planning to participate in this battle in a flexible manner, going as wild as they wished.

Lastly, there was Carrera and Esprit. Even though there were only two of them, they were still considered a formidable force. With these reinforcements, they were going to fight against the army of Insect Lord Zelanus, but it was still going to be a tough battle. After all, the enemy numbered more than three million, more than ten times their own numbers. The wriggling insects were coming to them like a gush of water. And so, the dawn of war was about to begin.⁵³

First up was Carrera.

"If Milim won't do it, then I guess it's my turn."

And with that said, she happily stepped forward.

"Well, I really wanted to show them what I could do, but Frey didn't want me to. It can't be helped, so I'll let Carrera have this one."

Milim didn't stop either. Before they had realized it, the two had become best friends.⁵⁴ The damage to those around them had not doubled, rather it had become immeasurable due to the synergistic effect, but that was irrelevant to the two of them. As long as they were enjoying themselves, that's all they cared about, and they only increased each other's power to do so.

That's right, power. Power was strength! And strength was a destructive force.

“Damn insects, I’ll give you annihilation! The ultimate and most powerful—‘Abyss Annihilation’!!”

Carrera was a master at unleashing the most powerful magic from the very first move. With this, more than two million insects were extinguished. The gap of more than ten times was now reduced to four times. Seeing this, the faces of the soldiers who had been lamenting the hopeless difference in strength were filled with hope. At first glance, Carrera’s action may have seemed foolhardy, but it was optimal in terms of boosting morale. By reducing the enemy’s numbers before they could inflict casualties, Carrera had kept her forces strong and increased their will to fight. With this, it seemed that the battle would suddenly turn in their favor—that’s what they thought, but...

Frey’s bad premonition came true.

“It can’t be?! That one’s channeling my magic to the Otherworld...”

“Carrera-sama’s magic... I can’t believe it, but it’s true. This is why I hate insectars. Some of them can nullify magic, truly, they are our natural enemies.”

It was exactly as Esprit said. Carrera’s magic had been redirected by a single insectar. A feminine insectar with beautiful long, slender, iridescent wings. Her name was Peliod, and she was one of the Twelve Insect Generals who had absolute superiority over magic.

“Well now, this is not the time to be impressed. They’re almost here. Geld-san, please defend⁵⁵ the area above with all of your might.”

“Mm, understood.”

Carrera’s smile faded as she instructed Geld. He had his doubts, but Geld obeyed without question. As that exchange was going on, Esprit was moving quickly in the background. She sensed the situation with her Unique Skill ‘Discerner,’ and deployed her own defense magic to reinforce

the ‘Defense Barrier’ that Geld had put up.

“...What?”

Frey was wondering, and that’s when it opened. There was a strange distortion in the sky.

“Hm, just as I thought.”

“That’s Carrera-sama for you! She was able to decipher that complicated magic rewrite in one shot.”

“Naturally, or rather, it’s something basic. But more importantly, can we withstand it?”

“Huh, then I’ll help. If this castle is destroyed, Frey will be furious!”

As soon as she said that, Milim also held out her hand to the sky. Then, Geld’s ‘Barrier,’ Esprit’s defensive magic, and Milim’s protective curtain, were activated simultaneously. Immediately after that, a wave of destruction poured down from the rift in the heavens. It was, as expected, Carrera’s very same ‘Abyss Annihilation.’

“Wait, could this be—”

“Oh, come on, you mean that...”

Frey used her brain to guess what had happened. And Karion, with his instincts, also sensed what was going on. One step behind, Midley muttered.

“I see, so Carrera-dono’s magic was channeled into the Otherworld and its exit was reconnected above our heads. What an absurd thing to do...”

That was the correct answer. Gabil was the only one who couldn’t see what was going on, but that couldn’t be helped. It was as if Carrera, who excelled in magic, was having her most powerful magic spell being thrown back at her. That was difficult to believe even if it was explained, so it would be unreasonable for one to imagine it.

In the first place, it was hard to believe that such imitation was even

possible. In any case, for now, they had no choice but to let Geld and the others do their best, and they all prepared for the impact with bated breath. And for a few moments, there was a violent flickering of light and an impact that could turn the world upside down. It gradually converged and eventually subsided. After the tremors had died down, Carrera finally spoke up.

“I can’t believe someone would do something like this. If this had been Milim’s magic, I’m not sure what would have happened.”

Carrera had finally calmed down, having somehow managed to erase the ‘Abyss Annihilation’ she had unleashed. She then made a casual remark, but the others paled when they heard it. This time, the power had been reduced to less than thirty percent, so they were able to endure somehow. Even so, the terrain around the castle was badly damaged and the streets and other parts of the city were no longer visible. Reconstructing this area would be a headache, but fortunately, no human casualties were reported. But what if this had been ‘Drago Nova’?

“Wahahahaha! My magic is not so easy to control. It’s possible, but I think that only some of its power would be returned.”

“Even if it is only some of it, we might not be able to prevent it. What is it called? That magic is based on an unknown theory. It’s impossible to rewrite the laws, and I’m not sure if we’ll be able to defend ourselves.”

Carrera replied honestly. Carrera was good at magic, but Milim’s magic was on another level. To be honest, the two had always competed in terms of power, so she knew better than anyone else how dangerous it was. That being the case, Gabil raised a question.

“If so, then wouldn’t the enemy have been able to throw back Milim-sama’s magic?”

That was a very good point. Gabil was surprisingly smart and had a

great sensitivity in this aspect. It was Milim who replied.

“No, it was returned. That person has mastered ‘Spatial Domination’ to great effect. It seems that she specializes in computing power, but I’m sure that she can change the flow of any directional magic, regardless of its nature.”

Carrera agreed.

“I agree with you. I hate to admit it, but I think the bigger and more complex the magic, the easier it will be for her to manipulate. Even if this were a base-triggered ‘Nuclear Flame,’ she’d be able to anticipate the point of activation and cut off that space to nullify it.”

If it was a spell that didn’t have a time lag, she wouldn’t have time to pass it off, but that wouldn’t be enough to inflict a fatal blow. Carrera felt as if she had been deprived of the demon’s greatest asset, which was to read and fight with magic. At any rate, it was annoying to have someone on the enemy side who was good at magic.

“I apologize.⁵⁶ If I had known more about the insectars, I could have prevented such a dangerous thing...”

Obera bowed her head in apology, but there was no one who blamed her.

“Well, I guess that’s how it is.”

“That’s right. In fact, we were able to reduce the number of enemies with zero damage, so if you only look at the results, it was a great success!”

“True...since we’re safe, there is no point in complaining, so for now, let us think about our next move.”

Milim and Frey were right. It was true that Carrera’s blow had greatly reduced the enemy’s strength, and the morale of the uninformed soldiers was high. It would be more meaningful to strike the enemy with this momentum rather than to seek blame.

“From now on, magic is prohibited.”

“No objection!”

Carrera responded to Frey’s decision.

“In that case, let’s go head-to-head in a straightforward manner.”

“Sounds like fun. I don’t see the enemy king, but he has about eight generals. We have exactly the same number of executives as they do, so we should have a quota of one general each.”

When Karion expressed his opinion as a member of the Generals’ Army, Midley started saying something stupid. Carrera was in on it.

“Hahaha, sounds interesting. Then I’ll take the one who’s slouching over there.”

The one in front of her was Zess, who was sitting on the back of a flying insectar. As the head of Insect Generals, his presence was tremendous.

“That’s not fair! Then I—”

“No, Milim. You are the leader, so you have to stand your ground.”

“That’s right. If we’re in trouble, we’ll need you to come in and help us.”

“H-hmm, okay, I understand.”

Frey, who had stopped Milim from joining the fight, looked around the battlefield and declared.

“That is why, I will deal with that flying insect.”

Before her gaze was, a flying gold insect?—It was Torun.

As Carrera and Frey took the lead, the rest of the group started to panic.

“In that case, I—”

“I will—”

“I’ll—”

Karion, Gabil, and Midley all opened their mouths at the same time and their eyes crossed.

“Well, first come, first serve, no complaints, right?”

“Hmm, that’s fine. It’s been a while since I’ve had a real fight.”

“The same is true for me! In that case, let’s play this game like normal!!”

There was no time to interrupt. The three of them ran out of the castle as if to restrain each other. As if getting caught up in this, the army also began to move. Thus, the curtain of the great war was dropped.



Geld bowed to Milim and left to take command. The only ones left were Milim, Obera, and Esprit.

“You’re not going?”

“To be honest,” Esprit reluctantly spoke her mind, “I am not good enough, so I think it’s safer to watch the battle situation carefully and join someone else’s support. If I overexert myself and end up losing, I’ll only be dragging us down...”

It was a very wise decision. For once, Esprit was not slacking off.

“You’re right. If you underestimate the Insect Generals, you’ll get hurt. I don’t have much experience in fighting them, but I know that they’re not ones to be taken lightly.”

In fact, many of her friends had been killed by insectars. In particular, the one named Zess, whom Carrera was headed towards, was said to be a challenge even for Zalario. In all honesty, Obera herself could not be sure that she would win against him. Therefore, the three remaining members decided to wait and see how the battle would go.

Carrera, who had taken the lead, was the first to meet the enemy.

“A hindrance.”

And with that, she beat up and killed a bunch of enemies at once, running across the battlefield. At the other end of the field, she fired her Golden Gun at Zess, who was standing calmly. But Zess easily avoided it. Even a supersonic bullet at close range was nothing more than an insignificant toy to Zess.

“Wow, you’re not bad.”

Carrera was impressed.

She transformed the Golden Gun into a military sword with a golden blade.

“I’m Carrera. The one who will reap your life.”

“Nonsense. Such a joke, you’ll have to wait until I’m on my feet before you can talk like that.”

With those words, the battle had begun.

Frey jumped out at the same time as Carrera, and without waiting for orders, the Soaring Flock surrounded her. Naturally, Milim’s Guards followed suit. They were not entirely dedicated to escorting Milim, but this was not a problem because their roles changed in wartime. In the first place, Milim did not need guards. Now that Obera was still there, Frey could rampage without worry. So, while kicking flying insects to the curb, Frey made contact with Torun.

Torun was an Insect General with a shiny metallic exoskeleton to protect himself. He was stocky and not very smart. Looking closer, he was surprisingly large, reaching a height of two meters. However, he was a powerful creature that should not be underestimated. By using his two pairs of wings like a dragonfly, he was able to freely fly in a variety of ways.

Frey realized that Torun was troublesome when he evaded her just as she thought she had struck her first blow. Torun had dodged her claws from a high-speed flight while still staying in the air. This was due to the difference in the way they flew, and Torun seemed to have the advantage in aerial combat. Torun's compound eyes could catch Frey's movements as if they were in slow motion. Although Torun was inferior to Frey in terms of straight-line speed, he could easily predict where Frey would move, making evasion a simple matter.

Torun did not possess any special skills. His power was divided between the strength of his exoskeleton, predicting the future, and his flight speed. Although simple, Torun had a very strong composition ability. In particular, the nature of its fists was a special bio-organic steel material called alienium, and its strength surpassed even that of adamantite. It was strong enough to reach the mythical-grade level. Equipped with all the important elements of combat—reaction speed, defense, and offense—Torun was inferior to Frey in terms of existence value, but superior in terms of combat ability. Frey, who had planned to take out the enemy general at full speed, was about to suffer a major miscalculation. However, Torun made a mistake at this point.

“Kishi, Kishishishishi. You, slow. Me, fast.”

“Hah?”

With this single comment, Frey lost her temper. Milim would speak of this later. Frey was by no means a mild-mannered person. Anyone who made stupid remarks would soon learn firsthand how foolish they were. Because Milim was always being scolded, her words carried a lot of weight. And Torun would soon understand the meaning of these words with his own flesh.

Gabil was following Frey with the Hiryou in tow.

“Everyone, the enemy is an insectar, the same species as Zegion-dono and Apito-dono. I think you all understand how strong they are, but you must not let your guard down!”

Gabil’s loud warning was met with wide nods from his subordinates. They had always been beaten severely during their training in the labyrinth. Everyone was aware of the danger and remained overly vigilant. Kakushin, Sukerou, and Yashichi followed Gabil as he swept away the swarm of insects that filled the sky with his breath.

“Hey, hey, Gabil-sama! Are you going to help Frey-sama?”

“Hm? If she’s struggling, then I’d be happy to help—”

Gabil seemed uncomfortable with Yashichi’s question. He thought that Frey would not be pleased. Rather, there was someone else he was worried about.

“Mm, Gabil-sama, there’s someone over there who seems dangerous.”

Sukerou had discovered the person Gabil had been worried about.

“Yes. He looks vaguely like Apito-dono, but I sense a more vicious presence!”

And Kakushin responded with a similar reaction to Gabil’s concern. That’s right, Gabil had also perceived his existence to be a greater threat than Apito. Apito’s existence value was lower than Gabil’s, but when it came to combat, they were practically even. His odds of winning were not that high, and he was always forced to fight his hardest. And yet, the presence of this creature was more frightening than Apito.

Gabil’s instincts told him. This guy is dangerous. The creature’s name was Beathop. He was an Insect General with the characteristics of a bee and a grasshopper. Gabil was at a loss as to what to do. Even if it was only him, he would still be in a position to take care of the lives of his subordinates.

Because Rimuru had ordered him not to die, he felt that he should not try to fight a battle that he could not win. Although he had been carried away by Karion's and Midley's enthusiasm, Gabil was not that much of a fighter. He wanted to test his skills as a warrior, but he did not want to fight for his life.

Besides, if I were to get seriously injured here, Souka might shut me out. I made her cry the last time, and it is unimaginable how much trouble I had to go through to get her to change her mood...

Gabil wept over the bitter memories. There was such a thing as battle compatibility, so there was no need to give up the advantage of being able to fly. He didn't need to go to the trouble of challenging a dangerous opponent here, so he could just find an easier opponent to beat. Gabil thought as such and went to find another general—however, that was too naive.

“Hey, don't run away!”

Beathop was a formidable Insect General. In an instant, he had closed the distance between them and was floating in front of Gabil.

“What?!”

Gabil was able to react to Beathop's kick a moment later because he was accustomed to Apito's speed. In addition, the Vortex Spear had been raised to a mythical-grade performance level and was able to withstand the kick. Beathop, like Torun, also had the exoskeleton of his limbs turned into alienium. The same was true of the vital parts of his head and torso. He had a slender body, and his flight speed exceeded that of Torun's. He was an Insect General with cheat-like combat abilities. While his defense was equal to Torun's, his attack was greater than his. Even if they were to simply compare existence values, he was superior to Gabil. Frey would have been a more fitting opponent, and it was a heavy load for Gabil. However, in this situation, there was no way to escape. The only way to survive was to fight

and win, and Gabil had made up his mind.

“There is no shortage of opponents! My name is Gabil! I have been entrusted with the title of Draco Lord by Rimuru-sama!!”

Gabil said as such and confronted Beathop.

Karion ran across the land. He was followed by an Insect General whose back was covered with spider-like limbs.

“My name is Abart. You, I kill.”

“Spit it out. Don’t talk about things you can’t do!”

As they ran, a battle was raging between them. The divine Karion’s strength was not half bad. If it had been a one-on-one match without thinking about the future, he would have already unleashed a ‘Burst Roar’ and defeated Abart long ago. But that was not the case because this was a battlefield. There were other Insect Generals in the area, and he couldn’t show them his secret moves.

Besides, unlike in the labyrinth, death was the end. The most important thing in a battle was to survive, so he had to find a way to fight without overworking himself while also preserving his strength. He made this decision because he thought that his opponent was a lower rank than him. In the face of a truly powerful opponent, Karion would have given it his all without thinking about the consequences. But instinctively, Karion did not doubt his victory.

Abart’s existence value was less than half of Karion’s. Like the other Insect Generals, Abart had a combat-focused ability structure, but so did Karion. In this battle, Karion had the advantage.

The one Midley encountered was Saril, whose body was drenched in a seemingly poisonous liquid. Needless to say, his reddish-purple exoskeleton

was made of alienium. And from his tail oozed a deadly poison that would kill anybody who touched it. The poisonous scorpion (Sasori), Saril. It was a difficult opponent for those who excelled in hand-to-hand combat. But that didn't apply to Midley.

“Hmm, that's a problem.”

“Kekeke. You're one unlucky bastard to be standing before me.”⁵⁷

“*Unlucky?* You seem to be mistaken, so I'll tell you, but in a battle, luck is not a factor.”

“Ah?”

“It is true that there are phenomena in the world such as lucky punches and giant killings, with lower-ranked fighters defeating higher-ranked fighters. However, such feats are the result of hard work, and they are achieved by those who have honed their own unique weapons that can be used against their superior. It is not worth the effort if something like that is reduced to mere luck, is it not?”

“What are you trying to say, bastard?”

“Hmm, I'll put it simply. I am strong.”

And as soon as he said that, Midley disappeared. No, rather...

With an ‘Instantmove’ that Saril's perception could not catch, he closed the distance in an instant. Saril was blown away, the result of Midley's fist smashing into his face.

“Hmm, it hurts a little, but you get used to it.”

Midley's fist was smoking purple as he muttered this. It was Saril's poison. Midley's entire body was covered in a protective barrier of energy from the ‘Battlewill.’ The poison was so deadly that it could have corroded it, but Midley didn't care.

“Wh-what the hell is wrong with you?! You've been poisoned by me, and you don't give a damn—”

“It’s my fighting spirit. If I couldn’t do this much, I wouldn’t be Milim-sama’s sparring partner!”

Midley shouted. Regardless of the logic, it was loud enough to upset Saril. At first glance, Midley didn’t look very strong. So Saril was confused.

No, that’s crazy! There’s no way he can hit my exoskeleton with his bare hands and be safe. So then, what the hell is going on?!

Despite his thoughts, Saril still believed his victory to be unwavering. There was no way that a mere fragile human could harm him, an Insect General. But that was naive thinking.

Midley. Although he may look human, his true nature was of a true dragonewt, like Gabil. Moreover—

Normally, Midley completely concealed his abilities with ‘Battlewill,’ but his existence value was actually twice that of Gabil’s. Now, against Saril, Midley would show his true colors.

Geld returned to the front and spoke to his subordinates.

“Our job is to make sure no enemies get through.”

“ “ “Yes!” ” ” ”

All the generals responded to Geld’s order with great enthusiasm. There was no fear on their faces, and they looked coldly at the approaching enemies. The enemy forces were of various shapes and sizes. They looked as if they had been transformed into monsters by incorporating the features of large insects. There were few humanoid forms, but strangely enough, the closer they looked to human form, the stronger they seemed to be. At that moment, Geld’s gaze settled on a single point. A figure was sitting on the back of a huge centipede, over thirty meters in length. Judging by the overwhelming presence, he guessed that it was definitely one of the Insect Generals.

“I will deal with him.”

Geld muttered, and several of his subordinates nodded.

“Good luck!”

With those voices at his back, Geld took a step forward.

Esprit picked up her sword. Milim called out to her as she headed to the window.

“Are you going?”

“Ah, yes. Carrera-sama seems to be struggling, so I thought I’d help out, even in a small way.”

Esprit replied in a casual tone, as if she was going for a walk. As she observed from there, Insect General Zess, who was dealing with Carrera, had a fearsome fighting ability. Moreover, Pelioid was blocking Carrera’s magic, and she was on the defensive. She could no longer stand idly by and watch just because she was weak. Therefore, Esprit took out her hidden sword without hesitation.

It was a sword forged by Kurobee, and it was a legendary-grade weapon. Esprit, who had always believed that anything other than magic was useless to a demon, was now learning to use a sword in secret. Esprit’s boss, Carrera, was addicted to this hobby, so she wanted to keep that in mind as a subordinate. And more than that, the experience of fighting with Agera had caught Esprit’s interest.

Esprit thought it would be interesting for a demon to specialize in swordsmanship and began to secretly work on the development of magic swordplay. It wasn’t really ready for actual use, but now was not the time for that. Pelioid’s anti-magic ability was so great that Esprit could not penetrate it. It was a humiliating fact, but it was true. So, she decided to use her magic sword instead of magic.

“Well, the enemy doesn’t seem to care about one-on-one, so we have to make a move, right? That’s why I’m going to head out for a while!”

Milim smiled as she said so cheerfully.

“Hm, go and do your best!”

And so, with Milim seeing her off, Esprit set off for the battlefield.

Now, only Milim and Obera remained in the castle tower of Frey’s prided skyscraper. Here, Obera opened her mouth.

“Well then, Milim-sama, I will head on out as well.”

“Hm? You’re not hurt anymore?”

“I am sorry to have caused you concern. I am already healed, so please do not worry.”

“You’re so stubborn.”

Obera chuckled when she heard Milim’s exasperated voice.

“It’s in my nature. And, as you may have already noticed—”

“Mm. It’s the source of that sticky feeling enveloping the battlefield, right?”

“Yes.”

Obera nodded, her expression tightening.

“Insect Lord Zelanus is incredibly strong. I’m afraid I’m no match for him, so please be very careful.”

In truth, it would be best if Milim never had to come into play. However, Obera guessed that if Zelanus made a move, there would be nothing they could do to stop him.

So, although unwillingly, they had no choice but to rely on Milim. Therefore, she wanted to reduce the number of enemy generals as soon as possible. Just now, Obera’s eyes had caught sight of a single, free-roaming Insect General. It was Tishorn, with both hands turned into sharp blades.

She thought she should take them out and use the momentum to cover the others.

Now, it was a race against time. She wanted to take out as many generals as possible before Zelanus could move. However, the enemy's strength was too unknown for that to be easy.

"From what I can tell, there are some dangerous ones out there. Obara, please help me get them all back safely."

"By your will!"⁵⁸

Obara was filled with elation. How pleasant it was to be commanded by her lord. Unlike the previous battles where she had fought out of a sense of duty, this time she felt as if her strength was swelling from the bottom of her heart.

I see, I wonder if it was the same for all of you? If so, I wish I could have rewarded you with more.

She felt deeply sentimental, but that was only for a moment. The fact that Obara was alive now was the result of the wishes of her dear subordinates. If so, she could not stand still.

"I will go."

"Mm! The results of the battle, I'll be expecting them!"

With Milim's encouragement, Obara also headed to the battlefield. And so, the Great War grew even more fierce.

**Chapter
3**

**The Royal Capital
in Flames**

That Time I Got Reincarnated as a Slime

Chapter 3

The Royal Capital in Flames

The Congress proceeded smoothly. This was all thanks to the advance preparations. The necessary number of votes to pass the resolution had already been secured, so there was no chance of an upset here. In the first place, there was no way that anyone would be stupid enough to oppose the resolution when a settlement with the Empire was about to be secured.

That's why Masayuki, as the Emperor, stood up to sign the settlement document. The room filled with cheers and applause, and everyone watched as Masayuki ascended to the podium. Exactly as planned.

Testarossa and others, who had worked so hard to make this day happen, were all smiling with satisfaction. I'm sure she was the one behind all this, so I'd make sure to give her a pat on the back later. Now, go ahead and sign it. Then after that, the fun buffet party will be waiting. I'm sure that Hinata will change and show us her lovely dress this time as well.

I made all the preparations in advance, and I properly asked Luminas as well. This time, I had asked Luminas to tailor a very aggressive design for me. It was perfect. The bribe was expensive, but we were like-minded people. Luminas was understanding and agreed to a very reasonable price.

I don't care about autographs anymore, so let's just move on to the party

venue. Perhaps it was my fault for being so occupied with evil thoughts, but a loud explosion sounded from the direction of the party venue.

A moment later, the hall also shook.

“Masayuki, are you okay?!”

“Eh, what’s going on?”

Quit acting so lovey-dovey in front of me. Masayuki has Velgrynd-san by his side, who is also the perfect bodyguard, but that doesn’t mean he can just flirt with her whenever he feels like it. There was no need for me to worry about him, but as the one who was supposed to be entertaining him, I decided to say something.

“Masayuki, are you okay?”

“Ah, I’m fine. I’m glad that everyone seems to be safe, and above all—”

While saying this, Masayuki was looking around the assembly hall. When I looked at him, I saw that everyone was calm as one would expect of representatives elected from various countries.

“Of course. You can’t work with me if you get flustered by something of this level.”

Before I knew it, Testarossa had taken charge of everyone as if nothing had happened. With her precise instructions, the knights guarding the council were also moving around in an orderly fashion.

“I’ve ordered the Holy Knight Order to be vigilant as well. I’ve sent them to investigate what happened at the party site as well as around the council chamber.”

“Ah, thanks.”

Hinata came up to me and told me, reminding me of an important matter. That’s right, was the party venue safe? Even if the delicacies I’d prepared for the party were safe, if the venue itself was badly damaged, it would affect the party tonight. No way to just cancel it...

It can't be?! If that happened, I wouldn't be able to see Hinata in her dress. Such fears flashed through my mind, and I tried to run in a panic. But then.

«Rimuru-sama! I just received a call from Frey-dono. The army of Insect Lord Zelanus has invaded, and the war will soon begin!!»

Benimaru sent me an inexplicably cruel report that shattered any remaining hopes I had. No, it's okay, if I fly over there now and take care of Zelanus, I can still make it back by nightfall—

«Hey Rimuru, there's trouble!! I've been communicating with the demon lords as per protocol, but I haven't heard back from Damargania. Isn't this bad?»

It was bad. Of all the possible situations, having no contact was the most dangerous.

This is why I prepared a manual for just such a situation. While complaining in my heart, I told them through 'Telepathy Net' to continue collecting information. Ramiris seemed to have remembered the existence of the manual after I pointed it out to her. "I'm not panicking at all," she said as she went back to talking with the other operators. In any case, without information, there was no way to make a decision. That being the case, perhaps we should give up on the buffet party tonight...

At a time like this, I was reminded of an incident in my previous life. Yes, it was when I was still in my twenties and working as a general contractor. That day was the scheduled day of a major update to an MMORPG, which had become a daily routine for me, and I was excitedly waiting for my work to finish. Just as I was about to finish my work, the machine broke down...

No way, I had thought. We hadn't even finished cleaning up the site when the machine stopped working. Until the machine was repaired, all

other work would be stopped...and that was the moment I knew I would have to work overtime.

After giving instructions to arrange for night lighting, I contacted the relevant authorities such as the municipal office and the police, explained the situation, and completed the work that I could do by myself. I didn't have time to mourn, as I went around explaining the situation to the local residents as necessary. I had so much to do that I found myself working long past regular working hours.

What I am feeling now was just like what I had been feeling back then. In other words, I had to give up on seeing Hinata's dress. If we had to invade two places at the same time, we would have to be prepared for a long battle. It would be impossible to finish the job by nightfall. There was a high possibility that one of the battlefields was a decoy, and there was no way to deal with it in a euphoric mood. However, I decided to never forget the resentment that was welling up in my heart. I had to teach those fools that taking away my fun time came at a steep price...

With that in mind, I changed my mindset and began thinking of countermeasures.



Hinata noticed the change in me.

“Something's wrong, isn't it?”

I nodded and explained briefly.

“Ah, the enemy is on the move. It looks like something's going on over here too—”

“Yeah, we’ll take care of it.”

That’s Hinata for you. I didn’t even have to ask her, she just agreed.

“Testarossa, I need you to cooperate with Hinata and take care of the situation.”

“I understand.”

This is fine. For the time being, I decided to get a situation report from Benimaru.

«Benimaru, how’s the follow-up going?»

«I’m checking, but it looks like the situation is pretty bad.»

He responded without panic, but the situation seemed to be quite tense. I waited for the rest of the report, hoping that the damage was not worse than expected.

«I’ve received word. Surprisingly, both forces are evenly matched. It seems that Carrera’s supreme magic was the beacon that started the war, but there was someone on the enemy side who could throw it back, and it turned into a head-on collision—»

Throwing back Carrera’s magic?! I was wondering how a spell with such crazy power could be thrown back, but was it possible with the ‘Spatial Domination’ ability?

«It depends on one’s computing power, but it is possible. It also depends on the scale and power of the spell being thrown, but if it’s a directional destructive spell, it is possible to channel the power by distorting space. If a mistake is made, your own allies will be harmed, so it is not recommended.»

I see. If you take too much time to predict the point of impact, your teammates may get caught. And if the prediction fails, needless to say, you

will be hit hard. I suppose Ciel-san can do it, but unless there was no other way, it would be rejected.

If you think of it that way, it's a strategy built on the sacrifice of your allies, and the risk of failure is too great, making the enemy seems like a very daring gambler. So, because of that, it became a head-on collision, and the enemy had eight Insect Generals. The official name of the group was the Twelve Insect Generals, but now there are only eight Insect Generals left, not twelve, so the group was all together.

In addition to this, there was the presence of the Insect Lord Zelanus, and Milim could not move. Therefore, the Milim Four Heavenly Kings and even Carrera and the others all joined in to fight the Insect Generals. What's with the Milim Four Heavenly Kings?—putting aside the question, I was amazed that even the number was the same.

〈So, do you think we can win?〉

〈I'm not sure, but I'm sure there will be some tough opponents.〉

〈All right. In any case, let's send reinforcements.〉

〈I've already sent out 300 Kurenai in anticipation of that.〉

Oh, I knew Benimaru was great. He didn't waste any time and acted quickly and decisively. The 'magic transfer circle' could only transfer about fifty people at a time, but if we replenished the magicule ourselves, we could operate continuously. In addition, since there were plenty of magicules in our labyrinth, the time required to reuse them would be short. With Veldora's help this time, we were able to send 300 people out safely. Gobua, the commander, was also very motivated.

〈It seems that she has been dating Phobio for some time and was burning up about her lover's crisis. Well, I don't think she will fall behind so easily.〉

〈That's fine, but I'm worried if they'll have enough forces.〉

When you hear that the number of enemies exceeds one million, it's

natural to worry with only three hundred additional people. The quality of the individual people was very good, as they were all Over A rank. However, if they made a series of mistakes due to fatigue, it would not be surprising for them to collapse at once.

«Do you want me to send Gobta?»

Hmm, a hundred Goblin Riders. Our country was guarded by the labyrinth, and Gobta and the others had no business there. Or rather, I didn't want them to. The Goblin Riders were more suited to a wide battlefield. If we let them fight in the labyrinth, it meant that we were in a very tight situation. In that case, it's probably not a good idea to leave anything out here.

«Okay, let's do that. Ranga, you go with Gobta and protect him!»

«Understood!!»

Ranga's presence disappeared from my shadow. Just as I was feeling relieved, I heard Benimaru laughing.

«Fufu, Rimuru-sama still has a soft spot for Gobta as usual.»

«Eh, is that so?»

«Yeah. He's a great leader too, so there's no need to worry so much about him.»

«But you know, he's a little off sometimes, right?»

«Hahaha, he usually is, but on the battlefield, he's serious. But well, perhaps it's better to be overprotective this time...»

Benimaru's happy mood had changed. It seems that he sensed something disturbing about the enemy's behavior.

«Which means, even in your estimation, the enemy is strong, right?»

«It's unsettling. I'm "seeing" them through Geld's eyes, but the insects have no fear. They are tireless and continue to attack over the dead bodies of their own comrades.»

«Wow, that's a nasty enemy...»

«Geld says it reminds him of the time when they were under the control of his father (their lord).»

«Ah, the Unique Skill 'Starved'...»

That was more of a bad memory than a nostalgic one. But the image came through clear enough.

«Anyway, I pray for everyone's safety. You keep watching, and if the worst happens, don't hesitate to go for backup.»

«I understand.»

With that, I ended the conversation with Benimaru.



Ramiris was the next person I contacted.

«Well, did you get any response?»

«Hold on a second. I'm in the middle of something important right now—wait, no Rimuru! Listen, it's not that bad!!»

You're noisy. It seems that she thought I was someone else, but there's no way the 'Telepathy Net' could get mixed up in this situation. Now then, this guy, she skipped her training, didn't she?! That's right. I trusted Treynisan and Beretta's handling of the situation, but I had a feeling that it was wrong to put Ramiris in command...

«Can you put Beretta on for me?»

«Oh, wait a minute. You have to trust me—»

«Never mind that.»

«Yes.»

She switched speakers without saying a word. It's not that I was dragging the Hinata situation behind me, and it's not that I was taking it out on her, but this was an emergency situation. It was not a game. So, I would like to hear from Beretta.

«I just received a call from Zonda-dono. They have escaped to the callable area under Ultima-sama's orders.»

That's Ultima for you. Unlike a certain slack-jawed fairy, she acted according to the manual.

«So, what about the enemy?»

«They said: "They're terrifyingly powerful, we're asking for urgent support." What should we do? Would it be better to request the other demon lords to return our forces?»

Hmm, that was a good suggestion, but I was concerned about the fact that they were so powerful. If we were to move our troops, there was a high possibility that we would fall into the enemy's trap, and if possible, I wanted to keep our forces at a minimum. Before that, Ingracia was the dominion of Luminas. We could not borrow from Luminas. Leon had fallen into the hands of the enemy and Guy did not want to move from his guard of El Dorado. Regardless of whether Velzard attacked, I felt that it was a good idea to leave him there. If that was the case, I was the only one left who could put up a fight...

I wondered what to do. Should I send out the labyrinth team, or should I go myself? I was worried about this place as well, but I didn't feel any ominous presence. Testarossa was also here, and Hinata and the Holy Knight Order were also in motion. They could expect reinforcements from Luminas if necessary, and above all, Velgrynd-san was here. In that case—

«Ah, Rimuru-sama! I have more information on the enemy's forces. They have confirmed the appearance of Dino-dono and Leon-dono!»

When I heard that, my mind was made up. If Leon was there, I had to be the one to go. Now there was no more hesitation. I should go by the book and have Leon returned to our side. Well, I still had lingering doubts, but I decided to turn them into anger and take them out on the enemy.

«All right, I'll head out. I'll leave the command there to Benimaru, so tell Ramiris to take her training seriously.»

«...Understood.»

Beretta seemed to express an almost sad feeling, but I got the point. I'm not saying that she (Ramiris) shouldn't play commander, but she would have to learn the manual properly. Well, I couldn't help but think that it might have been a mistake to make the Control Room more luxurious. I recreated it from my memory and made it as gorgeous as one from any anime or manga. I wasted so much money on it that everyone wanted to sit in the commander's chair, which was annoying. I had even prepared a special seat for Ramiris, so she was already in the mood...

It would be fine if we were just playing around, but this was a serious battle. I gave her a firm warning to fulfill her duty.



A gentleman stood before Dagrue. It was Fenn. The reason he looked so gentlemanly was because it was in comparison to Dagrue. Fenn was slender yet tall like a giant, and his supple muscles were toned. His skin was white. It was morbidly white, having been depigmented by isolation in a sunless room for an uncanny number of years. His green hair was long and shaggy, and his eyes shone like jade. He wore a long, loose robe with

an open bust. Accentuating his appearance were the chains wrapped around his waist and shoulders.

The Gleipnir⁵⁹ that had bound him for years was now Fenn's favorite. With an elusive movement, Fenn walked towards Dagrue, his body swaying back and forth. At first glance, he seemed defenseless, but that was not the case. He was moving like a martial arts master, ready to respond to any attack. Fenn smirked.

"I've missed you, Brother."

Fenn called out to him, and Dagrue let out a big sigh.

"It's true that I missed you, but I never wanted to see you again."

"Oh, come on, don't say such lonely things. It's only us three brothers."

"That's right. That's why I'm so sorry that we went down the wrong path."

"Huh! You've changed, Brother. You used to be such a cool guy."

Fenn responded with a disgruntled look. To Fenn, Dagrue was his idol. But now, he felt that Dagrue has lost his fangs and was no longer interesting to him.

"We once stood up against Veldanava-sama. And now we know the reality."

"That's your excuse, isn't it Brother? I don't accept that."

"Nonsense! We're only alive because of his kindness!!"

"That's the thing, I don't like my brother being such a coward! And what about Veldanava? If Feldway resurrects Veldanava, then I'll see who's better, black or white."

"You idiot!! You don't know who he is—"

"Enough of this argument. It's all pointless⁶⁰ anyway. Now then, let's fight. I'll beat you and wake you up, Brother."

"Fenn, you..."

Both Fenn's and Dagrue's bodies were engulfed in a swirling fighting spirit. Under the tremendous pressure, the Heaven's Tower, which should be indestructible, shook violently. The next moment, Dagrue's fist plunged into Fenn's face with an impact that seemed to pierce the earth and sky. However, Fenn held his ground.

Then, in return, he squatted down deeply and delivered a heavy, sharp uppercut into Dagrue's stomach. Dagrue's body flew helplessly in the air, but Fenn seized the moment and threw a kick to his legs. The impact of Dagrue's massive body hitting the wall made the Heaven's Tower creak as if it were about to collapse. But Dagrue got up as if nothing had happened.

"Tch, I see that your skills haven't dulled."

"It's the same with my brother. Any normal person would've been done by now, you know?"

"Don't underestimate me. The name Octagram is something to live up to."

"You seem to like it."

"Quite a bit, yeah!"

As soon as he replied, Dagrue unleashed the full power of fighting spirit. Dagrue had an existence value of over 40 million. Although Fenn's existence value was greater, his pressure was also comparable to that of the True Dragons. The battle was left to each side's abilities.

Leon quietly stepped onto the battlefield. Standing in front of him was Dagrue's younger brother and Fenn's older brother, Glassord. He was about two meters tall, large by other races' standards but small by Giants' standards. His skin color was yellow, somewhere between that of his older and younger brothers. His eyes were purple and had an intellectual glow to them. He had the tendency to believe that he must remain open-minded⁶¹

because of the hardships he had suffered as a result of being sandwiched between his unrestrained older brother and free-spirited younger brother.

He was aware of this, but he could not help his innate temperament. It is for this reason that Glassord used a two-handed sword (Greatsword), a weapon that emphasized technique, which was unusual for Giants who excelled in bare-handed or clubbed weapons. He did not carry a shield and his fighting style was completely offensive, but that was a sign of his confidence.

Although Glassord's existence value was just under 2 million, and although he seemed fragile compared to his brothers, he was undoubtedly a million-class competitor. And his skill-level was the highest among the three brothers.

"You are Demon Lord Leon-dono, I presume. My name is Glassord. I am the second-in-command of the Titan Corps. I would have preferred to test my skills against you when you were not being deprived of your free will, but that will have to wait for another time—I will give up the win for today."

With that, Glassord stepped in front of Leon.

The gentlemanly Veyron stood in front of the languid Dino. Veyron was a duke-class demon peer, second in rank only to Grand Duke Moss. However, he had to admit that his odds were not just a little, but very bad against a pillar of the originals, which was comparable to the primordials. Still, this was better than his master who was dealing with two such originals at the same time, and he intended to fulfill his role to the fullest. That was, to buy time.

When asked so adorably, "Dino won't take things seriously anyway, so I think you can be a match for him. If I come out, Dino might get serious.

That's why I'll leave this to you, Veyron," he had no way to refuse. In order to live up to his master's expectations, he was determined to give it his all.

"Well, I guess I have to fight too..."

"If you'd be willing to stall for time, I'd be more than happy to do so."

"I can't do that. Unfortunately, I'm not even allowed to slack off right now."

That's what Dino said, but he was still trying to figure out how much was acceptable. It was frustrating that he couldn't say that, but he was relieved that he could say the following line.

"Well, Ultima is one thing, but I'll take you on with swordplay alone."

In other words, he was declaring that he wouldn't use his skills. He knew from Leon's battle that he didn't need to fight with all his might. If Leon had been serious, the battle would have been much more intense. Dino had once witnessed Leon's true fighting style. The flash of his sword was like light and had the power to slice through even the spirit. As far as he remembered, he did not believe that the current Leon was serious at all. That's why Dino also imitated him.

This is not slacking off, rather it is a way of not betraying my friends, that is what Dino told himself. Observing Dino's behavior, Veyron also understood. He was a demon who was very sensitive to the subtleties of people and their emotions.

Hmm. As Ultima-sama predicted, Dino-sama does not seem enthusiastic about this battle. If that's the case, I'm sure I can be a worthy enough opponent.

Once he understood that, the decision was easy. Pretending to be challenged by Dino and fighting back.

"I've been taken for a fool. Then, allow me to break your arrogant nose."

Saying this, Veyron performed a change with his Ultimate Gift ‘Artist.’ The figure he imitated was, of course, the youthful form of Byakuya Araki, Agera’s former life. In his hand was a sword forged by Kurobee. It was a legendary-grade work of art, made to resemble a walking stick. In fact, Kurobee had improved his skills since he arrived here. As shown by the sword he had given to Esprit, he had become an incredibly skilled swordsmith, with seven or eight of his ten swords being legendary-grade. In fact, it would not be long before he would reach the level of a divine craftsman. Kurobee’s sword fit well in Veyron’s hand. Veyron was beginning to understand the appeal of swords, though only when using the Ultimate Gift ‘Artist.’

“Interesting. I’ll take it a little seriously.”

That was a lie. Dino’s eyes were flickering with anxiety.

You’re okay, right? You understand what I’m trying to say, don’t you?

He was desperately asking that question. Veyron nodded broadly as if to reassure him.

“I’ll take your word for it. Take it easy on me!”

And with that, he made Dino smile.

In front of Pico and Gracia, Ultima stood alone.

“Hey, hey, Violet Primordial. No, it’s Ultima now. I’m sure you understand the situation, but are you sure you want to take on the both of us by yourself?”

Gracia asked. Ultima responded with a smile.

“Well, it’s not an issue. As for me, as far as I’m concerned, you guys are just the right amount to get used to.”

“Hm, hmm...we’ve been taken as fools...”

“I’m pissed off too. I won’t forgive you even if you cry!”

Unlike with Dino and Veyron, the conflict here was quite serious. Rather, Ultima was even enjoying the situation. She had assessed Pico and Gracia's fighting ability and concluded that they were weaker than she. She was right. Pico and Gracia were not weak, and were of course million-class, but their existence values were around 2 million, a step below Ultima. On top of that, Ultima had the rare experience of having fought to the death against a competitor of equal ability (Damrada). This fact confirmed Ultima's confidence, and she thought that these two would be the perfect test for her to hone her skills.

"If I hit you, maybe you'll get your free will back, so I'll cooperate with you."

"That's the kind of thing that never works."

"Yeah, that's right. It's none of your business!"

While exchanging such casual remarks, the head-on collision began.



The battle between Dagrue and Fenn was, to the casual observer, extremely intense. But in reality, neither of them was serious. If they had been, everyone in the area would have been put under the pressure of their fighting spirit, and some of them might not have been able to even stand. At the very least, it would have been less of a battle. But the time for observation would soon be over. The other groups did not want to fight in the small building and moved to their own battlefields. As a result, Dagrue and Fenn were the only ones left in the multi-storied Heaven's Tower.

"It's been a while since I've been this heated. Brother, I'm about to get

serious.”

“Hmph! That’s what I want.”

Fenn’s fighting spirit swelled. His power, rivaling that of the True Dragon, exerted a visible pressure on Dagrue. However, Dagrue was not to be defeated either.

“Nnngh!”

And, by letting his own fighting aura permeate his body, he transformed his muscles into something specialized for combat. This was the start of a full-scale battle between the two brothers, and each of their goals was non-negotiable. Fenn wanted the Dagrue of his rampaging days back. Dagrue, on the other hand, was seeking stability and order. He was willing to go to war if necessary, but he was not willing to go to war in vain. They had incompatible goals. However, the winner of this fight would be able to make his opponent follow their wishes. Because—

The battle would intensify. And so, little by little, Fenn gradually began to gain the upper hand in what had been a tight competition. The difference in strength was apparent. In addition to that, the decisive factor was the Gleipnir, a chain that Fenn could control at will. Veldanava had created it with his own hands, and it was an indestructible chain that boasted strength and flexibility above even the mythical-grade. Fenn had been bound by it for so many years that he had come to be able to control Gleipnir as if it were a part of his own body.

“Kuh, you’re so cocky...you’ve gained even more strength than before to have pushed me so far like this—Eh?!”

Dagrue was caught off guard and had his hands and feet twisted together by Gleipnir. He had an expression of anguish on his face. Fenn smirked.

“Brother—you’d better accept the memories of the pain I deeply

experienced!!”

And with that, he delivered a powerful headbutt. A moment later, Dagrue and Fenn’s souls touched, and their memories and emotions crossed. What resulted from this was the sharing of memories. As a result—
Dagrue remembered.

“Do you remember now, Brother?”

“Hmph, I feel like I’m awake.”

“I see, well that’s good.”

Fenn’s smile deepened. He then offered his hand to his brother Dagrue in a gesture of affection. That hand was clasped tightly—

“Now then, it’s time to fight. Let’s show the world the might of our Titan Army!”

“Of course! As expected of Brother, that’s what I’m talking about!”

Dagrue shouted, and Fenn smiled happily. The member of the Octagram, and the giant demon lord who guarded the Heaven’s Tower, was no more. The ancient evil deity had returned.



Under Dagrue’s command, the Giant warriors had all been summoned. The Titan Army was renamed the Chained Titan Army. And they began their march into the barren desert to recreate the tyranny of ancient times. It was not an orderly movement at all. Each of them took their own weapons as they saw fit and acted in accordance with the orders of the king, Dagrue. Thus, without any preparation time, the collective action was completed with a speed that could make a mockery of the military organization. Even

Glassord, who had been in league with Leon, was no exception.

“Hmm, it seems that the reason for hostility has disappeared. From now on, I will be your comrade in battle.”

As soon as he said this to Leon, Glassord left the scene. Leon dealt with this unperturbed. It had been the expected conclusion if Fenn won. Seeing this, Ultima felt like crying.

“Hold on, are you kidding me? No matter how much stronger I’ve gotten, this is just too much...”

She was tempted to complain. After all, the number of allies had decreased, and the number of enemies had increased. This was exactly the strategy that Rimuru had been aiming for, and now the enemy was trying to pull it off. Fortunately, Dagrue, who was now the enemy, ignored Ultima and the others and started to advance. No, she shouldn’t take that as a blessing, but she couldn’t help but think that they were lucky, because if they had been targeted right now, they would have been defeated. In any case, the situation was terrible. Even Veyron, who had fought evenly against Dino, could not hide his impatience.

“Ultima-sama, what should we do? We’re running out of time, and I wonder if it’s best to start all over again.”

Not fearing Ultima’s displeasure, he even suggested so. Without complaining about this, Ultima fell silent. She was thinking.

“Hey, you’ve definitely gotten stronger. I’ll give you that. But with Dagrue joining us, you won’t be able to win anymore, right?”

“That’s right. You should just admit defeat and leave to the demon world. Then we won’t have to chase you, and we’ll call it a draw!”

Gracia and Pico, who had been completely outclassed, were now in high spirits. Like Ultima, Pico and Gracia were fighting without using their skills. As a result, they had been humiliated even when outnumbering the

opponent two to one. But now that the tables had turned, they felt happy, regardless of their position.

“Shut up... I know that, too. But if I back out now, I won’t be able to show my face to Rimuru-sama...”

Ultima was getting more and more grumpy. When this happened, she became more in the mood to go on a rampage, rather than win. She had been told by Rimuru that Dino and the other two were only under Michael’s control. Therefore, she had been trying to neutralize them without really trying. But the question was, if she really tried, would she be able to defeat all the enemies in this place? If it was a matter of life and death, the odds would be better.

But even so, Ultima knew that she could not be sure. Leon, Dino, Pico, and Gracia. Of the four, Dino would be the most troublesome. And perhaps, if Leon and Ultima were serious, it would not be surprising if either of them won. In other words, there was no chance of victory. Veyron was right, and that is why Ultima did not throw a tantrum and remained silent. She wondered what she should do, but the situation did not allow for it. And so, Ultima made up her mind.

“I believe in Rimuru-sama! He should be here soon, so we’ll hold them off until then. Any objections, Veyron?”

“By your will!”

And so, the plan was set.

“Kufufufu, you made the right choice. I commend you, Ultima.”

The long-awaited reinforcements had arrived just in time.



I took Diablo and Souei to the Holy Void Damargania. We met up with Zonda via ‘Spatial Transportation’ and rushed to Ultima’s side. The scene we saw on the way was horrific. The giants were gathering in a chaotic manner, and before I knew it, they were forming into a disciplined army. At the head of the group was Dagrue, but he seemed to be a different person from the one I knew. Our eyes met for a moment, and he grinned at me. To be honest, it felt dangerous.

I wondered what I should do, but there was only one answer. Now was not the time to be dealing with Dagrue. I contacted the relevant parties via ‘Telepathy Net’ and left the scene as quickly as I could.

And so now, I had just met up with Ultima and the others. I had brought Diablo and Souei with me. Add to that Ultima, Veyron, and Zonda, and we now had a force of six. The opponents were Leon, Dino, Pico, and Gracia. If we could bring Leon back to his senses as planned, our victory would be secured.

“What, Rimuru’s here too?!”

“That’s right, Dino-kun. However, I’ll deal with you later!”

I replied, focusing my attention on Leon. Leon seemed to be aware of my intentions. The fact that he wasn’t showing any signs of opposition was proof that Michael’s control was not at the brainwashing level. Although, I didn’t think it was possible for anyone to force a person with a will strong enough to acquire an Ultimate Skill to swear their allegiance wholeheartedly just by their own power. Even if there was such a thing, it would be fake, and the current situation suggested to me that it would only restrict the actions against Michael’s will. So, I decided to do something about the situation. As I had declared, I would start with Leon, leaving Dino for later.

“Leon, prepare yourself! Now devour all ‘Imaginary Space (Beelzebuth)’!!”

And so, a huge move was launched right from the start. With the ‘Imaginary Space (Beelzebuth)’ under the control of the Ultimate Skill ‘Void God (Azathoth),’ Leon was guided to the invisible world⁶². And then, immediately, Ciel-sensei performed a forced ‘Skill Alteration’ on him. That was how Leon—

“Sigh—even if it were part of the plan, I never want to do that again.”

...Well, he was successfully recovered. Thus, Leon had returned as one of us. The next target was the languid Dino. His resistance would probably be small, since he showed no motivation to begin with.

I had put it off, thinking it would be easy to bring him back to his senses, but let’s just finish it all at once. That’s what I thought, but it seems that it was a naive idea.

I felt a strong presence. It was an oppressive feeling, as if a True Dragon was getting serious. At the same time, there was a report from Souei, who had been in constant communication with the Control Room.

“Rimuru-sama, here—the area around the Holy Void Damargania has been isolated by an impenetrable ‘Barrier.’” It was confirmed. The enemy boss had arrived.

“Kufufufu, we’ve been taken for granted for you to be coming alone.”

Laughing, Diablo looked at the figure standing calmly. It was Michael, the man who had taken over Rudra, with a face very similar to Masayuki’s.

“Leon has been returned to us.”

“I don’t care about that. Leon’s Skill, the ‘Purity King (Metatron),’ is already in my hands, and he himself was merely the bait.”

“Bait...?”

«As I thought, it's a double check.⁶³ It seems that he was thinking of the same move as us, to the point of being brilliant.»

Uhh, dou-ble-che-ck...a double check?! Then, in this case—

«Leon is the bait, and the likely target is—»

It's Masayuki!

«...That's correct.»

I've been beaten. He dangled Leon in front of me as the bait and let me weigh it against Masayuki as the king. And then, I was caught brilliantly. In other words, Michael's plan had already been accomplished once he lured me to this place. I understood that Masayuki was important to the enemy, but I hadn't expected him to be so obsessed. Still, if I couldn't be contained here, Michael's plan would have failed...

“Isn't it too early to feel like you've won?”

“Is it? I don't think you guys will have a chance as soon as I get there.”

How confident. Even though Dino and the others were still with the enemy, I could free them from his control. I was surprised he was so confident while knowing that. Or perhaps, did he have some other plan to win?

“Hmph, your expression is saying that you think I'm up to something. Rest assured. You are nothing to me. I went along with Feldway because he was a worrier, but I should have done this from the start.”

The moment I finished listening to Michael's words, Diablo suddenly collapsed. I had been on guard with 'Magic Perception' as a matter of

course, so I was certain that it wasn't a surprise attack or something like that. To begin with, I had never seen Diablo fall before. I didn't think he was dead, but the fact that he wasn't moving at all worried me.

“Hey—”

The moment Souei was about to run over to him, Souei himself collapsed on the spot.

Wah?

I don't understand. Faced with a completely abnormal situation, Leon readied his sword—and collapsed. Are you kidding me? I have no idea what's going on. I wasn't the only one who was surprised, Dino and the others were as well. That meant that the only one who knew what was going on here was Michael, the one who was supposed to be attacking us. What the hell is going on—

«No way...»

‘No way,’ huh? In other words, even Ciel-san didn't understand. That's not good. I didn't know what was going on, and it seemed impossible to escape. However, the possibility of abandoning Diablo and Souei and running away was not an option from the beginning. Leon as well.

“Ultima, take those lying over there and get away from here.”

“B-but—?!”

“It's okay. I've got an idea!”

I didn't have one.

“K-kufufufu. Please wait, Rimuru-sama. I can still fight.”

Oh, so Diablo is okay after all.

“Hmm, I had the feeling he wasn't dead, but I guess I should've taken care of him.”

Seeing Diablo on his feet did not dampen Michael's spirits. He appeared to be absolutely confident that he could beat him as many times as he wanted. I thought to myself,

This is a serious problem.

"Okay, Diablo. Retreat. Take Leon with you and get going."

"But!"

"That's an order. There's no way to win, so the best thing to do is escape."

As I said that, I drew my sword and readied it. I knew that Michael wouldn't let me go since he was after me. So, the best thing to do was to use myself as bait and let the others escape. Diablo, of course, understood this. Even so, he seemed quite conflicted, but the word "order" appeared to have worked. He teamed up with Ultima and retrieved Souei and Leon. Then they retreated.

"Hmm, I thought you were going to interfere."

"I have no interest in small fry."

Wow, it's a good thing Diablo wasn't listening. That's a line that would put him straight on the must-kill list, right? He's vindictive, so he would definitely achieve it one day. That's what made him such a dangerous guy. Even so, on my own, it was one against four. Michael alone would have been hopeless, but now I was good as dead.

Well, worst-case scenario, Veldora was still here, so I think I could be revived, but the thought of actually testing it still felt bad. Would the resurrected me really be the same as the current me? That was the question that came to mind. That's why I didn't like the idea of Veldora dying either...

As I was thinking about this, Michael made a move.

"Dino, leave this place to me, you guys should return as well."

Oh, thankfully, he seems to want a one-on-one duel. Well, he might have found out that I was planning to free Dino and the others when I had the chance, but I knew the odds of that succeeding were slim, so it was definitely not a bad deal for me.

“Eh, is that okay?”

“It doesn’t matter. If I have complete control over his mind, I won’t be able to move as flexibly, and in his current state, he’ll cut corners, won’t he? I can’t use a pawn like that.”

Oh, I see. He knew that Dino and Leon weren’t really following him. So then, does that mean that Michael has completely beaten us to the punch this time?

«...»

No, it’s okay. Even Ciel-san makes mistakes, too.

«No. This is also part of the plan.»

Once again, you should be generous about your defeats⁶⁴. Ciel-san’s hatred of losing was also a problem. Well, I guess I’ll stop talking so casually and do my best to not make things worse. Now that I knew I was going to lose, I felt much better. I didn’t want to be seen in a bad light, but now that Diablo and the others were gone, it was fine. The only thing left to do was to give it my best. I prepared myself and began observing Michael. I could sense that his presence was much stronger than when I had met him before. Is it several times greater than mine?

«We aren’t in the labyrinth, so it can’t be measured exactly, but I’m

pretty sure the value is over 100 million.»

We can't win like that! Even if the difference was more than double, it would be unreasonable, but a difference of more than 10 times was just too much.

«No, it's okay. It is the power output that matters, so the outcome cannot be decided by the amount of energy alone.»

So, it's all about fighting spirit. Is it will-power? Ciel-san was bad at giving up, but it had a point. If you give up before the fight ends, your chances of winning become zero, but if you at least try, you might be able to unexpectedly get by. The problem, however, was Michael's mysterious attack that had even defeated Diablo. I had no idea what he did, but somehow, I felt a vague sense of déjà vu. That's right, that was—

«Yes, it was a familiar phenomenon. That sensation...I am almost ready to understand it—»

Oh, Ciel-san is very dependable after all. So, then it was expected that Michael would launch that attack?

«No. Regarding that matter, it was a complete miscalculation.»

I-I see. Well, it can't be helped. It's impossible to perfectly predict an enemy's moves, and we can also use this opportunity to uncover the mystery that would lead to the next victory. In that sense, this defeat is also—well, I haven't lost yet. I'm worried whether I'll actually be able to be

revived, so let's give it our best shot. While I was thinking about this, Dino and his friends had left. Only Michael and I remained here. Here, in the hall of Heaven's Tower, the battle between Michael and I was about to begin.



After seeing Rimuru off, Hinata tried to grasp the current situation. The Capitol building where the world conference was being held also had conference rooms and guest rooms on other floors. She rented one of these rooms as a temporary command center and began to compile reports from her subordinates. Once she grasped the situation, she let out a sigh as her head began to hurt.

“What the hell is going on...”

She couldn't help muttering to herself. The Capitol was fully guarded to protect the safety of the dignitaries from various countries. Not only the Holy Knight Order, but also knights and temporarily recruited adventurers from various countries, were on guard duty. If the Capitol were to fall, the chain of command would be disrupted, and so the refugees would be received elsewhere. The main hall of the Holy Church in the Kingdom of Ingracia was also opened to receive refugees, and there were plenty of refugee centers throughout the capital. This was because the city had always been prepared for the Tenma Great War, which was said to occur every 500 years or so.

This was the case in not only the Kingdom of Ingracia, but in the Western Nations as well. People were provided with shelters in underground bunkers and caves in the nearby mountainsides. This was also

the reason why they could sufficiently cope with the thorough evacuation, which was also on the agenda this time.

Regarding the current terrorist acts in the capital, they made sure to mitigate the human damage by evacuating the residents to such facilities. The purpose of this was to prevent major confusion from occurring and to prepare an environment in which they could concentrate on dealing with the enemy. As of now, the results of the daily training had been demonstrated and the people were successfully led away. The evacuation was complete, and the people who escaped were now calm.

However, this was not a solution to the problem. This time, it was not a natural disaster, but rather the people who caused the disturbance. According to reports, explosions were happening all over the capital, and they were turning into fires. The cause of the fires was said to be majins of Special A rank and above. The Holy Knight Order had been mobilized for this event, as it was a gathering of dignitaries from various countries. Fortunately, the Holy Knights who were on guard duty were able to handle the situation, but the situation was not good.

Hinata was disgusted, but due to her position, she was not allowed to show even a hint of her true emotions on her face. It would only increase the anxiety of her subordinates and create unnecessary work for her. Moreover, Hinata deeply understood that she should not become emotional in front of the evacuees. It would be a problem to further upset people who were already worried. So Hinata did not waver. All Hinata could do now was reduce the anxiety of the evacuees and prevent further chaos, even if only a little. Fortunately, the facilities were comfortable and there was a stockpile of food. At any rate, the right thing to do for now was to deal with the enemy without worrying the evacuees.

“I’ll leave this to you. Have at least one Holy Knight stay at each shelter.

Have the Templar Knights help as well.”

“ “ “Yes!” ” ”

The enemy wasn’t just on the outside. The evacuees could also turn into a mob at any moment. Things were still calm now, but there was no telling what would happen if it took too long to eliminate the enemy. Those confused by fear, and those who screamed and rioted from anxiety. It was expected that the number of such people would increase as time went on. It all depended on the future situation, but in the worst case, it might be necessary to devote troops to suppress the riots. With that in mind, Hinata swallowed a melancholy sigh.

A short time had passed since the explosion had occurred. Now, at last, the full extent of the enemy could be seen.

“A riot of the death penalty prisoners?”

“Yes. Moreover, the enemy has freed Prince Elric, who was under house arrest in the north tower of the castle, and has made him their flagbearer!”

“Prince Elric—I see, that man hasn’t shown any remorse at all.”

Elric was in the process of being re-educated due to his blunder at the council. He was on the verge of being deprived of his right to the throne, but Rimuru and King Aegil of Ingracia, who didn’t want to make things worse, agreed that he would be reduced to the first degree of guilt as he was only being used at the time. Still, it was a disgrace to the royal family, and for the past year he had been under house arrest in the north tower of the castle...but it seems that he had fallen into the hands of the enemy. To make matters worse, he seemed to be voluntarily cooperating with them. Not only that, but Elric and the others were accusing Hinata by name.

“My dear people! I have been deceived by a witch! She has framed me and ruined my standing in the council. And now she wants to murder my

father and bring chaos and misery to this land. Do not be fooled! She is trying to take away your freedom on the pretext of evacuating you! I trust that my dear and wise people will understand whose words are correct!”

...Said Prince Elric, who was apparently making a speech in the city’s main square.

“Is that true?”

“I heard it with my own ears.”

“Can you corroborate?”

“I can’t get into the royal castle at the moment. I am checking it via Luminism’s followers, but they seem to be quite confused...”

“Then there’s a good chance that King Aegil has been killed. What a terrible thing...”

It was a headache. Although she had expected a mob to be incited, she hadn’t expected someone to make the worst choice at the worst time. To make matters worse, it was the royal family of the Kingdom of Ingracia who were the cause of Hinata’s troubles. Prince Elric had caused problems, but the details of those problems had not been made public. That was an issue, and it only complicated the situation. He was using his position as a member of the royal family to the fullest to mobilize the power of the state. Even Hinata had not expected to see such a disruption in cooperation with the parties during an emergency situation.

“Now then, what should we do?”

A white-haired beauty garbed in a military uniform appeared in front of Hinata as she pondered this. Leaning back on the sofa as gracefully, as if she were the owner of the room, the beautiful woman, Testarossa, opened her mouth.

“I’ve gotten proof. Moss has confirmed with his own eyes that Aegil was murdered.”

“—In other words, the upper management of this country is unreliable. All hell is breaking loose, isn't it?”

Testarossa nodded with a laugh, saying that the castle was in a state of chaos.

“Yes. Going back and forth, the chain of command is in chaos.”

‘That’s right,’ Hinata nodded in agreement.

“Well, Gadra has been ordered to protect the council chamber, so the safety of the dignitaries is guaranteed.”

Testarossa assured her that he could at least buy them some time. This was a pretty high evaluation, and Gadra was surprisingly well acknowledged.

“Well, that does offer a bit of relief.”

Testarossa and Hinata nodded at each other. However, now things had become tricky. Not only was there an unknown enemy, but there was also someone who wanted to harm Hinata. They seemed to be accusing Hinata by name for being a witch who misled people, but this was difficult to deny. It would not have been a problem if the enemy was just an ordinary person. If they were a nobleman, Luminism’s public power could have crushed him. But this was the royal family of this country. The biggest problem of all was that Prince Elric was very popular among the people.

Prince Elric was a handsome man with delicate manners, and he was popular among women. Regardless of his abilities, he was popular with the people because of his good-natured exterior. His blunder in the council was not known to the people and was irrelevant. Hinata, though well known, was shunned for her cold-heartedness. In terms of popularity, she was far behind Prince Elric.

Incidentally, Hinata herself was not aware of the fact that she had a huge following among some people with certain tastes. The group was quite

gentlemanly, as they had the common sense to know that it would end once they were known. All that aside, the problem now was Prince Elric. The subordinates were looking at Hinata anxiously.

That was only natural. Because the prince of this country was loudly denouncing Hinata to fuel the people's anxieties. He was calling her a king-slayer, a witch enchanted by the demon lord, and someone who would lead the people to ruin.

But even so, I can't believe... I didn't expect him to be such a fool...

Inwardly, Hinata cursed herself for being so careless. She hadn't seen Prince Elric for the fool he was. Hinata had never expected that he would go to such horrible lengths to kill his father and usurp the throne. Just then, there was a knock at the door and a knight entered the room. It was Arnaud Bauman, one of the captains of the Holy Knight Order, Hinata's trusted subordinate.

"Hinata-sama, we have also confirmed the presence of Reiner, the former Knight Commander of the Kingdom of Ingria. In addition, we have confirmed the presence of dozens of knights who were supposed to have been captured as his accomplices."

Arnaud reported as soon as he entered the room.

"Then it was Reiner who murdered the king, wasn't it?"

"I'm sure of it."

"He's been framed as the culprit, but I doubt he'll have the chance to explain himself in court."

Hinata let out a big sigh in thought.

"Reiner, that fucking bastard. How dare he hold a grudge against Hinata-sama just because he was beat up at the council meeting!"

Fritz, one of the captains waiting in the room, complained indignantly. According to Arnaud's explanation, Reiner, who had been intimidated by

Hinata at the council meeting and had made the mistake of being incarcerated, was eager to clear his name. For this reason, he was planning to defeat Hinata in public to clear his name. It was a ridiculous story; a crime being committed out of personal resentment. However, the root of the problem was deep.

Reiner took forceful measures to make up for his mistake. This was the common understanding of everyone, but there was no way to prove it. The whole thing was a setup, and the evidence seemed to have been destroyed. There was a way to get other countries' representatives to testify, but that was only possible during peacetime. In such a case of emergency, they could not endanger the senators, and the people would not believe anything Hinata and the others had to say now anyway. Unfortunately, Prince Elric was very popular in this country. It was as clear as day who the people would believe.

“Hinata-sama has never had a good reputation...”

Fritz quipped, and Arnaud gave a small nod of agreement. Glaring at the two, Hinata changed the subject with a comment of her own.

“I guess we’re on the back burner.”

“But even so, I didn’t think he would kill his own father, the king. He seems to be trying to pin the blame on Hinata-sama, but that’s just absurd.”

Hinata’s mutter was echoed by Arnaud. The purpose of Prince Elric and Reiner was obvious. They wanted to take advantage of the chaos and pretend that all their own blunders and sins had never happened. Rather than taking revenge on Hinata, they may be using this as a check against other nations. They may be thinking that by defeating Hinata, the strongest of the Western Nations, they would be able to shut down protests from other nations.

“But I don’t understand. I don’t think this Reiner guy was good enough

to assassinate the king.”

From Hinata’s point of view, Reiner was not weak, but he was not strong either. He was the equivalent of an Over A rank adventurer. A country as large as Ingracia should have several other knights who could rival Reiner. Moreover, the magical inquisitors who were present at the council meeting at that time should have been able to overpower Reiner. How this tragedy had succeeded was more of a mystery to her. The answer came from Cardinal Nicolaus, who visited Hinata.

“Apparently, the magical inquisitors have all been killed. We had information that they were conducting a suspicious experiment in the underground of this place, but it seems that the experimental entities have gone out of control.”

“Nicolaus, huh?”

“I have come with a message from Luminas-sama, but I decided to look into this while I was here.”

Nicolaus replied, competent as ever. He was like a loyal dog who would do anything to be praised by Hinata. He was merciless to everyone other than Hinata, but he was also very good at keeping up appearances. Nicolaus maintained an expression of warmth and was well-liked by his followers. However, for those who knew his true nature, he was not someone they wanted to have anything to do with. In fact, Arnaud and Fritz kept a low profile, avoiding eye contact with Nicolaus.

Ignoring these outsiders, Nicolaus began to brew a pot of tea. He was a very diligent man who also earned points in this way. He prepared a cup of tea for Testarossa as well, and she looked satisfied when she took a sip of it. This was indicative of a very high score and proved that Nicolaus was no ordinary person. Hinata also sipped her tea and collected her thoughts.

“What if, rather than taking advantage of the chaos, this whole mess is

just what Elric and the others want?”

“Eh? But those are monsters running rampant in the city, aren’t they?”

“That’s the first thing that’s strange. How could a monster break into the royal capital that’s protected by the ‘city barriers’? To begin with, the strength of the monsters is also rubbish, isn’t it?”

The monsters reported were not in one, but rather several at the same time. They were said to be rampaging all over the capital, but their purpose was unknown. They were said to be going around destroying anything and everything they could find. Moreover, it seems that they had ‘Ultraspeed Regeneration,’ which allowed them to heal their wounds immediately. The fighting ability was more than that of a Holy Knight. Fortunately, they seemed to be of low intelligence, and the knights were currently preparing decoys to minimize the damage.

Judging that it would be dangerous to deal with them individually, the soldiers were ordered to stay behind for now. After considering how to deal with them, Hinata was scheduled to go into battle in the worst-case scenario, but now a problem had arisen that they had to worry about. Testarossa joined the conversation.

“On that note, it seems that some of my subordinates have been defeated. They were under strict orders to retreat before they died, so I didn’t get much information—”

She didn’t get much but would still disclose the information she had. Testarossa’s subordinates were the devil chevaliers. All of them are Special A rank, with existence values of over 100,000. It was no surprise that the magical inquisitors were no match for such a group of devil chevaliers, who had chosen to retreat.

“Apparently, the experimental subjects were incarnated by angels.”

“What is that?”

“The ones that failed to incarnate are the monsters that are running rampant right now. And the ones who still have their egos intact—”

The enemy who had defeated the devil chevaliers—Testarossa was convinced that it was one of Michael’s men. After hearing Testarossa’s explanation, Hinata tapped her fingers on the desk. The two remaining Holy Knight captains in the room were Arnaud and Fritz. Leonard, the second-in-command, was in charge on the scene with Bacchus and Ritase in tow. Thanks to the training in the labyrinth, even the common Holy Knights who were not captains had grown into powerful warriors. In fact, the captains had become so strong that they were capable of defeating Clayman-like opponents on their own.

However, against an experiment of magical inquisitors fused with the power of angels, it would be dangerous to take them head-on. And with Michael’s shadow flickering in the background as Rimuru’s adversary, she decided that they shouldn’t get involved carelessly.

“Nicolaus, you have a message from Luminas, right?”

“That’s right. She says it’s not an urgent matter, but she can’t send reinforcements.”

“That means there are other enemies.”

Luminas would never abandon Hinata. Therefore, the fact that she could not send reinforcements meant that there was a high possibility of other threats lurking about. If that was the case, they would have to protect the security of the Royal Capital with only the forces currently at hand—

“This is tough.”

That was the conclusion that Hinata came to. No matter how much the Holy Knights’ abilities had improved, it was still a heavy burden to have them take on an enemy that was clearly superior to them. What’s more, the monster has taken in the power of the angels and had become a light

attribute. The Holy Purification Barrier, which was effective against normal monsters, would not be effective at all.

“Well then, what should we do? Our usual winning tactics won’t work.”

“That’s true. It would be one thing if it was just the monsters, but there are also Reiner and the others.”

“That Reiner fellow, he is probably a success.”

Testarossa said, but only Hinata and Nicolaus understood what she meant.

“Uh, what do you mean by that?”

Arnaud asked fearfully.

“I’d tell you to think for yourself a little, but we don’t have much time. If Reiner was also on death row, it wouldn’t be strange if he was used as an experiment, right?”

“Ah!”

“I see, so it’s possible that he’s taken in the power of an angel...”

Arnaud and Fritz understood, and their faces paled at the same time.

“It’s not a possibility. Consider it a certainty.” Testarossa told them ruthlessly.



Now, that being the case, it was impossible for the Holy Knight Order to deal with this matter alone. Inevitably, it would be important to cooperate with Testarossa’s forces.

“So, what are you going to do?”

Testarossa asked, and Hinata answered without hesitation.

“I’m sure it’s what the enemy wants, but I suppose we’ll have to go to them for an explanation.”

Prince Elric claimed that Hinata was a king-slayer. There was no reason for Hinata to do such a thing, and she had a perfect alibi of being at the World Conference, so it was impossible for her claim to be accepted. However, that would only be true in normal peacetime. The current situation in the royal capital was chaotic. The people of Ingracia, accustomed to a world of peace, were in the midst of a catastrophe that had come out of the blue. If Hinata were to be killed here, all the claims about the real culprit would be accepted. In that case, running away was one option.

“Why don’t we just escape to Lubelius instead of foolishly going out there? Fortunately, the Holy Church in the capital has a transport team, and there is also a transfer spell if you pass through the suburbs. As long as Hinata-sama is safe, there can be many possible explanations later on, right?”

Cardinal Nicolaus remarked, and Hinata agreed, that it made sense. But she couldn’t simply nod in agreement.

“It’s impossible. We may be able to escape on our own, but we won’t be able to take out the conference attendees, right? Once they’re taken hostage, we won’t have many other options.”

Everyone agreed with that.

“Exactly. Besides, let’s not forget that the true enemy is not here. What would happen if the army of angels were to attack, and the nation’s key figures were killed?”

Upon hearing this, Nicolaus frowned.

“I see, you are right. If that were to happen, the cooperation between the nations would be torn apart. At the very least, no country would trust the

Kingdom of Ingracia.”

“I see, if that happened, we wouldn’t be able to fight against the angels.”

Fritz muttered with a bitter expression on his face, as if he had been convinced. In conclusion, there was no choice but to do as Hinata said. Based on her beliefs, Hinata set out to do what she could for now. She did not want to save everyone, but if there was someone in front of her who could still be saved, she would reach out to them, because that was how Hinata lived. Hinata knew very well that this would in turn lead to trust in them.

“Well, I guess that’s settled. Now, let’s decide the division of roles.”

Hinata said as such and declared that she would be Reiner’s opponent. Testarossa nodded in agreement.

“I will go with you. Now, as for the monsters—”

Without waiting for Testarossa’s words to finish, Arnaud and Fritz, who had become stiff and immobile, shouted.

“We do not need Testarossa-dono’s help. Please leave it to us!”

“If it’s a monster without an ego and no intelligence, we can fight them. The light attribute is a bit of a problem, but we’ve been trained in the labyrinth, so we’ll show you what we can do!”

Hinata looked at the two of them with a frown.

Why are they so conscious of Testarossa-dono?

She was taken aback, thinking that they were trying to look good in front of a beautiful woman. But the truth was something different. These two were truly scared of Testarossa. If they didn’t perform well here, they would be branded as useless. If that happened, it would be unclear what would happen regarding their special labyrinth training in the future. Besides, Testarossa had many sympathizers, not just in the labyrinth. She also had followers among the members of the parliament, so there was a

danger that they might lose their power to speak out in the future if they were not careful. This was how much Testarossa's influence had increased, but Hinata did not know that this was the case, having lost interest in politics.

For Testarossa, this was a very important time. Despite Rimuru's orders to make the World Conference a success, she had allowed the enemy to invade. On top of that, she was responsible for being unable to stop the destruction in the capital. Giving priority to human life was no excuse for that. Behind her smile, Testarossa was burning with rage. That was why she approved of Arnaud and the others' suggestions.

"In that case, please do. I will lend you some of my subordinates and you can incorporate them into your unit."

She told him as such and went on to help Arnaud and the others. This was all in preparation for her own move. She left the command to Arnaud and the others and gave them the task of restoring security to the capital. On top of that, she intended to strike the mastermind herself. Thus, the division of roles was decided.

"Well then, let's go now. We have to bring down the death penalty on those who have acted foolishly in this time of emergency."

Hinata said coldly. She was going to get rid of Reiner here to clear her own name. And she would capture Elric and make him confess to his crimes. Or rather—

"Well, the evidence is irrelevant. Once all the criminals have been taken out, the right story will be in the hands of the victor."

...Is what Testarossa said. This was a declaration that she would do exactly what the enemy was trying to do. Testarossa was a demon who did not care about ethics, and she believed that as long as she was the winner, she could do whatever she wanted. It was a very Testarossa-like argument.

And so, well aware that it was a trap, Hinata and the others headed to the stage where the enemy was waiting for them.



Once they were outside the Capitol, they found things in a terrible state. Part of the royal castle in the center of the city had partially collapsed, spoiling its beautiful appearance. The aristocratic district, where the Capitol and the branch of the Holy Church were located, was relatively better, but the downtown area facing the main street of the city was on fire.

“It can’t be helped that we prioritized evacuation, but this is going to be hard to clean up.”

“Full-scale battles are still to come, and there will be more damage. With the loss of the king and his successor, it will take time for Ingracia to recover.”

Nicolaus calmly responded to Hinata’s murmur. It was a cold reaction, unbecoming of a priest. But that was Nicolaus’ normal behavior. For Nicolaus, Hinata was the only priority, and he did not care about anything else. It was because he wanted to be of service to Hinata that he rose to the position of Cardinal, the highest rank next to the Pope. It is because he was such a man that he was still accompanying Hinata without regard for danger.

Incidentally, there were five of them now. Hinata, Testarossa, and Cardinal Nicolaus, who had followed Hinata out of concern for her. These three were joined by Moss and Cien who had been summoned. As they headed for their destination, they planned their strategy.

“Moss, you don’t have to fight, just go into ‘search mode’ and prepare for a surprise attack.”

“Understood!”

Moss was a yes man. He obeyed Testarossa without saying anything else. Even so, he would sometimes say unnecessary things and get into trouble, but as he had been Testarossa’s second-in-command for a long time, he knew how to take care of himself.

This, Moss’s ‘Search Mode,’ was a kind of ‘Barrier’ of sorts. He dispersed his own fragmented ‘Clone’ into a hemisphere of one kilometer in diameter. This allowed him to react immediately to a surprise attack from 500 meters away. At first glance, this may not seem to be any different from ‘Universal Perception,’ but that was not the case. That was because the speed of information transmission was much faster, and Moss’s own analytical ability was also added to deal with enemy attacks. Moreover, five hundred meters was a perfect distance for Testarossa, whose ‘perceptual speed’ could be increased by a million times with her skill. Even if it was an attack at the speed of light, under the influence of Moss’s ‘Search Mode,’ there would be more than a second before the attack would hit the target and it would be possible to deal with it.

Of course, it was not possible to move at the speed of light, and this was merely extending the time being perceived, but Testarossa would still be able to manage. Moss’s ‘Search Mode’ seemed to be perfect, but it had only one drawback. That was—

Moss was in the most danger because he was the one who would take the first hit.

Even if I’m damaged by that surprise attack, I doubt she’ll care...

Although obedient, Moss still complained inwardly. Taking a glance at Moss’s ability, Hinata saw through its nature.

“You are still wary of surprise attacks. So then, you’re saying that the one making all the noise is a decoy?”

Testarossa smiled when she pointed this out.

“That’s right. In the first place, we could narrow down the enemy’s objective when they targeted this conference.”

“To divide the West, or to aim directly at Rimuru. The biggest opportunity for them is Hero Masayuki who has become the Emperor of the Eastern Empire, correct?”

Testarossa’s grin deepened as Hinata replied without a second thought.

“As expected of you, Hinata-dono. Rimuru-sama did approve of you.”

“The flattery is nice. I’m sure it would be obvious to anyone who saw it.”

“Not really, but that’s fine.”

Testarossa chuckled as she thought of the faces of the people she had conversed with recently. She had been under a great deal of stress because many of them were not very perceptive. Those who did not listen to others were the worst. They would express their opinions only for their own benefit, and there were many times when they could not reach a consensus. Some of them would announce their agreements on their own after the meeting, and she had a good taste of the troublesome nature of political negotiations. There were even fools that the contract-oriented demon could not understand. Testarossa made sure that such people knew their place, but she had always wished that they would not create unnecessary trouble for her. In this respect, her conversation with Hinata was quick and pleasant.

“That’s exactly what Rimuru-sama’s objective must be.”

“I suppose so. There was an incident elsewhere at the same time as this ruckus, and Rimuru was headed there. They must have prepared a pretty big bait, right?”

“Yes, that’s correct.”

Testarossa nodded. It had been agreed in advance that if Leon showed up, Rimuru would go. Testarossa had been told this, but Hinata had guessed it without knowing about it. Testarossa explained the situation to a certain extent, since she had already guessed so much. Upon hearing this, Hinata also pointed out some problems. It was a very pleasant conversation.

I had heard that she was sharp, but I’d like to have her as my subordinate. Although, I’m sure Rimuru-sama would not approve.

With Rimuru, just the fact that he allowed himself to be called by his own name suggested that Hinata was a special person. Moreover, when he was with Hinata, he seemed to return to his true self and appeared to enjoy himself very much. Just by knowing Rimuru like that, it was the reason Testarossa couldn’t help but give Hinata a glance.

It truly is enviable. However, I suppose I am honestly pleased that the woman Rimuru-sama recognizes is not a fool.

Since ancient times, there had been numerous cases where a country had been turned upside down by a woman who had gained the favor of the king. In this respect, Hinata was not someone she had to worry about. In the first place, Rimuru and Hinata were not lovers, so Testarossa may have been thinking too much, but surprisingly, there were many people who thought like that. The only ones who didn’t know were the two people themselves.

At any rate, right now they needed to know about the enemy’s objective. Restoring Demon Lord Leon to his senses and bringing him back to their side. That was their basic strategy. But of course, it was expected that the enemy would be aware of that goal.

“Feldway was smart enough to know that Rimuru-sama was the one who brought Velgrynd-sama to her senses. If so—”

From Testarossa’s perspective, there was no doubt that Feldway was

capable. Despite his many shortcomings, she was certain that he had a plan to deal with Rimuru.

“We should also assume that he had a winning strategy in mind when he used Demon Lord Leon as bait to lure Rimuru out.”

‘That’s right.’ Testarossa nodded in agreement.

Of course, there was no way Rimuru could not see that. He must have been able to plan far ahead,⁶⁵ seeing through the depths so that even Feldway’s plan would be swallowed.

“Rimuru-sama was aware of this and went to rescue Demon Lord Leon.”

Testarossa assured her with absolute confidence. Hearing this, Hinata tilted her head in concern.

“But perhaps the enemy only called him over because they believed they could win. They say that Michael has taken in the power of the True Dragons, but can Rimuru really win against such a monster?”

Hinata’s concern was understandable. From Testarossa’s perspective, it seemed impossible that Rimuru could be defeated. But that was not a question that could be answered at this stage when they had not even seen the real enemy. What if Feldway or Michael were waiting for Rimuru at the destination?

Well, I’m sure they’ll take care of it, though.

Diablo and Souei were also there as escorts. She had no choice but to believe that Rimuru would be fine.

If the enemy’s goal was Rimuru, there was nothing for Hinata and the others to worry about. They could trust him, but the problem would be if the enemy had another objective.

“Although targeting the senators seems like a good idea, it’s unlikely.”

“I agree. There is no great advantage to splitting up the Western Nations right now. If they were capable of defeating Rimuru, they wouldn’t even bother with a united coalition of nations.”

The two agreed. After considering various other possibilities, they settled on the most likely conclusion:

“The enemy’s target is Masayuki.”

“So, where did His Majesty the Emperor disappear to?”

Hinata asked. At some point after the outbreak, Masayuki had disappeared from the Capitol. There were probably Imperial guards outside the Capitol, and the Scorch Dragon Velgrynd was at Masayuki’s side. Rather, it seemed to her that Masayuki was the safest one here. That’s why she had left him alone, but it was a different story if the enemy’s target was Masayuki.

“Perhaps Velgrynd-sama realized what the enemy was after and evacuated the area.”

No, no matter what the enemy’s intentions were, Masayuki’s safety was the priority. Testarossa knew that Velgrynd would have thought the same.

“Then I guess it’s safe to assume.”

It was at least better than defending themselves, Hinata agreed. If that was the case, the next thing to think about was their victory conditions.

“If the enemy’s target is Masayuki, we’re being used as bait, right? Do you think Masayuki will come to our rescue when we are about to be killed?”

Hinata had also known Masayuki before, so she knew that the boy was soft-hearted. However, since he had become an emperor, he should put his own life first, and she believed that he would be cool-headed about it. Testarossa agreed with her.

“That’s the main question. It is an unlikely assumption, but even if we

were about to die, I don't think Masayuki-dono would come to our rescue."

In this case, the problem was not just Masayuki's. Since Velgrynd was attached to him, there was no doubt that Masayuki should be given priority. Hinata and Testarossa agreed on this view as well. Therefore, the conclusion was also the same.

"Well, even if the people we're dealing with now only see us as bait, we have no reason to go along with them."

"You're right. Let's take out all of them and lure out those who are hiding."

In the end, winning would solve all their problems. With a shared awareness of the possibility of surprise attacks, Hinata and the others arrived at their destination.



Moss had disappeared, and only four people remained.

"Nicolaus, you stay here. If we are victorious, secure Prince Elric immediately."

Hinata did not say it, but it also meant to run away if they were defeated. Nicolaus was not a weak man, but he was not strong enough to stand on this battlefield. That's why she gave the order.

"Understood. I wish you luck!"

Nicolaus did not want to be a liability. He was prepared to use his own life as a shield in the event of Hinata's danger, but at that moment he obeyed quietly. Thus, Hinata and the others entered the square with only the three of them. When the group arrived at the square in the capital, they were

met by a group of fully armed knights. Not including Elric and Reiner, there were nearly twenty of them.

“You’ve finally arrived, I was tired of waiting!”

It was Reiner, whom Hinata knew well, who smirked and shouted. From a cursory observation, she could see that he had been strengthened tremendously. From the presence that she could feel, Hinata guessed that the amount of energy was greater than her own.

I was right to leave Nicolaus out of this. In a real fight, I definitely wouldn’t have time to worry about him.

If that happened, Nicolaus would have been involved. As a mere human being, Nicolaus would have had no way to survive, so Hinata was a little relieved. In any case, she ignored Reiner’s words and analyzed the enemy’s strength.

Elric has no dominating energy, so it seems that he’s still a normal human. But the others—

Elric seemed to have been just playing the role of a portable shrine and he looked the same as before. He was a little shabby, but that was probably because he had been under house arrest.

The others, however, were a problem.

There’s an unusual air about them. I see, they’re even more powerful than the Holy Knight captains. Perhaps they’re even as powerful as me...

Although it was impossible to say for certain just by looking at them, Hinata possessed the Unique Skill, ‘Mathematician.’ She analyzed the enemy and found them to be at least Calamity-class. Some of them, such as Louis and Roy, appeared to be comparable to Disaster-class, and with nearly twenty of them, it was going to be a tough fight even for the Saint Hinata. But that was not the biggest problem.

Reiner is insane. He probably even outperforms me.

Although not as powerful as Testarossa standing next to her, she could sense a great deal of power from him. This was dangerous, Hinata thought, and she became even more vigilant. If she could leave it to Testarossa, that would be the safest choice. But that was not possible. Because there was another man in this place who was just as dangerous.

“Gyahyahyaha! Reiner, we’re in luck! With two such beauties here, we won’t have to fight with each other!”

“No doubt. Brother Vega, I’ll take Hinata as promised, is that okay?”

“Of course. Eating such a weak woman won’t make me any stronger. Well, you can still enjoy her in other ways, but I’m afraid I’m on a mission right now.”

That was Vega, the man laughing with a vulgar voice. He was sitting on the edge of the fountain with his legs spread wide, radiating a terrifying aura without even trying to hide it. Vega’s attribute was evil itself, even though he had taken in the light-attribute spiritual life form of an angel.

It looks like I can’t do anything about him. I might be able to stick it out, depending on my strength, but my chances of winning are probably close to zero.

Hinata saw through this. In fact, Vega’s existence value was over 10 million, more than ten times greater than Hinata’s. Even though Hinata also had a hidden trick up her sleeve, the probability of her winning seemed unlikely even if she were to use it. In that case, there could be no other opponent for Vega than Testarossa. Inevitably, Hinata’s opponent would be Reiner.

“You are vulgar. I hate fools who don’t know their place.”

Testarossa smiled bewitchingly and looked down on Vega as she said this. Hinata found her confidence to be reassuring.

“Cocky bitch. Fine then, I, the great leader of the Seven Angels of

Death, will show you what I'm made of!!”

Very easily, Vega was provoked. As a result, the battle between Testarossa and Vega was decided. There was no way to escape this momentum. Hinata asked with a relaxed manner.

“So, who's going to be my opponent? I couldn't move under all of those glares, perhaps you are all planning to challenge me?”

With that, she was trying to incite them into a one-on-one battle with Reiner. If they all came at her, Hinata would have little chance to win. Even if she and Cien fought together, they would only be able to kill about ten people at most. However, if she could get rid of Reiner first, she would be able to discourage the remaining enemies. If that happened, they would not be able to show their full strength, and her chances of winning would be greatly increased.

Incidentally, Hinata thought that Reiner would have no choice but to accept the challenge. The reason was that there were magical devices in various parts of the capital that were connected to the underground shelters so that people could see what was going on above ground. The stone statue in the fountain of the main square was one of them, and the conversation between Hinata and Reiner was known to the people of the capital. Elric also knew this, which is why he was making a big speech here, and of course Reiner knew it too. If he runs away from the battle here, he will never be able to clear our name— Reiner would think so, Hinata thought. Her expectation was correct.

“Kukuku, I've been taken as a fool. I was a bit out of sorts at that time. I will prove it by beating you here.”

Thus, Reiner and Hinata were also thrown into battle with each other.



Hinata drew her sword. It was a gem given to her by Rimuru. It was not a unique-grade rapier. Since then, improvements had been made, and Kurobee's skills had improved, so the quality had risen to the legendary grade.

The weapon's name was Phantom Pain. Even though it was of the same legendary-grade level, its quality was lower than that of the Moonlight Sabre's. However, this Phantom Pain could perfectly reproduce the Dead End Rainbow. The sword she used when fighting Rimuru was capable of completely destroying the spiritual body on the seventh attack. This sword, however, was capable of destroying even the astral body. Needless to say, it was more powerful and stronger than the Moonlight Sabre in terms of usability.

“Are you ready?”

“You idiot, that's my line!!”

And so, the battle began. Hinata, as usual, analyzed the enemy's strength and searched for their weaknesses. At first glance, Reiner appeared to be a human, but his true nature seemed to have been transformed into a different creature. As evidence of this, his body movements were strange. Apart from walking, Reiner smoothly moves sideways. He even kicked the ground and jumped into the air in the same position. The secret seemed to be hidden in the soles of his shoes, but what was more striking were his shoulders. It was obvious that he was hiding something.

“Die!!”

Reiner swung his sword wide and swung at Hinata. Instead of deflecting it, Hinata quickly twisted her body to avoid it. It was the correct response

because she had sensed a premonition of danger.

That sword feels more powerful than just legendary-grade. I see, it's mythical-grade...

She didn't know how or where he got it, but it was the moment when she got a glimpse of Reiner's power. At this point, the difference in weapon performance was also disadvantageous. There was a risk that Hinata's Phantom Pain would be shattered if they were to slash each other properly. In reality, there was a huge gap between the two players' existence values.

Although Hinata was a Saint, she carried the Hero's Egg, but it never hatched and was left to Chloe. Her power as Saint remained unchanged, but it was a little over a million in terms of existence value. It was strong enough for a human. In fact, it was equal to King Gazel, but it was not as strong as Reiner, who was equivalent to 2 million.

However, this was only in terms of physical strength. Hinata had the memory and experience of traveling with Chloe. This was still alive and well in Hinata's pure skill level. There was a huge difference from when she had faced Reiner before, and when looking at things in overall strength, even if you put the difference in weapon performance into perspective, Hinata was much stronger. It was as if Hinata's victory was guaranteed as soon as she could get into a one-on-one fight.

But that was only if Reiner had been a knight of fair character. Hinata had misjudged him. Hinata had thought that Reiner was quite a lowly character, but Reiner was a coward beyond her imagination. Hinata was also quite cautious and never let her guard down, but there were unimaginably stupid people in this world who were even lower than the lowest of the low.

Reiner was exactly such a person. She didn't know and didn't care if this was due to his innate nature or if he had been distorted by the

experimentation. What was important here was that Reiner did not intend to simply fight her from the beginning. Hinata continued to dodge Reiner's sword, going back and forth several times. Then, at the right moment, she flicked Reiner's sword away from his side. This made her sure of victory and she gave Reiner a chance.

“Huh, you're not as good as you say you are. If you surrender—”

She would arrest Reiner as a traitor and put him on trial—showing him unnecessary mercy. This proved to be fatal. Reiner had fallen into a position where his men were standing behind Hinata. They all attacked her from behind, as if they had planned to do so.

Of course, Hinata had prepared for the surprise attack with ‘Magic Perception,’ and was also connected to the ‘Telepathy Net’ with Moss, so she was warned. However, it was Reiner that she needed to be wary of, and she could not afford to devote her attention to a bunch of random people. That was why she knew that she had no chance to win if they were outnumbered—she had to accept a certain amount of attacks. It was an instantaneous event.

“Hinata-dono!!”

Faster than Cien's shout, numerous light bullets exploded into Hinata. And then, as Reiner laughed loudly, he struck again. There was no sword in his hand, but his body was also covered by a mythical-grade full-body armor. His shoulders were wide open, and two pairs of thin, hard hands covered with mythical-grade armor sprouted out. They turned into four spears and pierced Hinata's limbs. Losing her support, Hinata fell to the ground. The sword fell from her hand. She lost her grip and could barely stand.

“Hahaha!! You've been acting all high and mighty, but you're no better than your mouth! You're too cocky, you're better off lying on the ground

like that!!”

Reiner laughed in an annoying high-pitched voice.

“Bastard! Wasn’t this supposed to be a fair fight?!”

Reiner snickered at Cien’s sullen shout.

“Criminals don’t have any human rights. But hey, we’re merciful. If you cry and beg for forgiveness, we’ll at least consider postponing the time of your execution for a little while.”

With that said, Reiner gave her a smirk. Without waiting for Hinata’s reply, he continued with his selfish argument.

“However, you’ll have to show some gratitude.”

The smile on Reiner’s face was unpleasant, as if he was thinking vulgar thoughts. Reiner’s subordinates did the same.

“Hahaha! The strongest of the West is looking good!”

“I guess the undefeated witch will have to be put down now.”

“No, no, we’re just getting too strong. It only looked like a good match because Reiner-sama was playing with her.”

And so on, they continued their self-serving comments. It was unclear if they had always been like that or not. However, it was a fact that they were inexplicably foolish. Hinata’s appearance had become too cruel.

The torn back of her ‘Holy Spirit Armor’ revealed her bare, burned skin. The tendons of her limbs had been severed so that she could not even move them. In spite of such misery, her bare face, wet with sweat, was beautiful. Her eyes never lost their brightness, and Hinata’s dignified expression showed that she had not given up yet.

“Come on then, cry and beg for forgiveness. Or shall I kill you right now?”

Reiner shouted, his eyes bloodshot with madness. The sight of Hinata crawling on the ground had given him a rush of lecherous pleasure. By now,

Reiner's rational mind had practically jumped away. Hinata was normally beyond his reach, a flower of the highest order, and to be able to violate such a high being surpassed all the pleasures Reiner had ever felt.

No matter how much of a fool Reiner was, he was aware of his inferiority compared to Hinata. No, he had realized it the moment he faced her. No matter how much he outclassed her in strength, he could not overturn the difference in quality. Even in terms of sword skills alone, Hinata's ability was light years ahead of Reiner's. Reiner had practically been mad with jealousy when he was confronted with this fact. That was why he had no hesitation in executing the trap that he had prepared for just in case. It was not as he had originally planned, but the result was all right.

I'm also lucky that her face wasn't damaged. I will enjoy watching her beautiful face contort and cry out in pain!

Reiner felt his blood boil and his strength pervade his body. Just imagining Hinata in such a state made him feel a black joy well up from the pit of his stomach. Now that this was the case, Reiner believed that his victory was unassailable. That was why he would beat Hinata into submission. And after that, there would be another kind of fun waiting for him...he thought it would be a shame to kill her now.

"Hey! If you don't hurry up, I'll really kill you!"

Reiner declared in a chilling voice. It was a serious threat. Part of him wanted to feel the pleasure of tormenting Hinata, but Hinata's strength was real. If her heart had not been broken at this point, he should have at least cut off her hands and feet. Reiner was a coward. That's why he was cautious and thought about what he was doing.

Even if Hinata were to call the others now, it would take them a long time to arrive. In the first place, it was unlikely that they could gather enough forces to fight against them. Besides, if he sensed any sort of sign,

he could give the order to attack as soon as possible. He had the absolute advantage. There was nothing to lose.

Hinata did not reply, but kept staring at Reiner. Her eyes told him that she hadn't lost yet.

Tsk, you really are a cocky bitch. In that case, I'll drop a leg off you!!

Reiner raised his sword in annoyance and swung it down towards Hinata



Hinata was in mortal danger, but Testarossa couldn't afford to help her. She has her hands full with Vega. Besides, she could tell from the look in her eyes that Hinata had not given up. In that case, she had to believe.

She was one of the few people who managed to beat Rimuru-sama to a draw. I don't think she'll just leave so quickly in such a place.

If that's what happened, then that's what would happen. Although it was very likely that Rimuru would be furious, Testarossa had not been ordered to protect Hinata. There were times for her to act in discernment, but for Hinata it felt like it was not her business. In fact, it seemed to be more likely to hurt Hinata's pride and displease Rimuru if she did something without permission. Testarossa decided that it would not be too late to come to the aid of Hinata after her defeat had been confirmed. So, without hesitation, she concentrated on Vega for now.

Vega was a nuisance. Vega's magicule count was several times larger than Testarossa's, but she thought it would be easy to kill him. However, it seems that she was wrong.

This guy, he's got roots all the way underground. If so, can he absorb the corpses to make his damage go away?

It was exactly as Testarossa was thinking. Vega had spread his power all over the capital of Ingracia, capturing and absorbing the corpses of the monsters that were still being defeated. It did not increase his strength, but it was the perfect way to replenish his missing parts and replenish his energy. This made Vega practically immortal.

What an annoyingly troublesome opponent...

That was Testarossa's true opinion. It might be possible to destroy him by burning down a large area with nuclear magic. But in order to do so, she needed to understand Vega in his entirety. That alone would have been a hassle, but even before that, she couldn't afford to do so. As long as they were fighting here in the royal capital of Ingracia, any action that would lead to the destruction of the city was basically forbidden. They were allowed to escape, but they were not allowed to do anything to win.

In that case, it would be almost impossible to kill Vega. Moreover, it was not a good idea to hunt Vega down. If she did so, there was a high possibility that he would use the people of the Royal Capital who had fled underground as bait and try to regenerate himself. For now, he still had Reiner's subordinates who had turned into monsters, and absorbing them would be enough. However, if she cornered him further, Vega would probably resort to any means necessary.

From Testarossa's perspective, she was being forced to fight a battle where she could not see a way to win. What made this situation even more frustrating for her was—

“Hey, hey, what's the matter?! For someone with all that bravado earlier, you're not doing much at all!!”

It was the attitude of Vega, who was getting carried away.

It's not easy to make me want to kill someone from the bottom of my heart. You should be proud of that.

Testarossa inwardly snapped. However, it was true that she could not afford to do so. She flicked her flaming whip and toyed with Vega, but her mind was able to see two or three moves ahead. As long as she was unable to get into a checkmate situation, she had no choice but to maintain the stalemate. In order to break that stalemate, some external factor would be necessary. There was a hidden force on the enemy side. There was no doubt about that, so Testarossa and her team were at a disadvantage from a broader perspective. If there was one factor that tipped the scales in Testarossa's favor, it was the presence of Velgrynd. However, she was unlikely to leave Masayuki's escort.

It's likely that Feldway's target is also Masayuki-dono. Velgrynd-sama is not so naive as to dare to play into the hands of the enemy.

Naturally, Velgrynd must be aware of Feldway's intentions. In that case, Testarossa believed that Velgrynd would not come to their aid. And at the same time...

Testarossa understood that they were being treated as bait to lure Masayuki out. This stalemate was a good situation for Feldway and his group.

It's really frustrating. I know what I'm doing, but I'm just going to have to live with it. Apparently, Carrera and Ultima have their hands full, and there is no one else in their ranks who can move. If only Zegion and the others could come—no, Rimuru-sama wouldn't approve of that.

She knew that her colleagues were also struggling, as evidenced by the emergency call through the Control Room. The Control Room had now declared a state of emergency and had shifted into combat mode. They were preparing for an enemy invasion, and there was no way that Zegion, the key

defender, could leave. Zegion was the only one who could be relied upon to move freely. The others were not weak, but they were not strong enough to overcome any situation. No, there was also the superpower force of Veldora—but he couldn't make the foolish move of leaving the labyrinth when Michael was after him. In other words, no reinforcements were coming. Testarossa had no choice but to conclude that she would have to fend for herself. But then, something unexpected happened—



Reiner swung his sword down on Hinata. At that moment—

Kwiing! A clear tone rang out as it was caught by someone's sword. No, it was not a sword. What the beautiful woman was holding in her hand was a feather fan that did not look like a weapon at all. The name of the beautiful woman, whose shining blue hair was fluttering in the air—it was the Scorch Dragon Velgrynd.

“Hinata, was it? Didn't my foolish brother say that he proved that the skills you've developed and perfected could reach us True Dragons? Wasn't that the case, Testarossa?”

If that's true, I will not allow you to be defeated in a place like this, that's what Velgrynd was saying. She ignored Reiner and turned her gaze to Testarossa.

“That's right, Velgrynd-sama. That said, I wasn't expecting you to come.”

“Ufufu, you're right. I didn't plan on intervening, but Masayuki did.”

Velgrynd turned to Masayuki, her eyes full of compassion. What she

saw before her was—

“Are you okay, Hinata-san?!”

“Ah...”

It was Masayuki squeezing Hinata’s breasts.

The man in question, Masayuki, appeared to be in a dignified state, but on the inside, he was in a state of panic.

Wh-what the hell is going on?

Due to the sudden event, Masayuki instantly lost all sense of reality.

Or rather, this feeling on my right hand is...

There was a soft and fluffy feeling coming from the palm of his right hand. This was the moment when Masayuki’s brain finally started to process what it was. In other words, it was caused by Masayuki getting distracted by Hinata. When he tried to help Hinata up, he tripped over a pebble that had fallen at his feet. As a result, Masayuki fell and carefully pushed Hinata down as well. Then his right hand touched Hinata’s chest regardless of Masayuki’s intention.

It was a lucky deviance⁶⁶, to say the least. And what’s more. Thanks to the proximity of their lips, Hinata’s true face could also be seen clearly. Her widened eyes sparkled like blackish purple amethysts. Her nose was straight, and her lips were full and fresh. Her fine skin was translucent without any makeup.

She’s a really beautiful woman. It’s no wonder Rimuru-san can’t resist her.

This was Masayuki’s way of escaping from reality. It was understandable. Hinata’s breath tickled his nostrils, and the sweet smell of her breath made his brain swoon. If it hadn’t been for Velgrynd’s repeated hugs and experiences, he might have fainted from sheer joy. It seemed like

a long time, but it all lasted less than a second. Masayuki's brain rebooted and he realized that he could not keep staring at her forever. Hinata's eyes widened in surprise, and Masayuki thought, *Of course she did.*

It was only natural that people would think, *What is this guy doing?*

He was afraid that Hinata would come to her senses. Masayuki feared that something terrible was waiting for him.

"I-it's not what it looks like!"

It's not, it's not true, Masayuki was screaming in his heart. Masayuki turned more and more pale as he tried to stand up and make an excuse—

Huh? Just now, something just...

Masayuki felt a jolt on his back and realized that something had just passed over him. Then he felt a creeping sense of dread.

"...Masayuki?"

What followed next was Velgrynd's scream. It was not a voice of anger towards Masayuki, but rather a voice of sincere concern. What had just happened? In fact, right at the very moment of Masayuki's fall, someone had attacked. Velgrynd was the only one who saw it coming. It was an attack that even Testarossa could not detect. At any rate, she was in a hurry to check the link with Moss. But before she even had the chance to call out to Moss, Masayuki managed to avoid the attack by accidentally falling. If he had not stumbled, his life would have been cut short. A lucky boy, indeed. The lucky guy showed a remarkable performance this time as well.

Whoa! Was I really being targeted?!

Masayuki, who found out late, was paling away in a different way, but he was still lucky that it was over. And then, Hinata moved. It would have been extremely dangerous and foolish to stay still in a place that was being targeted. Therefore, Hinata rolled over and took Masayuki in her arms. Masayuki was moved. The happy feeling of being embraced, the silky and

comfortable feeling of Hinata's hair on his cheek. It tickled and smelled so good, he wanted to escape from reality. However, that was not allowed...

Or rather, this was not the time.

"Tsk, no way... I never thought you'd be able to avoid my assassination attempt..."

A man in a black costume with pure white wings on his back let out a cry of astonishment—It was Arios. The Unique Skill 'Murderer,' whose base was the Ultimate Enchantment 'Punishment King Sandalphon,' had the power of 'Presence Concealment.' It was a Skill that made those under its influence unrecognizable until some action was taken. With this skill, he and Feldway had been hiding and watching the situation this whole time. And then, just as Masayuki appeared on the scene, he launched a desperate assassination attempt which failed miserably. Arios was ready to try again, but two men stood in front of him.

"Masayuki's enemies are my enemies."

"Well, that's how it is. I won't let you lay a hand on His Majesty."

And with that, Venom and Minits had entered the fray. A little later, Bernie and Jiwu also showed up.

"I was charged with protecting His Majesty's person, yet I overlooked the assassin. For this sin, I will—"

"No, it's fine!"

Bernie and Jiwu had been hiding and guarding Masayuki, but they hadn't realized that Arios was lurking within the perimeter. This was not either of their faults, but it was definitely a big blunder. However, Masayuki was in a panic to deny it. If he didn't, the two of them might have taken the blame and committed suicide or something annoying like that. At any rate, he decided to tell them to focus on the enemy for now, and let this matter go unanswered. As a result, the four of them took up arms against Arios to

protect Masayuki.

The battlefield had been rearranged. Testarossa and Moss were on high alert. Cien was fighting alone against the knights, trying to keep them restrained. Hinata was struggling to stand up, and Masayuki was in a quandary as he was lending a shoulder. Venom and the Empire's top executives had come to protect Masayuki. Nicolaus, who had called for Velgrynd and Masayuki, or rather had joined them on the way, was furious at the sight of Hinata's miserable state. And Velgrynd was smiling bewitchingly. On the other side...

Reiner, unable to finish off the cornered Hinata, looked disgruntled. Vega was smirking and enjoying the situation. Arios was unsuccessful in his attack. Feldway was displeased with the failure of his plan just after it seemed like it had succeeded completely. And then there were Reiner's subordinates who were still alive and well. With Masayuki and Velgrynd now on the battlefield, the situation had become even more chaotic.



The residents of the Royal Capital listened to the broadcast with anxiety. Those who could see the images had their eyes glued to the screen. Although Reiner's words were uncomfortable, there was no doubt that Prince Elric was on his side. However, as the battle intensified, people were turned off by Reiner's cruelty. He fought in a vile manner, unbecoming of a knight.

Besides, it was not the knights led by Reiner who were still desperately

defending the capital, but the Holy Knight Order and Templar Knights under Hinata's leadership. Regardless of who's words were true, it was Hinata's knights that they wanted to trust. There were some who supported Elric, but the ratio of those who supported Elric became smaller and smaller. And when Hinata was in trouble, everyone prayed for her safety in front of the screen.

This wish was fulfilled by the appearance of a certain person. Small whispers began to escape from the mouths of those who saw the shining figure.

"It's the Hero-sama..."

"H-Hero-sama?"

"It's the hero-sama!"

"I-it's Masayuki-sama! Hero Masayuki-sama has returned!"

"Masayuki-sama has returned as the emperor!!"

And it didn't take long for them to become a huge chorus.

"Ma-sa-yu-ki, Ma-sa-yu-ki!!!"

Everywhere, all over the underground evacuation shelters, the grounds were trembling from the cheers.

This phenomenon was not limited to the people. It was the same for the surviving royalty and influential aristocrats as well. No one would be so foolish as to be unable to discern whether Elric's justification was true or false. Hinata, who had protected humanity as the guardian of law and order, had no reason whatsoever to kill the king. On top of that, this was the middle of a world conference, and the Kingdom of Ingracia, the venue of the conference, was fully guarded.

Even if she really had been targeting the king, she would not have acted on it now. If there was anyone who would do such a thing, it would be none

other than a force that wished to bring chaos to human society. Even the ruler of the underworld, REG, had unofficially offered their cooperation to ensure the success of this world conference. Without the development of human society, there would be no future for the underworld. It was a very plausible argument, and the upper echelons of the kingdom had also chosen to work together. Therefore, the only people who would cause dissonance here were those who did not understand the situation. In other words, it was the opinion of those in power that Prince Elric himself was the ringleader.

“The people were confused, but thanks to Masayuki-dono, they have regained their composure.”

“That’s all well and good, but it puts us in an awkward position.”

“Indeed. If we had missed the true mastermind and left everything to the hands of others from another country, we would have been criticized later, no doubt.”

“The palace knights have been destroyed, but there are still other forces left, aren’t there?”

“Deploy the four armies on all sides of the Royal Capital. All of our troops.”

“ “ “Understood!!” ” ” ”

And with that, the plan to bring the situation under control started at once. Masayuki may be a champion, but he was now the Emperor of the Eastern Empire. Since they couldn’t lift him up, they at least had to sweat it out themselves.

The Three Drunk Sages also made a move.

“The three leaders do not want chaos in this land. It would be foolish to lose our forces unnecessarily, so it will be just me and the Musketeers Corps⁶⁷ who will go.”

Glenda Adley said as such. A number of prototype weapons had been secretly developed at Tempest and were never expected to see the light of day. The Musketeer Corps, led by Glenda, was the supplier of these weapons. They were her prized subordinates, who had been secretly modified in the Empire. Their individual combat abilities were at least A rank, and they were skilled in the use of various weapons. They had a variety of vicious weapons, such as small anti-tank guns (rocket launchers) and hand-held gatling guns. The ammunition used in these weapons was not ordinary, but was a hazardous material that had been designated for use only by those with specialized knowledge. Its power could only be guessed at.

“Now then, let’s go!”

“ “ “Yes!!” ” ”

“Best of luck to you.⁶⁸”

“Even if we die, our souls will surely be reborn as majins in the eyes of god!”

I’m not asking for that kind of thing, Glenda thought, but she laughed at her colleague’s thoughtfulness. Then, with less than a hundred subordinates in tow, she leapt onto the battlefield.



Masayuki was bewildered by the rapidly changing situation. He felt completely left out of everything that was going on. However, one comment from Hinata made Masayuki feel more trapped than ever.

“So, how long do you intend to keep squeezing my breasts?” she asked

him.

Pffft?! Masayuki couldn't help but choke.

I'm not squeezing them! It was just a touch of my hand, he tried to make an excuse, but as he unconsciously turned to face Hinata at close range, Masayuki tensed up at the sight of her beauty. There were many beautiful women in Tempest, but they were of the nature of extraordinary beauty. The same was true of Velgrynd, whose beauty was similarly outside the realm of humanity.

In contrast, Hinata's beauty was that of a familiar Japanese face. Although her beauty had been enhanced by becoming a Saint, she still possessed a unique charm that made one feel at ease. But one shouldn't be fooled by appearances. Masayuki had heard a lot about her from Rimuru. Hinata was the only one who must never be offended. Even Veldora agreed.

She's a persistent woman. No matter what you do, she will surely be avenged, he had warned him with a straight face.

It would be unfortunate if Masayuki were to do something inappropriate with someone who had made a demon lord and a True Dragon fear her. Fully aware of this, Masayuki hurriedly jumped to his feet and apologized to Hinata. Incidentally, although she pretended to be calm at that time, Hinata was also very upset. She had never had her breasts squeezed by another person before and was wondering how she should react. If it had been intentional, Hinata would have taken appropriate measures to deal with it, but in Masayuki's case, it was completely unavoidable. This made Hinata's judgment waver, and ultimately saved Masayuki's life.

"I-I'm sorry. I-it was by no means on purpose..." he stuttered, unable to come up with a good excuse.

But Masayuki's words were interrupted by Hinata.

"Just kidding. I know it was a force majeure," she said with a smile on

her face.

Despite the smile, Masayuki couldn't stop the cold sweat running down his spine. In fact, he had no idea what was going on. His understanding couldn't catch up. He wanted to tell her frankly, but he felt like he would be doomed if he did, so he could only keep silent.

"You can't be seriously offended by a mere breast rub, can you? Hey, Masayuki, I'll let you squeeze mine as much as you want," Velgrynd dropped a bomb with a laugh.

'No thank you' couldn't be said. Masayuki was still a young man after all.

However, he sincerely hoped that such a meeting would be held in a quiet and unobtrusive place. Hinata looked at them with a furtive glance, but when she tried to get up, she groaned in pain.

"Hi-Hinata-sama!" Cardinal Nicolaus shouted as he rushed over and held Hinata up. Her arms and legs were still pierced, and she could not even stand up.

"I will treat you immediately!" he said, panicking as he performed an impressive high-ranking holy magic High Heal with great skill. Hinata immediately recovered and returned to the battlefield.

Thus, the rearranged battle resumed.

"Hi-Hinata-sama...is this okay? Why don't you leave this to Masayuki-dono?"

Nicolaus asked, but Hinata turned a deaf ear to his suggestion. Masayuki, who was horrified by Nicolaus' words, was greatly relieved to learn that Hinata had no intention of doing so. There was nothing else to do but to ask Hinata to do her best. Knowing this, Hinata gave a small smile.

It was a truly cruel smile, a true expression of Hinata's beauty, a

beautiful woman wearing men's clothing. To tell the truth, Hinata had lost her temper with Reiner. And more than that, she could not forgive herself for her mistake of being careless.

“No, there's no problem. I'm done waiting around.”

It was a declaration of victory. There was no room for pity for the person who had tortured her so much. Hinata had completely read the path to victory. Hinata looked at Reiner with a benevolent smile on her face. Her eyes, however, remained cold.

“Well, now then. I'll take you seriously, so be prepared.”

“D-damn you! You're the one who killed the king, you big sinner...and now, I'm done playing with you! I'll kill you. You will never be able to win against me no matter what, you coward!!”

“Funny you should say that. You're the one who's a coward.”

There was nothing more annoying than having the truth pointed out to you, Reiner gritted his teeth.

“Tsk, I guess you misunderstood. I took it easy on you because you're a woman, you know? I was trying to be gentle with you, so I wouldn't accidentally kill you. Even so, I can't forgive your attitude.”

Reiner's eyes were bloodshot with excitement, and his mind was on the verge of going insane. In anticipation of this, Hinata continued to instigate him.

“Hmm, is that so? Well then, you'd better get yourself together and prove it to me.”

Hinata was no longer careless. She knew that Reiner was not a chivalrous man, and she had no intention of showing mercy to such a vulgar being. Perhaps Reiner understood this, and he howled with his face turning red.

“I won't forgive you even if you cry. Fine then, I'll grant you your wish!

Over and over again, I'll slash and slash and slash!!”

Reiner's sole purpose was to show off his strength to his subordinates and the public by overwhelmingly overpowering Hinata. Normal judgment was no longer something he could hope for. Perhaps sensing this, Hinata looked at Reiner coldly. There was not a trace of kindness in her eyes, and they were filled with contempt.

Reiner rushed towards Hinata. Unperturbed, Hinata readied her Phantom Pain. And then, their swords clashed.

“Hyaaaaaahaahaahaaa!! Die, die, die, dieeeeeeee!!”

Reiner shouted with an expression full of madness. The sword he swung down with all his might had the power to kill, but it was no match for Hinata. It could shatter even the Phantom Pain if taken seriously, but there was no need to meet it head on. There was no need to hesitate anymore. Even though Reiner's physical ability was better than Hinata's, it did not matter to her. She dodged Reiner's sword lightly and aimed at the gap in his armor to stab him.

“Gyaaaaah?!”

Reiner screamed. The intense pain rushed through his body, and he regained his composure for a moment.

What, what is this pain?! Didn't I—didn't I gain power and become immune to such half-hearted attacks?!

He became Vega's servant and had gained the power of a staff officer grade phantom. In addition, now that he had been given mythical-grade armor, there was no way he could be defeated by Hinata. Moreover, the fact that he could feel pain was unusual. He could not hide his confusion at the fact that his 'pain blocker' was ineffective. The damage itself was not serious, but the pain did not seem to subside. Reiner gritted his teeth. Earlier, he had thought that he was just in bad shape, but now he was

beginning to show serious impatience.

“Ufufufufu. Did I hurt you? Cry harder and entertain me!”

Hinata had an ecstatic expression on her face and lasciviously moistened her lips with her tongue. This gesture suited Hinata very well. It was reminiscent of a superior predating on the inferior.

While Nicolaus was staring at Hinata with a passionate gaze, Masayuki was horrified. It was a gesture that might create a rabid fan base among some of the sexually inclined, but for Masayuki, it was a pity.

This person is scary!! I'll make sure to never offend Hinata-san...

He was truly convinced that Rimuru was right. Hinata pursued Reiner without caring about the reactions of the people around her. Fearing the incomprehensible pain of the stab, Reiner desperately tried to defend himself. However, the attack was not so sweet that it could be escaped from.

“Now die! ‘Dead End Rainbow’!!”

With a fluid movement, Hinata accurately pierced Reiner. Each blow was painful and tormented Reiner.

Th-This much! If I can endure this pain—Gugyaaaaaoooooooo?!

Because his mind had been destroyed, there was no way he could endure it. To begin with, Reiner's physical body had been strengthened tremendously, but his mental body was still immature. Even if he had absorbed the phantom, which was a spiritual life form, his mental defense had not been strengthened.

“H-help me, Vega-san! Th-The pain won't go away!!”

Reiner tried to heal the damage he had suffered, but he could not heal his mind. It was not surprising that Reiner, who was in a state of panic due to the intense fear and suffering, lost his normal judgement and was unable to do anything. Moreover, because his spiritual body had grown too large,

the time he spent in pain was much longer. It was so bad that he thought he would rather be dead—



At the beginning of the battle, Venom had been the main opponent for Arios, with the remaining three players serving as supporters to keep Arios in check. Masayuki stood with his arms crossed, watching Venom's battle—or more accurately, standing there and staring in the general direction. The occasional glow was the only proof that the battle was still going on, as the speed was too fast for Masayuki to follow with his eyes. It was impossible for him to understand what was happening. He was just pretending to be able to see.

...I mean, there's nothing I can do about it.

Not wanting to get in the way, he left the fighting to the others. Masayuki now understood exactly what he was capable of. It was on the level of enlightenment, so his sense of fear was diminishing. Even so, fear was still fear. To distract himself from his fear, Masayuki recalled a happy memory. That is, the feeling that lingered in his right hand—the softness and warmth of Hinata's breast.

Of course, Gryn-san⁶⁹ would let me squeeze them without asking, but that's not the point. I'm afraid of what might happen later, so I think it's a little different.

In this respect, Hinata was wonderful. She was quite scary, but he was forgiven for something unavoidable. With this, there was no need to worry anymore. He could enjoy his happiness without worrying about the future.

Without even realizing it, Masayuki's happy mood had a tremendous impact on the scene.

In response to Masayuki's wish, a 'Lucky Field' was set up, granting an immense blessing for all those who stood by Masayuki. The truth of the world had been reached—the Ultimate Skill 'King of Heroes' was in full effect. As such, Venom and the others had a relative advantage in the battle. Venom attacked without hesitation, as if he were strolling along on a walk.

“'Doom Enemy'!!”

The claws on Venom's hands turned jet-black and grew long. The surface of his claws vibrated finely with a technique that generated waves that could split all matter. Clicking his tongue, Arios evaded. But it didn't stop there.

“How naive.”

Leaving the mutter behind, Minits took aim at Arios, who had lost his stance. He tilted his body unnaturally, ignoring gravity and inertia, and rushed forward like a cannonball. With his Unique Skill 'Oppressor,' he adjusted his trajectory to Arios, forming an obstacle-free path. He then compressed and exploded the air under his feet to gain thrust. Minits reached his maximum speed in an instant and unleashed a barrage of blows that left Arios no time to react.

“You small fry, you're getting carried away!”

Arios, who had been head-butted in the jaw and knee-kicked in the stomach, glared at Minits in fury. But Arios could not afford to do so.

“Assassination is my specialty.”

A black flash of light ripped through Arios. Jiwu, who had been hiding in perfect cover, had aimed for the moment when Arios's mind was turned to Minits. As Arios tried to retreat, a spear of lightning pierced him. It was Bernie's special strike, a condensed version of 'Thunder Rain' fused with

spearmanship.

“Don’t forget about me, either.”

Even though he had lost his Ultimate Enchantment ‘Alternative,’ it was a skill he had once acquired. Bernie had tried his best to be useful to Emperor Masayuki and was able to recreate his former abilities to some extent. The same was true for Jiwu. Incidentally, Minits had become stronger than before, but he seemed to have been empowered by experience, just as he said he loved fighting.

Perhaps the strength of will had something to do with the fact that people with abnormal personalities became stronger. That’s what Bernie thought, but he wasn’t stupid enough to say that. Right now, he honestly felt that strong friends were reassuring. And so, the four of them put up a good fight against Arios, who was incomparably stronger in terms of existence value. Moreover, this did not change even when Arios became serious.

“Hmph, I don’t have time to play around here. I’m going to give it my all, so be prepared.”

Arios politely declared as he held two daggers in his hands. The mythical-grade two-sword style was Arios’ original style of melee combat.

Damn them...they’re only halfway competent, and yet they’re still getting in my way...

Arios was indignant. Arios was convinced that this would be the best way to deal with the small fry without much trouble. It turned out that he was careless in the next attack. A slash of divine speed struck Venom, slicing off the black claws that had barely caught him. Even the vibrations that cut through all matter seemed powerless before the mythical-grade weaponry—or so it seemed.

As if it was a natural result, Arios kept his expression unchanged and looked at Venom with a smile. It was as if he was looking at an insect.

‘This is the difference in strength between you and me,’ he seemed to say with an air of pride on his face. But then it was distorted by an impossible situation. Pain shot through both of Arios’ arms.

“Haha, look at you! I’m lucky, I didn’t think you’d get two stabs.”

Arios’s expression twitched when heard Venom’s laughter. As Venom pointed out, Arios had one black claw in each of his arms. Arios was so proud of his superiority that he had looked down on Venom and the others as inferior. And yet, he had been wounded. He hadn’t really been serious a while ago, but this time that wasn’t the case. Arios was getting impatient because he could tell that he had not been careless.

“Bastard, you were aiming for this?!”

“Well, yeah. I was hoping it would be a little more difficult, but I’ve been lucky again today.”

‘I thought I’d be lucky to get one,’ Venom said, making no secret of his true feelings.

That’s right. When one was with Masayuki, they were lucky enough to be loved every day. It wasn’t the kind of luck that made you win over women or gambling, so he didn’t always feel it, but he felt that everything he did would go better than expected.

“Damn bastard—I won’t take it easy on you anymore.”

“Idiot! You just said you were going to give it your all!”

Venom cheerfully incited Arios, who was filled with anger. Venom was now using himself as bait. The larger the gap between Arios and his friends, the easier it would be for them to move. Although Venom mocked Arios with his words, in reality, he was not letting his guard down. He quickly regenerated his severed black claws and focused his attention on Arios’ movements.

And rightly so. Venom was not overconfident in his power. It hadn’t

been long since he had been reincarnated as a demon, and thanks to the overwhelming presence of Diablo, he had learned to see himself from a thoroughly objective point of view.

He's a tough one. Aside from this good luck, we're completely outclassed in terms of strength. It's time for me to switch places with Bernie and focus on being an attacker instead of a decoy—

This time, Venom had been assigned as a decoy because he was judged to be the most difficult to kill. Normally, Bernie played the main role of shield, so this time it was an irregular division of roles. The so-called evasive shield was the role that Venom was expected to play. It would be the end if Arios' attack hit. That's why it was decided that Venom was the best choice, because he was hard to hit and would not be killed instantly.

—Although, it might take several hundred years to revive if I die. I seriously hope that doesn't happen.

Venom's nerves sharpened as he thought about this. Bernie and his friends also understood that Venom was really desperate. That's why they were in no hurry to join up with him. The role of the Minits was to distract Arios with a series of big moves. It didn't matter if it worked or not, the goal was to keep the attack going.

Offense is the best defense, as the saying went, and Venom was able to get around well because of Minits.

Bernie used 'cognitive inhibition' to contain Arios' power and keep the influence of 'Punishment King Sandalphon' small, though not completely. This also made Minits' attacks more effective. Of course, Jiwu also acted as a second shield, attacking at key points, and making sure that Minits could move freely. Jiwu had become a true trump card.

Unlike Arios, Jiwu's concealment was of a nature that only Jiwu herself could hide from. But that was enough. Needless to say, it would come in

handy in battle. The diminutive Jiwu activated her Skill the moment she was out of Arios' sight. Then, when Arios was caught completely off guard, she unleashed a fatal blow. Unfortunately, Arios was not weak enough to be defeated by such a blow, but even so, the damage was steadily accumulating. Each player's role had its own meaning, and Masayuki's 'Lucky Field' was the perfect combo to make this happen. Arios, who had underestimated his opponent's superiority, found himself unknowingly in a tight spot.

It can't be, I'm being pressured?!

While he was feeling disgusted, the situation was worsening in earnest. He was at their mercy, unaware of this as time continued passing by. If he continued like this, he would incur the wrath of Feldway. Aware of this, Arios lost his cool and became increasingly impatient...



Reiner was rolling on the ground, screaming. But no one wanted to help Reiner. Currently, Hinata had defeated Reiner, but Feldway was still alive. Velgrynd was dealing with him, but as long as the 'Castle Guard' was in place, her attacks wouldn't work. As for Reiner's subordinates, Moss and Cien were already holding them off. It was a surprisingly comfortable fight. Moss was restraining them, Cien was bringing them into a one-on-one situation, and Nicolaus was supporting them. He helped Cien by using magic to stop the enemy's movements, giving them an advantage in the battle.

Arios had no time to spare either. That's why none of the Feldway forces

had time to worry about Reiner. Rather, it would be more correct to say that they would not care even if they did. As proof of this, Vega, the one who had been asked for help, was smirking as he dealt with Testarossa.

“Is it okay if you don’t help your friend?”

“Hah! He’s a minion, not a friend. But you have a point. Perhaps it’s about time.”

Testarossa had a bad feeling when she heard Vega’s comment.

This person, he’s up to something...

Testarossa had noticed that Vega had been using the corpses to recover from the damage so far. But she had a feeling that he was hiding more than that. That feeling was correct.

“You’re the one who’s misunderstanding. I still haven’t taken things seriously. It seems that you’re trying to figure out how to kill me, but you won’t need to worry about that.”

“What do you mean?”

“Hah! You’re even dumber than I thought. I’m telling you that you’re no match for me!”

Upon hearing this, Testarossa was about to become furious. However, she stopped and observed Vega with a cold gaze.

This person, he appears to be gaining strength little by little even during the current battle. I wonder if this arrogant attitude is not just a bluff?

She saw through this and refrained from acting out in anger. Vega then declared to Testarossa.

“Hehe, Feldway-san should be getting impatient by now. All right then, I’ll show you my best shot, so you can die in despair!”

Vega said as such and laughed loudly. And then—

He unleashed the power he had just learned to use. It was the beginning of the nightmare.

“Awaken, ‘Evil Dragon Spawn’—”

Vega ignored Testarossa and put his hands on the ground. It was a production. There was really no need for him to do so, but he dared to act in a flawed manner to show that Testarossa was no match for him. Testarossa would not be fooled. She was prepared to calmly analyze what was about to happen. From the palm of Vega’s hand, a wave of evil gushed forth. It traveled through the earth, engulfing Reiner’s subordinates as they fell to the ground. Those who were already dead and those who were still alive were equally affected. However, he just managed to avoid Elric.

“Moss. Gather everyone.”

Moss moved in response to Testarossa’s voice. He called Bernie and the others back to Masayuki’s location to protect them from Vega’s wave. Venom and Cien were no exception, and they all gathered in one place. They watched with bated breath as the situation unfolded. Before their eyes, the living and the dead began twisting together. Then they transformed into an evil life form that emitted a foul odor. Reiner was no exception.

“H-hey! Brother... Brother Vega!! Help me, I am, I too am, in this sludge?!”

Reiner was in pain, but was still desperately calling out to Vega for help. But Vega only grinned at Reiner. Reiner had been a pawn from the beginning. Therefore, he could experiment with his new power without any hesitation.

“Oh, brother. Rest assured. If you’re useful to me, I will help you as often as I can.”

“R-really?!”

Vega’s grin deepened to a wide smile, as if to reassure Reiner. Reiner, who was relieved to see this, was then attacked by the sludge made from the melted corpses. Seeing this, Arios’ face turned pale.

“Hey, Vega! Y-you’re not going to use me as your test subject, are you?!”

Vega sneered.

“I’m gonna do this!”

“B-bastard! I will never forgive you. Just because you’re the leader of the Seven Angels doesn’t mean that you can get away with such tyranny!!”

Arios was furious, but his lower half had already been swallowed up by the sludge.

“F-Feldway-sama! Please help! Vega is out of control. At this rate, I will —”

Alas, Arios’ desperate pleas were silently ignored by Feldway. It wasn’t because he was having trouble dealing with Velgrynd, but rather because he simply wasn’t interested. Besides, he didn’t see the need to stop a useless person from being strengthened.

“Damn it!!”

Arios also sank into the sludge, leaving behind a scream. And now it was ready. The corpses melted and twisted together, and the sludge formed into several humanoid forms. At this moment, a fearsome creature was born into the world. It was a reappearance of the Dead Birthday that produced undead elves with Vega’s power.

Of course, the effect was not the same. That was the true value of the ‘Organic Domination’ and ‘Mass Reproduction’ from Vega’s Ultimate Skill ‘Evil Dragon King Azi Dahaka.’ In Vega’s words, it was ‘Evil Dragon Spawn Production’—it was the power to create evil lifeforms to be his loyal subjects.

There were four Evil Dragon Spawns born in total. Although they resembled human beings, their appearance was nothing short of hideous. The Evil Dragon Spawns’ entire body was covered with black scales that

were transformed from mythical-grade material. On their bellies were a large rift, reminiscent of a mouth with teeth. On their backs, there were two pairs of the blackened wings of a bird of prey. They appeared to be the remnants of an angel. The heads of the creatures were distinctive, with a smooth mass from the neck up. There were two hollow-like holes in them, and red eyes glittered in the blackness.

They were no longer people. They were writhing beings with the presence of evil. They had no heads to begin with, so there was no light of intelligence in their eyes. Nevertheless, they seemed to have the power of judgment, and were glaring hatefully at Hinata and Venom, perhaps influenced by the hatred they had felt before their deaths.

“Gwahahahahaha!! What do you think of my lovely pets?! It seems that you small fry have been working hard, but that’s all over now. These Evil Dragon Spawns are far too powerful for little peons like you, so enjoy them to your hearts’ content!!”

Vega said, laughing loudly. And then, while crossing his arms, he ordered, “Go play with them.”



Although Evil Dragon Spawns were a distorted life form, they were still very capable of fighting. They had no eyes, but that was no problem since they had ‘Magic Perception’ to begin with. They could accurately grasp the situation around them and act according to orders. The individual existence values reached 2.4 million. This was more than the average Insect General, so one could understand how much of a threat these Evil Dragon Spawns

were. Of course, that was obvious to those who were facing them, without needing to be explained.

“Whoa, whoa, seriously...”

Venom muttered. He felt that they were in serious trouble. It had been tough even against Arios, but these four additions were out of the question. It was only thanks to Masayuki that the battle had been manageable, but these Evil Dragon Spawn seemed unlikely to be able to use any kind of battle tactics. Emotion had both good and bad aspects. The prideful Arios was too impatient to show his true strength. Masayuki’s ‘Lucky Field’ had been one of the factors that contributed to bringing out the worst in him.

This time, however, such factors had been eliminated. The creatures’ lack of intelligence may work to their advantage, but for the Evil Dragon Spawns, who’s only remaining assets were their offensive instincts and unparalleled fighting sense, there seemed to be no inconveniences just by being a fighting machine. Venom sensed this intuitively.

“This will be very dangerous if we don’t take things seriously.”

Hinata spoke, breaking out in a cold sweat. The Evil Dragon Spawns were dangerous, that’s what Hinata’s survival instincts were telling her. Even Hinata’s Phantom Pain could not penetrate the black scales that covered their outer skin. The only possible openings were the eyes and the mouth on the belly, but Hinata judged that there was little hope for that either. That was why she told the Holy Knights who had gathered one after another.

“Attention, all Holy Knights below the rank of captain. Keep a large distance from the target and get in formation! Do not let that evil being escape from this place, and do not let that Vega accumulate any more power than he already has. Isolate this area with a ‘Barrier.’”

At this order, the Holy Knights that had arrived reacted immediately. For

some reason, the monsters that had been rampaging all over the place suddenly melted into the ground. In order to find out the cause, they had come to the center of the disaster, where the unimaginable situation had occurred. Seeing the Evil Dragon Spawn, which was clearly beyond their control, the Holy Knights' morale was about to drop. However, Hinata's shout gave them a purpose and revived their fighting spirit.

"That's right. Let us do what we can do for now."

Cardinal Nicolaus nodded broadly.

"Understood, Hinata-sama."

Fritz nodded.

"Well...this is just going to cost us more lives."

Ritase did not disagree. She was scared, but she couldn't just escape either.

"Leave it to me! We'll show you the results of our training here."

Bacchus laughed. Everyone knew that he was in a state of false cheerfulness, but the sound of his laughter seemed to give them energy.

"Well then, let's go!"

Arnaud shouted at the end, bringing everyone together. Everyone nodded their heads in agreement. They would not give up just because the enemy was out of control. If they ran away now, their futures would remain bleak. Cardinal Nicolaus and the four captains of the Holy Knight Order were leading. Following them, the members of the Holy Knight Order began to act in accordance with several training patterns.

They scattered in five directions around the square, forming a five-pointed star. Then, they constructed an 'Isolation Barrier' with everyone's combined power. This time, although the enemy was evil, they did not use magicules as their energy source. Rather, although magicules were also energy, the enemy had taken in other powers, so the effect of the Holy

Purification Barrier was expected to be limited. In fact, considering the presence of the monsters in this barrier, it was judged that they may be a hindrance to it. Therefore, Hinata's choice was to use 'Material Area,' which aimed to completely isolate this place from the rest of the world. Hinata's choice was supported by Testarossa.

"That's great. Cien, Venom, you guys should help as well. If we don't reinforce the barriers even a little, they'll seek out bait beneath the ground."

That bait was the evacuated residents of Royal Capital. Testarossa had hypothesized about Vega's abilities with some accuracy from his previous attacks. As long as it was within the influence of Vega's power, any organic matter could be used as food for Vega. So far, it had only been overlooked because it was ineffective, but there was no telling when the slaughter would start in order to recover the damage. That possibility was the reason why Testarossa was holding back her attack.

"You guys should help as well." Velgrynd ordered Minits and the others.

"But we have His Majesty—"

"With me here, there's no way anyone will be laying a finger on Masayuki. If you understand that, then get out of here."

" " "Understood." " " "

Minits, Bernie, and Jiwu were also dispatched to help maintain the 'Material Area.' Thus, only the strongest remained in the area.

Confronting Feldway was Velgrynd. Still facing Vega, was Testarossa. In the form of a boy, was Moss. Having been revived, was Hinata, and just standing there with his arms crossed, was Masayuki. As mentioned, these were the five members of the group.

Why am I even still here?

There was one person who still had questions, but no one offered a helping hand or even a suggestion.

And finally, the situation had changed.

“Go play with them.”

With a single order from Vega, the four Evil Dragon Spawns began to move in unison at a furious pace. Obeying orders, they kicked off the ground, flew through the air, and pounced on the prey they had set their sights on—

**Chapter
4**

**The Gathering
of the Giants**

That Time I Got Reincarnated as a Slime

Chapter 4

The Gathering of the Giants

As I faced Michael, I was in the biggest pinch of my life. I feel like I'm always in these kinds of situations, but this time it was for real. Michael's unexplainable attack had defeated even Diablo, and there was nothing I could do about it, to be honest. The only reason I could afford to be like this was because Veldora was waiting for me in the labyrinth. As long as Veldora was safe, I could be resurrected. More importantly—

Are things really okay?

«Not a problem, but if you're worried, you just have to not lose.»

You're right about that. Ciel-san's argument was so correct that it was difficult to respond to it. If I could do that in the first place, I wouldn't have any troubles at all, which is why I'm worried and anxious.

«It's okay. I wondered if something like this might happen, so I have already taken steps to deal with this situation—Will you take immediate action?»

Hey, what?! I haven't heard anything, but you've already taken action? I don't know why you're trying to deceive me...or rather, you can't deceive me, so you're doing it on purpose.

«Apologies. Well then, while we're at it, you would like to activate 'Emergency Response Mode'?»

When you say, "you would" instead of "would you," I'm guessing that means you're ready to activate it...

Well, that's fine. It's Ciel-san, so things won't go bad. Apparently, there was a way out of this, and I liked to think that there was still some hope.

«I will do my best to meet your expectations.»

Perhaps realizing that I was convinced, Ciel-san's motivation seemed to have been ignited. I had no idea how this would affect it. If so, I should just take action instead of worrying. There's no other answer anyway—in that case, let's just attack. It wasn't that I was going to give up and try my best until the end, but rather that I was feeling quite at ease. I would do everything I could with the intention of gathering information for the next battle. I didn't want this experience to go to waste, even if I had to throw it away. I was risking my life, and I wanted to get as much useful information as I could out of it. With that in mind, I readied my sword. But it seems that I was too naive.

"I commend you for not despairing. However, you are no match for me."

The moment I heard Michael's supercilious remark, I stopped moving. No, it wasn't just me who stopped. The whole world had stopped. I remember this feeling—

«I knew it.»

Eh, what?

«As seen with the attacks that defeated Diablo, Souei, and Leon earlier, this phenomenon is the same as the one that Guy Crimson and Chloe Aubert once activated—»

Uh, could it be...that the déjà vu pattern I experienced was the correct answer?

«That's correct. This is definitely a 'Time Stop.'»

Hah?! We can't win like that! That's a foul! It may be acceptable in manga or anime, but in real life, that's just shocking.

Those who cannot reach the 'suspended world' are no match for those who can, no matter how strong they are; it seems that I was right in recognizing that.

In fact, there was nothing I could do. Well, of course Diablo would lose. I thought I could never imagine him losing, but I guess it's inevitable when the enemy can stop time. Yup, time to disband! Already, I have honestly accepted my defeat—uh, huh?

Time has already stopped now, right? How are we even having this conversation?

«Thanks to the 'Emergency Response Mode,' we can now recognize a suspended world!»

Seriously?! As expected of Ciel-sensei!

The report was a bit smug, but I can forgive it now, rather, I'm very grateful. I was relieved to know that things were going to work out, but it seems that I was mistaken. It was only when I saw that Michael's sword was approaching that I realized it. I rushed to deal with it, but my body would not react at all. Being able to recognize the suspended world did not mean that I could move in it, which, when I thought about it, was only natural. I thought I would be able to do something because Ciel-san was so smug...

Well, I didn't manage to do anything about it in the first place, so it wasn't my place to complain. It was a bit of a blessing in disguise, but oh well. Even if I gave up and let Michael cut me down, I would at least like to remember his sword line and fighting habits for the next time.

«No, it's too early to give up.»

I was about to give up, but Ciel-san calmed me down. And in the next moment, I felt that a clear sound was echoing in my ears. I remembered this sound, and I even felt a sense of familiarity. At that time, it was definitely—

“Rimuru-sensei, I'm here to help!”

That's right, it was Chloe. While I was helpless against Michael's sword, her long black and silver hair swept in front of me as if it were scattering silver light around me.

In her hand was the Moon Mistress, and she was cloaked in Divine Spirit Armor. The Moonlight Sabre and the Holy Spirit Armor entrusted to her by Hinata had undergone a long journey to reach the mythical-grade level. The wielder was, of course, the beautifully grown Hero Chloe.



Well, Chloe had come, but I still remained motionless. In other words, it was impossible to reply to her—

«No problem. It turns out that information particles are unaffected by time or space and can transmit information to any point in time. This means that they can transmit thoughts even in a suspended world.»

Is that so? The conversation between me and Ciel-san was happening instantly. However, the voice I heard from Chloe had a slight time difference. The reason for this remained unknown though, right? If the information particle was unaffected by time and space, then wouldn't it make sense that communication would be instantaneous as well?

«I am a part of Master, so I am not affected by time at all. However, if you want to know what's going on outside in the suspended world, an information particle needs to be flown out to grasp the information of the surroundings—»

Hmm, that's hard to explain. In short, the information particle is not affected by space-time, so it can move in any situation. That's why, by interfering with the information particle as a substitute for magicules, you can maintain your vision and transmit your thoughts. In other words, interfering with the information particle was not enough to move in this situation. Chloe seemed to be talking normally, but I guess we shouldn't confuse her with the real world.

I thought that she was using ‘Thought Acceleration,’ but it seems that this was not the case. Apparently, we were just exchanging information particles with no time lag, and it was possible because we shared the same ‘soul.’ In that case, if I wanted to communicate my intent to a third party in this ‘Suspended World’—

«You can imprint your will on the information particle and hit the other person.»

This may sound rough, but I understood it well. Ciel-san could now interfere with the information particle, so it’s possible to reply. In the first place, the reason why I could see what was going on around me now was because I was reflecting the information particles. I wondered whether or not the speed of the information particles was constant in this ‘Suspended World,’ but I was glad to hear that the conversation was established.

〈Sorry, you saved me! But I don’t seem to be able to move yet, so—〉

I immediately sent my intent to Chloe. Then Chloe responded with ‘Telepathy Net’ to match me.

〈Yeah, I know. Rather, you can use ‘Telepathy Net’ now, can’t you?〉

〈Well, sort of.〉

〈That’s right, Rimuru-san has ‘Ciel’ with him. It’s no wonder he can do this.〉

Oh, so Chloe knows Ciel-san too.

«Yes. Through Chronoa, my existence was revealed. That’s why she secretly took on the role of an escort this time.»

Ah, that made sense. So that was the trump card that Ciel-san was

hiding. Or rather, if it had gone this far, it must've guessed that things were too dangerous.

«Yes. I hadn't been able to fully determine the enemy's objective, but I was certain that they were targeting Masayuki Honjou. Similarly, I guessed that Master was also a likely target.»

Hoho, so you're saying that I was used as bait? That was a rare decision for Ciel-san, who always played things too safe. Huh? Are you saying that the double check from that time...

«Yes. It was a metaphor for Michael, who thought he had the upper hand on Master.»

Damn it, I've been beaten! I'm ashamed that I didn't notice. At that time, it felt like Ciel-san was stalling. My answer was not wrong, but it was not right either. It was because I wasn't sure whether to point it out or not!!

«—I thought that Michael would naturally assume that Master would go to Leon to bring him back to his senses. In that case, it was expected that he would use Leon as bait, so I wondered how much importance Michael would place on this, and how much force he would put into it.»

S-so that's how it was. No, it made sense when you thought about it. I had already brought Velgrynd back to her senses. Michael and Feldway were not so stupid as to think that Velgrynd had come back on her own. It turned out that my thinking had been too shallow...

Michael would have been wary of us getting Leon back and would have

done something about it. Rather than worrying about Leon, he thought of a way to take advantage of the situation. In other words, Michael's plan was to use Leon as bait to lure me out. And Ciel-san had planned this plan in anticipation of that. There was no room for me to intervene.

It may sound simple when explained, but both of them had been thinking two or three moves ahead, and even the slightest deviation in the course of events could have led to a catastrophic failure. No, perhaps that was why. If I hadn't come here, Michael would have taken a different approach, so it was easier for Ciel-san to read the situation by pretending to be fooled. My safety is guaranteed when Veldora is around, so it decided that it would be better for me to go along with Michael's plan.

«Yes. Of course, Master's safety was given the utmost consideration.»

I'm sure it was. It's scary that it was all going according to plan, but what even Ciel-san didn't calculate was that Michael also had the 'Time Stop' ability.

«That was also considered as a possibility, so I negotiated with Chloe Aubert and asked her to be on standby just in case.»

I see, so you guessed that Chloe would not enter the battle. But because Michael was too strong, I ended up being saved by Chloe. Even Ciel-san couldn't foresee the situation, so there was nothing for me to do.

«Michael's ability to handle 'Time Stop' was the biggest miscalculation. However, it turned out to be a good thing in the end.»

Hm? Why is that?

«Because there are very few people who can handle this ability, it is a very valuable experience. It was fortuitous that we succeeded in developing the ‘Emergency Response Mode,’ If we observe the Suspended World in this way, it will only be a matter of time before we are able to move.»

That confidence is as strong as ever. It was only a matter of time, so I guess it was a losing battle to argue while time was stopped. I feel like I’ll be judged otherwise, so I’ll just praise you for this. The question was whether I could actually move when time was stopped. If I couldn’t do that, there would be no talking about it in the future, so it was our urgent task to solve this problem. For now, I had to rely on Chloe...

At any rate, there was nothing I could do right now. In all seriousness, I’ve decided to wait and see how the battle between Chloe and Michael goes.



Michael did not move, perhaps because he was wary of Chloe’s appearance. But finally, he lifted the sword in his right hand with a swaying motion.

“—To be honest, it’s hard to believe that something so unexpected happened.”

“Is that so?”

“I didn’t realize that there were others besides Velzard and I who could move in this stopped time. Aside from manas, the ultimate beings such as

myself, I don't know how you could have reached this realm."

Whoa, Michael himself said the word "manas" just now, was this a trick? If Chloe reacted, he seemed to be hoping to get closer to her true identity. I was a little worried and thought about advising Chloe, but there was no need.

"Hmm, is that so? It was surprisingly easy."

Chloe just brushed it off. Seeing her response made me remember. Although I couldn't help but think of her as my own student, Chloe was a great warrior in her own right. After a long, long journey through time, she had reigned as the strongest Hero. She also had a Manas named Chronoa, so I didn't have to worry about her.

"Stop laughing. The 'Hope King Sariel' response has disappeared from you, are you willing to answer why?"

Ah, I knew it. I had thought that Michael might be able to detect the angelic Ultimate Skills, but now it was confirmed. And the fact that the response was gone meant that Chloe had successfully sublimated the 'Hope King Sariel' and turned it into her power.

«I didn't even need to help her. It's very disappointing.»

I suppose it is. To the skill-maniac Ciel-san, Chloe's skill must have been drool-worthy. If it had been able to find out the secret, we would have been able to move in the Suspended World by now. No, rather than Chloe being stingy, I think Ciel-san was too much of a foul...

"Is there any reason for me to tell you that?"

No, not really. Michael didn't seem to be expecting an answer either and silently repositioned his sword.

"In that case, I must eliminate the uncertainty."

“I agree. I’ll make you regret making me your enemy.”

After that conversation, the battle between Chloe and Michael began.

The battle was, in a word, tremendous. As it turned out while watching the battle, the speed of the information particle was constant. Conversation had been established and the reaction speed of vision was also constant. This was as clear a physical phenomenon as the fact that all things cannot exceed the speed of light. In that case, why did the information particles exceed the speed of light?

This was not a matter of the speed being exceeded. It was as if the information particles, which were supposed to be at different coordinates, were transferring information to each other with zero time difference. Regardless of how far they were from each other, as long as the information particles existed in the recognizable space, there was no time difference. In other words, an information particle transcended time and space. Our communication had also been established by using the information transfer between information particles. In that case, how can one move? Could it possibly be...

«If it is a spiritual life form, then they must have transformed all matter into ‘information particles,’ thereby resulting in a Digital Lifeform.»

I knew it. Assuming that the mind and spirit are also information, it’s not impossible. Whether it could be done or not was another matter, but it is significant that there was an answer there. I should have eliminated the thought I couldn’t do it and instead concentrated on how I could get there.

«You’re right. We’ll make the ‘Emergency Response Mode’ even more

fully operational, and aim to evolve into a Digital Lifeform, is that okay?»

Of course, Ciel-kun. I'll leave it all to you, so please do as you like.

—That's what I profusely ordered. Because nothing could be done if we didn't, and if there was a possible countermeasure, we should try everything. Ciel-san understood my intentions correctly and energetically started its activities. All that remained was to wait for the results. I was still concerned about the fact that I was leaving everything to others, but it couldn't be helped anymore. I made up my mind and focused on the battle between Chloe and Michael.



Now then, Chloe and Michael were quite close in terms of their abilities. I couldn't tell exactly, so I was just making inferences, but I thought that they were evenly matched in terms of physical ability. Or perhaps I should say that they were evenly matched in their ability to interfere with the information particles. Since the speed had a fixed maximum value, it was one's power of interference that determined superiority or inferiority. The key point was how well one could control the information particles and outperform the enemy. That would be the decisive factor in a 'Suspended World,' I guessed.

There were a few more things that I noticed while observing. First, there was no concept of defense in the 'Suspended World.' Those who could move, such as Chloe and Michael, could interfere with each other's information particles to form a unified offensive and defensive battle. On

the other hand, those who could not move would be attacked without being able to take any defense. Moreover, the fact that time was stopped meant that all the forces were not working. Intermolecular forces such as star attraction and repulsion would not work, and there were no binding forces. There was no inertia and no external factors, so an object retained its original state. In that case, what would happen if something was attacked in this state? The answer was simple—it would collapse in an instant.

Whether it was a reinforced concrete wall, a solid bedrock, or a lump of steel, there was no resistance because the atoms were not even bonded to each other. There was nothing in this world that could endure. That was the conclusion. A world in which all the laws of physics do not apply was a terrifying thing when I thought about it. I wouldn't know what would happen, and if I entered the world carelessly, I was likely to get severely harmed. Between those who could move in the 'Suspended World' and those who couldn't, there was a dimensional barrier that could never be overcome. With that in mind, I was surprised that Diablo and Souei had survived...

«Diablo seemed to have anticipated this and activated a magical 'Defense Barrier.'»

Whoa, newsflash. Diablo's anticipation of this situation was amazing, but the fact that his magic was also effective in the 'Suspended World' was an unexpected bonus.

«However, you cannot activate magic while in the Suspended World. You must prepare for it beforehand, and once its effect is broken, it's over.»

I see, so that's why he was safe. I wonder if that's what Michael meant when he said he "should have finished them off." It was meant as a follow-up. Whoa, then what about Souei?

«Souei survived because he was a 'Parallel Existence.' I believe he is still pretending to be beaten up, hiding in Master's shadow and looking for an opportunity to abruptly attack Michael.»

It didn't make much sense because time had stopped—that's what Ciel-san explained to me. I had completely forgotten that he could now use 'Parallel Existence.' In any case, Souei was very impressive. This was the only time I didn't think I'd be able to use him, but I thought to myself that he was really reliable under normal circumstances.

—And so, the first thing I noticed was that the 'Suspended World' had no concept of defense, but the other thing I noticed was that the person who activated the 'Suspended World' seemed to be at a disadvantage. I wasn't completely sure, but I didn't think I was wrong. It appeared that stopping time consumed a lot of energy. In that case, there was no point in suspending all the people who were able to move in the 'Suspended World.' This time, Michael chose not to release the 'Suspended World' because he didn't want me to join in.

«Not only that, but it seems that repeatedly stopping and deactivating it consumes more energy.»

Ah, I see. It's almost like an electrical appliance. In that case, perhaps Michael was not yet accustomed to 'Time Stop,' and unknowingly

deactivated it several times earlier?

«I'm sure of it. Anyone who can observe the 'Suspended World' would have noticed it as soon as someone activated the 'Time Stop' somewhere.»

Mm, I understand what Ciel-san is trying to say. Time was not something that flowed only in a limited space. It was the 'Suspended World' that affected time and space in all worlds. Ever since Guy and Chloe had fought briefly, I hadn't experienced the strange sensation I had felt at that time—the feeling that time had stopped. It was proof that, as Ciel-san had said, no one had triggered the 'Time Stop.' Well, it was a world that only a limited number of people could understand, but even so, this ability was surprisingly difficult to handle. It was useless if the other party could also use it—wait, what? What happens if you aim for the moment your sword hits the opponent?

«That's what Guy and Chloe were doing when they were fighting.»

Ah, I see...

I didn't realize it at the time, but those two had been fighting with unimaginable and transcendental skill. But that had just been a light test of skill, and the more I learned about them, the scarier they got. That means I have to be ready to respond at a moment's notice. Otherwise, I won't be able to compete with this level of combat.

«I'll make sure not to neglect my research as well.»

Ah, please do. I had been feeling overwhelmed, but those words made

me feel relieved. It felt truly reliable to have a partner, Ciel-san, whom I could count on.



While I was thinking about this, the battle was reaching its climax. Chloe and Michael were still competing against each other, but my fingertips twitched. And little by little, I felt my senses returning from all corners of my body.

«Your evolution into a Digital Lifeform will soon be complete.»

Ciel-san's words were truly a gospel of victory. If it was a one-on-one battle, then I'd have the upper hand once I entered the fray. And that time would come.

"It's time for you to be destroyed, you clever little Hero."

"That's my line. You bragged about being a Manas, but that's nothing unusual."

The psychological warfare had reached its climax. At this point, Chloe also revealed that she had Chronoa within her. Michael was upset by this, and it created a small opening.

Chloe wouldn't let that go—

"Goodbye, your fate ends here."

A cold gaze pierced Michael.

"Reveal all things as they should be. 'Reverse Fate'!!"

Referring to the long and short hands of a clock, it accelerated the rotation in the opposite direction of the clock. Even in this ‘Suspended World,’ Chloe’s skills were still intact. She didn’t let us know it until the very end and played it as a decisive move. The effect was dramatic.

Chloe had said to reveal all things as they should be, but that was not exactly what she meant. For Chloe, it was to change things into what you think you should be. Therefore, it was not a return. And as for Michael, who was hit by the ‘Reverse Fate’...

“I, I...what am I doing...? Who am I, what am I?”

A hollow being inhabiting Rudra’s body. A skill that had lost its master, lost its reason for being, and had gone mad to fill its emptiness. Its true identity was—

“Ultimate Skill ‘Justice King Michael,’ huh.”

Rudra’s body, which had been preserved by the effects of the skill, began to crumble because it couldn’t withstand the excessive force it contained. Now that it had been turned back into a mere skill by Chloe’s hands, it had no reason to maintain its host. In the face of this emptiness, Chloe spoke softly.

“If you’ve lost sight of where you should go, will you come with me?”

Hm? I thought, but I decided to keep quiet and watch.

〈...?!〉

Just like me, Michael—No, rather, ‘Justice King Michael,’ whose ego as a Manas had faded and returned to mere skill, seemed to be puzzled by the proposal. Chloe’s proposal was to let it choose between disappearing or staying in this world with Chloe as its master. There was no easy answer, and it seemed like ‘Justice King Michael’ would disappear and time would start to move on—but at that moment, the ‘Voice of the World’ echoed in the ‘Suspended World.’

«It is confirmed that the three elements of ‘Courage,’ ‘Hope,’ and ‘Justice’ have been gathered in the Individual: Chloe Aubert. This fills in the missing elements of the Ultimate Skill ‘Hope King Sarel,’ and begins the complete integration into the Ultimate Skill ‘Spacetime King Yog-Sothoth’...Successful. Ultimate Skill ‘Spacetime King Yog-Sothoth’ has fully evolved into Ultimate Skill ‘Spacetime God (Yog-Sothoth).’»

It was already obvious that it had been super-enhanced without being explained. Inside Chloe, the ultimate evolution had taken place without her even being aware of it.

“Chloe, are you...okay?”

“Yes. Rimuru-san, I feel like I’ve truly become one with Chronoa.”

Having seen the change in Chloe firsthand, I thought that it might be true. It was because I felt that her faint childishness had disappeared, and that she had now acquired a seductiveness that reminded me of an adult woman. Since this was a characteristic of Chronoa, I thought that perhaps—

Smooch

«...?!»

Yes?

“Ch-Chloe, you, what are—”

Chloe kissed me out of the blue. I didn’t know what I was saying, but Chloe’s beauty had suddenly approached me, and then I suddenly felt a soft touch on my lips. There was nothing I could do to stop it. There was no need to verify whether it could have been avoided or not.

“Ufufu. I’m an adult now.”

That’s true, I admit it. But even so, I don’t think you should take people

by surprise like that. Well, it's a good thing that it was me, but wouldn't it be a problem if it was Leon? I'm fine with it, I am. And just like that, I made excuses to no one. However, why would Chloe suddenly kiss me...

"Wasn't that something Rimuru-san needed? I just felt like it, you know?"

Even if you say it in such a cute way...wait, what do you mean I needed it?

«...Tsk, what a clever form of bribery... I received the remnants of 'Hope King Sariel' from Chloe. I'm sure that there were other ways to do this, so I'll be more vigilant against surprise attacks in the future.»

Uh, did you just click your tongue? Or rather, you don't really have to be so vigilant...

«I will keep a close watch.»

Uh, yes. I wasn't sure why, but it felt like I shouldn't disobey anymore. I think it's better to let Ciel-san do what it wants, so I decided to change the subject and cover it up.

"So then, now that you're talking about becoming one with Chronoa, does that mean Chloe can't return to her child form?"

"Oh, that's still okay."

She could change her appearance at will, from a baby to an old woman. Whether that made any sense or not, I was relieved that I wouldn't have to startle Kenya and the others.

"Okay, I'm going to release the 'Time Stop.'"

Taking over from Michael, it seemed that Chloe was now in control of

stopping time. She did it as naturally as if she was breathing. It was hard to imagine how much stronger she had become. Even without the assistance of a Manas, she seemed to be able to control her powers to the fullest. At the very least, I didn't need to be told that she was better than me who just relied on Ciel-san. Okay, this is not the time to be so impressed.

“Before that, just one thing. I think, probably after this—”

“Yeah, I understand. I'm pretty sure the amount of power I absorbed was less than expected.”

“Got it. Then leave it to me this time. And you, take it easy and get some rest.”

And so, I strongly cautioned Chloe. Even though Chloe appeared to be fine, there was no way she could be safe after evolving so rapidly. I had to make sure she got a good rest, whether she wanted it or not.

“Ufu, I'm glad you're worried about me.”

“I won't be fooled.”

Even if she smiles at me in such a cute way, I'm not like Leon. It was time for me to show my dignity as an adult.

“All right. I'll be quiet for a little while then. So, you won't lose, right?”

“Of course. Thanks to Chloe, I understand the concept of time.”

“Fufu, that's right.”

I promised Chloe I would win. Well, I wasn't going to admit it even if I lost, so it wouldn't be a lie. And so, Chloe released the ‘Time Stop,’ and the world began to move once more.



I was stopped in time while confronting Michael, but for those who couldn't recognize it, it must have seemed as if Michael suddenly disappeared, and Chloe had appeared. Specifically, Souei hurriedly spoke to me through 'Telepathy Net.'

◁Rimuru-sama, I apologize. I lost sight of the enemy—▷

◁It's okay, but don't come out yet.▷

◁...?! Understood!!▷

That was all Souei needed to know. He was the best of the best, so it helped to talk fast. And then I began to play innocent.

"Oh hey, Chloe. Thanks for coming to save me. He almost got me."

"Fufu, Rimuru-san's not a very good actor, huh?"

Shut up! I'm honest at heart so I'm just not good at deceiving anyone.

"That's enough. No more cheating. Chloe, you should go back and relax."

"Okay. I'll trust you, then."

After that, Chloe kept her promise to me and returned to Tempest. From here on, she would be in her room in the labyrinth, recovering from the aftereffects of her rapid evolution. Then, I grinned towards the empty space.

"Come on out, you're hiding, aren't you?"

"...I thought my presence was perfectly 'concealed,' so how did you notice?"

If he was asking me why, I'd have to say it was pretty obvious. In my case, it was a hunch. It was common knowledge that the moment you thought you won the battle was the moment when the opening was the largest. Therefore, I assumed that a 'Parallel Existence' would be hidden during the battle. Or rather, it was something I definitely would have done. In my case, unlike Velgrynd and Souei, I was unable to split my consciousness, so I couldn't take such a measure, but if it were possible, I

would have adopted such a strategy. I was sure that Michael would have prepared such a strategy. When I tried to advise Chloe with that in mind, she told me that Michael was using ‘Parallel Existence.’

It was a part of Michael that Chloe had taken in. However, she received all the information on ‘Justice King Michael,’ and by taking it in, she was able to find out Michael’s plan. I was planning to wait for Michael to take me by surprise, but I decided not to bother. I figured I should just beat him head on and end his stupid ambitions.

“I see. Just because you’ve read my thoughts, doesn’t mean you saw through my skills. But even so—”

Michael spoke to me, looking slightly surprised.

“I didn’t think you’d be able to defeat my ‘Parallel Existence.’”

“Well, yeah. Though it wasn’t me, but that girl.”

“Hero Chronoa. I underestimated how far she had come.”

“It’s not Chronoa, but Chloe. Well, you’re done here anyway, so there’s no need to correct you.”

I said as such, lightly loosening my body. It had been a while since I had fought with all my might. Just to make sure, I would do some preparatory exercises.

“What nonsense. How dare you bark at me when you’ve only been hiding behind the Hero?”

“That’s one way to look at it. But you know, Chloe was my student. If I don’t show her some dignity as a teacher, I’ll lose my standing, won’t I?”

I replied, but Michael just gave me a cold stare with no expression. The look on his face told me that he didn’t understand me. Well, from the perspective of someone who could stop time, I probably wasn’t important. But that was before.

“Demon Lord Rimuru, you have a bad memory. I taught you that you

were an obstacle, but not an enemy. You should learn your lesson and leave this world quickly.”

Are you saying I should die? Obviously, I don’t want that.

“Don’t tell me what to do, just come and get me.”

As soon as I finished saying that, time stopped. Michael’s sword closed in on me with a look of victory on his face. But alas! I, too, had made this ‘Suspended World’ my own. Even in this soundless world, I could hear the echoing clashes of swords and blades.

“It can’t be, you?!”

“I’ve learned how to move in a suspended world!”

I shouted and faced Michael with a different expression. I saw Michael as an enemy. It was the same for Michael. He recognized me as an enemy to be defeated, and his condescending attitude disappeared. And then we—

This time, in the truest sense of the word, we faced each other with the fate of the world at stake.



Velgrynd was in dire straits. She had said she would protect Masayuki no matter what, but Feldway was not so naive as to allow her to do so.

“I’ve been made a fool, haven’t I? Velgrynd, are you going to take me with one hand?”

“Yes. Unlike you—what is that presence?!”

Feldway, who had been on the defensive until now, unleashed the power he had been hiding before Velgrynd. It was just as powerful as Velgrynd’s—no, it was even greater.

“You probably thought that you had ‘Parallel Existence’ anyway, but I can use it too. If you’re planning to go help Masayuki, I’ll do my best to stop you.”

“Tsk, you still have that disgusting personality. I hate you.”

“Is that so? That’s a shame.”

Velgrynd frowned when she heard Feldway’s curt reply. In the ancient past, Feldway had been a lieutenant for her brother Veldanava, who had also complained to Velgrynd. Remembering that time, Velgrynd became even more irritated. Besides, the reality of the situation was harsh. Velgrynd had her hands full just dealing with Feldway, and Testarossa, who was the most reliable, was facing Vega herself. In that case, there were not enough allies to go against the four Evil Dragon Spawns.

I guess I underestimated Feldway too much. Was it a mistake to leave those three out? No, it would have been impossible to maintain the ‘Material Area’ otherwise...

Without Minits, Bernie, and Jiwu, the strength of the ‘Material Area’ would have been weakened. In that case, there would be no way to stop Vega from forcefully rooting into the ground and feeding on the evacuated people of the Royal Capital for energy. Therefore, Velgrynd’s orders were not wrong, but she was worried that she might have made the wrong choice because she cared about Masayuki the most. The only people who could protect Masayuki were Moss, Testarossa’s confidant, and the Saint, Hinata. She didn’t think they’d be able to stop the four Evil Dragon Spawns, so Velgrynd’s mind grew impatient.

“By the way, to take on three at the same time...you can’t do it.”

“I appreciate your understanding, but can you please stop looking at me like you’re disappointed? I’m trying my best too!”

She could hear the conversation between Hinata and Moss, which made

her worry even more. Hinata and Moss were each restraining two of them. But that was the best they could do, and it didn't look like they could defeat them. In fact, this was a pretty good fight. They were only just able to deal with Evil Dragon Spawn because they had little experience in fighting them, and the two of them were outmatched in terms of combat ability. It would be absurd to expect more than this. And Testarossa as well.

“The ‘Material Area’ is finally complete.”

“So what?”

“It means that I can now destroy you without restraint.”

It was all well and good until she told him so and launched her onslaught. But after that, Vega's indestructibility made it difficult to fight him. Testarossa's skill-level was by far the highest. Despite the fact that Vega's existence value was several times greater, he was not an unbeatable opponent. And yet, Vega had evolved in the middle of the battle. He had eaten Arios and gained his power. And now, something happened that made things worse. Unbeknownst to Testarossa and the others, Michael's 'Time Stop' had been activated.

Velgrynd and Testarossa were the only ones who felt confused by the discomfort. Both of them immediately realized what had just occurred. Even if they panicked after time began to move again, everything would already be over. Because they understood that, the two of them did not panic. However, there was just a small opening. And to that extent, Masayuki's 'Lucky Field' should have been able to overcome it. However, when she felt the strange sensation for the fourth time, something happened to Masayuki.

“Huh?”

Masayuki fell to his knees on the spot. He was exposed to sudden dizziness, but at that point, the effects of his power had disappeared.

“Masayuki?!”

Velgrynd’s worried voice rang out.

“Hyahaha! You shouldn’t look away from me!”

And then Vega attacked, taking advantage of Testarossa’s opening. Hinata and Moss were in a difficult situation as well, because the good luck had worn off when they had already been struggling. Masayuki’s collapse was enough to put them all in a desperate situation. Then came the worst moment of all. Velgrynd’s attention turned to Masayuki, and she exposed an opening that she shouldn’t have. Feldway was not so naive as to let this go unnoticed.

“It’s my victory!”

Feldway shouted, his sword piercing Velgrynd’s chest.



Masayuki could not comprehend the reality of what was happening before his eyes. The woman who smiled fearlessly, confidently, and always took care of herself no matter what the situation was, was kneeling on the ground, holding her chest. This was something that should not have happened. Feldway was an outrageous monster, and he was no match for him, and if Gryn-san had been defeated, there was nothing he could do but run away—but he didn’t care about that. Masayuki reconsidered what his heart was feeling and looked once more.

Intense rage. From the top of his head to the tips of his toes, he found himself feeling a rage running through his entire body, threatening to burst out.

“Bastard, what the hell are you doing?”

A quieter voice than expected spilled out of Masayuki’s mouth. Feldway reacted to it.

“Hm? You’re the real deal, but just wait a minute. In any case, I’ll destroy Velgrynd once and for all here—”

He couldn’t finish his sentence.

“I asked you what the hell you were doing to my woman!”⁷⁰

This was because Masayuki had stepped in at an unnoticeable speed and struck Feldway in the side with his rapier. This gem had been forged by Kurobee’s hands, mainly to reduce weight and increase strength, and was a unique grade product. However, there was no way he could just carelessly hit an enemy protected by mythical-grade armor and be safe. The weapon was shattered into pieces by the blow. But Masayuki didn’t care. Ignoring Feldway, who took a step back in surprise, he picked up Velgrynd.

“—Masayuki?”

“You’re safe now, so don’t worry.”

“No, it can’t be...”

“I’ll take care of the rest. Rest well, Gryun.”⁷¹

“Ahh!!”

Tears spilled from Velgrynd’s eyes. That name was a nickname from her beloved, and there was only one person in the world who knew it—

“Welcome home, Rudra!”

“Yeah. It’s only for a little while, but I’m back.”

And then, Rudra, who was inhabiting Masayuki, smiled. From here on, it was time for a counterattack.



Feldway furrowed his brow in displeasure.

“Rudra? What kind of nonsense is that—”

“Hah! Feldway, I’ll be the one to deal with you, but it looks like the others are having a hard time too. I’ll give them a hand. Come now, Gran, you too, Damrada!”

Space-time flickered, as if in response to Rudra’s call. Completely ignoring the ‘Material Area,’ two figures were summoned there.

“Well, well. I’ve spent beautiful days with Maria, but you’re a harsh master even after your death.”

—Complained the first person summoned, a man with blond rather than white hair. Then, with a sharp, eagle-like gaze, he smiled.

“Hinata, my unworthy apprentice. It’s a pity that you, the most talented of all the people I’ve worked with, have yet to become a Hero.”

When Hinata was told this, she was astonished to think of that person’s name.

“It can’t be, you’re...”

“I couldn’t show you then, so I’ll show you now. Let me see what you can do!”

“—Master Granbell?!”

He was too young to be her master, but it was definitely Granbell Rosso. Granbell had returned to this land in his best, most powerful form.

“Come, ‘Truth.’”

Granbell called out to his beloved sword. The longsword Truth, which had been stored in subspace, appeared in Granbell’s hand without losing its mythical-grade glow. And the next moment. An ‘Overblade—True Slash’ casually sliced one of the Evil Dragon Spawns into dust.

“No way...”

As if to ridicule Hinata’s struggles, Granbell’s victory was too easy.



The man who had been called after Granbell knelt down before Rudra.

“Your Majesty, you have awakened from your long sleep, I am so very pleased!”

Rudra looked at Damrada in exasperation.

“You’re stubborn, Damrada...you, did you always have that kind of personality?”

“Ah, I missed you, my friend. I went through a lot of trouble because of you!”

“Sorry. I don’t remember, so I don’t know.”

“Yes, that’s right. That’s the kind of guy you are! I knew it!!”

Damrada was indignant, but hot tears were flowing from his eyes.

“Don’t cry, it was my fault.”

“Not exactly, but that’s good enough. You’ve kept your promise, so I’m satisfied.”

Even reincarnated, Rudra was still Rudra. Rudra, to whom Damrada had sworn his loyalty, had rejected the control of the demon lord and aimed to establish a unified nation, a world where everyone could live happily and harmoniously by their own hands—“The establishment of a unified nation” was his goal. However, due to a series of tragedies, Rudra lost sight of this dream, and his heart had become worn out. He regretted the days when he was powerless to do anything for his master—But now...

In this boy named Masayuki, the former Rudra had been brilliantly manifested. The sight of his old master was enough to make Damrada happy.

“Is that so? I still feel like I’m in the middle of a dream—”

“Well, dreams do come true if you don’t give up, don’t they?”

“If it’s me, yeah.”

“Fufufu, if it’s Rudra-sama, apparently. Well, I don’t want to talk too long, and I don’t want to lose to Gran either, so I’d better get going.”

Damrada, with a refreshing smile on his face, ended the conversation with Rudra. He then stood next to Moss with an unhurried gait.

“The great demon that has tormented my empire for so long, how unsightly.”

“Tsk, I’ve got my own problems at the moment...”

“Is that an excuse? Well, I’m not interested in hearing it.”

“You’re back to your old self, I see.”

“Of course. I have always been Rudra’s friend and His Majesty’s loyal servant. I can’t help but cut corners a bit while His Majesty is away.”

“We’re not enemies now, but well, I guess that’s fine.” Moss said, shrugging lightly. Smiling back at Moss, Damrada took a step forward.

“Now then, let’s get this over with.”

As soon as Damrada said this, he crouched down into a cat-legged stance. Putting his weight on his right foot, he became one with the earth and performed a ‘warp movement’ as if he were gliding across the ground. By a principle different from the ancient martial arts gait, Damrada’s body moved forward like a cannonball. And then, just like that, he crossed paths with the Evil Dragon Spawn—

“‘Holy Supreme Crumbling Fist’!”

From the part of the body that was struck, Damrada’s fighting spirit was transmitted to the entire body. There was no way to block it, and it disintegrated the entire spirit of Evil Dragon Spawn.

“I’m relieved to see you’re still as good as ever.”

Moss complimented him, sounding really unhappy.

“Then I guess it’s your turn next.”

“Of course it is.”

Moss agreed, thoroughly unsatisfied to his core.



Moss was reminded of his old troubles and bitter memories at the sight of his adversary still alive and well, but for now, he could only do what he had to do. Moss hated defeat. It was fine if he only lost, but he absolutely hated to be blamed for it by his horrible boss (Testarossa).

That alone was unacceptable, so he focused on how to fight without losing. This time, he had judged that he could not win immediately. That’s why he was trying to buy time, but if there was only one opponent, that was a very different story.

“If it’s only one, then I can win.”

While muttering to himself, he decided to show off his serious mode for the first time in a long time. He gathered the tiny ‘Clones’ that he had scattered in the air and returned to his true form.

What emerged was a beautiful man with silver hair and blue eyes. He was the Grand Duke of Hell, second only to the primordials. That was Moss. With the growth of his master Testarossa, Moss himself was growing more powerful every day. The value of his existence has surpassed the 1,079,397 EP reported to Testarossa, and he had now reached 1.5 million. Moreover, in his hands were a countless number of chakrams—the ‘Infinite Loop.’

At the same time as Moss was evolving, the ‘Infinite Loop’ had also

reached the mythical-grade level. The current Moss, who had completely taken in the power of the ‘Infinite Loop,’ had reached an existence value of 2.5 million, surpassing that of the Evil Dragon Spawns. If such a Moss were to get serious—

“Now you die. ‘Infinite Eater’!”

As soon as Moss activated the technique, his body shuddered. He became transparent and fragmented, enveloping the Evil Dragon Spawn.

“Gugyah?!”

Looking at Moss with emotionless eyes, and then finding himself unable to move, the Evil Dragon Spawn was baffled by its inability to carry out its orders. But that would only be for a short time. Moss’s attack was a dark magic that used his own body as a medium, and it also had the characteristics of a technique with the effect of his Unique Skill ‘Collector.’ Its effect was to absorb the same amount of energy as himself.

In other words, the amount of magicule in Moss’s body was directly converted into attack power, and although it had the disadvantage of not being able to be used again until the absorbed energy was sublimated, the ‘Infinite Eater’ was his strongest attack at the moment. If he used it, he knew it would be useless for a while, so it couldn’t be used in a crowded battle. Rather, it was a technique that was difficult to handle and had few uses, but in this case, it guaranteed Moss an overwhelming victory.

“That’s still a hell of a move. I wonder how many of the generals have been eaten.”

“I didn’t use it much on the weak ones. Maybe you were in a hurry and got unlucky. In the first place, I don’t want to hear that from someone who uses a poison that can corrupt the mind and slaughter demons.”

“Just let it out.”

Damrada and Moss praised each other’s performance in a way that

looked as if they were trying to humiliate each other.



Thus, Moss also won. And the last one left was Hinata, who was casually entrusted with the sword by Granbell.

“Master, this is...”

“You can have it. It is no longer of any use to me.”

With these words, Granbell gave Truth to Hinata.

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The Granbell here was nothing more than a fictional entity with an actual body. In fact, the sword he had just given to Hinata had also been recreated and held in his hand. The ability to summon past champions in the form of entities of the same nature as digital lifeforms. This was the essence of the Ultimate Skill ‘King of Heroes’ that Masayuki had awakened. Minits and Calgurio had regained their power because of the influence of this skill. And now, this time...

Masayuki’s anger had unknowingly triggered the ‘Hero’s Beacon’ to become more powerful. Rudra, the oldest and strongest of the champions, was called upon. The timing was also good. Perhaps it was a coincidence, or perhaps it was an inevitability due to Masayuki’s good fortune... When Michael’s ‘Parallel Existence’ was defeated by Chloe, the information of the physical body that had served as a substitute was on its way back to the heavens. As a result, all of them were called by Masayuki to be integrated.

Now, Masayuki's ego as Rudra had become more apparent.

And Rudra was able to use Velgrynd's powers as his own. Using Velgrynd's 'Parallel Existence' as a basis, Rudra did the insane thing of giving temporary bodies to the champions summoned by 'Hero's Beacon.' Granbell's new mythical-grade long sword was also created by borrowing Velgrynd's power.

"You used my power again, didn't you?"

"Is that bad?"

"No, not at all. Everything I have is yours, Rudra."

It was a show of their lovey-dovey couple-ness,⁷² but what they were doing was completely absurd. Masayuki's 'King of Heroes' was an insane power that was the ultimate balance breaker. It was no wonder that Feldway's face twitched as he confronted him.

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"Be thankful. This is a divine sword given to me by my master over there, Rudra Nasca. It can't be compared with other dull swords. And since you're going to inherit it, you'll have to prove your merit."

Granbell commanded Hinata.

"My...merit, you say?"

"Mm. I will see if you're worthy of holding the sword inherited by a Hero."

Granbell nodded magnanimously to the confused Hinata. Now that Granbell had said that much, there was no way for Hinata to back down. In the first place, she was a self-proclaimed defender of humanity, and she was not the kind of person who would hesitate at this point.

"Hah, then rest assured. The current me will not lose, even to my

master.”

“You sure are talking big when you’re not even at the level of these old bones. Listen, and do not forget. It is the strength of our emotions that makes us who we are. Victory is not what’s important. It is the better outcome that matters.”

The words of Granbell, who acted more for the future of humanity than for his own victory, were heavy. Hinata chewed them over.

“Yes, I understand.”

Just as she had entrusted her hope to Chloe, Granbell had entrusted his beliefs to Hinata. Hinata accepted it and looked forward. In her line of sight, she saw the last of the Evil Dragon Spawns. Hinata was surprised as she tried to focus her consciousness. Her consciousness was changing more smoothly than usual, and the more she looked, the more the surrounding situation filled her brain. Despite this, the information was organized, and she was able to grasp the movements of Evil Dragon Spawn as if she were holding it in her hand. The sword and the will that had been entrusted to her; those were what brought about the change in Hinata.

Truth had recognized Hinata as its master and had unleashed her full power. As a result, the value of Hinata’s existence was greatly increased. Furthermore, Granbell’s words had washed away Hinata’s worries.

‘It’s a pity that you have yet to become a Hero,’ that’s what Granbell had said.

Paradoxically, it was a declaration that Hinata could become a Hero.

In that is the case, I must live up to his expectations.

The master, who was stricter than anyone else, had acknowledged Hinata. Her mood was uplifted.

“I’ll finish you in an instant.”

She said as such, bidding a final farewell to the Evil Dragon Spawn.

“’True Slash’!!”

She didn’t even let her opponent realize that it had been slashed. Countless slash marks appeared on the Evil Dragon Spawn’s body, and at that moment, its gaze crossed with Hinata’s.

“Hinaw...he...hewlp—“⁷³

The Evil Dragon Spawn was about to say something, but its words failed to come out. Before it could even finish, its body disintegrated into tiny pieces. Perhaps the remnants of Reiner’s consciousness had asked Hinata for help, but if he had lost his human essence at this stage, there was no way to save him. This was Reiner’s own fault, but—

“Have a good night. Sweet dreams.”

Hinata threw in a few words of comfort. There were many reasons why she did not like Reiner, and she didn’t think she could forgive him for what he had done, but she hoped at the least that he would be at peace when he died. In this way, Hinata’s victory was confirmed, and Evil Dragon Spawns were annihilated.

The victorious Hinata was greeted by Granbell with a round of applause.

“Well done.”

“No, it was because my master lent me his sword.”

Granbell stopped Hinata from giving Truth back to him.

“It is yours now. I am already dead. The me here is nothing more than a fake, a perfect reproduction created from memories.”

“That’s...”

It didn’t look like it, but Hinata knew it was true.

“The boy who inherited my master’s ‘soul’ has created an extraordinary power.”

With that said, Granbell smiled. Hinata agreed. This was not a

resurrection from the dead, but it was, if anything, an even more terrifying power. The ability to recreate the champions of the past in their prime...

Even if the power was limited to those who had a relationship with Masayuki, it would still be an absurd story. Moreover, there was a strong possibility that he would be able to call upon even those who had no connection to him. At the very least, Granbell and Masayuki were not acquainted with each other. Even so, he was able to summon them because Hero Rudra, who was said to be a past life of Masayuki, had been Granbell's mentor.

Even Hinata had only just heard of this story, and Masayuki should have known nothing about it. To begin with, it was unclear as to how many people could be summoned at the same time, and she had to admit that it was an unfathomable ability. It was only natural that Granbell, who stood here from Masayuki's power, had no regrets about the sword he was leaving behind in this world. Even so, Hinata was not sure that she was worthy to hold it.

"I understand that Master is an illusion, but that's not the point. In the end, I couldn't become a Hero. My qualifications were passed on to Chloe, and unfortunately, I was never meant to awaken—"

The Hero's Egg that Hinata carried had been passed on to Chloe to give birth to the strongest Hero. Therefore, the current Hinata would never awaken, and could not live up to Granbell's expectations. Knowing this, Hinata showed off her current self to Granbell. Through this, one could see Hinata's strong will that she doesn't mind being disappointed. She was declaring to Granbell that she had nothing to be ashamed of. Granbell laughed at such a Hinata.

"Do you really think so?"

"...Eh?"

“It was my master Rudra’s will that I be called, but I suppose it was inevitable. I remembered from the Promised Land that I was unable to entrust you with my will either. Maria was very angry with me.”

This conversation itself was an illusion told by a fake. And yet, it was still so concrete and vivid. Then, Hinata realized the meaning of Granbell’s words.

“Huh?! This power is—”

Granbell’s qualification as a Hero—the Holy Spirit of Light that guided those to victory, had been handed over to Hinata along with Truth.

“This is where my role ends. Hinata, I’ll leave the rest up to you.”

Granbell spoke, smiling with a freshness that had never been shown in his lifetime. Hinata vowed with that smile.

“Rest assured, Master. I will do my best.”

“Then, good!”

Granbell said and gave a small smile. Then he turned his back on Hinata, as if his business was done.



Damrada stood alongside Granbell as he walked toward Masayuki.

“Gran, are you finished satisfying your regrets?”

“Yes. You also seem to have complained to Rudra.”

“Heh, he didn’t listen to me, as usual.”

“That’s just like him.”

“Yeah, definitely.”

The two of them appeared to be on good terms with each other. It made

one think that this was the way things were in the ancient past, the way things should have been. No, it was the truth. Granbell had studied under Rudra and parted company to unite the West. After the West was united, he was scheduled to return to Rudra's service.

Granbell's struggle with the monsters of power who dominated many nations had exhausted him greatly. The empire that he had set up as a virtual enemy eventually became a real threat to Granbell. And so, trapped in his own madness, he, and his friend Damrada became nothing more than superficial friends who played tricks on each other...until today.

Those petty ties were no longer relevant. Just like in the old days, they were simply laughing and talking to each other. Without a doubt, this was not something a mere illusion could do. Rudra was waiting for them.

"Hey, hey, you guys aren't going to speak trash right in front of me, are you? You'd better prepare yourselves."

"Hm, we were complimenting you."

"Yes, that's right. We can't do anything without you."

"Tsk, you're making me sick. Well, that's fine then. It's my turn now, so get some rest until I call you back."

Rudra laughed. Granbell and Damrada laugh back, and then disappear. They left, satisfied that their part in the story was over. Rudra, who was entrusted with the rest, accepted their trust without hesitation.

"Rudra, are you okay?"

Rudra smiled at Velgrynd's concern, hugged her around the waist, and even kissed her lightly.

"I don't think this is the time."

"Fufu, I'll be gone once this is over. I just got my reward first."

Velgrynd stared at Rudra in ecstasy. She adored the naive Masayuki for his innocence, but Rudra, the man she had once loved, was exceptional.

Someday, Masayuki would become Rudra. Velgrynd had always believed that, but she never thought that her dream would come true. It may seem contradictory, but those were her true feelings. Because she could love any Rudra, the original was the best—Masayuki, who recreated such a Rudra, had become a supreme being for Velgrynd. The word love was no longer enough.

“I love Masayuki. All of you, Rudra.”

“I know. So those words shouldn’t be said to me, but to Masayuki himself.”

“But, that kid, he’s a bit shy.”

“I’m sure he’s happy on the inside. I’m the one who said it, so I’m sure of it.”

Yes, those words were also true. The current Rudra was not an illusion, but Masayuki himself with Rudra’s memories. Rudra then turned to Feldway as if to hide his embarrassment.

“Now then, sorry to keep you waiting, Feldway.”

“...Apparently, you’re the real deal. Do you intend to defy the laws of this world and say that you’ve transcended death?”

“No. I’m still dead and there’s no coming back to life. However, I can hit a man from the other side if he makes the woman I love cry.”

“Don’t be silly.”

“I’m serious though? Well, I haven’t gone to the other side yet.”

Rudra’s statement, though said in a joking manner, was quite true. Because he was dwelling within Masayuki like this, as long as Michael’s body was still incarnated, not all of his memories would be recreated. As soon as the effects of Masayuki’s power expired, Rudra’s personality would disappear. However, his memories and experiences would remain in Masayuki’s heart. This meant that Rudra could continue to manifest

himself. Rudra was not so sincere as to tell him this, but he had no intention to hide it.

“Now then...”

Muttering to himself, Rudra glanced at Vega. Then, turning to Testarossa and Hinata, he gave them an order with an expectant look.

“Hey, you guys. I’ll leave that small fry to you.”

Naturally, the two rebelled.

“So high and mighty...”

“Agreed.”

However, it was in their best interest to follow Rudra’s lead, and they were not so stupid as to not understand that. That’s why it felt even worse, but in this case, they chose to follow him quietly.

“Let us go with a united front, Hinata-dono.”

“You’re right, Testarossa-san. With you as a partner, I can rest assured.”

“Fufufu, it is the same for me.”

And so, an impromptu duo was formed to take on Vega. Vega vs. Testarossa & Hinata. And—

Feldway vs. Rudra.

The final battle in the Royal Capital had begun.



Two beautiful women stood in front of Vega. Testarossa was smiling bewitchingly, while Hinata was smiling coldly.

“I’m going to finish him off, so would you mind keeping him occupied for a while?”

“Yes, of course. He seems to be difficult to kill with a sword, and widespread annihilation magic cannot be used in the Royal Capital, so let’s share the work.”

As smart people, it was easy for them to come to an agreement. Testarossa stepped back and began to search for the range of influence of the power that Vega had activated. That tended to be neglected while fighting, but this time, she activated her detection spell carefully in order to kill him seriously. Hinata stood in front of Vega.

“Oh hey, what happened to my buddy Damrada and the other bastard?”

“They have gone back.”

“Hmm, I see. They looked like they were going to do some damage, but they’re not my enemy. Neither are you guys. You got carried away just because you beat my Evil Dragon Spawns, but let me give you a reality check.”

Vega boasted to Hinata. As a former colleague, Damrada had felt that Vega was quite capable. However, he had thought that the current Vega was no match for him and did not consider him a threat. Even so, he felt that it would be annoying to be swarmed by such a strong class of people, so Hinata’s words that Damrada had gone back honestly made him happy. Well, it was just that it was less troublesome.

“Well, what do you think? Don’t underestimate me, or you’ll regret it.”

Even Hinata could see that Vega was a very powerful opponent. Normally, Hinata would try to instigate things from the start, but she understood that it would be ridiculous for her to say such a thing now. The right thing to do was to win and show her strength. As soon as the exchange was over, Vega moved.

He chose to use his greatly increased strength and speed to confront Hinata head on. Vega’s stiff arm destroyed an object with a shock wave

even though it had not been touched. The same went for his kicks. His entire body had become an incarnation of destruction that surpassed that of strategic weapons, and he was causing extraordinary damage to those around him. If it weren't for the 'Material Area,' the capital would have been reduced to ashes in a matter of minutes. Exposed to such a tyranny, Hinata would normally have been in great trouble. In fact, Hinata's existence value had increased significantly, but Vega's rate of increase was even greater. The difference was more than tenfold, and he even possessed the Ultimate Skill. Even though Granbell had awakened her as a Hero, Vega was still too dangerous for Hinata. And yet, Hinata was unfazed.

It's strange. I'm not scared at all. And for some reason, I can read the flow of attacks—

It was more accurate than the 'Predict Future Attack' that Rimuru had mastered and could now be called 'Future Prediction.'

It was no wonder, then, that Hinata's current Skill was—

«Confirmed. Unique Skill 'Mathematician' has evolved into Ultimate Skill 'Fate King Fortuna'... Successful.»

With the evolution of Hinata herself, she had reached the ultimate realm. This 'Fate King Fortuna' included the abilities 'Thought Acceleration,' 'Universal Perception,' 'Divine Haki,' 'Spacetime Manipulation,' 'Multidimensional Barrier,' 'All of Creation,' 'Computational Domain,' and 'Virtual World.'

By making full use of these powers, Hinata was able to embody an almost perfect 'Future Prediction.' It was only through this power that Hinata was able to master Granbell's sword technique, 'True Slash.' Hinata had lost her Unique Skill 'Usurper,' but because she had made 'Fate King

Fortuna' her own with such talent, she did not need it. Hinata was able to see through all of Vega's tricky attacks, including altering himself and branching his arms. Even when Vega was several times faster than her, Hinata was able to toss him around with ease.

"Damn it, you're just jumping around!"

No matter how terrible Vega's shockwaves were, they wouldn't do much damage to Hinata if it didn't hit her directly, especially now that she was able to turn into a full spiritual life form as a Hero. Of course, if it was Vega, whose entire body was hardened with mythical-grade armor, he might be able to kill Hinata with just one blow. However, Hinata now had Truth in her hands.

Until now, it would have been difficult for her to even take him on seriously, considering the difference in weapon performance, but with Truth, there was no need to worry about that. Combined with Hinata's 'Future Prediction' calculation, it was possible to parry Vega's attacks head-on. Although the difference in strength was too great and there was a need to adjust the angle, it was an easy task given Hinata's skill level.

"You're not going to hit me?"

"Damn it! However, you don't have the means to reach me!!"

Vega shouted, unwilling to admit defeat, but he still had a point. But there was no need for Hinata to be ashamed of that. After all, that's what Testarossa was there for.

"It's very helpful to have a good vanguard. I'm ready."

"Well then, please go ahead."

"Yes. There's no need for repentance, you can go straight to purgatory."

Vega's survival instincts told him that he was in trouble.

"Don't screw with me! W-wait! Wait for—"

But Testarossa did not listen to Vega's pleas for his life.

“‘White Flare.’”

Testarossa had created the ultimate magic: interpersonal magic with her Ultimate Skill ‘Death King Belial’—that is, the ‘White Flare.’ It consumed life and reaped death. There was no escape for those who had been targeted by it, their bodies would be consumed by the white flames, and they would be cast into hell. It was a terrible magic that caused no damage to the surrounding area, but its power and heat level surpassed that of nuclear magic. There was nothing he could do about it; Vega was burned to the ground in an instant.

But Testarossa’s expression was dark.

“...The worst. Apparently, it seems that I’ve failed.”

She muttered gravely. Overhearing this, Hinata asked.

“What do you mean by that?”

“I was unable to reap that fool’s soul. Perhaps if it were anyone else, but my eyes can’t be deceived.”

When Vega died, Testarossa took in a massive amount of ‘soul.’ However, there was no scent on it that could be attributed to Vega. Hinata thought to herself.

That magic was of a terrible nature. Even I think it would be difficult to withstand. Would I be able to escape it?

If it were her, she would definitely be defeated the moment the spell was activated. Hinata admitted this but then retracted her argument when she remembered Vega’s attitude.

“...Or rather, it’s likely, I’m almost certain that they’ve escaped.”

“You think so too?”

“Yes. Because that guy seemed like he was acting.”

“Yeah. The begging for his life wasn’t as desperate or sneaky as it should have been.”

Testarossa had heard a lot about Vega's despicable behavior from Moss. He was a cowardly bastard who would immediately pull the trigger if he knew he was at a disadvantage. The fact that such a man did not stop looking down on her until the end assured her that he did not think he would die.

"It's the worst. I'm so embarrassed, I don't think I can face Rimuru-sama..."

Testarossa was writhing in shame over her mistake. And so was Hinata.

"Ah, I can just see Rimuru's face, so happy to hear my story. Just great, that guy, he's always so delighted when I fail..."

She couldn't stop thinking about it.

I'm always right, with an expression like that, Rimuru was very pleased when Hinata was in trouble. She hated him for that, but at the same time, she was pleased that he was happy whenever she relied on him. Hinata had mixed feelings about that.

Moss, who was listening to the conversation of these women, thought in silence as if he were air.

If I do it, I'll be tormented for three hundred years or so, he thought.

To say that he had let the enemy escape—he was too scared to report it. However, Moss was not foolish enough to point out his superior's mistake here. He knew from the bottom of his heart that if he did such a thing, he would be blamed for not keeping a watchful eye on things.

Ahhh, if other executives blame me, Testarossa-sama will be in trouble...

For the time being, Moss was depressed, expecting that his boss would be in a bad mood. At the very least, he secretly hoped that he would not be the one to bear the brunt of it.



Rudra leisurely took off his Emperor's coat and left it in Velgrynd's hands. Now wearing a shirt, he looked at Feldway.

"Come, 'Deva.'"

Rudra's favorite sword from his Hero days answered his call. It was a sacred sword, given to Rudra by his friend and mentor, Veldanava. Its grade was the highest of all mythical-grade swords. The Asura and the Deva were a pair of swords that could be boasted as the most powerful swords ever made. While the Asura, which was given to Guy and later to Milim, was a long, curved, single-edged sword, the Deva was a normal-sized, double-edged sword. Because of its ease of use, it was a perfect match for Rudra. Feldway narrowed his eyes.

"That sword is Veldanava-sama's..."

"That's right. I got it from him."

"...That's unforgivable. It's too valuable to be wasted on a mere mortal."

"What do I care?"

Rudra walked towards Feldway. Velgrynd watched anxiously but did not wish to interfere. She believed in Rudra.

"So then, you're still a coward, huh? You're the type of person who would never use all your strength to decide between two people."

"What does that matter? The leader must outlive everyone else. You're well aware of that, aren't you?"

"Well, I suppose. But if that's the reason why you miss the chance to win a battle you could've won, it's not worth it, is it?"

"Huh, what are you—"

“I’m grateful. If you hadn’t relied on the ‘Justice King Michael’ and fought Gryun on your own, she would’ve been injured much worse.”

“...”

“However, I won’t forgive you for hurting her. Prepare yourself!”

By the time he finished, Rudra was in close proximity to Feldway. He casually swung his sword. Feldway caught it with his own. The sword, just like with Rudra and Guy, was given to Feldway by Veldanava. It was a masterpiece named the Ark. The grade of the swords was the same. The rest of the battle would be decided by skill level. The ground was shattered by the footsteps and even the air was broken by the impact of running through the sky. The impact of the swords clashing was so great that the smell of burning air filled the surroundings.

“It’s tremendous...”

Hinata muttered, who was now one of the spectators. Hinata’s mentor, Granbell, respected Rudra as a master, and his power was real. Despite the fact that he was inhabiting the fragile body of Masayuki, his power was equal to that of Feldway’s. No, it was more than that. After several clashes, Feldway was the one who was outmatched.

“You’re weak, bastard.”

“Don’t you dare make a fool of me, Rudra!!”

“Hmph, that’s what happens when you rely too much on your Skills. I knew you were trying to copy me, but you can’t be that naive.”

Rudra’s sword flicked Feldway’s sword away. There was an overwhelming difference in ability.

“The Ultimate Skill ‘Justice King Michael’ is a complete defense in the truest sense of the word. I had been using it for a long time, so I’m sure of it.”

“...”

“However, while it’s active, you can’t take any offensive measures, right? No magic, no other powers, no fighting spirit (aura). You can’t even use magic to deflect attacks. However—”

There was a loophole. Although it was impossible to blow off attacks with things like fighting aura, the overwhelming power of Haki was effective. Besides, he could attack with hand-held weapons without a problem, though that was the main concern. Rudra was proficient in this. He was so skilled that he was able to release the Castle Guard only at the moment of attack and increase the power through his fighting aura.

“You knew that, so you misunderstood that you were in a one-sided position, but it was a strategy that was possible because you were me. If you’re not the best with a sword, you’ll easily lose your means of attack.”

His words hit the nail on the head. Feldway knew this because he had been a member of Rudra’s inner circle. Therefore, when he acquired the Ultimate Skill ‘Justice King Michael,’ he tried to recreate that power, but it was not so easy. It was not a skill that Rudra had learned overnight, but rather a method of combat that he had learned over and over again while being beaten down by his master, Veldanava. That’s why it was a great achievement to even be able to imitate him. Besides, losing a sword fight did not mean that the ‘Castle Guard’ had been broken. Feldway was still intact and he had not lost his overall advantage.

“Yes, I’ll admit to your point. However, don’t think you’ve won.”

Feldway spoke arrogantly. He was so confident in his own defense that he believed he would never be defeated. However, Rudra replied to Feldway as if to ridicule him.

“You really think you can beat me, don’t you? Do you have any idea how many years I spent with Veldanava after he entrusted me with ‘Justice King Michael’?”

“What do you mean?”

“I’m asking you if you really think that I didn’t come up with a way to attack it.”

“You fool. Do you think there’s any way to defeat the most powerful of all Angelic, no, Ultimate Skills? You can’t bluff your way through me.”

Even so, Rudra only snickered. Then he narrowed his eyes and thrust his sword at Feldway.

“I’ll tell you something. What I received was the ‘Covenant King Uriel,’ what do you think its characteristics were?”

“It’s just a power for management purposes. Veldanava-sama used the ‘Covenant King Uriel’ to figure out how to create his many powers.”

Upon being asked by Rudra, Feldway answered. It was the correct answer, but it did not express the whole truth.

“There’s more to it than that. As you may know, the ‘Covenant King Uriel’ also had the ability to listen to the voices of the people. Or rather, the voices of those connected to Veldanava. It could be a wish for hope, a prayer for salvation, or any number of other desires, but it didn’t lose its power when I had it.”

“...So what do you mean?”

“See the resemblance? With the ‘Justice King Michael’ you’re using now.”

As long as there was loyalty to its owner, the ‘Castle Guard’ was invincible. In other words, the ‘Covenant King Uriel’ and the ‘Justice King Michael’ were similar in the sense that they listened to the voices of those who were connected to them.

“By the way, ‘Covenant King Uriel’ also has an ‘Absolute Defense’ which is an application of the ‘Infinite Prison’ and can be broken at the critical moment. I’m proud to say that the means of attack I devised by

using it was quite impressive.”

Rudra grinned after saying this. He lightly swung Deva in his hand, making its blade glow with light.

“You can ‘see’ it, can’t you?”⁷⁴

“Mmm...”

Upon seeing the light, Feldway’s face changed color. He realized at a glance that it had the same properties as the ‘Castle Guard’ he wore.

“The more people who believe in me, the more power I have. How many of your followers do you have? I’ve got over a billion people counting on me!”

Rudra’s words were true. The total number of Feldway’s followers was less than a million. The number of those who believed in Feldway had been greatly reduced and was now believed to be less than 300,000. On the other hand, the number of those who believed in Rudra reached 800 million among the subjects of the Empire alone. Here in the royal capital of Ingracia alone, millions of people had placed their hope in Rudra. Rather, it was for Masayuki, but since they were the same person, it was accepted without any issues. There was a huge gap between Rudra and Feldway in regard to the absolute number of supporters they had. Feldway’s face twisted in frustration as he realized this.

“This is the deadly blow that will unleash the united will of those who believe in me— ‘Absolute Severance’!!”

Feldway could sense the danger.

“Quit screwing around!! How can you use the power of the ‘Covenant King Uriel’?! It’s still missing—”

When Veldanava died, the ‘Covenant King Uriel’ was supposed to be lost. And yet, Rudra was using it as if it were only natural. It was an unacceptable situation.

“You’re not paying enough attention. For that matter, that Gran guy was using ‘Hope King Sarial’ too.”

Rudra told him in utter exasperation. Masayuki’s ‘King of Heroes’ could even recreate skills that had disappeared. Rudra smiles broadly, as if it didn’t matter what he told them.

“You really don’t like these tactics, do you?”

Velgrynd was also exasperated, but more than that, she was in love with Rudra’s bravery, and in the end, no one other than Rudra’s sister Lucia had ever cautioned him. This was a scene that had been repeated in the past, and it was being recreated precisely now.

“If so, then you—”

“That’s right. I can use the ‘Justice King Michael’ right now, but the one who’s going to end you here is the ‘Covenant King Uriel’ who boasts the strongest attack power.”

“Che?!”

Feldway was on full alert, mobilizing not only the Castle Guard but also all of his ‘Barriers’ in a defensive posture. And immediately after that—

“I’ve been waiting. Let’s see how long you can hold out!!”

At Rudra’s voice, the ultimate blow was unleashed.

“It’s not going to work, Rudra—ah!!”

“Star King Dragon Flash, ‘Nova Break’!”

The clash was instantaneous. A terrifying rampage of destruction erupted on the spot. The ‘Material Area’ meant nothing. Even though Velgrynd had contained the main shockwave and sent it skyward, it was still shattered in the aftermath. This was not the kind of power that could be generated by mere swordplay, but this was what made Rudra, Rudra. Irrational strength, that was the power of the “hero of the beginning” who could compete with Guy. And of course, it was Feldway who fell.

“Well, that’s a fair result.”

Rudra smiled refreshingly and raised his right hand to the sky. It was, without a doubt, a declaration of victory.



Feldway fell to his knees and coughed up blood. His blood was crimson, staining his pure white robes.

“I-it can’t be, I’m the one...”

“You’re too conceited, Feldway. It’s always been that way, but you’ve always thought you had to be the best in everything you do. That’s why you lose sight of the essential.”

“Don’t make me puke... I don’t need to be told what to do by someone who’s a shell of his former self!”

“You’re right. That’s why I can understand some things.”

The victor and the vanquished fell silent and stared at each other for a moment. Feldway was the next to move.

“—There will be no next time. Today’s defeat will be your last.”

And with that, he stood up as if the injury he had just sustained had never happened in the first place. If it weren’t for the crimson flowers blooming on his clothing, one would have thought that the attack from Rudra’s sword had been an illusion.

“You’re still as stubborn as ever. Well, I’ll always win, no matter how many times you come, so be my guest.”

The two men looked at each other again, and then away. Feldway turned his back on Rudra, and ordered Mai, who had been waiting at a distance, to

disappear from the scene with ‘Instantaneous Movement.’ Not only the ‘Material Area,’ but also the ‘Barrier’ of the Royal Capital had been destroyed, so it was impossible to prevent his escape. However, it was a good decision not to pursue him.

Even though he was wounded, Feldway still had a lot of power left. Although he had been mentally cornered by the defeat from Rudra, his fighting ability was still sufficient. If it had not been for the defeat of the invincible ‘Castle Guard,’ he would not have chosen to flee so easily. Feldway swore revenge on Rudra, never forgetting today’s humiliation. Now then, as for the victorious Rudra—

“Great job, Rudra!”

Rudra’s face was pressed against Velgrynd’s chest, and he seemed to be in no mood to complain. No, upon a closer look, it was something else. He was blushing and his eyes were spinning. It wasn’t Rudra anymore—he was back to Masayuki again. He had used up all his soul power when he had unleashed the ‘Nova Break,’ and it had become difficult for him to maintain his Rudra persona. That was the reason why he had missed Feldway. Rather, until Feldway’s departure, Rudra’s personality had only been maintained through sheer force of will. Hinata walked up to Masayuki, who had been released from Velgrynd.

“It’s nice to meet you, First-sama.⁷⁵ My name is Hinata Sakaguchi. Before you leave, I wanted to say a few words—”

In the middle of Hinata’s greeting, the noise of the people began to be heard. Seeing how strong Rudra was, they were excited that Masayuki had taken things seriously. It was a misunderstanding, but to those who did not know the situation, it was the truth. When they saw that the battle was over, they came rushing to the area. Once they were within a certain distance, they formed a circle around Masayuki. This was the result of Minits and the

others taking the lead and holding back the people.

“—Wow, Masayuki-san’s so cool!”

“I saw it for the first time! The true ‘beacon of light.’”

“Yeah. I had no idea what was going on, but I could tell it was awesome!”

And so, naturally, the credit went to Masayuki. Because Reiner and the others had made the video available, there were many people in the capital who had witnessed the entire thing.

No, that wasn’t me!

No, it was me, but, Masayuki’s inner thoughts were in turmoil. However, he activated on his ‘it-never-happened skill’ and succeeded in making a face that seemed to say, ‘It was only natural, and so?’

How on earth did this happen? That was Masayuki’s current state of mind. From Masayuki’s point of view, Rudra had done everything on his own. Even though he was told that he was amazing, it didn’t really feel like it. It was difficult for him to accept such praise without thinking of himself as another person, but the people didn’t understand his feelings.

“Thank you for your hard work. You looked great, Masayuki.”

Velgrynd handed him a jet-black, gold-embroidered Emperor’s robe, and as he put it on, he tried to think. It was embarrassing to be the center of public attention, but he also had a feeling that there was trouble to come. To be more specific, the knights of the capital had arrived.

Wow, this is going to be troublesome...

As Masayuki’s escort, Minits was acting as a negotiator. He seemed to be refusing the request, saying that if they wanted an audience with His Majesty the Emperor, they should talk to them first. He listened to the conversation, thinking that his escorts were very reliable, but the content of the conversation was very disturbing. It sounded like the king had been

assassinated, but Masayuki had nothing to do with it. Masayuki's heart continued to pound as he heard something about an important witness. He had been through a lot of hardships, and now he was able to accept any difficulties naturally—that's what he had thought, but now he realized that that was an exaggeration. Although he has gotten accustomed to the nervous tension of public appearances, Masayuki was still a bit of a coward. Not to mention, he'd rather not be suspected of murder...

"I'm sorry. I seem to have gotten you involved in our situation."

Hinata, noticing that Rudra had reverted back to Masayuki, softly apologized.

"Uh?"

"Reiner murdered King Aegil and blamed me for his sins."

No way, Masayuki thought.

That's such a big deal!

It was hard to be involved in such an incident and accept it. But it was also impossible to pretend that he had nothing to do with it now. Even if he wanted to complain, there was no one to complain to. After all, Masayuki was the most important person here right now. Masayuki had no choice but to take charge of the situation. As the crowd continued to cheer, Masayuki took a step forward. Then, as he always did in practice, he tilted his head at an angle and looked down. After a two-second pause, he turned his head to the front and looked at the audience. Just by doing this, the excitement of the people was palpable. It was frighteningly effective.

As expected, it's exactly as Rimuru-san told me.

That's right. Masayuki's current gesture was the result of Rimuru's guidance—or rather, it was the result of practice based on Ciel's production. By adding the gestures that were calculated to win the hearts of the people, the effect of his Skill was increased. And now that it had evolved into the

‘King of Heroes,’ the effect was enormous.

“Everyone, please calm down. I need you to stay composed and tell me what happened—”

When Masayuki quietly began to speak, the excited people fell silent at once. Like a receding wave, the entire area was enveloped in silence. Masayuki was inwardly horrified at the unimaginable impact of his influence. This was the achieved effect after only a small amount of performance guidance. With nothing to do but to laugh at the situation, Masayuki resolved to continue his performance.

Uh okay, don't panic and take your time. Even if you stutter or choke a little, it's fine because there's a way to fix it!—was that it?

Ever since he decided to become Emperor, Rimuru had consulted him many times. There were many other people who supported Masayuki, and he was now able to play the role reasonably well. It never occurred to those who were watching him intently that Masayuki was actually really nervous.

“Everyone! What is right and what is wrong? I think it should be obvious from this scene. If you are wise, you will know the right answer without me saying anything. I ask that you believe in that answer, and I want to believe in you, too!”

Masayuki didn't think he was explaining himself very well. Nevertheless, he was convinced that it would have a significant effect. Because that was the effect of Masayuki's ‘King of Heroes.’ He didn't know what the right answer was, but at the least, he wanted to avoid the hostility of the people. It seems that he succeeded in doing so and decided to take this opportunity to lead the people in a cynical manner so as not to be taken advantage of.

It's perfect. I didn't say anything important, so I can't be blamed if I'm wrong.

Masayuki praised himself inwardly. As Masayuki began to speak, the crowd that had been in an uproar suddenly calmed down. Along with that, Minits came up to Masayuki with a knight in tow. He was a large man with a stern face and metal armor all over his body. Masayuki was scared. However, the knight saluted Masayuki with the highest of respect.

“It is my great pleasure to have an audience with His Majesty Masayuki, Champion of my Kingdom of Ingracia and Emperor of the Great Eastern Empire!”

“Ah, yes.”

Masayuki was overwhelmed and just nodded his head. However, he felt compelled to say what he needed to say and opened his mouth to the knight.

“Um, King Aegil—”

He had heard that the King of Aegil was killed, but it wasn’t Hinata-san who did it—He was about to continue, but the knight interrupted him and spoke up.

“Please rest assured! If His Majesty Masayuki is on her side, then the suspicions about Hinata-dono can be cleared! Rather, we, the knights of Ingracia, would never suspect Hinata-dono!!”

The knight laughed loudly.

“So then, have we identified the culprit?”

Hinata glanced at Prince Elric. He had been trembling behind the fountain ever since the battle had started, but Moss had moved him out of the way. It was not a kindness, but an instruction from Testarossa. It was an act to secure the culprit, and not to allow him to escape. Seeing such a situation, anyone with an intelligent mind would have been able to guess who was behind this. It may be true that the king was murdered, but was Hinata really the culprit? These were the questions that came to the peoples’ minds.

Prince Elric was certainly a popular man, but it was only by looking at the sequence of events that the full picture of what had happened became clear. Masayuki knew nothing about the incident, but Hinata had been looking at Prince Elric. At that moment, he looked up and she met Elric's eyes.

"Fu-Fuhahahahaha... It's all over now, I'm ruined..."

Elric suddenly started laughing as Masayuki looked at him. And then, for some reason, he took the liberty of confessing his misdeeds.

No, what? I don't understand the situation, but what's going on?!

It was just that Elric misunderstood that he had seen through everything and self-destructed on his own. Unbeknownst to Masayuki, he decided to hide his inner turmoil and continue acting as if he understood everything. And so, the situation came to an end with a furious turn of events.

"It seems that Masayuki-sama has identified the culprit and solved the problem..."

"Prince Elric killed His Majesty the King, his father..."

"The mastermind behind it was Reiner, the former Commander of the Knight Order."

"That's why Hinata-sama..."

"Reiner was the bastard who blundered at the council meeting, wasn't he?"

"Oh, how shameful of the former Commander of the Knights of Ingracia."

"So, then he was trying to take revenge on Hinata-sama with the help of a monster?"

"But it was our Masayuki-sama who saw through that and resolved Hinata-sama's dilemma!"

"As expected of hero-sama!"

“Even though he became the Emperor of the Eastern Empire, he still remembered us!!”

The prince’s confession was decisive. The people were convinced without needing any explanation from Masayuki or Hinata.

“Hurray, Masayuki-sama!”

“Glory to our Masayuki-sama!!”

Such cheers naturally arose. It quickly spread among the people, and the chorus began.

“ “ “Ma-sa-yu-ki, Ma-sa-yu-ki, Ma-sa-yu-ki!!” ” ” ”

And it wasn’t long before the Royal Capital was filled with the usual cheers. With one hand raised awkwardly and his cheek twitching, Masayuki responded to the people. The contrast between Hinata’s slightly dumbfounded expression and Velgrynd’s satisfied look was striking. Masayuki’s inner self was filled with tears and screamed ‘Whatever, I don’t care anymore!’—but that’s just the way things always were.

Incidentally, the next day, Masayuki suffered terrible pains from the aftereffects of harboring Rudra, as well as from a variety of other reasons, regardless of the use of restoration magic—This included a very rare kind of growing pain called ‘soul pain,’ but he had no way of knowing that now.



Michael was acutely aware of his own naivety. To be honest, at first he had thought that the Demon Lord Rimuru was insignificant. That changed the

moment Rimuru defeated Velgrynd. From then on, he regarded him as an enemy and took extra precautions. Even so, he still thought that he would not be much of an enemy in a head-on battle. But now, Michael had no choice but to admit that he had been naive. After all, the Demon Lord Rimuru had entered the ‘Suspended World,’ a place that only a limited number of people were allowed to enter, without permission.

What a troublesome guy. He’s always getting in my way.

At this point, there was no point in stopping time. Michael lifted the ‘Time Stop’ and decided to crush Rimuru with an overwhelming difference in power. The ‘Time Stop’ had been obtained by analyzing Velzard’s ‘Patience King Gabriel,’ but it was useless to someone who could manipulate information particles at will. Since maintaining it would only consume unnecessary energy, he decided that it would be more advantageous to fight in a straightforward manner.

In fact, Michael has gained great power by taking in the factors of the two ‘True Dragons.’ His body had been strengthened to the point of invincibility, and he was overflowing with energy. And that wasn’t all. Michael, as befitting of the head of the Angelic Ultimate Skills, was able to fully display all the powers he had analyzed and taken in.

From Velzard’s ‘Patience King Gabriel,’ the concept of ‘fixation’⁷⁶ had given him an unrivaled and powerful defensive ability. It was not as powerful as Castle Guard, but it was more useful in that it could be used to attack at the same time. Moreover, the concept of ‘fixation’ had given him the ultimate ‘time stop’ ability. As long as he had this, it was as if he could never be defeated by any entity. Another example was Velgrynd’s ‘Charity King Raguel’ which boasted the ultimate offensive capabilities.

The information from the ‘Purity King Metatron’ that he had retrieved from Leon was also very useful in terms of energy efficiency. Even the

powers he had lent out to his subordinates were at Michael's disposal. He could manipulate them at will, as he had done with the 'Concealment' power from Arios' 'Punishment King Sandalphon.' For Michael, who had reached such a state of existence, there was no doubt that he could win any battle as long as he was present.

He had been defeated by the Hero Chloe, but that was only a 'Parallel Existence' at less than 20 percent of his power. The current Michael was perfect, and his lost energy had been replenished. In fact, there was a disparity of more than ten times between Michael and the Demon Lord Rimuru in front of him. He was assured that there was nothing to lose.

In the first place, a serious Michael would have easily defeated Obara's army. Considering that, defeating Rimuru personally should have been a piece of cake. However, it was not that simple.

This guy is a monster, Michael admitted from the bottom of his heart.

Every attack he launched at Rimuru was unsuccessful. Even the Scorch Dragon Cardinal Acceleration, which he had unleashed with deadly intent, was instantly drowned out. Michael could not believe his eyes. The moment he lost the overwhelming advantage of stopping time, he no longer had an effective means of attack against Rimuru. By the time he realized this, the battle had already been decided.

"Hmm, all these attacks are so easy to understand. This is enough, I can handle—"

Just as he thought he was muttering something, Rimuru's threat level rose several notches. The color of his eyes glowed gold. Rimuru was no longer a reachable opponent for Michael. If he couldn't attack, then could he defend?

Michael's 'Castle Guard' was no longer effective, but he still had the

‘Patience King Gabriel’ from Velzard. Its essence was ‘fixation’ and boasted absolute protection. With that in mind, he activated the ‘Snow Crystal’ to coagulate the moisture in the air. Pouring all his strength into it, he created an indestructible object that wrapped around Michael. However...

“Eh, this can be eaten too? Seriously?”

For some reason, Rimuru himself was surprised as he made a hole in the ‘Snow Crystal.’ It was an unbelievable reality.

“You, what did you just do?! What did you say just now?!”

Michael couldn’t help shouting... Rimuru replied matter-of-factly.

“I ate it.”

“You ate it?”

“Well, yeah. That’s my ability. Well, I didn’t think I could eat the ‘Barrier’ either, but I guess it’s possible if you try.”

It couldn’t be. Michael was astonished.

‘What the hell are you talking about?’ he felt like shouting.

Michael acted on the basis of rational judgment. That was why he could not simply nod his head to such an irrational story. But the results were all that mattered. Michael was not so incompetent as to ignore the reality shown before him. So, what should he do? All means of attack had been neutralized and his defenses were gone.

‘You should run away,’ a calm voice whispered.

At the same time, something else suggested that he should search for information here. Either way, Michael had ‘Parallel Existence,’ so even if he was defeated here, he could be revived. In fact, since he had transferred his power to Feldway, it was possible to attack him even if it was reckless. However—

Demon Lord Rimuru was too incomprehensible. And Michael’s escape

had already been blocked.

«I have confined this area to the ‘Imaginary Space.’ With this, it is now impossible for Michael to escape from this place.»

He felt as if he heard an unidentified voice. He thought it was absurd, but apparently it was true. If so, there was only one answer, so there was no need to worry. If he couldn’t defeat Demon Lord Rimuru here, then there would be no way out either way.

“Huh, in that case, I’ll respond. I’ll show you how serious I really am.”

Michael declared, attempting to summon not the sword in his hand, but the most powerful sword ever created.

“Come, ‘Deva.’”

But there was no response. Rudra, the true owner of the sword, was already using it, so there was no way it would respond to Michael’s call, who was only a fake master. If he had been able to use ‘Parallel Existence’ as Velgrynd did, he would have been able to understand the world as seen through Feldway’s eyes. However, Michael, although he transferred the function as an ability, was not able to synchronize completely. The reason for this failure was that he thought it would be no problem to exchange information later. As soon as that happened, Michael just put divine energy into his sword. Rimuru’s reaction was ‘Huh?’ but he was ready to respond with his own sword.

“Um, what about Deva?”

“Never mind that.”

“That’s fine then, but...”

Rimuru looked a little unconvinced, but his expression tightened as Michael’s divine presence increased. Then the two men went into the final

battle.

“‘Melt Slash.’”

Michael, having taken over Rudra’s body, had already mastered his swordplay. It was impossible for the current Michael to recreate Rudra’s most powerful technique, the ‘Nova Break,’ but he was fully capable of using the most powerful sword techniques that manipulated one’s spirit. He was also adept at Disintegration and chosen to use the transcendental holy sword technique, ‘Overblade’ for this match. Rimuru, on the other hand, showed his hidden move without any hesitation.

“‘Void Collapse, World of a Thousand Blooming Changes’⁷⁷.”

As if in courtesy to those who would soon perish, he generously revealed it to the public for the first time. It was a terrifying technique. The trajectory of the sword changed in thousands upon thousands of directions, slicing through the enemy with elusive movements. Its power was impeccable, and it scattered the target like a flower. It was out of the realm of human reach and seemed impossible for even a demon lord. The toughness of a True Dragon, combined with the flexibility of slime, must have enabled him to achieve such an incomprehensible sword technique.

“It’s over, I’ve lost...”

Michael realized that his body was disintegrating. And before he had time to face that inescapable reality—

“So then, do you have any last words?”

Rimuru asked him. Accepting defeat, Michael thought to himself. How could he have lost when he had outperformed them in every way? He could not find the answer. That’s why he asked a different question rather than sighing in defeat.

“You, who are you...?”

To which Rimuru replied with a puzzled look.

“Eh, me? I’m just a slime...”

What was he talking about? Michael suddenly felt ridiculous. He didn’t care about his crumbling body, but for some reason—

Perhaps, is this what it feels like to be happy?

He suddenly understood. It was a feeling that he hadn’t felt since his Lord had abandoned him and his ego had grown. He had tried to imitate it, but later dismissed it as something that he could not understand...

And now, in this last moment, he suddenly understood. It was something beyond his control, Michael thought in self-mockery.

“What slime? You’re an anomalous existence that is too incomprehensible to be understood, and yet it suits you. You have defeated me, a Manas—”

The decay rate increased. As particles of light dispersed, more and more of his body was being chipped away.

“You know, I’m actually not alone.”

“...?”

“Take your time, you’ll have to ask my partner about that.”

With that said, Rimuru broke off the conversation. His hand came to rest on Michael.

“Devour all things, ‘Void God Azathoth’!”

For the first time in this world, the ultimate and most powerful skill bared its fangs. The irresistible power of peace⁷⁸—the ‘Soul Devourer’⁷⁹, swallowed up all of Michael.

.....

.....

...

In truth, he understood. That He, his creator, had abandoned him. He didn’t want to admit it, so he had struggled with it until now. But that was

over now. It was warm with an all-encompassing completeness. A familiar comfort.

Ah, I see, Michael thought as he faded away.

Perhaps everything had just been a misunderstanding. Everything was here, and he felt himself becoming a part of it. Michael was no longer alone. This was inevitable, it must have all been part of a harmonious plan.

—Ah...my wish has been granted. Feldway, my only regret is leaving you behind—

It suddenly occurred to him, and—

Michael's consciousness vanished into thin air.



I confronted Michael and immediately realized...

Oh, this is no big deal. Because Michael's attacks were too textbook.⁸⁰ It was good to be faithful to the basics, but he didn't seem to have any variety. In other words, he only threw strikes, so no matter how powerful they were, they were easy to predict and easy to deal with. That's why Ciel-san and I switched players as soon as the battle started, and I had a good time watching the high-level exchanges. During the battle, Michael had used a great defensive move, which made me nervous. No matter how much I could handle, the difference in strength was obvious. I thought that if he could create a 'Defense Barrier' that I couldn't break, I would be helpless.

However, Ciel-san was even more amazing. No, seriously. It saw

through the weaknesses of Michael's moves with scary calmness. As a result, even the defensive move called 'Snow Crystal' was eliminated by 'Void God (Azathoth)' in a matter of seconds. It was an overwhelmingly one-sided battle. Michael was so pitiful that I decided to score a complete victory.

In the end, I showed him the 'Void Collapse, World of a Thousand Blooming Changes,' which may have been a test in battle for Ciel-san, but for me it was a final gift to Michael. I defeated Michael, but at the end, I was asked a strange question.

'Who are you?' Even if asked, I'm honestly not sure.

I am me. It's nothing more than that. However, that doesn't mean there isn't anything that comes to mind. Michael probably noticed Ciel-san's existence. That's why I wanted to have them communicate from Manas to fellow Manas.

Michael seemed to be proud of being a Manas, so it would be surprising for him to learn of Ciel-san's existence, but it was the last time, so there was no problem. With that in mind, I activated my first use of the 'Soul Devourer' ability on Michael.

I was surprised when I did it. I had thought that it would be impossible to devour all of Michael, since his existence value was probably ten times greater than mine, but Michael disappeared in an instant. And there was also the feeling of satiety. A feeling that I had never felt before, no matter what I ate, filled my heart.

«With this, the data of the Seven Angelic System Ultimate Skills are complete⁸¹. Velzard's dragon factor has also been acquired, so I will start the 'Analyze and Assess.' ♪ »

Well, not only was I satisfied, but Ciel-san seemed to be happy as well. After the battle with Michael, I checked on Diablo and the others. I was glad everyone was okay.

“Kuh, I have no excuse for my mistake this time, and I can’t tell you—”

“No, no, that was unavoidable. What can you do if they can stop time?”

“No, I should have thought of more countermeasures. I regret that I naively thought that it would be of no use for those who could move within the Time Stop, and that it would only be less fuel efficient and less useful. I swear not to make such a mistake next time!”

Diablo was unusually depressed, and I had a hard time calming him down. I thought Time Stop was a foul, but since there were very few people who could handle it, I didn’t think we’d need to worry about it that much. That’s what I thought, but Diablo and Souei thought differently.

“Diablo, tell me how to deal with it too.”

“I managed to get a sense for it, but it’s difficult to go beyond that. If you know how to do it, please tell me.”

“Of course, Souei-dono. And Ultima as well.”

They were enthusiastically discussing countermeasures. Well, yeah. If you’re not careful, you can make the same mistakes over and over and again. If there is an answer for this, it is better to prepare in advance. I think that Diablo and the others’ actions are not in vain, because they can think of a solution to any problem if given enough time. With that in mind, I decided not to interfere.

It seemed that Leon had not regained consciousness yet, so I ordered Diablo to take him to Tempest. I didn’t think he’d be a target anymore, but it was just in case. I also ordered Ultima to go to Shion’s aid. Now that Dagrue was on the march, I decided that Lubelius would be the next

battleground.

“Kufufufufu, I will be back soon, so it is goodbye for now.”

“Well then, Rimuru-sama, I’m off!”

And the two immediately sprang into action. Veyron and Zonda followed Ultima, leaving Souei and I alone. However, there was still work to be done. Here, we would investigate the Holy Void Damargania. Dagrue didn’t seem like someone who would betray us, so something must have happened here. I wanted to know what that was, and I also thought I should find out what the current situation was in this city.

“I’m counting on you, Souei!”

“Understood!”

It was safe to leave it to Souei. After giving the instructions, I returned to the capital, which had been my last concern. But apparently, there was no need to panic.

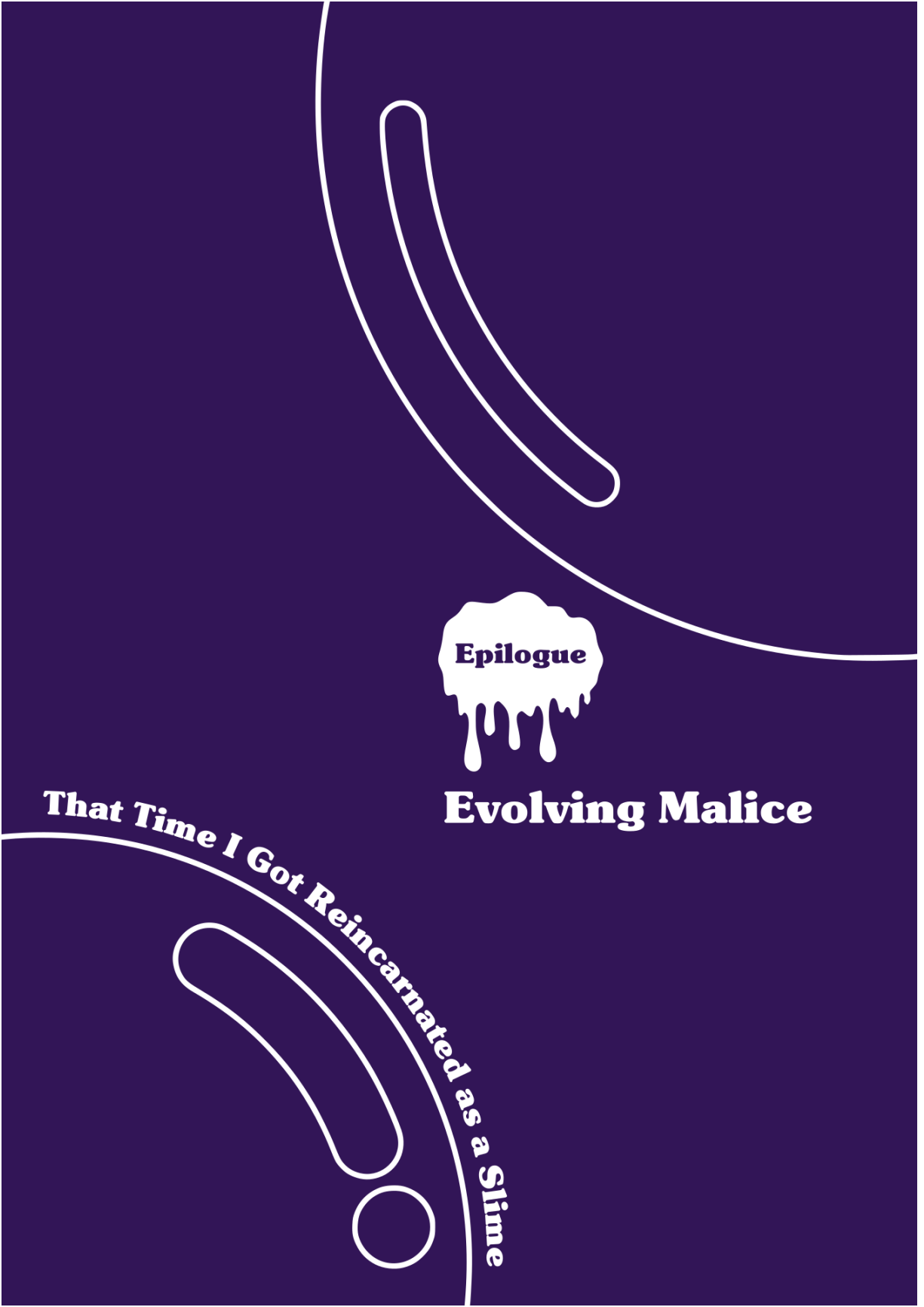
“You’re too late. It’s over.”

Velgrynd proudly told me what had happened. Surprisingly, Masayuki had defeated Feldway, the enemy’s leader.

“That’s amazing!”

“Wait a minute! Before you praise me, please listen to what I have to say first!”

Well, yeah. I understood. I’m sure Masayuki was not happy about this. But he still won, so he should be proud of it. I was relieved too. Really, I was just glad everyone was okay. I was relieved about it, but it seems that it was too early to relax. Soon after that, reports of the war situation began to arrive from all over the world. It was more horrible than I had imagined... my mind instantly switched to the upcoming battles.



Epilogue

Evolving Malice

That Time I Got Reincarnated as a Slime

Epilogue

Evolving Malice

Feeling a great surge of power, it opened its eyes dimly. All it could see were the little people who always got in its way. The being that stood before it was eradicating the swarm of them. It was a force that even it—the World-destroying Dragon Ivarage could not ignore, and the carnage ended in the blink of an eye. The victor—Michael, had left the scene without paying a single thought to Ivarage.

A little uncomfortable with this, Ivarage moved slowly and walked over to the site of the battle. The remains of those who had fought against him for so many years. He unconsciously spoke of the many corpses floating there. Fools who launched feeble attacks that didn't even itch. Nevertheless, they were comforting to Ivarage's endless boredom. It was probably because he felt that their deaths were a bit of a waste that he took such a futile action. However—

Such a mere whim brought about an incredible change in Ivarage. Ivarage, a being without intelligence, without reason, and who had done nothing but carry out destructive actions out of instinct, was now imbued with an emotion. Until now, Ivarage's only purpose in life had been the urge to destroy. But in that moment, he felt hatred. It was the germination of an

intellect and an emotion. Even the gods could not have foreseen that the grudges of those who were destroyed by Michael would provoke Ivarage.

Moreover, the transformation did not stop there. As a result of taking in more than ten thousand souls, Ivarage had entered a time of evolution.

No.

It should be said that the time had arrived. The evil god would be reborn as an incarnation of malice. More cunning, more evil, and more intent with the goal of destroying the world. Just before it began—the evolution into an evil god, the Halloween Carnival—Ivarage did indeed see it. Michael had left, and the gate to the other world had opened. Looking forward to it, Ivarage fell asleep. What was beyond that gate? And what joyous events awaited him there...

And... And, was there an enemy worthy of this hatred, Ivarage wondered, his heart almost bursting with anticipation. These were new emotions; desires he should never have had. But it was too late. The day of awakening of the dreaming evil god was near.

Afterword

It's been a long time, everyone.

For the first time, the deadline was extended by one month. I thought it was going to be a disaster when I started writing it, but then I felt that it was actually impossible. As I was rearranging the contents for the completion, various developments came to my mind. The reason was that I couldn't write them down easily, because whatever I added would have a big influence on the future.

Of course, I had other work to do as well, and one of the reasons was that I couldn't switch my mindset well. I feel that my brain is not working as well as it used to, and I wonder if it's my age. When I mentioned this to I-San, he gave me a warm encouragement saying, "Don't make excuses like that, just write it down."

I don't get it. He even told me that he would never change the schedule of the next volume, so I will start the next volume as soon as I finish this postscript. Oops, the manuscript still has to be revised before that. Proofreaders are really amazing. They search not only for inconsistencies in the current volume, but also for errors in the entire volume set.

However, with so many volumes, it seems that small discrepancies tend to accumulate. It would be easier if it were just a matter of spelling mistakes or rewriting the text to make it easier to understand. In my case, I started

writing with only a rough plot, so I did most of the checking only in my head. I realized that I could only get away with that for a short number of books, and reminded myself to refine the plot before I start writing.

And so, here is the 19th volume.

The last war has broken out, and the forces are locked in a standoff in various places. I cannot write everything in this volume and will continue to the next volume as a matter of course. This is how I would like to run through the remaining three (planned) books!

Michael-san, who was a candidate for the last boss, has left the scene, and I wonder who will become the last boss. I have a vague idea in my head, but whether it will be adopted or not depends on the future. It is quite common for me to change my direction while writing. I will continue to work hard on the story so that readers can enjoy it more!

I hope that you will continue to support That Time I Got Reincarnated as a Slime.

See you in the next volume!

**That Time I Got
Reincarnated as a Slime 19**

Story by Fuse, Illustration by Mitz Vah



Notes

[← 1]

The word used for “bases” is “Kyoten (拠点)” also meaning “location/position,” or “point”—kind of like a foundational point/base point.

[← 2]

Basically, the enemy is surrounded on all angles, even from below because there is no ground.

[← 3]

The word used is “usankusai (胡散臭い)” which would translate to “stinky” in English. However, in Japanese, it is used to describe something as “shady” or “suspicious looking.”

[← 4]

In case it was forgotten, in V18, Oma was the one who had lost both her eyes, and instead got a single eye that could see everything. Her mouth was sewn shut, and she had only communicated through telepathy until then.

[← 5]

It doesn't come through in English, but Oma says this while still sounding formal/respectful with her form of speech.

[← 6]

I brought this up in V18, but as a recap, the word used here for

Primordial angels is different than the one used for the Primordial demons. The general translation is “Shigen (始原)” which translates to the “source,” or “origin.” When used in conjunction to “Nanatenshi” (which means seven angels), together they can translate to the “Seven Original Angels” (or Seven Angels of the Origin. That’s why I tend to call them the Seven Original Angels. It also helps with the confusion with the Seven Primordial Demons.

[← 7]

The word used here is “Kisama” which translates to “you” but more brash/rude and is used when people are angry/holding contempt. It’s basically like saying “you bastard!” Obara normally speaks very formal/politely so it’s a bigger contrast in Japanese than in English.

[← 8]

The soldiers refer to Obara here as “Kijō-sama” which is like a respectful way to refer to someone like a noblewoman or lady. I guess it’s kind of like saying ‘milady’ but more polite.

[← 9]

This sentence is spoken with Kansai dialect, so I’m pretty sure it’s Laplace.

[← 10]

Another translation can be “special move,” but I am sticking with “sure-kill technique” from here on out due to consistency, and because I think it is a more accurate translation than “special move.” If there are any One Piece fans out there, the kanji is actually quite similar to Usopp’s “sure-kill” shots which is partly why I went with that

translation.

[← 11]

The Kanji that was used in this technique is the same as the ‘Oboro -- Hyakka Ryouran’ except for the added “Kokuen” part which means “Black Flames.” Very fitting for a Benimaru technique.

[← 12]

Broken as in it has a cheat-like foul play.

[← 13]

I think that this part is like a better version of Hinata’s ‘Dead End Rainbow’ attack that has the 7-hit kill effect.

[← 14]

The Japanese phrase was that they would end up in a “Sennichite (千日手)” which literally translates as “moves for a thousand days.” It’s actually a phrase for “repetition draws” used in Shogi where if the same game position occurs four times with the same player to move and the same pieces in both sides, then the game ends as sennichite. Rimuru uses this phrase here to explain that the fight would end up as a pointless number of actions with no conclusive winner. An ongoing draw.

[← 15]

El-tan is Rimuru’s nickname for Empress Elmesia

[← 16]

I think this is referring to the fact that they share the same system. Silvia’s Ultimate Skill ‘Thunder King Indra’ is the ultimate power of

nature, and Leon's Ultimate Skill 'Purity King Metatron' is the ultimate power of the holy attribute. They are very similar by nature/lineage.

[← 17]

It should be noted that Rimuru speaks more formal/robotically in this sentence. It kind of implies that he is just saying all the right words just to be polite.

[← 18]

It doesn't come through in English, but the word used for "owner" in Japanese here is "Kainushi (飼い主)" which is closer to a "dog owner" or "shepherd." It makes it way more hilarious because Feldway is making Diablo seem like Rimuru's naughty pet dog (which, let's be honest, is kinda true).

[← 19]

A medieval club-like weapon consisting of a shaft connected to a round spiked ball. Similar to a mace.

[← 20]

This was also brought up in V18. 妖(よう)天(てん) -> The word is pronounced "Yōten." The Chinese character 妖 can mean many things from spirit, to demon/devil, to ghost, etc. and the Chinese character 天 means heaven/sky. Because we still don't have an official translation for this, and because I am not fluent in Japanese, I will temporarily be translating it as "Heavenly Demon/Spirit," until something more official is chosen.

[← 21]

千 (せん) 手 (じゅ) 影 (えい) 殺 (さつ) -> I read this as something like “senjū eisatsu” or “one thousand hands shadow killings.” So for now, “Thousand-Hand Shadow Kill” is what I’ll call this until an official translation is decided.

[← 22]

The word used here was a Japanese concept of interpersonal communication known as “Haragei (腹芸).” It literally translates to “stomach art” and refers to an exchange of thoughts/feelings that is implied in conversation. Basically, it’s a form of rhetoric meant to communicate real intention/meaning through implication. The closest English phrase I could think of for this was “conversational implicature” which is an indirect/implicit act of speech. By the way, the raw MTL of this was hilarious—“belly tricks” or “abdominal arts,” lmao.

[← 23]

A Japanese idiomatic phrase was used here. Sajikagen (さじかげん) - > making adjustments based on experience, feeling, skill, or knack. It’s also a phrase for making adjustments in seasoning or medication.

[← 24]

Can also be translated as spiritual power/energy

[← 25]

It should be noted that Vega refers to himself as “Ore-sama” which is a really arrogant/pompous way of doing so. It’s kind of like saying “the great me” instead of just “I.”

[← 26]

Actually, the translation was “Souei thought his expression would fall off,” but I changed it to make more sense in context.

[← 27]

To be more clear, they are being forced to sit in a seiza-style (which is like kneeling on the floor with a formal posture) like in a form of repentance.

[← 28]

He actually says “Rimuru-sama” twice in the same sentence, even though it sounds repetitive.

[← 29]

“Amazake” is a sweet fermented Japanese rice drink (sometimes called sweet sake). But this time, instead of normal white/black rice being used to make it, this version is made with the magic black rice from Tempest.

[← 30]

“Seishu” is a refined/clear sake. The traditional Japanese sake is a form of this as well.

[← 31]

The phrase used here was Shin-shō-hitsu-batsu (信賞必罰) which was a pretty confusing term for me until I did some research. It literally translates to “sure punishment or reward” and basically means to be sure to strictly reward those who have done well and punish those who have committed crimes. To strictly reward and punish.

[← 32]

夫婦喧嘩は犬も食わない -> This is a Japanese idiom that basically means that one should never interfere with lover's quarrels. I might not have translated the "dog" part perfectly, but I think I came pretty close after doing some research.

[← 33]

I'm actually not positive about what was going to be said here, but it might have been an insult that was cutoff before finishing. The Japanese just says "Ano ba— (That ba—)" and then stops.

[← 34]

She says "Kansha shimasu" here, which is a more formal way of thanks. It also means "I appreciate it."

[← 35]

A lot of these positions were difficult for me to categorize in terms of rank. Michael is the "Shujō (主上)" which is something like a Chief or Leader or Commander.

[← 36]

"Saikō shirei-kan (最高司令官)" means something like Supreme Commander or Commander-in-Chief.

[← 37]

"Saikō sekinin (最高責任)" To be honest, I'm not sure if Michael is ranked higher than Feldway or vice-versa, but both Michael and Feldway clearly have the highest of positions.

[← 38]

Same kanji as Three Phantom Commanders except the “phantom” part was replaced with the character “Hoshi 星” meaning star. Hence, the Three Star Commanders.

[← 39]

“Jinzai (人材)” -> Can also mean “manpower,” “manpower resources,” or “assets.”

[← 40]

This word, “Teshita (手下),” can also mean “minion” or “underling.”

[← 41]

He’s not saying that Feldway is talking about him, but rather that Feldway seems to be choosing him for the job.

[← 42]

The word used was “Kangeki (感激)” which can also mean many things like “wrought with emotion,” “inspired,” “great impression,” and “thrilled.” It can even be used to say that something “moved you to tears.”

[← 43]

He called her “chibisuke.” It can also mean little runt, or midget/dwarf.

[← 44]

The phrase was “with black and white eyes,” but that didn’t make much sense to me in English unless the author is saying that her eyes are literally black and white, but I have seen this expression being used in other places.

[← 45]

To be clear, he is not literally calling him his brother, but more like referring to him as a “bro” (兄弟 “kyōdai”). Vega will continue to do this later as well.

[← 46]

“Sanbō (参謀)” -> Staff officer.

[← 47]

“凶悪巨神 (kyōaku kyoshin).” “凶悪” can mean Vicious/evil/heinous, so Evil Titans is another possible translation.

[← 48]

Glassord calls Dagruel “Anija” which is an older way of saying “Aniki” which means “Brother/Elder Brother.”

[← 49]

He calls her “shutaru (主たる)” Ultima. Shutaru as in lord, master, chief, king, etc.

[← 50]

She calls him “Ojisan” which can mean “uncle,” “old man,” or “mister.” That said, “uncle” is the most common usage, while the others are a little less common.

[← 51]

Normally, I would have put “insectars” here, but they actually used the word for insects here (and many other places) instead of “insectar.”

[← 52]

“Hi-jū kishi-dan (飛獣騎士団)” -> Flying Beast Knights/Knight Order. Can also be called the “Order/Knights of the Flying Beasts”

[← 53]

Rather than “dawn of war” the word used was “sentan (戦端)” meaning “opening of hostilities” or even “edge of war.”

[← 54]

The word used here for best friends is “mabudachi” which is the same word Milim uses for Rimuru. It is kind of an older slang way of saying true/close/best friend.

[← 55]

By “defend,” she means to set up barriers/wards.

[← 56]

She says “Mōshiwakegozaimasen” which is a very formal/humbling way to say I’m sorry. It literally means, “I have no excuse” or “There is no excuse.”

[← 57]

Saril refers to himself (I, me, my) using “Orecchi.” I believe it’s a unique version of the “Ore” that many men tend to use. Men tend to use either “Ore” or “Boku” and woman tend to use “watashi.” That said, there are other variants other than the common ones.

[← 58]

Obera uses the word (御意) or “Gyoi” which I believe translates to “by your will” or “as you wish.” Kind of like when a servant says he will obey orders.

[← 59]

The special chains that were sealing him are called Gleipnir.

[← 60]

Specifically, he says that “It’s all *parallel lines* anyway” meaning that it’s all pointless/won’t go anywhere because their opinions won’t ever agree/meet, as is the case with parallel lines.

[← 61]

Rairaku (磊落) -> open-minded/open-hearted, free and easy, to not be bothered by unimportant things.

[← 62]

“幽世” or “Kakuriyo (かくりよ)” can also mean “hidden world” or “mysterious world.” It can also refer to the afterlife, or the realm of the dead. I used “invisible world” because it was referring to the imaginary space from Rimuru’s skill.

[← 63]

In chess, a “double check” is when two pieces are simultaneously putting the king in checkmate. Ciel is basically saying that there were two “checkmate” attacks being placed.

[← 64]

Basically, you can’t be a sore loser.

[← 65]

Actually, the term “Shinboōenryo (深謀遠慮)” was used here. It is a Chinese idiom that translates to “far sight and deep design” or “deep plans and distant thoughts.” Basically, it is an idiom that means to

“plan far ahead” and refers to a careful plan with long-term consideration. Ironic, because it wasn’t really Rimuru’s style this time.

[← 66]

The word they used was “rakkīsukebe (ラッキースケベ)” which is literally “lucky sukebe.” “Sukebe” basically means lewd or perv or deviant. You could also translate this to mean “it was a lucky fondle” or “lucky lewdness” or something similar.

[← 67]

“Jushitai (銃士隊)” -> means “the musketeer corps/squad” but “musketeer” also refers to a group of gunners or rifle shooters.

[← 68]

The term used here is “gobuunwo (御武運を)” which basically means “good luck” but more formally when in a battle or war. It’s like saying “good luck” and “I hope you will survive in the war/battle.”

[← 69]

Masayuki’s nickname for Velgrynd.

[← 70]

Even the way Masayuki/Rudra speaks is very different than the usual Masayuki. He refers to himself using “Ore” instead of “boku” and is more assertive in his communication.

[← 71]

Masayuki’s nickname for Velgrynd has always been “Gryn-san/Grin-san” up until now (seems to be taken directly from Velgrynd’s name). But this new nickname is different and kind of difficult to spell out

properly in English, but it's closest to "Gryun" or even "Guryun"—kind of like taking the end of Velgrynd's name (Gryn) and adding another "yu" sound to it (Gryun). If it helps, "Gryn" kind of sounds like "grin" or "green" and "Gryun" kind of sounds like "gr-yoon."

[← 72]

The word used was “バカッフル (bakappuru)” which means “love birds” or a “sickeningly sweet and soppy couple.” It combines the word “baka (stupid)” and “kappuru (couple).” It's also kind of like calling them a stupidly sappy couple.

[← 73]

The Japanese words are broken and purposely misspelled to imply a lack of fluency. I'm not 100% positive, but the words in Japanese looked like he was saying “Hina(ta), save/help me” but misspelled/mispoken on purpose. Hence, I purposely misspelled the sentence “Hina(ta), help” to “Hinaw, hewlp.”

[← 74]

It's quite possible that this is just me making wild observations that mean absolutely nothing, so feel free to ignore this, and don't take it too seriously. However, the way Rudra would say “You can see it” would normally sound like “mi eru yo na” in Japanese. However, because the word “see” was isolated in parentheses, it ends up sounding like “'shi' eru yo na” (at least it did through the machine translators). I wondered why the word “see” was being emphasized, but when Rudra says “'shi eru' yo na” it contains the same word “shieru”->Ciel. “Shieru yo na” also sounds like the sentence “It's Ciel.” This 100% could just be a random word pun I found, or just something

completely not true, but I still thought it was interesting enough to become a little footnote, hehe.

[← 75]

She calls him “Shodai-sama” which I’m guessing refers to the “first” or “first generation” of heroes.

[← 76]

The action of making something firm or stable, or the process of preserving or stabilizing. Immobilizing/anchoring.

[← 77]

I’m not gonna lie, I had no clue how to translate the name of this move. There were so many different variations that came popping out, so I just settled with a mixture between the Google and DeepL MTLs (which also kept changing every time I put them in by the way). So, I appreciate everyone’s understanding! For anyone who might be fluent in Japanese, here is what the raw said! “虚（こ）崩（ほう）朧（ろう）千（せん）変（ぺん）万（ばん）華（か）”

[← 78]

There are many words for peace in Japanese. The one used here is “安寧 (annei)” which is more like “peace of mind,” “stability” and “tranquility.”

[← 79]

I chose the translation “soul devourer” because although the hiragana came out as “soul-eater,” the characters used stood for something more like “soul,” “violent,” and “eat”—hence, “Soul devourer.” -> “魂（こ

ん) 暴(ぼう) 喰(しょく)”

[← 80]

The Japanese actually says that his attacks were too “honor-student,” but “by the text” or “textbook” makes more sense in English.

[← 81]

Ciel actually says the English word “complete (konpurīto)” here. To me, it gives off the feeling that Ciel is very pleased/giddy.

That Time I Got Reincarnated as a Slime, Volume 19

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